

ASTROLOGY, GENTLY · BOOK TWO

Your Life in Seasons

A kind guide to the dasha system
and what each season of your life is asking of you

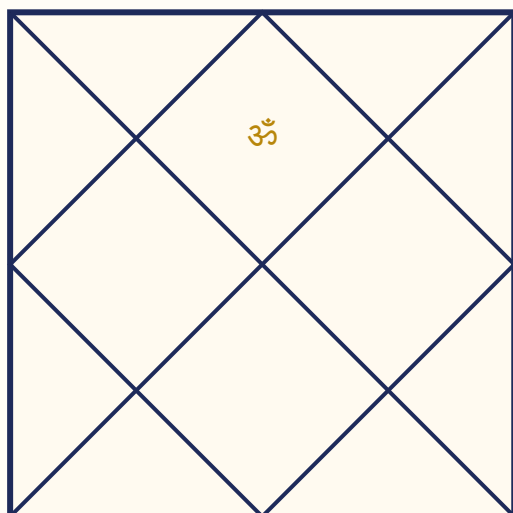


Plain words. A reason for every rule.
And no fear.

Anushka Bharti

Your Life in Seasons

A kind guide to the dasha system, the Vedic astrology of timing, and what each chapter of your life is asking of you



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Your Life in Seasons: A kind guide to the dasha system, the Vedic astrology of timing, and what each chapter of your life is asking of you

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A note on what this book is and is not. This book teaches Vedic astrology (Jyotish) as a way of understanding tendencies and timings. It is not medical, legal, financial or psychological advice, and nothing in it should be used to make decisions about health, money or law in place of a qualified professional. Every person named in the examples is a composite, and the three case-study charts are constructed for teaching.

Sources. The backbone is Parashari astrology (*Brihat Parashara Hora Shastra*). Anything drawn from *Lal Kitab* (Pt. Roop Chand Joshi, Urdu editions 1939 to 1952) appears only inside boxes labelled **From Lal Kitab** with the source stated. Jaimini, Tajaka and KP appear where named.

Boxes used in this book: Anushka's rule of thumb · Why? · Story · Did you know? · Common beginner mistake · Consultation tip · From Lal Kitab (red dashed border) · Practice. **Colour dots:** ● good or friendly · ● mixed or neutral · ○ difficult or hostile.

*For everyone who has ever asked, in a hard year,
"how long will this last?"*

Contents

Why This Book

Part I: The Idea of Seasons

Chapter 1: The Same Person, Different Lives

Chapter 2: The Sky's Timetable: How the Seasons Work

Chapter 3: Seasons Inside Seasons

Part II: The Nine Seasons

Chapter 4: The Ketu Season (7 Years): The Art of Letting Go

Chapter 5: The Venus Season (20 Years): The Long Bloom

Chapter 6: The Sun Season (6 Years): Who Am I When Nobody Is Watching?

Chapter 7: The Moon Season (10 Years): The Household of the Mind

Chapter 8: The Mars Season (7 Years): The Commander Takes Charge

Chapter 9: The Rahu Season (18 Years): The Great Churning

Chapter 10: The Jupiter Season (16 Years): Growth and Grace

Chapter 11: The Saturn Season (19 Years): The Long Audit

Chapter 12: The Mercury Season (17 Years): The Clever Years

Part III: Reading Your Own Timetable

Chapter 13: Where the Planet Sits Changes the Season

Chapter 14: Weather Inside the Season

Chapter 15: The Changeover

Chapter 16: Three Lives in Seasons

Chapter 17: Living Well in a Hard Season

Chapter 18: Your Season Map

Appendices

Appendix A: The Tables

Appendix B: Plain Words to Sanskrit

Appendix C: Getting Your Season Map from Free Tools

Appendix D: The Story Bank: Every Memory Tale in One Place

About the Author

Why This Book

Dear reader,

The most common question I am asked is not "what am I like?" It is "how long will this last?"

A woman whose marriage has gone quiet. A man who has sent out two hundred applications and heard nothing. A mother whose child has changed overnight into someone she does not recognise. A friend who feels, for no reason she can name, that a door is closing behind her and another has not yet opened. None of them wants a personality reading. They want to know whether the weather will change, and when, and what they are supposed to do in the meantime.

Vedic astrology has an answer to that question, and it is one of the most beautiful ideas in the whole subject. It says that a life is not one long undifferentiated road. It moves in seasons. Each season is run by one of the nine planets, for a fixed number of years, in a fixed order, and the one you are born into depends on where the Moon was standing in the sky the night you arrived. The system is called the dasha system. The word simply means a period, a stage, a season. The Venus season lasts twenty years. The Saturn season lasts nineteen. The Sun season lasts six. Inside each season are smaller seasons, and inside those, smaller ones still, like a year that holds months that hold weeks.

Once you know this, you stop asking "what is wrong with me?" and start asking "what is this season asking of me?" That change of question is, in my experience, worth more than any prediction.

I wrote my first book, *Astrology, Gently*, for people who wanted to learn to read a whole chart. This one is narrower and, in a way, more personal. It is about time. You do not need to have read the first book. You do not need to know any astrology at all. You need your date, time and place of birth, a free app, and about two hundred pages.

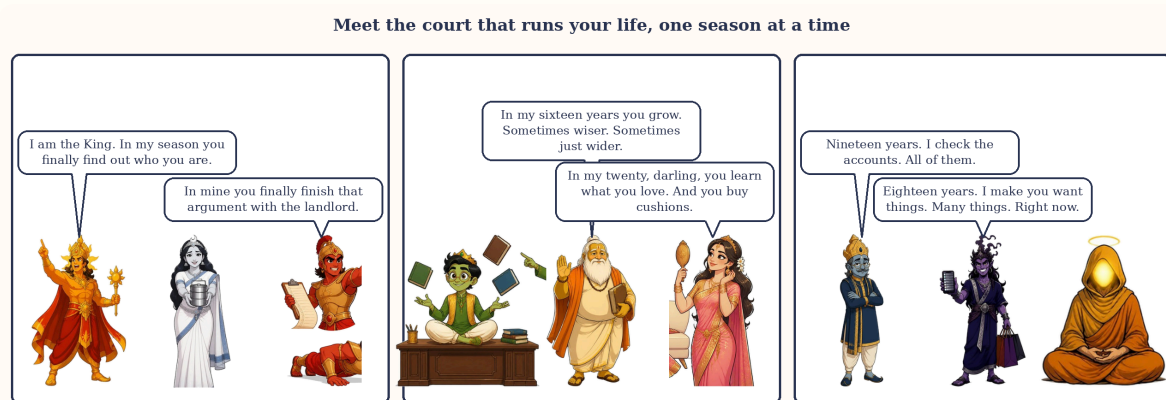
Three promises.

Plain words. The Indian astrology books on my shelf are heavy with Sanskrit that nobody explains, and I watched that weight push away friend after friend who genuinely wanted to learn. So in this book a mahadasha is a *season*, an antardasha is a *sub-season*, a nakshatra is *the Moon's star*, a house is a *room*. Every Sanskrit word appears once, in brackets, when the idea is introduced, and lives afterwards in the glossary at the back, so that you can still talk to any astrologer in their own language. In the chapters themselves, you will read English.

A reason for everything. Where a rule comes from astronomy, I say so. Where it comes from the logic of the system, I show the logic. Where it is simply what the tradition hands down, with no reason given, I tell you that too, because you deserve to know how firm the ground is under your feet.

No fear. A hard season is a season with a task, not a verdict. You will not find the words "you will" followed by anything frightening in this book. You will find "this season tends to ask for" and "this is a time to take care of", and you will find, in every chapter, what to actually do.

The planets appear here as the same cast of characters as in the first book: a King and a Queen Mother, a Commander, a clever young Prince, a Priest, a Minister of Pleasure, an old Judge, and two strangers at the gate. A season, in this telling, is simply the years when one of them is running your household. You will meet them in stories and in small comic strips, because a planet you can picture is a planet you can live with.



The cast: the nine planets as they appear in the comic strips, with you in the middle.

Three constructed lives run through the book: Meera, Arjun and Devika. Their charts are made up for teaching, their events are composites, and their season maps are worked out in full so that you can see the method before you turn it on yourself. By the last chapter you will have drawn your own.

My hope is modest and specific. I hope that the next time a hard year arrives, for you or for someone you love, you will be able to open your season map, find where you are, understand what the time is asking, and know roughly how long it will last. That knowledge does not make the year easy. It makes it bearable, and it makes it useful. For me, that has been the whole gift of this subject.

Go gently.

Anushka Bharti

Chapter 1: The Same Person, Different Lives

Let me tell you about a woman I will call Nandini. She is a composite, stitched from several people I have read for and a little of myself.

At 24, Nandini is in love. Not only with the boy from her office, though there is one; she is in love with everything. She buys a kurta in a colour her mother would never choose. She spends her first salary on a haircut and a dinner she cannot afford. She sings in the kitchen. She is soft, generous, a little lazy about her career and not worried about it. Asked what she wants from life, she says: to be happy, and to be loved.

At 31, you would not recognise her. She has a title at work and a corner of the office with her name on it. She argues with her father at dinner, and she wins. She has stopped singing. She wakes at five to exercise. People call her "strong", and some do not mean it kindly. She wants to be seen, respected, right. The soft girl of 24 looks, to her, like a stranger who wasted seven years.

At 40, she is softer again, in a different way. She has moved house twice in three years. Her mother has come to live with her. She feeds everyone who walks through the door and worries about them after they leave. Her moods rise and fall with the news, the weather, her daughter's face after school. The title matters less. She cries easily and laughs easily. She is, in a word her family uses with love and exasperation, "emotional".

Three women. One life. If you met them separately you would say they had different natures, different values, different gods. And yet the same birth chart sat under all three. This book is about why.



Same person, three seasons. The planets as the court that runs your household, one season at a time.

Life moves in chapters

You already know this in your bones. We say "that was a different phase of my life", "the year everything changed". The person who sat the board exams is not quite the person who sat in the delivery room, and neither is the person at the kitchen table at fifty, wondering where the time went.

What most of us do not have is a map of the chapters. We find out that a chapter has ended only when we look back. We find out that a hard stretch was a stretch, not the rest of our lives, only when it lifts. And inside it, the question that keeps us awake is almost never "why am I like this?" It is "how long will this last?"

Vedic astrology has a timetable for exactly this: the dasha system, which simply means the system of seasons, and the subject of this book.

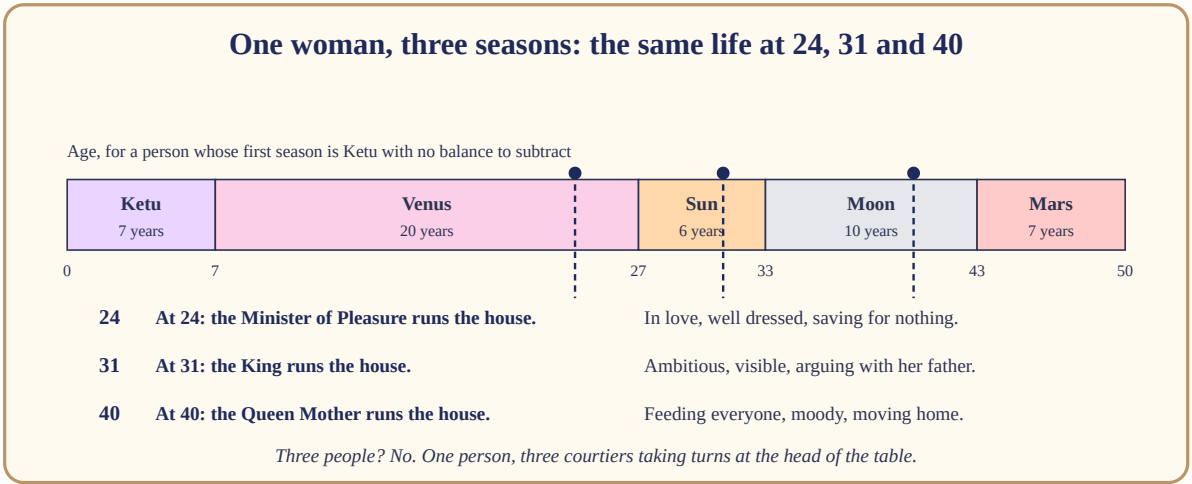


Figure 1.1: Nandini's three scenes on a timetable of seasons: Venus at 24, the Sun at 31, the Moon at 40. Three courtiers, one woman.

What the dasha system is, in one paragraph

Here it is, whole, so you can see the shape before we take it apart. The sage Parashara, in his great textbook of astrology, gives a timetable of 120 years (the Vimshottari dasha; the word means "a hundred and twenty"). The 120 years are divided among the nine planets, each getting a fixed number of years, always in the same order. Where you start depends on where the Moon stood at your birth, in which of the 27 small star-groups along its path (your birth star, nakshatra). From there the timetable rolls forward. The planet whose years you are in colours everything: your wants, your fears, the people who arrive, the doors that open and close. We will call those years a **season**, and the planet in charge the **season lord**. Each season divides again into nine **sub-seasons**, in the same proportions, so every stretch of life has a main colour and a second colour laid over it. That is the whole machine. The rest is detail and kindness.

STORY: THE HOUSEHOLD CHANGES HANDS. In Book 1 the nine planets were a royal court, and I am keeping them. The **King** (the Sun), proud and warm, wants to be seen. The **Queen Mother** (the Moon) runs the household and knows everyone's moods because she has them all herself. The **Commander** (Mars) guards the gate and starts the fights. The clever young **Prince** (Mercury) writes the letters and counts the coins. The **Royal Priest** (Jupiter) teaches, blesses and gives too much. The **Minister of Pleasure** (Venus) arranges music, weddings and comfort. The old **Judge of Labour** (Saturn) keeps the ledger of every debt. At the gate stand two strangers: **Rahu**, the smoke-headed traveller who wants everything he sees, and **Ketu**, the headless sadhu who wants nothing. When the Minister holds the keys, the house fills with music and visitors. When the Judge takes over, the music stops and the accounts come out. Same household, different person in charge. **Rule:** a season is the years when that courtier runs your household; to understand the season, ask what that courtier wants.

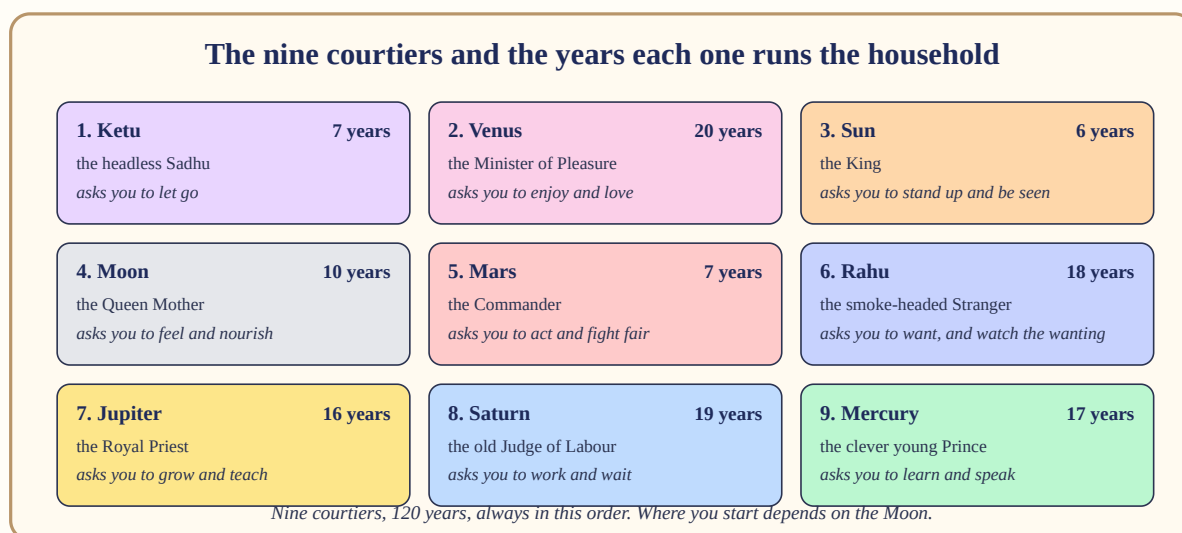


Figure 1.2: The court, with each courtier's share of the 120 years. Chapter 2 explains the lengths and the order.

Why timing, not character, answers the questions people ask

Most astrology books, including most of Book 1, are about character and structure: what your chart says about your mind, your marriage, your work, your mother. That is useful. But think about what people actually ask when they sit across from me. Almost nobody asks "what am I like?" They ask: how long will this go on? Why *now*? Is it me, or the time? When does it get better? Every one of those is a question about timing. The chart alone cannot answer them, because the chart is a photograph: it does not move. The seasons make the photograph into a film.

WHY? This is the system's own logic. A birth chart shows every promise in a life at once: the good marriage and the hard stretch at work, the move abroad and the quiet years, all in one picture. But a life is not lived all at once. Something has to decide *which* promise ripens *when*, and that is the season system: a planet's promises come due, says Parashara, in that planet's own seasons and sub-seasons. The chart is the seed packet; the seasons are the sowing calendar. Everyday parallel: a school timetable. Every subject is "in" your year, but on Tuesday morning it is Maths and nothing else. You do not ask whether you are a Maths person; you ask what period it is.

This is why the same person seems to become three people. Nandini's chart did not change; the courtier in charge did. And it is why a hard year is not a verdict on you. It is a period on the timetable, and periods end. Now the honest part, which I would rather say on page five than have you discover on page two hundred.

What the dasha system is not

It is not a script. The season system tells you which courtier is in charge and what that courtier wants, not what you will do about it. Two people in a Saturn season both feel the weight of work and limits. One grows bitter. The other learns a craft so well that it feeds her for the rest of her life. The season was the same; the person was not.

The tradition itself says this, more clearly than many modern astrologers do. It divides karma into three kinds. In plain words: **the whole store**, everything you have ever set in motion, which nobody can read; **the portion allotted to this life**, the part that has ripened and is due now; and **what you do now**, the choices you make inside each season, which no chart can show because you have not made them yet. A birth chart, and the seasons built on it, show only the second kind.

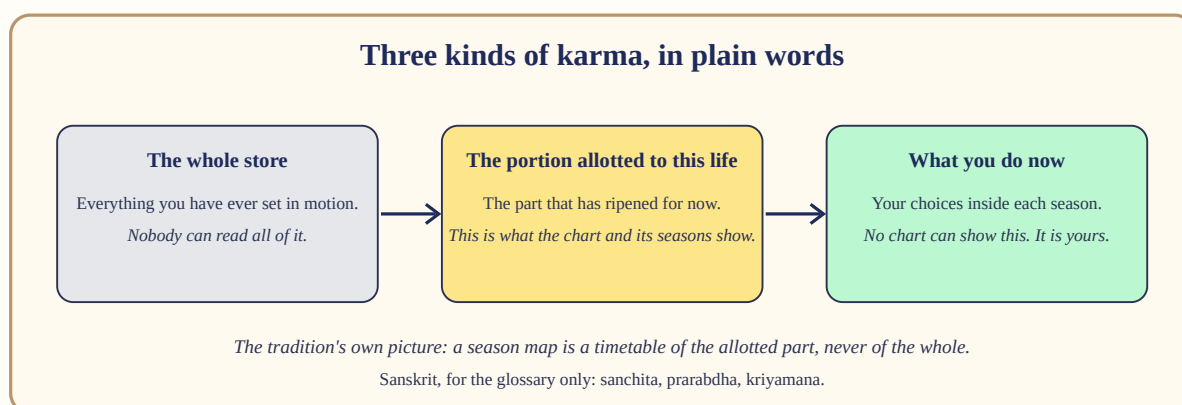


Figure 1.3: The tradition's picture of karma. A season map is a timetable of the allotted part only.

WHY? This is the tradition's own teaching, not my softening of it; the three Sanskrit names are in the glossary. If the chart showed the whole store, every life would be fully written and no effort would matter, and the tradition plainly does not believe that, because it spends whole chapters on conduct and practices. The middle position is the only one that fits: the chart and its seasons show what has ripened for this life, and leave what you do now to you. Everyday parallel: the monsoon arrives on its own calendar; nobody chooses that. Whether your roof is fixed by June is up to you.

It is not a fortune-telling machine. This book will never tell you that a particular month brings a death, a divorce or a lost fortune. I do not believe anyone can read a chart that precisely, and I have seen what fear does to people who were told such things. You will read instead that a season "tests a marriage" or "asks you to take your health seriously". That is as precise as honesty allows, and it tells you where to put your attention.

It is not the whole of astrology. The seasons are one layer. The chart underneath (which planets own which rooms of your life, how strong each is, who sits with whom) decides *how* a season lands on you in particular. That is why one woman's Venus season is a wedding and another's is a lesson about wanting the wrong things. Part III returns to the chart, and Book 1 goes deeper still, but you do not need Book 1 to use this one.

The plain-words promise

Indian astrology books fail their readers in one particular way: they are written in a Sanskrit nobody explains. You open a page, meet a sentence made of six technical words, and close the book feeling stupid. You are not stupid. The book was written for people who already knew the words.

So here is my promise. In this book, **the prose is in English**. When I introduce an idea that has a Sanskrit name, I give you the Sanskrit once, in parentheses, so you recognise it when an app or a family astrologer uses it. After that I use the English word only. A major period is a *season*. A sub-period is a *sub-season*. The ascendant is your *rising sign*. The houses of the chart are *rooms*. The 27 lunar mansions are *the Moon's stars*. The planets moving overhead today are *the weather*. Appendix B lists every English term with its Sanskrit. The one Sanskrit word I keep is *dasha* itself, because it is in the title and on every app screen; think of it simply as "season".

DID YOU KNOW? The textbook I keep calling "Parashara's" is the *Brihat Parashara Hora Shastra*, shortened to BPHS, a conversation between the sage and his student Maitreya. It describes many season systems; the 120-year one is the system Parashara says to use in ordinary times. When this book says "the tradition gives no reason", it means Parashara states the rule and moves on.

Why the Moon is the starting point

The whole timetable begins with the Moon: not the Sun, not your rising sign. Where the Moon stood at your birth decides which courtier runs your first season. Newcomers find this odd. The Sun is the King; surely the King should set the calendar?

WHY? Two layers. The first is tradition: Parashara keys the timetable to the Moon's star, and the texts do not argue the point. The second is the system's own logic. The Moon is the fastest hand on the sky's clock; it crosses one of the 27 stars in about a day, so it is the only body whose star changes fast enough to make the timetable differ between two children born a day apart. The Moon also stands for the mind, the part of you that feels each season. A season is lived through the mind long before it is lived through events, so the mind's planet is the natural place to start the clock. Everyday parallel: a household runs on the Queen Mother's calendar, not the King's. The festivals, the fasts, the days the home is full or empty: she decides those. The King makes speeches; she decides what day it is.

STORY: THE QUEEN MOTHER'S CALENDAR. The court argued about who should keep the royal calendar. The King said: I am the light of the kingdom, measure the year by me. The Priest said: I move slowly and wisely, measure it by me. The old Judge said nothing and kept his own accounts. The Queen Mother listened, then asked one question. "Which of you knows, tonight, what every member of this household is feeling?" Nobody answered. "Then the calendar is mine," she said, "because a year is not what happens in a kingdom. It is what the people in it live through." From that night the court's seasons were counted from where she stood when each child was born. **Rule:** the first season is chosen by the Moon's star at birth, because seasons are lived through the mind, and the Moon is the mind.

What you will be able to do by the end

You will be able to **find your own season and sub-season** with a free app (Chapters 2 and 3); **understand what each of the nine seasons asks of a person**, as a task and not a verdict (Chapters 4 to 12); **read the shape of your own life so far**, laying the seasons under the chapters you already know (Chapters 16 and 18); **prepare for the next changeover** (Chapter 15); and **live a hard season without fear**, with practices that cost nothing and a clear sense of when to ask a doctor or a counsellor instead of an astrologer (Chapter 17).

You will meet three constructed lives again and again: Meera, born in Jaipur in 1988; Arjun, born in Pune in 1995; and Devika, born in Kolkata in 1979. They are composites built for teaching, so we can take their lives apart without hurting anyone.

COMMON MISTAKE: reading your season as a sentence rather than a season. I have watched people see "Saturn" or "Rahu" against their current age and go quiet for a week. Every one of the nine seasons has been lived well by millions of people. The question is not "is it good or bad?" but "what is it asking of me, and for how long?" That question has an answer.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: when life feels like weather you did not order, look up your season before you look inside yourself for a fault. Half the time the weather explains it.

A word about dates

Every date in this book is approximate, and I will say so once in each chapter. Season tables depend on the exact minute of birth and on a setting in the software, and both can shift a changeover by weeks or months. When I write that Meera's Venus season ends "around June 2027", I mean that stretch of the year, not a particular Tuesday. A date in this book is a tide, not a bell. Read the book in order once; after that, open it at the season you are in.

In one breath

- Life moves in chapters, and the same person can seem like three people at 24, 31 and 40; the dasha system, which simply means the system of seasons, is Vedic astrology's timetable for those chapters.
- Parashara's timetable is 120 years long, divided among the nine planets in a fixed order; where you start depends on the Moon's star at your birth.
- A season is the years when one courtier runs your household; to understand it, ask what that courtier wants.
- Timing answers the questions people actually ask ("how long?", "why now?"); the chart is the seed packet, the seasons are the sowing calendar.
- It is not a script: a chart shows only the portion of karma allotted to this life, never the whole store and never what you choose to do now.
- This book speaks English, gives each Sanskrit word once in parentheses, and keeps a glossary in Appendix B; all dates are approximate.

Try this

TRY THIS:

1. Divide your life so far into chapters, the way you would divide a book. Give each a title and an approximate age range. Do not use astrology yet; use your memory. Keep this page for Chapter 16.
2. Pick one chapter and write three lines: what you wanted then, what you feared then, who was closest to you then. Notice how different the answers are from today's.
3. Think of one hard stretch that has ended. How long did it last? Did you know, while inside it, that it would end?
4. Without looking back at the Story box, name the nine courtiers and what each one wants. Then check.

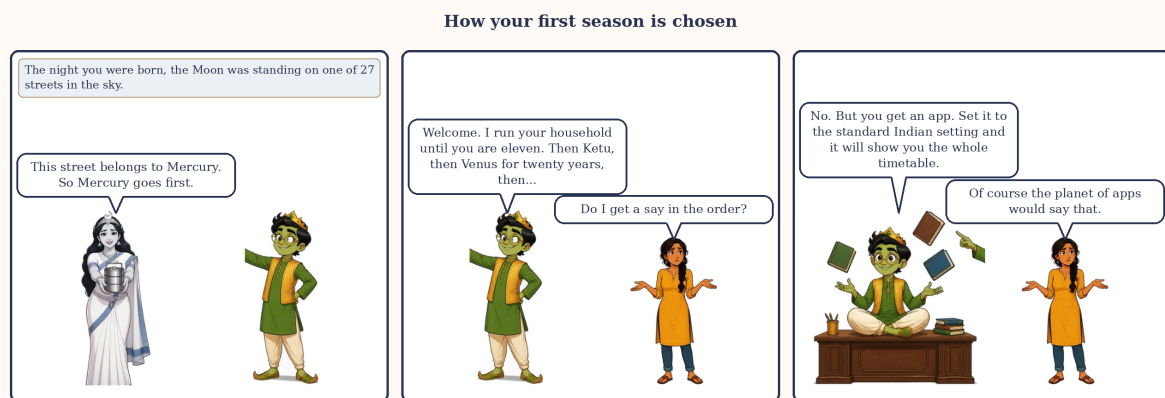
Answers

Exercises 1 to 3 are yours alone. For 4: the King (Sun) wants to be seen; the Queen Mother (Moon) to feel and nourish; the Commander (Mars) to act and win; the Prince (Mercury) to learn and talk; the Royal Priest (Jupiter) to grow, teach and give; the Minister of Pleasure (Venus) love, comfort and beauty; the Judge of Labour (Saturn) the work done and the debts paid; the Stranger (Rahu) everything he sees; the headless Sadhu (Ketu) nothing at all.

Chapter 2: The Sky's Timetable: How the Seasons Work

Think of a railway line with nine stations. The train always stops at them in the same order, never skipping one, never turning back. What differs from passenger to passenger is only which station you boarded at, and how far along the platform you stood when the train pulled in.

That is the whole of the season system's mechanics: nine stations, one fixed order, and a starting point chosen by the Moon. This chapter gives you all three, then shows you how to read your own timetable off a free app in five steps. All dates here are approximate.



How your first season is chosen: the Moon's street on the night you were born decides who goes first.

Nine planets, nine seasons

Each planet gets a fixed number of years. Here they are, in the order the timetable always runs.

Order	Season lord	The courtier	Years	Share of the 120
1	Ketu	the headless Sadhu	7	5.8%
2	Venus	the Minister of Pleasure	20	16.7%
3	Sun	the King	6	5.0%
4	Moon	the Queen Mother	10	8.3%
5	Mars	the Commander	7	5.8%
6	Rahu	the smoke-headed Stranger	18	15.0%
7	Jupiter	the Royal Priest	16	13.3%
8	Saturn	the old Judge of Labour	19	15.8%
9	Mercury	the clever young Prince	17	14.2%

Add them up: $7 + 20 + 6 + 10 + 7 + 18 + 16 + 19 + 17 = 120$. Nobody lives all of it. Most of us see five or six seasons, and the first is usually cut short. Notice how unequal the shares are: three long seasons (Venus, Saturn, Rahu) take almost half the cycle, three short ones (Sun, Ketu, Mars) barely a sixth. A Venus season is an era; a Sun season is a chapter.

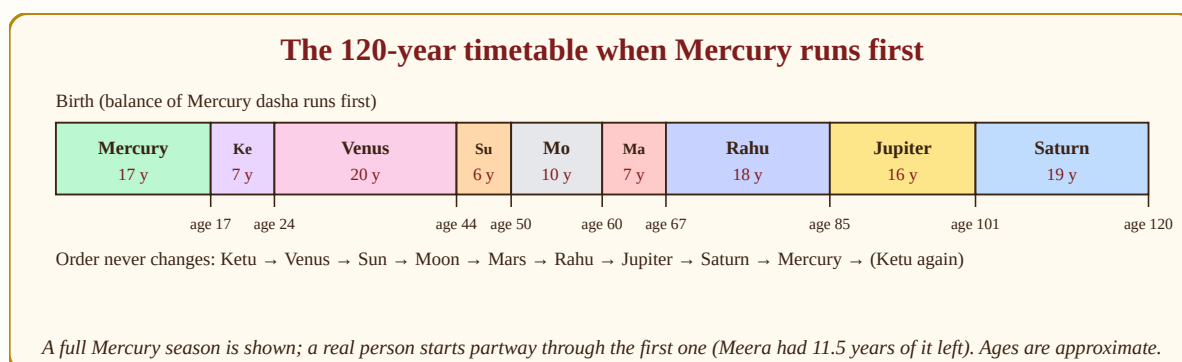


Figure 2.1: The timetable as a bar, for a first season of Mercury. The ages assume a full first season; a real person starts partway through it.

The order that never changes

Ketu, Venus, Sun, Moon, Mars, Rahu, Jupiter, Saturn, Mercury, and then Ketu again. Whatever season you were born into, the next is always the next on this list. Meera was born in a Mercury season, so her life runs Mercury, Ketu, Venus, Sun, Moon. Arjun was born in a Sun season, so his runs Sun, Moon, Mars, Rahu, Jupiter. Same list, different boarding station.

WHY? Here I owe you honesty. The order and the lengths are tradition: Parashara states them and gives no reason, and I have never seen a convincing one. They do not follow the planets' speeds (the Moon, the fastest, gets 10 years; Venus, not much slower, gets 20) or their distance from the Sun. What I can tell you is that the order is ancient, shared by every school of Indian astrology, and consistent: the same nine lords in the same order also label the 27 stars, which is what ties the timetable to the Moon. Everyday parallel: the order of courses at a wedding feast. Nobody can tell you why the sweet comes last, but everyone knows it does, and the whole kitchen is organised around it.

STORY: THE ORDER OF THE PROCESSION. Once a year the court walks in procession through the city, in an order settled so long ago that nobody remembers the quarrel that fixed it. The headless Sadhu goes first, because he wants nothing and cannot be bribed to let anyone ahead. The Minister of Pleasure follows, strewing flowers for a very long way. Then the King, briefly, in full sun. Then the Queen Mother, slow and attentive. The Commander marches past quickly. The Stranger wanders for miles, looking at everything. The Priest walks and teaches. The old Judge walks longest and checks that nothing has been left behind. The young Prince runs alongside, talking, and then the Sadhu is at the front again. A new courtier once asked to change places. The Judge said, "You may change your pace. You may not change your place." **Rule:** the nine seasons always run Ketu, Venus, Sun, Moon, Mars, Rahu, Jupiter, Saturn, Mercury, and then round again.

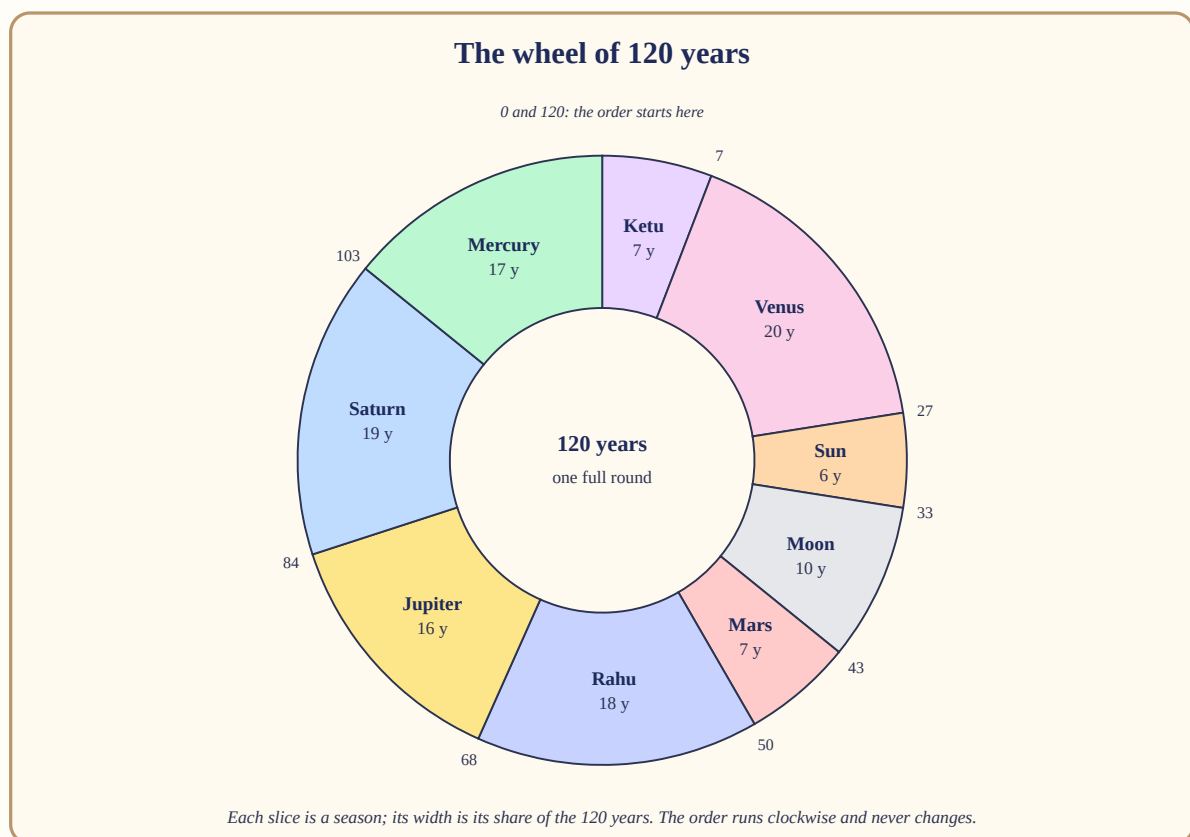


Figure 2.2: The wheel of 120 years. Each slice is a season; the numbers outside are the running total of years.

DID YOU KNOW? Why 120? The texts call it the full span of a human life in our age. Treat it as a convention, like a 100-point exam: the marks are real, the total is a choice.

Where you board: the Moon's star

Now the part that makes the timetable yours. The Moon's path round the sky is divided into 27 equal parts, each 13°20' wide ($360^\circ \div 27$). These are the Moon's stars (the 27 nakshatras), and each has a name and a lord. The lords run in exactly the order you just learned: the first star belongs to Ketu, the second to Venus, the third to the Sun, and so on through Mercury at the ninth. Then the list repeats for stars 10 to 18, and again for 19 to 27. Three rounds of nine. Find the star your Moon was in at birth. Its lord is your first season lord. That is the whole rule.

Your Moon's star chooses your first season: 27 stars, three rounds of nine		
Round 1	Round 2	Round 3
1. Ashwini 0°00' Ar to 13°20' Ar Ketu 7y	10. Magha 0°00' Le to 13°20' Le Ketu 7y	19. Mula 0°00' Sg to 13°20' Sg Ketu 7y
2. Bharani 13°20' Ar to 26°40' Ar Venus 20y	11. Purva Phalguni 13°20' Le to 26°40' Le Venus 20y	20. Purva Ashadha 13°20' Sg to 26°40' Sg Venus 20y
3. Kritika 26°40' Ar to 10°00' Ta Sun 6y	12. Uttara Phalguni 26°40' Le to 10°00' Vi Sun 6y	21. Uttara Ashadha 26°40' Sg to 10°00' Cp Sun 6y
4. Rohini 10°00' Ta to 23°20' Ta Moon 10y	13. Hasta 10°00' Vi to 23°20' Vi Moon 10y	22. Shravana 10°00' Cp to 23°20' Cp Moon 10y
5. Mrigashira 23°20' Ta to 6°40' Ge Mars 7y	14. Chitra 23°20' Vi to 6°40' Li Mars 7y	23. Dhanishta 23°20' Cp to 6°40' Aq Mars 7y
6. Ardra 6°40' Ge to 20°00' Ge Rahu 18y	15. Swati 6°40' Li to 20°00' Li Rahu 18y	24. Shatabhisha 6°40' Aq to 20°00' Aq Rahu 18y
7. Punarvasu 20°00' Ge to 3°20' Cn Jupiter 16y	16. Vishakha 20°00' Li to 3°20' Sc Jupiter 16y	25. Purva Bhadrapada 20°00' Aq to 3°20' Pi Jupiter 16y
8. Pushya 3°20' Cn to 16°40' Cn Saturn 19y	17. Anuradha 3°20' Sc to 16°40' Sc Saturn 19y	26. Uttara Bhadrapada 3°20' Pi to 16°40' Pi Saturn 19y
9. Ashlesha 16°40' Cn to 30°00' Cn Mercury 17y	18. Jyeshtha 16°40' Sc to 30°00' Sc Mercury 17y	27. Revati 16°40' Pi to 30°00' Pi Mercury 17y

Ar Aries, Ta Taurus, Ge Gemini, Cn Cancer, Le Leo, Vi Virgo, Li Libra, Sc Scorpio, Sg Sagittarius, Cp Capricorn, Aq Aquarius, Pi Pisces.

Every star is 13°20' wide. The same nine lords repeat in the same order, three times round the sky.

Figure 2.3: The 27 stars, their spans and the season each one opens. The nine lords repeat three times in the fixed order.

So Ashwini, the first star, opens a Ketu season; Bharani opens Venus; Kritika opens the Sun; and so on to Ashlesha, the ninth, which opens Mercury. Magha, the tenth, starts the round again with Ketu, and Mula, the nineteenth, starts the third round. Appendix A lists all 27 with their spans.

WHY? Two layers again. The astronomy: the Moon takes about 27.3 days to go once round the sky against the stars, so the ancients marked one "resting place" for each night of its journey, and 27 of them fit. The system's own logic: 27 is three times nine, so the nine lords fit the stars exactly, three rounds each, with nothing left over; that neatness is almost certainly why nine lords and 27 stars were married in the first place. Everyday parallel: a nine-day duty rota in a joint family kitchen. Run it three times and the month is covered; whoever's day it is when a guest arrives, that person cooks.

Every chart app prints your Moon's star beside its degree: Meera's is Ashlesha, Arjun's Kritika, Devika's Purva Ashadha.

The balance at birth: how much of the first season was left

Here is the subtlety that trips up almost everyone, and the reason your first season is almost never a full one. The Moon does not usually sit at the very start of its star at birth; it is somewhere inside. And the rule is proportional: **however much of the star the Moon has still to cross, that same fraction of the first season is still to run.** A quarter of the way in, three quarters of the lord's years remain. At the very end, you get a few days of the first season and then the next begins.

Let me walk through Meera's; every app does this sum silently, and you should see it once with the lid off.

- Her Moon is at **21°00' Cancer**, in **Ashlesha**, which runs from 16°40' to 30°00' Cancer and belongs to Mercury.
- Already crossed: 21°00' minus 16°40' = **4°20'**. Still to cross: 30°00' minus 21°00' = **9°00'**.
- As a fraction of the star's 13°20': $9 \div 13.333 = \mathbf{0.675}$, that is 67.5%.
- 67.5% of Mercury's 17 years = **11.475 years**, about 11 years and 6 months.
- Born 12 December 1988, so Mercury's season ends around **June 2000**, and Ketu's seven years begin.

After that, every season is full length: Ketu to June 2007, Venus to June 2027, the Sun to June 2033, and so on down the list.

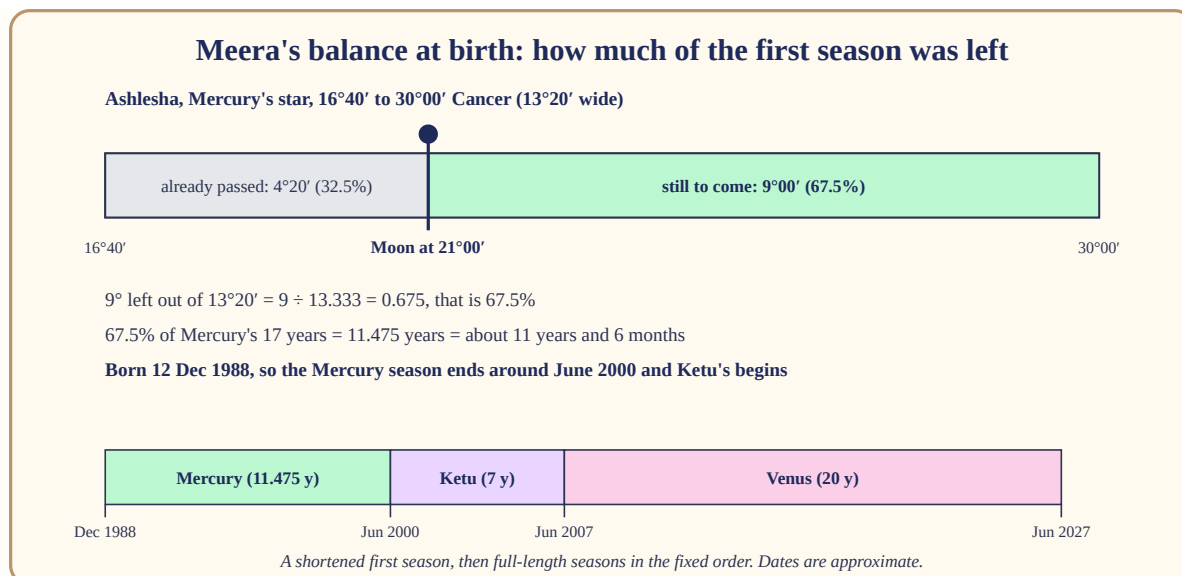


Figure 2.4: Meera's balance at birth. The shaded part of the star is still to come; the same share of Mercury's 17 years is still to run.

WHY? This is the system's own logic, the one piece of the timetable that is pure arithmetic rather than tradition. If the first season did not shrink in proportion, two babies born hours apart in the same star would have identical timetables for life, and the Moon's precise position would mean nothing. The proportional rule makes the exact degree matter, and so makes each timetable personal. Everyday parallel: walking into a film forty minutes late. Your ticket is valid, but you only get the part that is left, and the next show starts on time regardless.

STORY: THE PRINCE'S HALF-FINISHED TERM. A child was born in the palace while the clever young Prince was steward of the household. He had already spent a third of his term; two thirds remained. The nurse asked whether the Prince would start again from the beginning, for the baby's sake. The old Judge, who kept the ledger, shook his head. "The term belongs to the household, not to the child. She joins it where it stands." So the child's first season was the Prince's remaining years, not a day more, and when they ran out the headless Sadhu took the keys exactly on schedule. **Rule:** your first season is only the part of its lord's years still unspent at your birth; the fraction of the star left for the Moon to cross is the fraction of the season left for you.

COMMON MISTAKE: trusting a rough birth time. The Moon moves about 13° a day, roughly half a degree an hour. An hour's error shifts the Moon by about 4% of a star, and so shifts *every changeover in your life* by 4% of the first lord's years: about three months for a Sun start, five for the Moon, eight for Mercury, ten for Venus. If the family says "around six in the morning", give every date a margin of several months and let your own life events tell you which side is right (Chapter 18 shows how).

Finding your seasons in a free app, in five steps

You do not need to do that arithmetic. You need to know it was done.

1. **Collect three facts:** date of birth, time of birth as exactly as possible, and place of birth (town is enough).
2. **Open a free tool.** On Windows, Jagannatha Hora is the professional's workhorse. On a phone, the AstroSage app is easiest. On the web, Drik Panchang has a chart page.
3. **Check two settings.** The zodiac must be sidereal (star-fixed), with Lahiri as the reference point (the standard Indian setting; the technical name is the ayanamsa), and the season system must be the 120-year one (apps call it Vimshottari). These are the defaults in all three tools, but look.
4. **Find the season table.** In Jagannatha Hora it is the "Dasas" tab; click a season to open its sub-seasons. In AstroSage, open your chart and find the "Dasha" tab. In Drik Panchang, the dasha section sits below the chart.
5. **Read the row that contains today's date.** Write down the season lord, its start and end, and the indented sub-season row you are in. Keep this note; the rest of the book talks to it.

Appendix C has more detail for each tool.

IF YOU READ FOR OTHERS: ask for the birth time twice, once at the start and once in passing. People round. "Six o'clock" often turns out to be "before the milk came, maybe quarter to seven". Ask for a photograph of the hospital record when you can.

Which season am I in? A quick table by age

If you have no app to hand, this table gives a rough answer. Find the row for your first season and read along to your age. It assumes a full first season; in real life, subtract the part you missed, which shifts everything earlier.

First season	Ages at which each season runs (full first season assumed)
Ketu	Ketu 0 to 7, Venus 7 to 27, Sun 27 to 33, Moon 33 to 43, Mars 43 to 50, Rahu 50 to 68, Jupiter 68 to 84, Saturn 84 to 103, Mercury 103 to 120
Venus	Venus 0 to 20, Sun 20 to 26, Moon 26 to 36, Mars 36 to 43, Rahu 43 to 61, Jupiter 61 to 77, Saturn 77 to 96, Mercury 96 to 113, Ketu 113 to 120
Sun	Sun 0 to 6, Moon 6 to 16, Mars 16 to 23, Rahu 23 to 41, Jupiter 41 to 57, Saturn 57 to 76, Mercury 76 to 93, Ketu 93 to 100, Venus 100 to 120
Moon	Moon 0 to 10, Mars 10 to 17, Rahu 17 to 35, Jupiter 35 to 51, Saturn 51 to 70, Mercury 70 to 87, Ketu 87 to 94, Venus 94 to 114, Sun 114 to 120
Mars	Mars 0 to 7, Rahu 7 to 25, Jupiter 25 to 41, Saturn 41 to 60, Mercury 60 to 77, Ketu 77 to 84, Venus 84 to 104, Sun 104 to 110, Moon 110 to 120
Rahu	Rahu 0 to 18, Jupiter 18 to 34, Saturn 34 to 53, Mercury 53 to 70, Ketu 70 to 77, Venus 77 to 97, Sun 97 to 103, Moon 103 to 113, Mars 113 to 120
Jupiter	Jupiter 0 to 16, Saturn 16 to 35, Mercury 35 to 52, Ketu 52 to 59, Venus 59 to 79, Sun 79 to 85, Moon 85 to 95, Mars 95 to 102, Rahu 102 to 120
Saturn	Saturn 0 to 19, Mercury 19 to 36, Ketu 36 to 43, Venus 43 to 63, Sun 63 to 69, Moon 69 to 79, Mars 79 to 86, Rahu 86 to 104, Jupiter 104 to 120
Mercury	Mercury 0 to 17, Ketu 17 to 24, Venus 24 to 44, Sun 44 to 50, Moon 50 to 60, Mars 60 to 67, Rahu 67 to 85, Jupiter 85 to 101, Saturn 101 to 120

Look at how different two lives can be. A person who starts in Venus spends childhood and youth in one soft season and meets the first changeover at 20. A person who starts in Ketu or Mars has three changeovers before 35. Neither is better, but the first feels a season ending as a rare, large event and the second as a familiar rhythm.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: a season lasts about as long as it takes to become a different person. Six years changes your job; twenty years changes your face.

In one breath

- Nine planets, nine seasons, fixed lengths: Ketu 7, Venus 20, Sun 6, Moon 10, Mars 7, Rahu 18, Jupiter 16, Saturn 19, Mercury 17; total 120 years.
- The order never changes. Order and lengths are tradition, stated by Parashara without a reason; the arithmetic built on them is exact.

- The Moon's path is cut into 27 stars of $13^{\circ}20'$, labelled by the nine lords three times over; the lord of your Moon's star is your first season lord.
- The first season is cut short in proportion: the fraction of the star still to cross is the fraction of the first lord's years you receive (Meera: 9° of $13^{\circ}20'$, so 67.5% of 17 years, 11.475 years).
- An hour's error in birth time moves every changeover by three to ten months.
- Free tools (Jagannatha Hora, AstroSage, Drik Panchang) show the whole table; check sidereal, Lahiri and the 120-year system, then read the row containing today.
- All dates are approximate.

Try this

TRY THIS:

1. Arjun's Moon is at 6° Taurus, in Kritika ($26^{\circ}40'$ Aries to $10^{\circ}00'$ Taurus, the Sun's star). How much of the star is left, and how long was his Sun season at birth?
2. Devika's Moon is at 14° Sagittarius, in Purva Ashadha ($13^{\circ}20'$ to $26^{\circ}40'$ Sagittarius, Venus's star). Work out her balance of Venus.
3. A friend's Moon was in Rohini and she is 36. Using the quick table, which season is she in (full first season assumed), and which is next?
4. Open a free app, enter your own details, and find your season table. Write down your first season lord, your balance at birth, your current season and the date it ends. Did any changeover fall near a year you already think of as a turning point?

Answers

1. The star ends at $10^{\circ}00'$ Taurus and the Moon is at $6^{\circ}00'$, so 4° of $13^{\circ}20'$ remain: $4 \div 13.333 = 0.30$. Thirty per cent of 6 years is 1.8 years: March 1995 to around December 1996. 2. $12^{\circ}40'$ remain of $13^{\circ}20'$: $12.667 \div 13.333 = 0.95$. Ninety-five per cent of 20 years is 19 years: July 1979 to around July 1998. 3. Rohini is the Moon's star. Moon 0 to 10, Mars 10 to 17, Rahu 17 to 35, Jupiter 35 to 51: at 36 she has just entered Jupiter; Saturn comes at 51. A real balance shifts everything a little earlier. 4. Your own answers. Chapter 3 opens the current season into its sub-seasons.

Chapter 3: Seasons Inside Seasons

The monsoon is one season, but nobody lives through it as one thing. There is the week the first clouds come and everyone is happy. There is the fortnight when the drains fail. There is the long grey middle, the hot break in August, the last heavy burst, the clear light at the end. One season, many weathers.

A planetary season is the same. A twenty-year Venus season is not twenty identical years. It has nine stretches inside it, each with a second courtier beside the first, and the pair together is what you actually live. This chapter shows how those stretches are cut, in what order they run, how to read them off an app, and the two questions that tell you whether a stretch will feel like a help or a test. Then we open Meera's Venus season and watch her marriage arrive on time. Dates, as always, are approximate.



Seasons inside seasons: the season lord runs the house, the sub-season lord runs the kitchen.

The proportional rule

Each season is divided among the nine planets again, in the same order and proportions as the big timetable. These are the **sub-seasons** (antardasha). The rule for their length is one line of arithmetic:

Sub-season of B inside the season of A = (A's years × B's years) ÷ 120.

Inside Venus's 20 years, the Rahu sub-season is $20 \times 18 \div 120 = 3$ years exactly. The Sun sub-season is $20 \times 6 \div 120 = 1$ year. Venus's own is 3 years 4 months. Add all nine and you get 20 years back, because the nine lords' years add to 120. Here is the full table.

Season \ Sub	Ketu	Venus	Sun	Moon	Mars	Rahu	Jupiter	Saturn	Mercury
Ketu (7y)	0y 4m 27d	1y 2m 0d	0y 4m 6d	0y 7m 0d	0y 4m 27d	1y 0m 18d	0y 11m 6d	1y 1m 9d	0y 11m 27d
Venus (20y)	1y 2m 0d	3y 4m 0d	1y 0m 0d	1y 8m 0d	1y 2m 0d	3y 0m 0d	2y 8m 0d	3y 2m 0d	2y 10m 0d
Sun (6y)	0y 4m 6d	1y 0m 0d	0y 3m 18d	0y 6m 0d	0y 4m 6d	0y 10m 24d	0y 9m 18d	0y 11m 12d	0y 10m 6d
Moon (10y)	0y 7m 0d	1y 8m 0d	0y 6m 0d	0y 10m 0d	0y 7m 0d	1y 6m 0d	1y 4m 0d	1y 7m 0d	1y 5m 0d
Mars (7y)	0y 4m 27d	1y 2m 0d	0y 4m 6d	0y 7m 0d	0y 4m 27d	1y 0m 18d	0y 11m 6d	1y 1m 9d	0y 11m 27d
Rahu (18y)	1y 0m 18d	3y 0m 0d	0y 10m 24d	1y 6m 0d	1y 0m 18d	2y 8m 12d	2y 4m 24d	2y 10m 6d	2y 6m 18d
Jupiter (16y)	0y 11m 6d	2y 8m 0d	0y 9m 18d	1y 4m 0d	0y 11m 6d	2y 4m 24d	2y 1m 18d	2y 6m 12d	2y 3m 6d
Saturn (19y)	1y 1m 9d	3y 2m 0d	0y 11m 12d	1y 7m 0d	1y 1m 9d	2y 10m 6d	2y 6m 12d	3y 0m 3d	2y 8m 9d
Mercury (17y)	0y 11m 27d	2y 10m 0d	0y 10m 6d	1y 5m 0d	0y 11m 27d	2y 6m 18d	2y 3m 6d	2y 8m 9d	2y 4m 27d

Table 3.1: Sub-season lengths in years, months and days. Row: season lord. Column: sub-lord.

The table is symmetrical (Venus inside Saturn and Saturn inside Venus are both 3 years 2 months), a handy check when reading an app.

WHY? The system's own logic, pure arithmetic once the lengths are given. Each season is a miniature of the whole 120 years: the same nine courtiers take turns inside it, each taking the same share of it that they take of the whole. Rahu's share of any season is $18 \div 120$, that is 15%. Everyday parallel: a school year is divided into terms, and each term has the same subjects in the same proportions as the year. Maths gets its usual share of a short term and a long one; what changes is how many weeks that share comes to.

The order: the season's own lord goes first

Sub-seasons run in the same fixed order as the seasons, with one twist: the sequence **starts with the season's own lord**. A Venus season opens with Venus/Venus, then Venus/Sun, Venus/Moon, Venus/Mars, Venus/Rahu, Venus/Jupiter, Venus/Saturn, Venus/Mercury, and ends with Venus/Ketu. A Rahu season opens with Rahu/Rahu, then Rahu/Jupiter, and so on round to Rahu/Mars.

So the first stretch of any season is its purest taste: the same courtier holds both keys. And the last sub-season is always run by the planet who walks just ahead of the season lord in the procession; it closes the door for you.

STORY: THE MINISTER TAKES THE FIRST TURN. *When the Minister of Pleasure was given the keys to the household for twenty years, she invited the whole court to serve under her, one at a time. "But I go first," she said, "so that everyone sees how I like things done." For three years and four months she ran the household alone, all music and new curtains. Then the King came to help, for one year, and the house became grander and louder. Then the Queen Mother, then the Commander, each bringing their own manner into her rooms. The old Judge's turn came late and lasted over three years, and the household learned that even the Minister's house has accounts. The headless Sadhu came last and quietly took down the curtains for the King's own term. **Rule:** sub-seasons run in the fixed order, starting with the season's own lord; the first stretch of a season is its purest expression, the last already smells of the changeover.*

The small turns

Each sub-season divides once more, by the same rule and order, into nine smaller stretches (the *pratyantardasha*; I will call them the small turns and mention them only here). A small turn inside Venus/Rahu lasts six weeks to six months. They are useful for one thing: when two readers disagree about whether an event fits a sub-season, the small turn often settles it. Do not live at this level. A season is a chapter, a sub-season a scene; the small turns are sentences, and nobody plans a life sentence by sentence.

How to read a dasha table from software

Open the table you found in Chapter 2. Every app shapes it the same way.

- The **top level** rows are the seasons, with start and end dates; most apps label them "MD".
- Expand a season and nine **indented** rows appear: the sub-seasons ("AD"). The first carries the season lord's own name.
- A third indentation, if shown, is the small turns ("PD"). Collapse it.

- A pair like "**Venus/Rahu**" or "**Ve-Ra**" always means season first, sub-season second: the weather of the decade, then of the year.

Find today. Note the season, the sub-season, and how long until it ends.

COMMON MISTAKE: reading the sub-season as if it were the season. If an app says "Saturn" in an indented row under "Venus", you are in a Venus season with a Saturn flavour for about three years. People who read only the indented row frighten themselves nine times per season.

The changeovers: sensitive stretches

Every line where one lord hands over to another is a **changeover** (dasha sandhi), and the months on either side are the stretches most worth watching. The changeover between two *seasons* is the big one; Chapter 15 is devoted to it. But each sub-season has its own smaller changeover, and these too are often the weeks when things happen: the job offer, the argument, the move.

WHY? Tradition and the system's logic together. The tradition treats the junction of two periods as unsteady, the way a turning tide makes confused water. The logic: at a changeover two courtiers are in the room at once, one packing and one unpacking, and neither fully runs the household. Everyday parallel: the fortnight when a new manager takes over your office. The old one has stopped deciding, the new one has not started, and that is when the strange emails arrive.

The two questions for any sub-season

Nine sub-seasons per season, nine seasons: eighty-one pairs. Two questions sort almost all of them.

Question one: is the sub-lord a friend of the season lord? The nine planets have fixed friendships, not always mutual. Parashara gives them for the seven; for Rahu and Ketu the tradition uses a working convention (Rahu is friendly to Venus, Saturn and Mercury, hostile to the Sun, Moon and Mars; Ketu is friendly to Mars, Venus and Saturn, hostile to the Sun and Moon). Read along the season lord's row in the grid to the sub-lord's column. A friend works with the season lord; a stranger pulls against it.

Friend or stranger? The season lord (row) looks at the sub-lord (column)									
Season lord	Sun	Moon	Mars	Mercury	Jupiter	Venus	Saturn	Rahu	Ketu
Sun	itself	●	●	◐	●	○	○	○	○
Moon	●	itself	◐	●	◐	◐	◐	○	○
Mars	●	●	itself	○	●	◐	◐	○	●
Mercury	●	○	◐	itself	◐	●	◐	●	◐
Jupiter	●	●	●	○	itself	○	◐	◐	◐
Venus	○	○	◐	●	◐	itself	●	●	●
Saturn	○	○	○	●	◐	●	itself	●	●
Rahu	○	○	○	●	◐	●	●	itself	◐
Ketu	○	○	●	◐	◐	●	●	◐	itself

● friend: the sub-lord works with the season lord
 ◐ neutral: neither helps nor hinders by itself
 ○ stranger: the sub-lord is not friendly to the season lord; Rahu and Ketu by the common working convention. The diagonal is the planet's own sub-season.

Figure 3.1: Friend or stranger? Read the season lord's row, then the sub-lord's column. Filled circle: friend. Half circle: neutral. Empty circle: stranger. A planet's own sub-season doubles whatever that planet is for you.

Question two: where does the sub-lord sit, counted from the season lord? Call the season lord's room the first and count round to the sub-lord's room. If it is the **6th, 8th or 12th**, that sub-season tends to pull against the season: delays, friction, a change of direction you did not ask for. I call these the **wrong rooms**: the three hard rooms of any chart (dusthana), counted afresh from the season lord instead of from the rising sign. The 1st, 5th and 9th are the lucky rooms, where the two work together easily. The pillar rooms (4th, 7th, 10th) are steady; the 2nd, 3rd and 11th are gains and effort.

Counting rooms from the season lord: the 6th, 8th and 12th are the wrong rooms											
Meera's chart: Venus sits in room 12, so room 12 is the 1st counted from Venus, room 1 is the 2nd, and so on round the circle.											
1st room 12 Venus	2nd room 1 Sun Mercury	3rd room 2 Saturn	4th room 3	5th room 4 Rahu	6th room 5 Mars	7th room 6	8th room 7 Jupiter	9th room 8	10th room 9 Moon	11th room 10 Ketu	12th room 11

■ 6th, 8th, 12th from the season lord: the wrong rooms. Here Mars (6th) and Jupiter (8th).
 ■ 1st, 5th, 9th from the season lord: the lucky rooms. Here Rahu sits in the 5th, and her marriage came in Venus/Rahu.

The 4th, 7th and 10th are pillar rooms (steady); 2nd, 3rd and 11th are gains and effort; all count from the season lord, not from the rising sign.

The same twelve rooms, counted afresh from wherever the season lord stands.

Figure 3.2: Counting from the season lord. Meera's Venus sits in room 12, so her Mars (room 5) is 6th from it, her Jupiter (room 7) 8th, her Rahu (room 4) 5th.

WHY? The system's own logic. The 6th, 8th and 12th rooms of a chart are the rooms of struggle, upheaval and loss; that much is Book 1. The season system says: for the length of a season, the season lord is the centre of the chart, so count the rooms from it. A sub-lord in the 8th from the season lord is to that season what the 8th room is to a life: where the ground shifts. Everyday parallel: in a joint family, where a visiting relative sleeps matters. Next to the kitchen, the household runs; in the store-room at the back, there is friction every day through nobody's fault.

STORY: THE GUEST IN THE WRONG ROOM. The Minister of Pleasure was running the household when the Commander's turn came to serve beside her. The two had always been civil. But his quarters lay in the sixth room from hers, past the kitchens, and every morning he marched through her music-room in boots to reach the door. Within a month the musicians had left and the Minister had a headache. "It is not that he is bad," she told the Queen Mother. "It is where he lives." When the Stranger's turn came, he lodged in the fifth room from hers, with a window onto the same garden, and they got on so well that there was a wedding. **Rule:** count the sub-lord's room from the season lord's; the 6th, 8th and 12th pull against the season, the 1st, 5th and 9th pull with it, whatever the planets' temperaments.

These two questions are a first sieve, not a verdict; Part III adds the third layer, whether the sub-lord is on your side by your rising sign and how strong it is.

Worked: Meera's Venus season, opened

Meera's Venus season runs from June 2007 to June 2027, age 18½ to 38½. Here it is, opened into nine sub-seasons, with the two questions answered. Venus sits in her room 12 (Libra, its own sign), so we count from there.

Sub-season	From	To	Friend of Venus?	Room from Venus	First impression
Venus/Venus	Jun 2007	Oct 2010	itself	1st	☛ Venus doubled
Venus/Sun	Oct 2010	Oct 2011	☉ stranger	2nd ●	☛ mixed
Venus/Moon	Oct 2011	Jun 2013	☾ stranger	10th ●	☛ mixed
Venus/Mars	Jun 2013	Aug 2014	☛ neutral	6th ☉	☉ pulls against
Venus/Rahu	Aug 2014	Jul 2017	● friend	5th ●	● works with
Venus/Jupiter	Jul 2017	Mar 2020	☛ neutral	8th ☉	☉ pulls against
Venus/Saturn	Mar 2020	May 2023	● friend	3rd ●	● works with
Venus/Mercury	May 2023	Mar 2026	● friend	2nd ●	● works with
Venus/Ketu	Mar 2026	May 2027	● friend	11th ●	● closes the door

Table 3.3: Meera's Venus sub-seasons with the two questions.

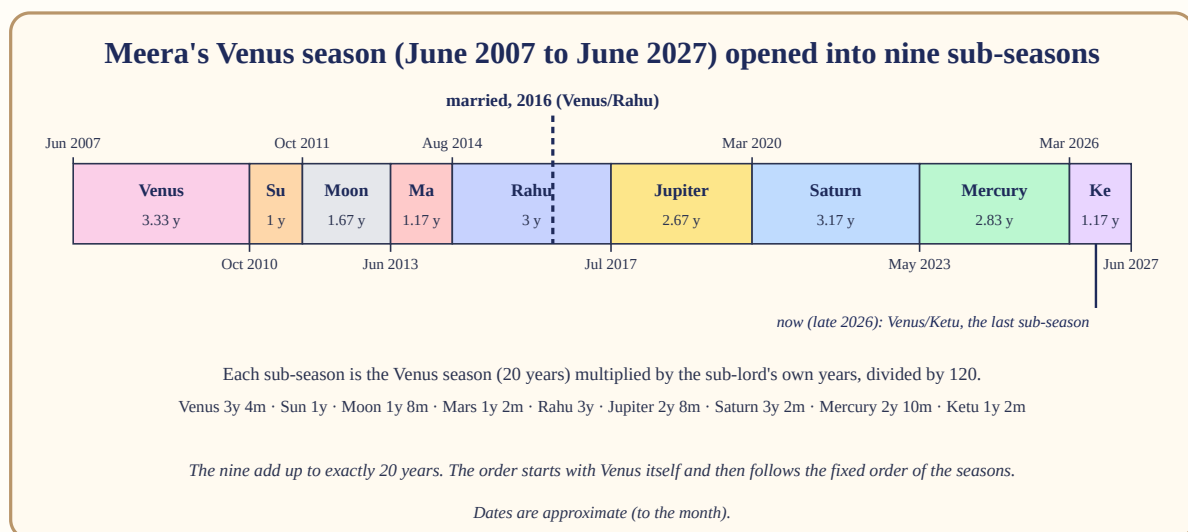


Figure 3.3: Meera's Venus season as a timeline. The marriage falls inside Venus/Rahu; late 2026 sits in Venus/Ketu, the last sub-season.

Now the row that matters most. **Venus/Rahu, August 2014 to July 2017.** Rahu is a friend of Venus. Rahu sits in Meera's room 4, the 5th counted from Venus in room 12: a lucky room. Both questions say "works with". And Venus, for a Scorpio rising sign, owns room 7, the room of marriage, as well as room 12. A marriage-owning season lord, in a sub-season run by a friendly planet in a lucky room from it: if you had to pick three years out of twenty for Meera's wedding, you would pick these. She married in 2016, in the middle of them. A season map cannot tell you the day; it can tell you which three years out of twenty to look at.

Two honest footnotes. Venus/Mars and Venus/Jupiter both land in wrong rooms, and Chapter 5 shows they were restless stretches, though Jupiter is strongly on her side, which softened it. And Venus/Saturn passes

both quick tests, yet Chapter 5 treats 2020 to 2023 as her testing stretch, because Saturn mildly tests her by rising sign and is outshone by the Sun in her chart. The two questions are the first sieve; the chart is the second.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: say the pair out loud with "in" between: "Rahu in Venus's household." The host sets the menu; the guest sets the mood.

IF YOU READ FOR OTHERS: when someone asks "what is coming?", point to the sub-season rows, not the season row. Three years is a length a person can plan around. Twenty is a wall.

In one breath

- Every season divides into nine sub-seasons by one rule: $(\text{season lord's years} \times \text{sub-lord's years}) \div 120$; the nine add back to the season's length.
- Sub-seasons run in the fixed order, starting with the season's own lord; the first stretch is the purest taste of a season, the last already belongs to the changeover.
- Each sub-season divides again into nine small turns; use them to settle a dispute, never to live by.
- In any app, the outer row is the season (MD), the indented row the sub-season (AD); Venus/Rahu is always season first, sub-season second.
- The junction between any two lords is a changeover and a sensitive stretch.
- Two questions sort most sub-seasons: is the sub-lord a friend of the season lord, and does it sit in the 6th, 8th or 12th room counted from the season lord?
- Meera's marriage came in Venus/Rahu (August 2014 to July 2017): friend, lucky room, marriage-owning season lord. All dates approximate.

Try this

TRY THIS:

1. How long is the Jupiter sub-season inside a Rahu season? Work it out from the rule, then check Table 3.1.
2. Arjun's Rahu season runs December 2013 to December 2031. Which sub-season runs in late 2026? (Starts: Rahu/Ketu Jun 2024, Rahu/Venus Jul 2025, Rahu/Sun Jul 2028.)
3. In Arjun's chart Rahu sits in room 4 and Venus in room 7. Counting from Rahu, which room is Venus in, and is Venus a friend of Rahu? What is your first impression?
4. Open your own table, find your current sub-season, and answer the two questions. Then write one sentence about what this stretch has actually felt like. Do they agree?

Answers

1. $18 \times 16 \div 120 = 2.4$ years = 2 years 4 months 24 days, as in Table 3.1. 2. Rahu/Venus, from July 2025 to July 2028. 3. Room 4 is the 1st from Rahu, room 7 the 4th: a pillar room, steady. Rahu counts Venus a friend. First impression: works with the season (Chapter 9 adds the chart's view, since Venus tests Arjun by rising sign). 4. Your own answers. If they disagree, Part III usually explains why.

Chapter 4: The Ketu Season (7 Years): The Art of Letting Go

There is a moment in every Indian wedding that nobody photographs. The band has packed up, the last relatives have been seen off, the hall is full of folding chairs and marigold petals, and someone has to stay behind to count the steel plates. That moment is what a Ketu season feels like from the inside, and it is why so many people tell me, halfway through one, that "nothing is happening in my life".

Something is happening. It is just not the kind of thing that photographs well.

Ketu's season lasts seven years. In the royal court, Ketu is the headless Sadhu, the renouncer at the gate who wants nothing. When he runs the household, the household learns to want less. Possessions, titles, friendships and plans that were never truly yours fall away, often without drama. What is left is lighter, and more honestly you. All dates in this chapter are approximate; a free app may show a month or two of difference.



The Ketu season in three panels.

The headless Sadhu runs the household

STORY: THE SADHU TAKES THE KEYS. When it was Ketu's turn to run the palace, the courtiers panicked. Who would arrange the feasts, plan the campaigns, keep the accounts? The Sadhu said nothing, having no head to speak with, and simply walked through the palace opening windows. Within a year the storerooms were half empty, the guest list short, and the King's youngest daughter sat in the courtyard reading manuscripts nobody had opened in decades. "Nothing is being done," the courtiers complained. The Queen Mother disagreed. "Everything that did not matter is being put down," she said, "so that our hands are free when the Minister of Pleasure returns." **Rule:** Ketu's season does not build; it clears. Judge it by what you have put down, not by what you have picked up.

What the season asks is one thing, repeated in different rooms of your life: let go of what is finished. The task can arrive gently (a hobby you no longer enjoy) or sharply (a job that ends). Ketu also pulls you inward: solitude, research, spiritual practice, meaning. People in Ketu seasons take up meditation, go deep into one subject, or simply spend more time alone than ever.

WHY? Astronomy first, then tradition. Rahu and Ketu are not bodies in the sky but the two points where the Moon's path crosses the Sun's, which is why eclipses happen only near them. In the old story the demon who stole the nectar of immortality was cut in two: Rahu kept the head, forever hungry, and Ketu kept the body, which cannot eat, speak or want. Tradition gave the south crossing-point that body, so Ketu is the planet of what is done with wanting. Everyday parallel: a retired uncle who has given away his good shirts and sits on the verandah content while the house runs around him. He is not idle; he has finished.

How it feels

Body. Puzzling, hard-to-name complaints: tiredness without cause, sensitivity to noise and crowds. See a doctor early about anything that lingers.

Mind. Detached, sometimes to the point of numbness; people describe watching their own life "from a little distance". Deep concentration becomes easy, small talk nearly impossible. Intuition sharpens.

Home. The house empties in some way: a sibling leaves for college, a grandparent's room becomes a store room. The family WhatsApp group goes unanswered for days.

Love. Ketu removes the hunger from love. Relationships built on need tend to end; those built on companionship deepen quietly.

Work. Visibility drops. You step back from a leading role, or the ladder you were climbing stops interesting you. Research, archives and solitary depth go well.

Money. Flat: rarely loss, rarely growth. Expenses shrink because wants shrink.

The arc: first year, middle, last year

The first year (Ketu's own sub-season, under five months, then Venus's) is the strangest. The previous season's energy is still in the room and Ketu is opening windows. Things end abruptly. People mistake this for bad luck. It is clearing.

The middle years settle into the Sadhu's rhythm. Life becomes smaller and deeper. The research gets done, the practice takes root, the real friends are counted. It can be lonely. It is also, for many, the first time they hear their own thoughts.

The last year is Mercury's sub-season, and the clever Prince chatters again. Curiosity and plans return and Venus's twenty-year season starts to glimmer. Do not grab the first bright thing that passes.

When Ketu is on your side and when it tests you

Ketu owns no sign, so the usual question ("which rooms does this planet own?") has no direct answer. The common rule, and the one I follow, is that **Ketu takes the colour of the lord of the sign it sits in, and of any planet it sits with**. Ketu in Leo behaves as the Sun does for your rising sign; Ketu beside Jupiter borrows Jupiter's manners.

WHY? This is the system's own logic rather than a rule from Parashara, who says little about the shadow planets. A planet with no home of its own has nothing to express but its landlord's intentions. Everyday parallel: a tenant in a joint family's spare room is judged by the family he lives with; in a kind household he is a blessing, in a quarrelling one he joins the quarrel.

So the table reads: for your rising sign, Ketu is on your side in these signs and tests you in those.

Rising sign	● On your side in	○ Tests you in	● Mixed in
Aries	Leo, Aries, Scorpio, Sagittarius, Pisces	Gemini, Virgo, Taurus, Libra, Capricorn, Aquarius	Cancer
Taurus	Capricorn, Aquarius, Leo, Gemini, Virgo	Cancer, Sagittarius, Pisces, Aries, Scorpio	Taurus, Libra
Gemini	Taurus, Libra, Capricorn, Aquarius, Gemini, Virgo	Aries, Scorpio, Sagittarius, Pisces, Leo	Cancer
Cancer	Aries, Scorpio, Sagittarius, Pisces, Cancer	Taurus, Libra, Gemini, Virgo	Leo, Capricorn, Aquarius
Leo	Aries, Scorpio, Sagittarius, Pisces, Leo	Gemini, Virgo, Taurus, Libra, Capricorn, Aquarius	Cancer
Virgo	Taurus, Libra, Gemini, Virgo	Aries, Scorpio, Sagittarius, Pisces, Cancer	Leo, Capricorn, Aquarius
Libra	Capricorn, Aquarius, Gemini, Virgo, Taurus, Libra	Sagittarius, Pisces, Leo, Aries, Scorpio	Cancer
Scorpio	Sagittarius, Pisces, Cancer, Leo, Aries, Scorpio	Gemini, Virgo, Taurus, Libra, Capricorn, Aquarius	(none)
Sagittarius	Leo, Aries, Scorpio, Sagittarius, Pisces	Taurus, Libra, Capricorn, Aquarius	Gemini, Virgo, Cancer
Capricorn	Taurus, Libra, Gemini, Virgo, Capricorn, Aquarius	Aries, Scorpio, Sagittarius, Pisces, Cancer	Leo
Aquarius	Taurus, Libra, Capricorn, Aquarius	Sagittarius, Pisces, Cancer, Aries, Scorpio	Gemini, Virgo, Leo
Pisces	Aries, Scorpio, Cancer, Sagittarius, Pisces	Capricorn, Aquarius, Taurus, Libra, Leo, Gemini, Virgo	(none)

Even a friendly Ketu season clears. It just clears the right things, leaving relief rather than loss.

The room Ketu sits in changes the story

Room	What the seven years tend to clear and deepen
1	You stop performing yourself; a quieter, odder, more honest person comes forward.
2	Family ties loosen, speech grows sparse, savings stay flat but wants shrink to match.
3	Effort for its own sake feels empty until one pursuit proves worth it.
4	The home empties or changes; peace is found after the furniture goes; mother may need care.
5	Studies turn inward and specialised; romance goes cool; children teach patience.
6	Old quarrels and debts quietly end; good for healing work and daily service.
7	Partnerships are tested by distance or silence; two people learn to be alone together.
8	The natural research room: deep study, hidden matters, slow inner transformation.
9	Faith is questioned and rebuilt; a teacher is found, or outgrown.
10	You step off the stage; work moves behind the scenes; the career path dissolves and re-forms.
11	The friends circle shrinks to the few who matter; income steady, wishes change.
12	The Sadhu in his own room: retreats, far places, dreams; the most natural seat for him.

The sub-seasons that matter most

Chapter 3 gave you two questions for any sub-season: is its planet a friend of the season's planet, and where does it sit counted from it? In the 6th, 8th or 12th room from Ketu it works from the wrong room, and even a helpful planet delivers late, sideways, or through a loss.

WHY? The system's own logic, following Parashara's rule for judging sub-seasons. The three hard rooms of any chart are the 6th, 8th and 12th (struggle, upheaval, loss). Counting them from the season's planet asks: from where the season lord stands, is this sub-lord in a place of struggle, upheaval or loss? Everyday parallel: a good colleague in another building. The help is real, but it arrives by email, a day late.

Ketu/Venus (fourteen months). The Minister of Pleasure visits the Sadhu, and they are friends. Comfort, affection and a little beauty return. If Venus is on your side, this is the sweet spot of the season; if Venus tests you, it brings a tempting attachment the season will later ask you to release.

STORY: THE SADHU AND THE MINISTER OF PLEASURE. *The Minister of Pleasure arrived at the Sadhu's bare courtyard with musicians and sweets. He could not eat them, having no mouth, but he did not send her away. He let her hang one lamp, plant one jasmine bush, and sit with him in the evenings. When she left she took the musicians but left the jasmine. Rule: Venus inside Ketu brings a small, real comfort. Keep the jasmine; do not try to keep the band.*

Ketu/Rahu (a year and eighteen days). The two halves of the severed demon face each other, always exactly opposite in the sky. The restless stretch: a sudden craving, a new gadget, confusion about what you want. Rahu is always the 7th room from Ketu, never a wrong room, but a loud one.

STORY: THE TWO STRANGERS FACE EACH OTHER. *Once a year the Sadhu and the smoke-headed Stranger must share a corridor. The Stranger talks all night about distant cities and new machines; the Sadhu cannot answer, and cannot leave. By morning the Stranger has sold him a telescope. Rule: In Ketu/Rahu, sleep on every purchase and every plan for a month. The hunger is borrowed and will pass.*

Ketu/Saturn (thirteen months). The old Judge audits a house that owns almost nothing. Saturn and Ketu are friendly by convention, so the audit is fair, but slow and heavy: duty, work, the feeling of being tested by time.

Ketu/Mercury (the closing year). The Prince chatters, plans and studies. On your side, Mercury ends the season in a clear decision; testing you, in a crowd of options. Either way, it is the bridge to Venus.

What to do and what not to do

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: In a Ketu season, ask of every attachment, "Is this finished?" If the honest answer is yes, let the season take it. If no, hold it gently and expect the season to test the grip.

Do keep one steady daily practice: a walk, a prayer, a page of writing, ten minutes of sitting quietly. **Do** take up the deep subject that keeps calling. **Do** serve someone quietly; feeding animals and caring for the elderly are traditional Ketu practices, and they work because they teach the hands to give without expecting.

Do not start large, shiny ventures expecting the season to feed them; wait for Venus. **Do not** buy a stone because a stranger frightened you about Ketu. **Do not** confuse detachment with depression; if the numbness comes with sleeplessness, hopelessness or no interest in anything at all, that is a medical matter, not a planetary one. See a doctor.

COMMON MISTAKE: Reading "nothing happened in my Ketu years" as the season failing. Look again at what ended, what you stopped wanting, and what you learned to do alone. That record is usually long.

Meera's Ketu season: June 2000 to June 2007

Meera, our Chart A, was born in Jaipur in December 1988 with Scorpio rising. Her Ketu sits at 16° Leo in her 10th room, the room of career, visibility and standing. Leo is the Sun's sign, and the Sun is on her side for Scorpio rising, so her Ketu borrows a friendly colour. Her Ketu season ran from around June 2000 (age eleven and a half) to around June 2007 (eighteen and a half): the whole of her secondary schooling.

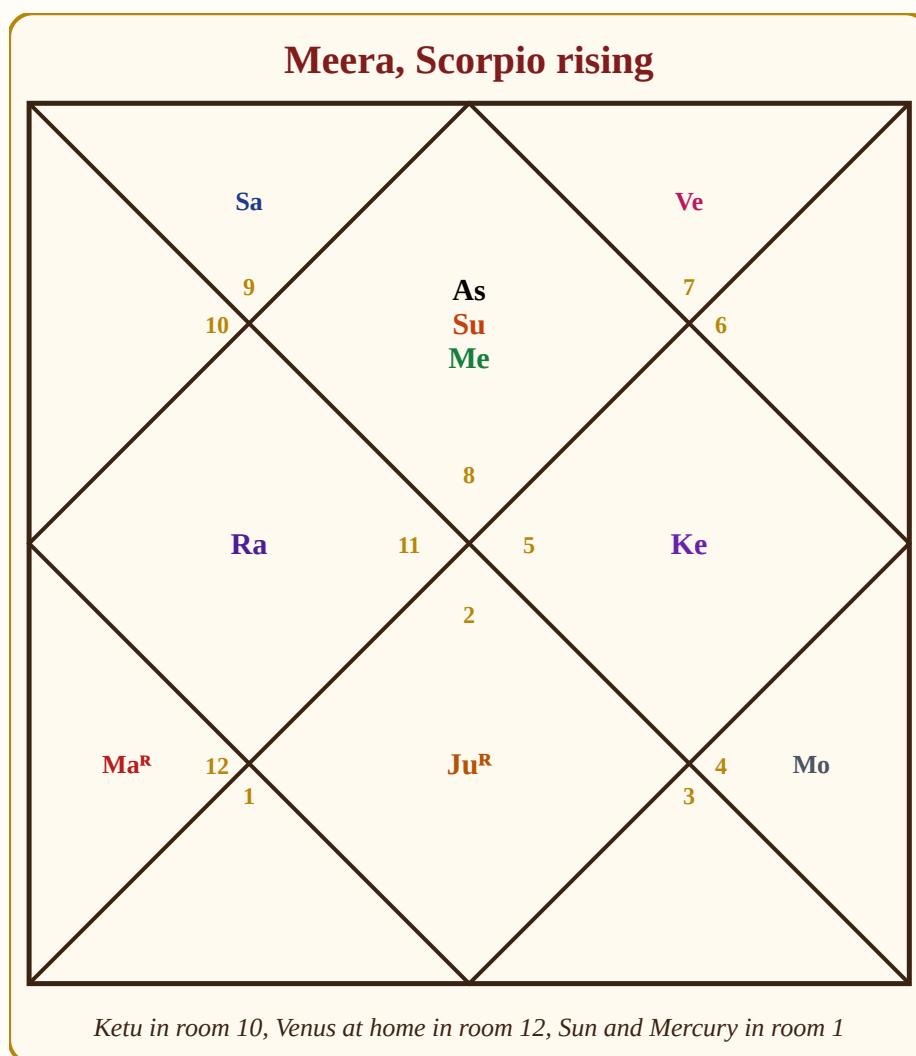


Figure 4.1: Meera's chart. Ketu (Ke) sits in room 10, the career room, in Leo, the Sun's sign. Her Moon is in Cancer in room 9.

Two things coloured these years. The first is Ketu in the 10th room: this was a girl who stepped back from the stage, refusing the annual-day play for the library. The second is that Saturn's seven and a half years (Saturn passing over the sign before her Moon, her Moon's sign of Cancer, and the sign after) overlapped the

whole Ketu season, around 2000 to 2007. The Sadhu's quiet was weighted by the Judge's seriousness; she was, by her own account, an old child.

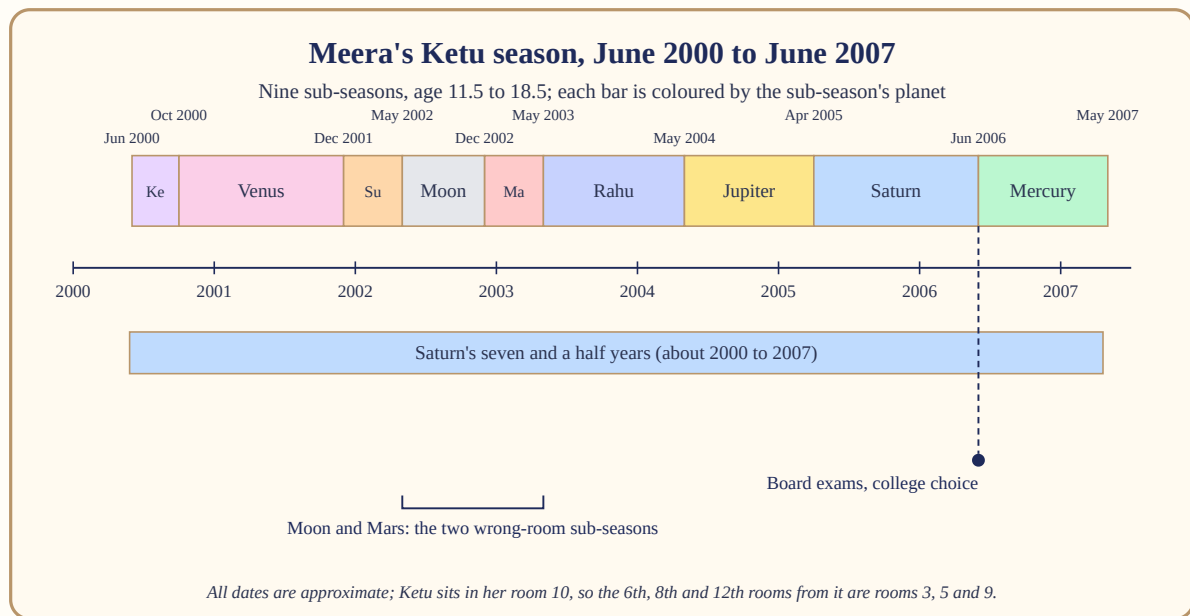


Figure 4.2: Meera's Ketu season, around June 2000 to June 2007, with Saturn's seven and a half years running underneath it the whole way.

Now the wrong-room count. From Ketu in room 10, the 6th, 8th and 12th rooms are her rooms 3, 5 and 9. Her Mars sits in room 5 and her Moon in room 9. So **Ketu/Moon (around May to December 2002)** and **Ketu/Mars (around December 2002 to May 2003)** were her two wrong-room sub-seasons, even though both planets are on her side. She was thirteen and a half to fourteen and a half: a year in which home felt far away (the Moon, from the 12th counted from Ketu) and energy came in bursts she did not know what to do with (Mars, from the 8th). The help those planets carry was real, but it arrived late and sideways, exactly as the rule says.

Ketu/Rahu (around May 2003 to May 2004) brought the first computer into the house (Rahu in her 4th room, the home, in Aquarius, Saturn's sign of machines) and the restless curiosity of the two strangers facing each other. **Ketu/Jupiter (around May 2004 to April 2005)** was gentler: Jupiter is on her side and sits in room 7, the 10th counted from Ketu, and this was the year a teacher noticed her and her Class 10 results surprised everyone but him. **Ketu/Saturn (around April 2005 to June 2006)** was the heavy year of Class 11, a demanding stream chosen under family pressure (Saturn in her 2nd room, the family room, outshone by the Sun). **Ketu/Mercury (around June 2006 to May 2007)**, the closing year, was board exams and entrance season, Mercury in her 1st room chattering about options. The changeover to Venus around June 2007 took her out of Jaipur to college, where the next chapter begins.

What did seven years of Ketu give her? A habit of solitude, a comfort with silence, and a very short list of real friends. Nothing happened, her relatives would say. Everything that mattered later was planted.

In one breath

- Ketu, the headless Sadhu, runs a seven-year season whose task is letting go of what is finished; it clears rather than builds.
- It feels detached, quiet and inward: visibility drops, wants shrink, depth and solitude come easily.
- The first year ends things abruptly, the middle years deepen, the last year (Mercury's sub-season) brings curiosity back.
- Ketu owns no sign, so it takes the colour of its sign's lord and of any planet it sits with.
- The room Ketu sits in says which part of life is cleared; a sub-season's planet in the 6th, 8th or 12th room counted from Ketu works from the wrong room.
- Meera's Ketu season (around June 2000 to June 2007) was her secondary schooling, weighted by Saturn's seven and a half years, and planted the habits her later life grew from.

Try this

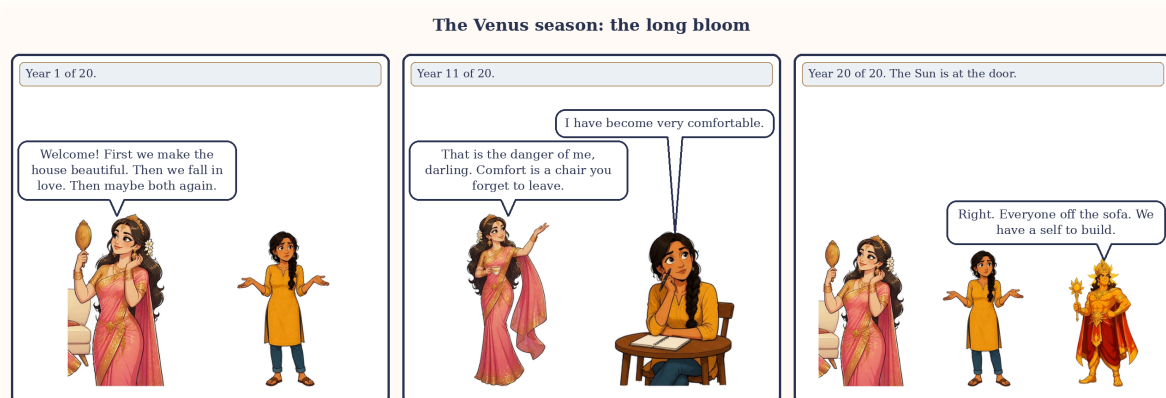
1. Open your season map in a free app and find your Ketu season. Note its start and end years and your ages at each.
2. Find Ketu's sign in your chart and look it up in the rising-sign table. Is Ketu on your side, testing you, or mixed?
3. If you have lived through a Ketu season, list three things that ended in it and three that began quietly. Which list mattered more?
4. Count the 6th, 8th and 12th rooms from your Ketu's room. Which planets sit there? Mark those wrong-room sub-seasons on your map.

Chapter 5: The Venus Season (20 Years): The Long Bloom

Twenty years. Say it slowly. A child who enters a Venus season in Class 1 leaves it with a job. A woman who enters it at thirty leaves it at fifty. Nobody is the same person at both ends of twenty years, and that is the first thing to understand: this season is not an event, it is a climate. You will remember your twenties, your marriage, your first house, and only later notice that one courtier was running the household the whole time.

In the royal court Venus is the Minister of Pleasure, who arranges the music, the weddings, the comfort and the beauty of the palace. When she runs the household, life softens and fills: love, marriage, money through taste, good food, friendships, art. The season asks something that sounds easy and is not: to enjoy without drowning, to receive without going soft.

This chapter follows the long bloom through its arc and its sharp corners, and then through Meera's own Venus season, around June 2007 to around June 2027, which is in its closing year as I write. All dates here are approximate; a free app may differ by a month or two.



The Venus season in three panels.

The Minister of Pleasure runs the household

STORY: THE MINISTER HANGS THE LAMPS. *The Sadhu left the palace bare, and the Minister of Pleasure walked in behind him with a long list. She hung lamps in every corridor, planted the courtyard, hired musicians and sent for the cooks. Within three years the palace was full of guests, laughter and the smell of ghee. The old Judge grumbled about the bills. But the Queen Mother noticed that the courtiers were kinder, marriages were being arranged, and the treasury, oddly, was growing, because people like to pay a house that makes them welcome. "Twenty years of this," said the Judge. "Yes," said the Minister, "and you will have to find your own way not to get fat."* **Rule:** Venus's season fills the house. The task is to keep your shape inside the abundance.

What does the season ask? To open. To let yourself be loved, to make things beautiful, to earn through what gives people pleasure, and to build the partnerships, especially marriage, that most people build in this stretch. It also asks for taste: choosing among many good things rather than grabbing all of them.

WHY? Tradition and the system's own logic together. Parashara makes Venus a minister, the adviser who knows what people want. Venus owns Taurus (food, wealth, the face, the voice) and Libra (balance, the scales, partnership), so by the system's logic her season turns on comfort and on the other person. Everyday parallel: the aunt who runs every family wedding. She knows which caterer, which sari shop, which cousins must be kept apart; the wedding is beautiful because of her, and so is the bill.

How it feels

Body. Softer. Weight tends to come on; skin and hair often improve; the appetite for sweets and rest grows. Take care of the kidneys, lower back and reproductive system, Venus's territory.

Mind. Agreeable, aesthetic, a little lazy. You care more about harmony than winning; decisions get made to keep the peace. Creativity flows if given a channel.

Home. Fills up: furniture, guests, a better flat, a car, curtains that match. People in Venus seasons buy things for the house without noticing.

Love. The season's heart. Most people who marry do so in a Venus season or sub-season. Romance comes easily; so does the temptation to stay in a comfortable relationship that is not right.

Work. Smoother than it is productive. You are liked; promotions come through relationships as much as results. Beauty, design, hospitality, food, fashion, film and finance do especially well.

Money. Grows, and goes. Venus earns well and spends well; the savings at the end depend on whether Saturn's sub-season taught you discipline.

The arc: first years, middle, last year

The first three years and four months are Venus's own sub-season, the longest opening of any season. The house fills: new friends, new comforts, often a first love. It feels like spring after Ketu's winter, and people overspend on everything, including affection.

The middle is where the twenty years earn their reputation. Rahu's three years bring appetite and often the marriage itself. Jupiter's two years and eight months bring children, faith, growth. Saturn's three years and two months arrive around the fourteenth year and sober everyone up: the bill for the bloom is presented, and the real character of the season is decided.

The last year and two months belong to Ketu, and the Sadhu starts opening the windows again. Attachments loosen. People feel restless, done with comfort, ready for something sharper: the Sun's season, which asks who you are when the comfort is taken away.

WHY TWENTY YEARS? Honestly: tradition gives the length and no reason. The nine lengths add to 120 and come down from Parashara without an astronomical explanation. I will not invent one. Everyday parallel: nobody knows why a cricket over is six balls; it simply is, and the game is built around it.

When Venus is on your side and when it tests you

Venus is gentle by nature, but whether she helps or tests you depends on which two rooms she owns for your rising sign. Parashara's rule, explained in full in Book 1: the lord of rooms 1, 5 or 9 is on your side; the lord of 3, 6 or 11 tests you; the lord of a pillar room (4, 7, 10) is neutral unless the other room decides; the lord of 2, 8 or 12 goes by its other sign.

Rising sign	Venus	Rooms Venus owns for you
Aries	○ Tests you	2 and 7
Taurus	● Mixed	1 and 6
Gemini	● On your side	5 and 12
Cancer	○ Tests you	4 and 11
Leo	○ Tests you	3 and 10
Virgo	● On your side, your best planet	2 and 9
Libra	● On your side	1 and 8
Scorpio	○ Tests you	7 and 12
Sagittarius	○ Tests you	6 and 11
Capricorn	● On your side, your best planet	5 and 10
Aquarius	● On your side, your best planet	4 and 9
Pisces	○ Tests you	3 and 8

A Venus that tests you does not take love away. She still brings the wedding, with complications, costs or lessons attached. A Venus on your side brings the same wedding and pays for it.

The room Venus sits in changes the story

Room	What the twenty years tend to fill
1	Charm and good looks; you are liked everywhere and a little vain.
2	Money through taste or voice; family comfort grows; watch sweets and spending.
3	The arts, writing, music, short travels; a sibling's wedding; courage through charm.
4	A house bought or made beautiful, a car, mother's comfort; Venus's strongest seat.
5	Romance, creative flowering, the joys of children.
6	Love found through work or service; comfort that costs health; debts from luxury.
7	The natural marriage room; partnerships prosper; the public likes you.
8	Love with secrets; money through a partner or inheritance; intense attachments.
9	Luck through a partner; teachers and travel; perhaps a partner from far away.
10	A career in beauty, design, hospitality or the arts; respected and liked at work.
11	Income from many sources; a wide circle; too many parties.
12	Comfort far from home; spending on pleasure; a private, sensual life.

The sub-seasons that matter most

Four of the nine deserve special attention. For each, ask Chapter 3's two questions: is this planet a friend of Venus, and does it sit in the 6th, 8th or 12th room counted from Venus?

Venus/Venus (three years, four months). The Minister alone in her own house; everything Venus promises, undiluted. On your side, golden years; testing you, pleasant years in which habits form that you will pay for later.

Venus/Rahu (three years). The smoke-headed Stranger is Venus's friend by convention, and he magnifies her: appetite, glamour, unconventional love, foreign partners, matrimonial apps, weddings with a twist. Many marriages happen here. In a wrong room from Venus, the magnification comes with confusion.

STORY: THE STRANGER AT THE WEDDING. *The Minister of Pleasure was arranging a wedding when the smoke-headed Stranger offered to help. He doubled the guest list, hired a band from another country, and introduced the bride to a man nobody had vetted. The wedding was the talk of the kingdom, and the marriage, surprisingly, was good: the Stranger's choices are often right, only reached by strange roads. Rule: Venus/Rahu brings love and commitments by unconventional routes. Check the road, not just the destination.*

Venus/Saturn (three years, two months). The old Judge and the Minister are natural friends, which surprises people. He comes to audit her bloom: money tightens, work gets heavy, romance cools into responsibility. In a wrong room from Venus this is the hardest stretch of the twenty years; otherwise it is simply the sobering one. Either way it builds the discipline the season otherwise lacks.

STORY: THE JUDGE INSPECTS THE GARDEN. *After thirteen years of feasts the old Judge of Labour walked through the Minister's garden with a ledger. He did not uproot a single plant. He simply asked of each one, "Who waters this, and with what?" By the end of his three years the garden was smaller and every plant in it was paid for. Rule: Venus/Saturn does not end the bloom. It asks what you can actually afford to keep.*

Venus/Ketu (the closing year and two months). The Sadhu opens the windows. Something comfortable is set down. People feel vaguely dissatisfied with a life that looks, from outside, very pleasant. This is the bridge to the Sun, and the time for the closing rituals of Chapter 15.

WHY? The wrong-room rule again, the system's own logic: the 6th, 8th and 12th rooms counted from the season's planet are places of struggle, upheaval and loss as seen from where that planet stands, so a sub-lord sitting there delivers late, sideways or at a cost. Everyday parallel: an excellent wedding caterer based in another city. The food arrives, and so does the delay.

What to do and what not to do

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: In a Venus season, say yes to love and beauty, and keep one habit that has nothing to do with either: a budget, a sport, a fast, a craft that requires sweat. Softness is the only real danger of the season, and one hard habit is enough to prevent it.

Do marry, build partnerships, make your home beautiful, learn an art. **Do** keep a monthly account of money from the first year, because Saturn's sub-season will present the bill. **Do** move your body; Venus does not ask

for it, which is exactly why you must. **Do** be generous; Friday is traditionally Venus's day, and a small act of hospitality on a Friday is the practice that suits the season.

Do not stay in a relationship because it is comfortable. **Do not** confuse being liked with being right. **Do not** buy a stone to "strengthen" Venus; if she tests you, a stone makes the test louder, and if she is on your side, she does not need it.

COMMON MISTAKE: Expecting twenty uninterrupted years of pleasure. The Venus season contains Saturn, Rahu and Ketu sub-seasons. The season is soft overall; its parts are not.

Meera's Venus season: June 2007 to June 2027

Meera's Venus sits at 22° Libra, at home, in her 12th room. For Scorpio rising Venus owns rooms 7 and 12, so she tests Meera, but a Venus at home is a strong Venus, and a strong planet that tests you gives real things with real lessons attached. The 12th room is the room of far places, expenses, private life and bed pleasures. So we should expect a Venus season lived away from home, with comfort, spending and love, and the lessons of a planet not quite on her side.

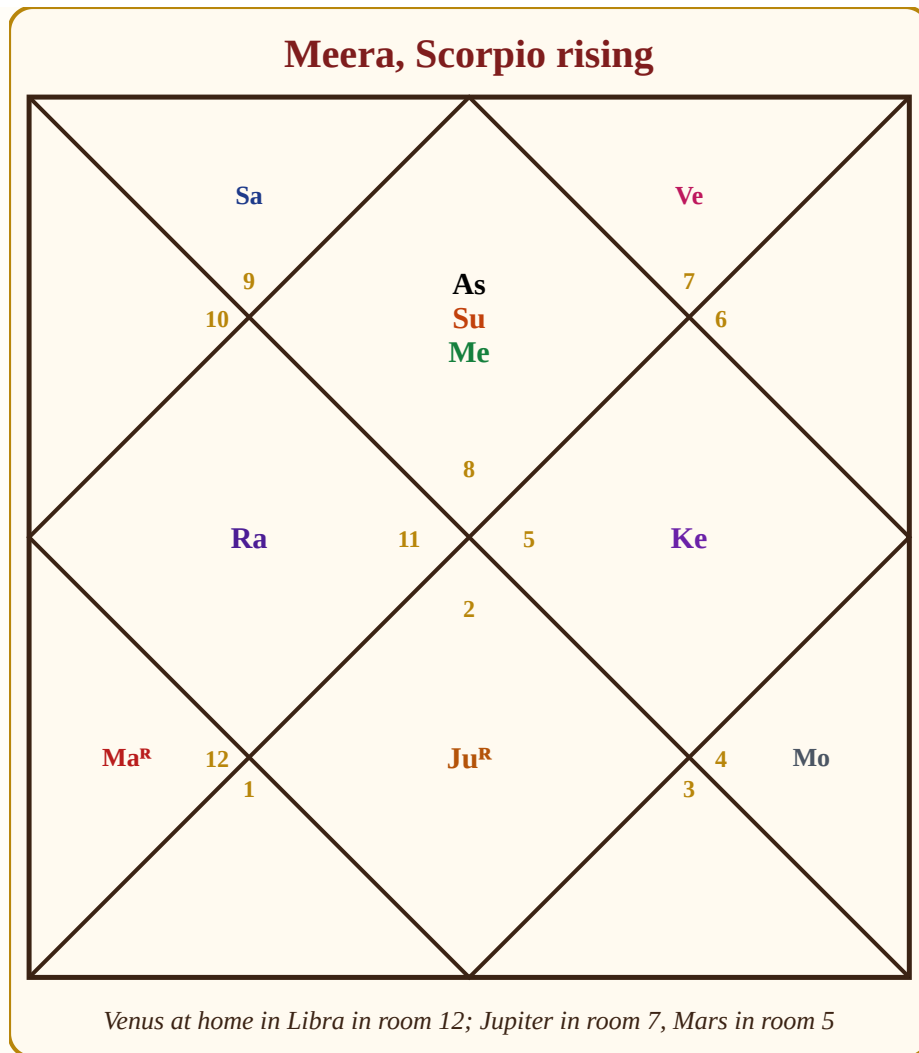


Figure 5.1: Meera's chart. Venus (Ve) is at home in Libra in room 12. From there the 6th room is her room 5 (Mars) and the 8th is her room 7 (Jupiter).

The season opened around June 2007, at eighteen and a half, with her leaving Jaipur for college in another city: Venus in the 12th room, far from home, on time. **Venus/Venus (around June 2007 to October 2010)** were the hostel years: friendships, a first love, a wardrobe, more spending than her parents knew about. **Venus/Sun (October 2010 to October 2011)** brought her first job; the Sun is on her side but is Venus's natural enemy, so comfort and ambition pulled against each other. **Venus/Moon (October 2011 to June 2013)**, her Moon in room 9, the 10th from Venus, was an emotional, homesick, studious stretch with a further qualification.

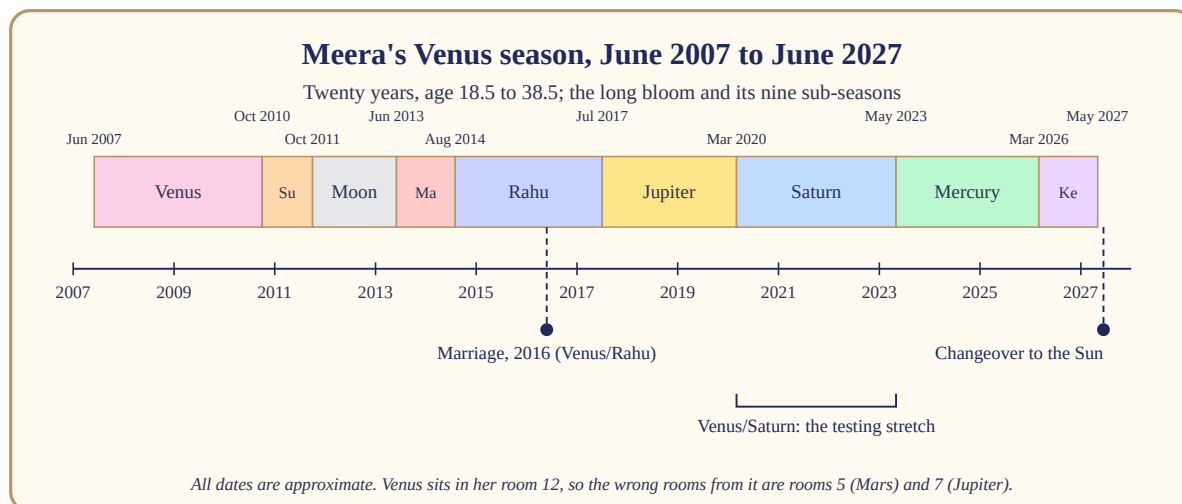


Figure 5.2: Meera's Venus season, around June 2007 to June 2027. The marriage falls in Venus/Rahu, the testing stretch in Venus/Saturn.

Now the wrong-room count. From Venus in room 12, the 6th is her room 5, where Mars sits walking backwards, and the 8th is her room 7, where Jupiter sits. **Venus/Mars (around June 2013 to August 2014)** was a strained romance (room 5 is the romance room) that ended; Mars is on her side, but from the wrong room the help came as a clean break rather than a wedding. **Venus/Rahu (around August 2014 to July 2017)** brought the wedding in 2016. Rahu is Venus's friend and sits in her 4th room (the home) in Aquarius; the match came through an online matrimonial route her mother distrusted. A new home, a new city, the Stranger's road.

Venus/Jupiter (around July 2017 to March 2020) is the one that puzzles people. Jupiter is her best planet and sits in her 7th room, the marriage room, yet that is the 8th counted from Venus: the wrong room. These were the adjustment years of early marriage, with in-laws (an 8th-room matter) and a slow settling rather than a flowering. Real help, sideways. **Venus/Saturn (around March 2020 to May 2023)** was the testing stretch. Saturn sits in her 2nd room (family, savings, speech), outshone by the Sun, and tests her mildly; he is also Venus's natural friend. Money was tight, work heavy, family duties multiplied, and she learned to keep accounts. Those three years built the discipline the first three had not.

Venus/Mercury (around May 2023 to March 2026) was busy and talkative, full of work and new skills, Mercury in her 1st room. And **Venus/Ketu (around March 2026 to May 2027)** is where she stands as I write: the windows opening, a comfortable job that no longer fits, a restlessness she cannot name. Around June 2027 the Sun's season begins, with the Sun in her 1st room. The question it will ask, after twenty years of being liked and comfortable, is the title of the next chapter.

In one breath

- Venus, the Minister of Pleasure, runs the longest season: twenty years of love, comfort, beauty, partnership and money through pleasure.
- The task is to enjoy without going soft; the danger is comfort that becomes a cage.

- The opening three years and four months fill the house; Saturn's sub-season in the middle presents the bill; Ketu's closing year opens the windows.
- Whether Venus is on your side depends on the two rooms she owns for your rising sign; she favours Virgo, Capricorn and Aquarius most.
- Venus/Rahu often brings the marriage, by an unusual road; Venus/Saturn builds the discipline the season otherwise lacks; a sub-lord in the 6th, 8th or 12th from Venus works from the wrong room.
- Meera's Venus season (around June 2007 to June 2027) took her away from home, married her in 2016, tested her from 2020 to 2023, and is closing now.

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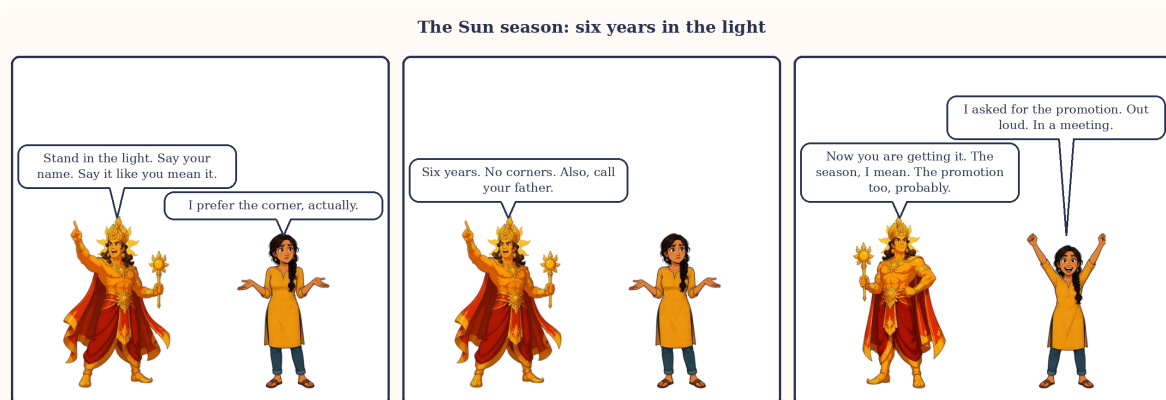
1. Find your Venus season on your season map. If you have lived any of it, mark your first love, your marriage or partnership, and your biggest purchase. Which sub-seasons were they in?
2. Look up your rising sign in the Venus table. Does the verdict match how love and money have treated you?
3. Count the 6th, 8th and 12th rooms from your Venus. Which planets sit there? Those are the sub-seasons to prepare for.
4. Write down one hard habit (a budget, a sport, a craft) you could keep through a soft season. Start it this month.

Chapter 6: The Sun Season (6 Years): Who Am I When Nobody Is Watching?

After twenty years of Venus, the Sun's six years feel like someone has switched on the tube light in a room lit by candles. Everything is suddenly visible, including you. The music stops, the guests go home, and a question the long bloom let you avoid stands in the middle of the floor: who are you when nobody is clapping?

In the royal court the Sun is the King. He does not arrange feasts or keep accounts; he is the centre, and when he runs the household everything is measured against him. His season is about identity, the father, authority, visibility, the heart and spine, and the hard, clean business of standing on your own name. It is the shortest season, six years, but almost nobody comes out of it the same person.

This chapter follows the King's six years, then Devika's Sun season (around July 1998 to July 2004), in which she married, and finally the one Meera enters around June 2027. All dates here are approximate; a free app may differ by a month or two.



The Sun season in three panels.

The King runs the household

STORY: THE KING WALKS THE KINGDOM ALONE. *When the Minister of Pleasure's long tenure ended, the King sent the musicians home and walked out of the palace in plain clothes. For six years he visited every village and asked everyone he met one question: "What are you for?" Many could not answer; they had been busy being comfortable. The King was not angry; he wrote their names in a book and moved on. When he came back, those who knew what they were for were given work; those who did not had been given six years to find out. **Rule:** The Sun's season asks what you stand for and makes it visible. There is nowhere to hide, and that is the gift.*

What the season asks is to become yourself in public: to take authority where it is yours, to stop borrowing confidence from partners or comfort, to make peace with your father (and the fatherly voice inside you), and to look after the heart and back.

WHY? Astronomy first: the Sun is the centre of the system, and every other planet, including the Moon, shines by its light. Then tradition: Parashara makes the Sun the King and the planet that stands for the soul, the father and the government, as befits the source of the light the others reflect. Everyday parallel: the head of a joint family. When he walks in, the television goes off, the children sit up, and everybody remembers who they are supposed to be.

How it feels

Body. Warmer, more upright, more tired by evening. The Sun stands for the heart, spine, eyes and bones: a season to take the heart and back seriously, with posture, blood pressure checks and sleep.

Mind. Clear, proud, impatient with pretence. You see through people and they see through you. Confidence rises if the Sun is on your side; self-doubt sharpens into self-examination if not.

Home. The father comes to the centre: his opinions, his approval or the lack of it. Property and family standing come up.

Love. Harder than in Venus. The Sun wants respect more than comfort, and relationships that depended on you dimming yourself are tested.

Work. Visibility: promotions, titles, government and institutional work, leadership. You are noticed, wonderful if your work is good and uncomfortable if not.

Money. Through position rather than pleasure. Salaries and titles rise; so does spending on status.

The arc: first year, middle, last year

The first year is short and bright. The Sun's own sub-season lasts under four months, then the Moon's six. People feel the light switch on, make bold declarations, quit things. Then the Moon softens it and the real question forms.

The middle holds Rahu, Jupiter and Saturn in turn: a year of ambition and shadow, a year of growth and recognition, a year of audit. Most of the identity work gets done here, usually through conflict with an authority, a father or a boss.

The last year belongs to Venus, the King's natural enemy, and it is the season's quiet surprise. Softness returns; marriages, partnerships and pleasures come back into focus, as if the kingdom, having found out who it is, can afford to enjoy itself again. It is the bridge to the Moon's ten years.

When the Sun is on your side and when it tests you

The Sun owns only one sign, Leo, so for your rising sign he owns one room, and that room decides. Parashara's rule: the lord of rooms 1, 5 or 9 is on your side; the lord of 3, 6 or 11 tests you; the lord of a pillar room (4, 7, 10) or of 2, 8 and 12 is neutral unless the planet's nature tips it, and the Sun's steadiness tips the pillar rooms his way for Taurus and Scorpio.

Rising sign	The Sun	Room the Sun owns for you
Aries	● On your side	5
Taurus	● On your side	4
Gemini	○ Tests you	3
Cancer	◐ Mixed	2
Leo	● On your side	1
Virgo	◐ Mixed	12
Libra	○ Tests you	11
Scorpio	● On your side	10
Sagittarius	● On your side	9
Capricorn	◐ Mixed	8
Aquarius	◐ Mixed	7
Pisces	○ Tests you	6

WHY? The system's own logic: one room, one verdict, the cleanest case of Parashara's rule. Everyday parallel: an employee with one responsibility is easy to appraise; one with five is always "mixed".

A Sun that tests you does not stop you being seen; it makes the seeing uncomfortable. Egos clash, authority figures block you, you are promoted into a job you cannot yet do. The lesson is the same, learned the hard way.

The room the Sun sits in changes the story

Room	What the six years tend to light up
1	A strong, visible self; you become the centre; watch pride and headaches.
2	Authority in the family; earning through position; speech turns commanding.
3	Courage and initiative; a brother's rise; short journeys for work.
4	The father's presence at home; property; education; take care of the heart.
5	A child's achievements; recognition for talent; leading in creative work.
6	Victory over rivals; government or institutional service; health needs watching.
7	A strong-willed partner; a marriage of two egos; public dealings.
8	The self tested by sudden change; deep interests; the father's affairs.
9	The father's season proper; higher learning; luck through authority; pilgrimage.
10	The natural throne: promotion, government, visibility; the Sun's strongest seat.
11	Income through position; powerful friends; a wish fulfilled.
12	Identity found abroad or in retreat; spending on status; the King in the shadows, his hardest seat.

The sub-seasons that matter most

As always, ask Chapter 3's two questions: is the sub-season's planet a friend of the Sun, and does it sit in the 6th, 8th or 12th room counted from him?

Sun/Sun and Sun/Moon (the first ten months). The King, then the Queen Mother: the season announces itself, then asks how you feel about it. The Moon is the Sun's friend, so the opening is usually kind, unless the Moon sits in a wrong room from the Sun.

Sun/Rahu (ten months, twenty-four days). The smoke-headed Stranger swallows the King: literally, the eclipse pair. Ambition, borrowed identity, a craving for status or a foreign stage, confusion about who you are. Rahu is hostile to the Sun by convention, so this is loud whatever room it sits in.

STORY: THE ECLIPSE AT COURT. *One afternoon the smoke-headed Stranger stood in front of the King and, for a few minutes, the court could not see the throne. Ministers took orders from the Stranger; courtiers wore his clothes. Then the shadow passed and the King was exactly where he had always been, embarrassed by how quickly everyone had forgotten him. Rule: In Sun/Rahu you will be tempted to become someone else. Wait for the shadow to pass before signing anything in the new name.*

Sun/Saturn (eleven months, twelve days). In the old story Saturn is the Sun's neglected son, and the two cannot stand each other. The season's hard year: conflict with authority, with the father, with a boss; duty, delay, a reckoning. It is almost always where the identity work actually gets done.

STORY: THE KING AND THE JUDGE. *The old Judge of Labour came to audit his father's household and found the ledgers empty, because kings do not keep accounts. For eleven months he made the King sign for every lamp, every meal, every title he had handed out. The King hated it. At the end he knew, for the first time, what his kingdom cost and what he was for. Rule: Sun/Saturn is the audit of your authority. Do the paperwork; the clarity is worth the humiliation.*

Sun/Venus (the closing year). The Minister of Pleasure returns to a kingdom that has found itself: marriages, partnerships, comforts, and often a decision about love that could not be made while identity was in question. The Sun and Venus are natural enemies, so the softness has an ego cost: you have to let someone else matter.

WHY? Tradition and myth, named as such. Saturn as the Sun's rejected son and Rahu swallowing the Sun are Puranic tales, and the friendship table in Book 1 follows them. Everyday parallel: the father and grown son who quarrel at every family dinner and are, underneath, the two most alike people in the room.

What to do and what not to do

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: In a Sun season, do the thing that would embarrass you if you were caught not doing it. The season will make you visible anyway; let it find you at work.

Do take responsibility, ask for the title, lead the project. **Do** call your father, or make peace with his memory. **Do** look after the heart and spine: walk at sunrise, sit straight, check the blood pressure. **Do** keep a Sunday practice; ten minutes of stillness facing the morning sun suits the season.

Do not confuse authority with arrogance; the Sun's shadow is pride, and Saturn's sub-season collects on it. **Do not** take Sun/Rahu's borrowed ambitions as your own. **Do not** buy a ruby to "strengthen your Sun"; if he tests you, a stone makes him louder, and if he is on your side, he does not need help.

COMMON MISTAKE: Reading the Sun's season as six years of guaranteed promotion. It is six years of visibility, which promotes good work and exposes poor work with equal efficiency.

Devika's Sun season: July 1998 to July 2004

Devika, our Chart C, was born in Kolkata in July 1979 with Aries rising. Her Sun sits at 5° Cancer in her 4th room (home, mother, education, the heart) with Jupiter at 26° Cancer, at Jupiter's strongest place. For Aries rising the Sun owns room 5, so he is on her side. A Sun in his friend the Moon's sign, beside a strong Jupiter, in the education room: expect a season about learning, home and the father, lived with a scholar's seriousness.

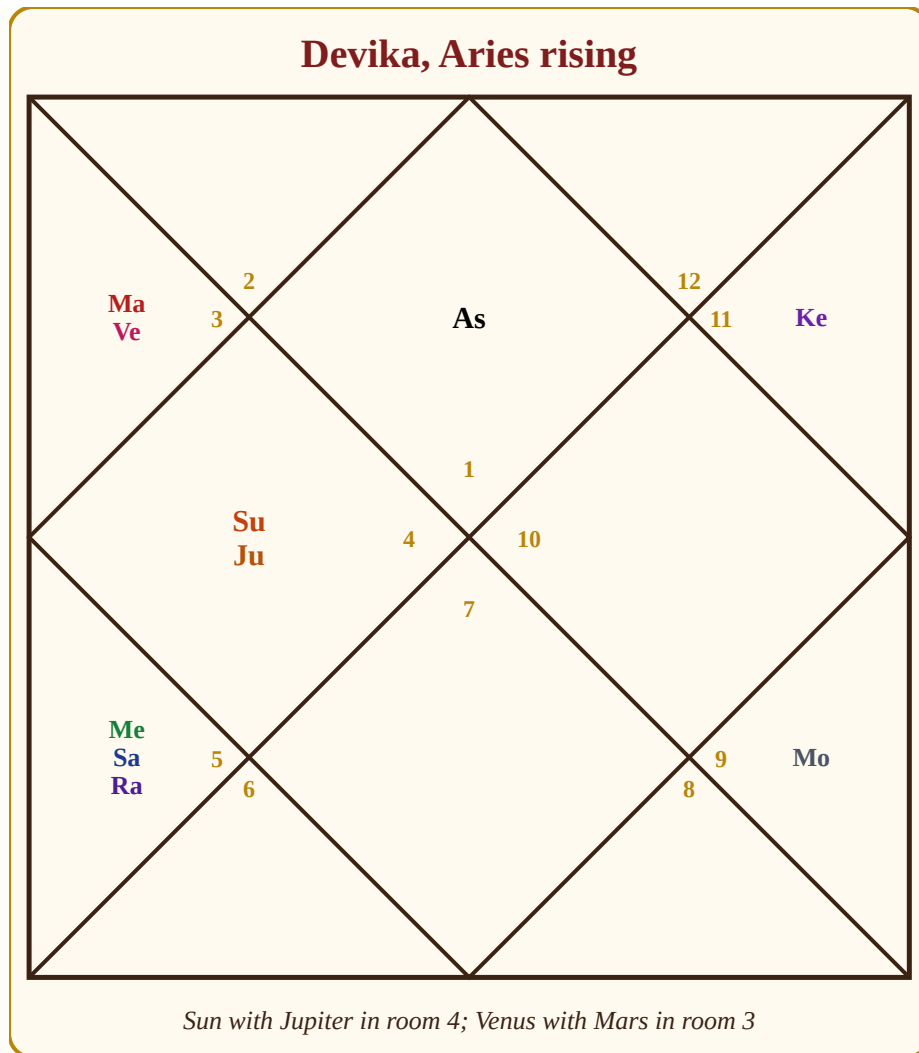


Figure 6.1: Devika's chart. The Sun (Su) sits with Jupiter in room 4. From there the 6th, 8th and 12th rooms are her rooms 9, 11 and 3.

The season ran from around July 1998 (age nineteen) to around July 2004 (twenty-five): her college and postgraduate years in Kolkata.

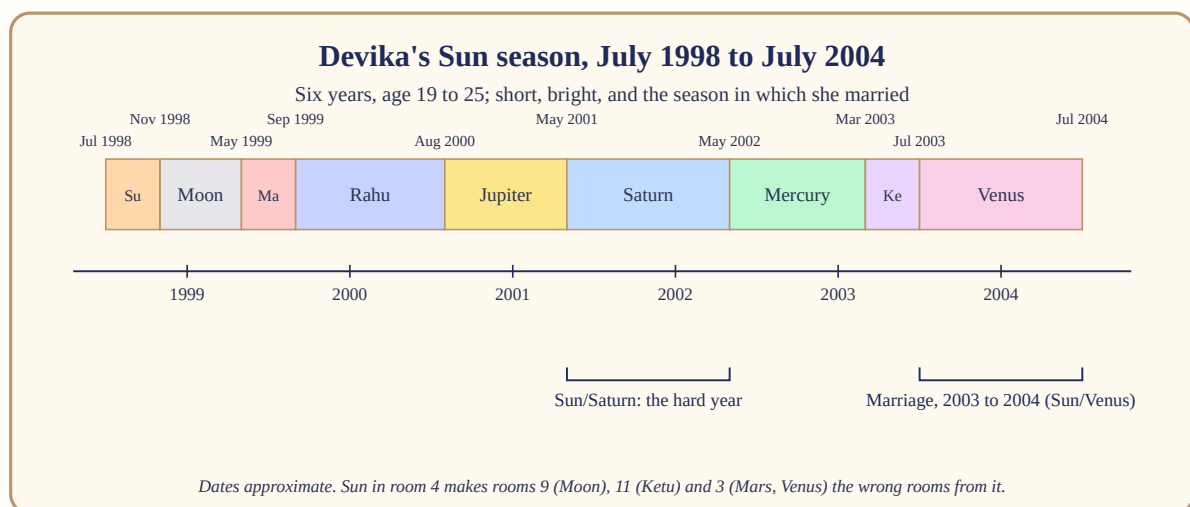


Figure 6.2: Devika's Sun season, around July 1998 to July 2004. The marriage falls in Sun/Venus, the closing year.

Now the wrong-room count, and it is unusual. From the Sun in room 4, the 6th room is her 9th (the Moon), the 8th her 11th (Ketu) and the 12th her 3rd (Mars and Venus). Four of her nine sub-seasons ran from the wrong room. **Sun/Moon (around November 1998 to May 1999)** and **Sun/Mars (May to September 1999)** made the opening year emotional and scattered: a quarrel with a sibling (room 3), energy without direction. **Sun/Rahu (around September 1999 to August 2000)** was the eclipse year: Rahu sits in her 5th room in Leo, the Sun's own sign, and she spent a year among clever, unconventional friends who nearly pulled her out of her course.

Sun/Jupiter (around August 2000 to May 2001) was the season's gift: Jupiter sits with the Sun, at his strongest, on her side, and she graduated with distinction into the course her father had hoped for.

Sun/Saturn (around May 2001 to May 2002) was the hard year. Saturn sits in her 5th room, tests her (he owns rooms 10 and 11 for Aries) and is the Sun's enemy. Her father retired, the household's money changed, and she took a job she did not want. The audit. **Sun/Mercury (around May 2002 to March 2003)** was busy with exams and writing. **Sun/Ketu (around March to July 2003)**, from the 8th counted from the Sun, dissolved a friendship circle.

And then **Sun/Venus (around July 2003 to July 2004)**: the marriage. Venus owns room 7, the marriage room, for Aries rising, so her sub-season is when marriage is most likely to arrive. But Venus tests Devika (she also owns room 2), and she sits in room 3 with Mars, the 12th counted from the Sun: the wrong room. Read it plainly: the Sun is her parental home (room 4), and the 12th from it is leaving that home. Marriage took her out of her father's house, by a route more adjustment than romance, and asked the newly lit Devika to make room for another person's light. The Moon's ten years began around July 2004: Chapter 7.

Meera's coming Sun season: a forward look

Meera's Sun sits at 28° Scorpio in her 1st room, with Mercury. For Scorpio rising the Sun owns room 10, career, so he is on her side, and he sits in the room of the self. The season beginning around June 2027, at thirty-eight and a half, will ask her to let her work become her identity, after twenty years in which comfort and partnership were.

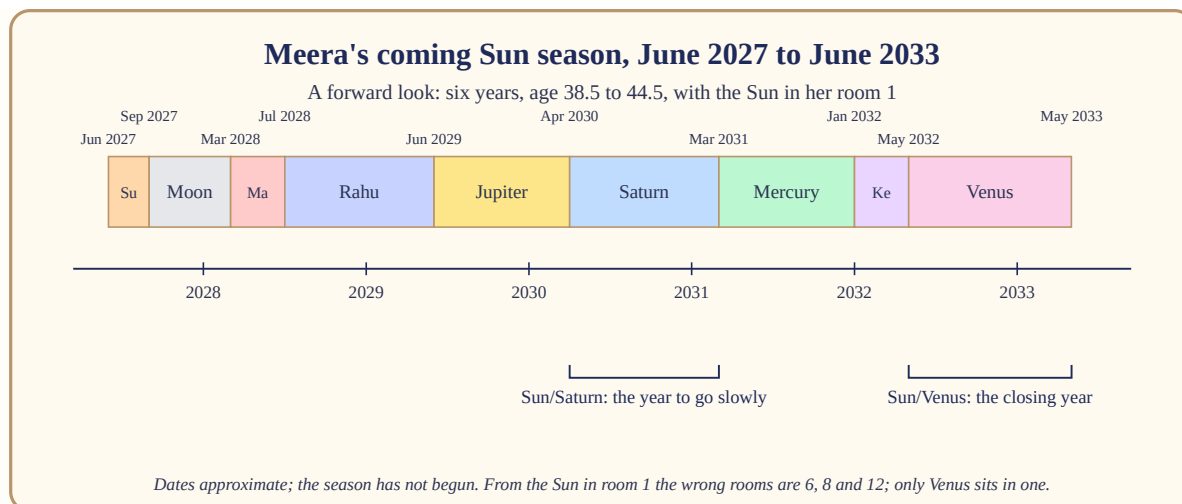


Figure 6.3: Meera's Sun season, around June 2027 to June 2033, as a forward look.

From the Sun in room 1 the wrong rooms are simply rooms 6, 8 and 12, and only Venus sits in one. So **Sun/Venus (around May 2032 to May 2033)**, the closing year, is her one wrong-room sub-season: the comfort she set down in 2027 asking to be renegotiated. Before that, **Sun/Rahu (around July 2028 to June 2029)**, Rahu in her 4th room, will test the home; **Sun/Jupiter (around June 2029 to April 2030)**, Jupiter in her 7th, is the year to lean on the partnership and a mentor; and **Sun/Saturn (around April 2030 to March 2031)**, Saturn in her 2nd room and outshone by this very Sun, is the year to go slowly with money and family. I do not know what will happen in these years; nobody does. I know what they will ask.

In one breath

- The Sun, the King, runs a six-year season about identity, the father, authority, visibility, the heart and the spine.
- It feels bright, proud and exposed: good work is promoted and poor work is seen.
- The first year switches the light on, the middle (Rahu, Jupiter, Saturn) does the identity work, the last year (Venus) softens.
- The Sun owns one room for your rising sign and that room decides; he favours Aries, Taurus, Leo, Scorpio and Sagittarius.
- Sun/Rahu is the eclipse, Sun/Saturn the audit; a sub-lord in the 6th, 8th or 12th from the Sun works from the wrong room.
- Devika's Sun season (around July 1998 to July 2004) was college, a father's retirement, and a marriage in Sun/Venus that took her out of the parental home; Meera's begins around June 2027.

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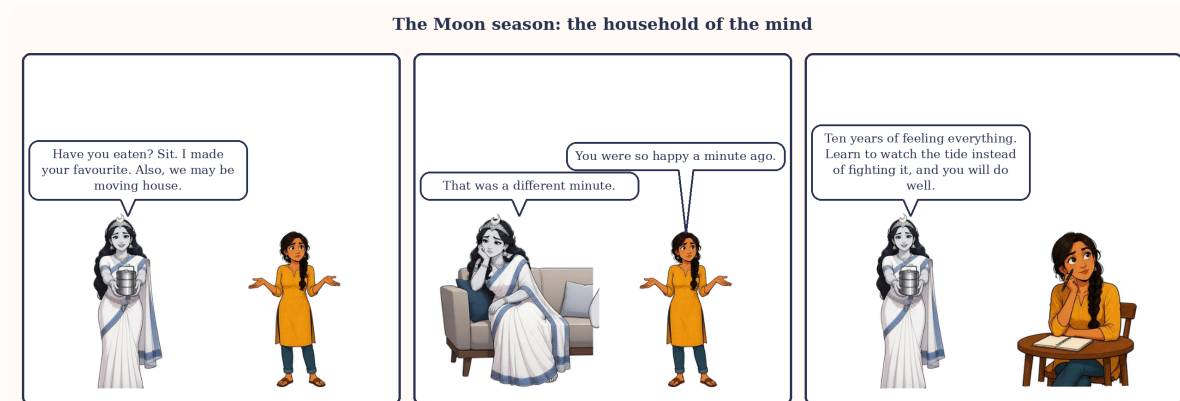
1. Find your Sun season on your season map. If you have lived it, write down who held authority over you then and what you did about it.

2. Look up your rising sign in the Sun table. Does the verdict match how authority and visibility have treated you?
3. Count the 6th, 8th and 12th rooms from your Sun. Which planets sit there? Mark those sub-seasons on your map.
4. Write one sentence answering the King's question, "What are you for?" If you cannot, that is what the season is for.

Chapter 7: The Moon Season (10 Years): The Household of the Mind

A woman I read for once described her Moon season in one sentence. "For ten years, everything happened in the kitchen." She meant that the centre of her life moved indoors: to her mother, her children, the people who came through her door, the question of where home was. Ask her what those years were *about* and she would name a house, not a promotion.

That is the Moon season. Ten years when the Queen Mother holds the keys, and the household of the mind becomes the main stage.



The Moon season in three panels.

The Queen Mother takes the keys

In the court of Book 1 the Moon is the Queen Mother. She does not sit on the throne; she runs the palace. She is the mood of the whole building, and she changes a little every day, because the Moon in the sky changes a little every night.

When her season begins, the court reorganises itself around her concerns. Nourishment. Shelter. Belonging. What the public thinks of you, because the Moon is also the crowd that reflects you back to yourself. And underneath it all, the mind: your moods, your memory, your need to feel safe.

STORY: THE QUEEN MOTHER TAKES THE KEYS. *When the King's season ended the court expected quiet. Instead the Queen Mother walked through every room with a bunch of keys and opened doors nobody had opened in years. "Who sleeps here? Who cooks for them? When did this child last see her mother?" The Commander wanted a campaign; she sent him to repair the well. The Prince wanted to publish accounts; she asked him to write to the relatives. By the end of the year the palace was fuller, warmer, noisier and more emotional, and nobody could say what had been achieved, except that everyone had been fed. Rule: the Moon season measures success by how well the household is held, not by what is won.*

What the season asks of you is simple to say and hard to do: **tend**. Tend your mind, your body, your home, your mother and the people who depend on you. Build the kind of safety that does not depend on anyone else's mood.

How the Moon season feels

Body. The Moon stands for fluids, the stomach, sleep and the chest. Weight comes and goes; everything depends on sleep; a bad week shows up in digestion first.

Mind. More changeable. Not worse, more changeable. Old memories return. Hurt comes faster, and so does tenderness.

Home. Houses change: people move, renovate, return to the family home or leave it. The women of the family come forward.

Love. Security over romance. You want to be known, held, cooked for.

Work. The public comes into it. Work that faces people (teaching, nursing, hospitality, food, caring) grows; solitary work feels lonely.

Money. It flows towards the household; saving becomes emotional ("in case").

The arc: first year, middle, last year

The **first year** (the Moon's own sub-season, ten months) is a turning inward: after the Sun's six years of visibility, the mind wants a nest. It can feel like a loss of drive. It is a change of priority.

The **middle**, roughly years two to eight, holds the big sub-seasons: Rahu, Jupiter, Saturn and Mercury, each well over a year. This is where the events happen and the quality of the season is decided.

The **last year** belongs to Venus (a year and eight months) and then the Sun (six months). Venus softens the end: comfort, companionship, the house finally furnished. The Sun's months are the bridge to Mars, and you

can feel the temperature rise.

WHY TEN YEARS? Tradition, honestly. Parashara's timetable gives the Moon ten of the 120 years and no astronomical reason, and I will not invent one. Everyday parallel: the school system decides a child needs about ten years before anything else; nobody derived that from the stars either.

When the Moon is on your side, and when it tests you

Whether the Moon runs your house kindly depends on two things: which room it owns in your chart (Parashara's rule about rooms, from Book 1), and how bright it was when you were born.

Rising sign	The Moon owns	In your Moon season
Aries	room 4 (a pillar)	🔴 mixed: home and mother come to the front
Taurus	room 3	🟡 tests you: restless wanting, effort for its own sake
Gemini	room 2	🔴 mixed: money, food and family speech
Cancer	room 1	🟢 on your side: your own planet runs the house
Leo	room 12	🔴 mixed: expenses, sleep, faraway places
Virgo	room 11	🟡 tests you: gains with worry
Libra	room 10	🔴 mixed: work and public standing move
Scorpio	room 9	🟢 on your side: luck, teachers, journeys
Sagittarius	room 8	🔴 mixed: hidden changes, in-laws
Capricorn	room 7	🟡 tests you: marriage and partnerships tested
Aquarius	room 6	🟡 tests you: debts, health and rivals
Pisces	room 5	🟢 on your side: children, creativity, study

"Tests you" does not mean "bad": it means the season brings a hard room's matters to the front. That is work, not punishment.

Now the second thing, which matters more in a Moon season than anywhere else: the Moon's phase at birth.

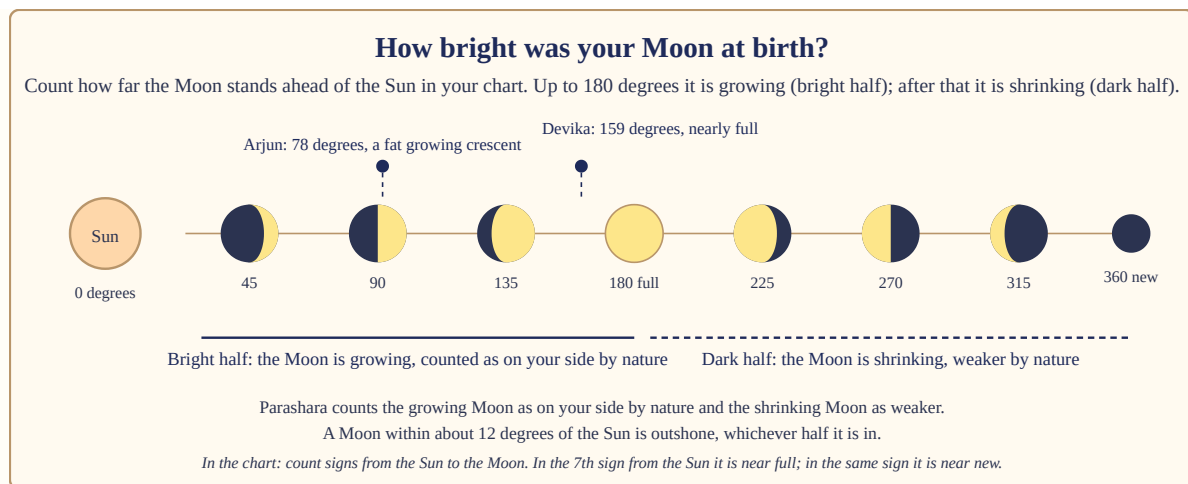


Figure 7.1: How bright was your Moon at birth? Growing (up to 180 degrees ahead of the Sun) is the bright half; shrinking is the dark half.

WHY DOES THE MOON'S PHASE AT BIRTH MATTER? Two layers. **Astronomy:** moonlight is sunlight bounced off the Moon, and how much we see depends on where the Moon stands relative to the Sun. **Parashara's rule:** the growing, bright Moon is a planet on your side by nature; the shrinking, dark Moon is weaker and harder; within about twelve degrees of the Sun it is outshone altogether. Everyday parallel: two travellers start the same long train journey, one with a full water bottle and one nearly empty. The journey is identical. How they feel at hour six is not.

To check, count signs from your Sun to your Moon, going forward: same sign, new; seventh sign, full; up to the seventh, growing. A bright Moon steadies the whole season. A dark Moon asks you to protect your sleep and mind, and that is all it asks.

STORY: THE QUEEN MOTHER'S LAMP. Every evening the Queen Mother walked the corridors with a lamp. Some years it was full of oil and the whole palace saw her coming and felt safe. Some years the oil was low, and the servants said she was angry, when really she could not see them. The King said nothing; he was the Sun, the source of the oil, and he lit her only when she stood far enough from him to catch his light. **Rule:** a Moon far from the Sun at birth is a bright Moon and a steadier mind; a Moon near the Sun is a dark Moon, not a bad one, and needs tending.

The room the Moon sits in changes the story

The Moon sits in	The Moon season tends to be about
room 1	your body and your moods on display
room 2	the family table, food, savings, speech
room 3	siblings, short journeys, the courage to speak
room 4	mother, house, land, inner peace; the Moon's natural room
room 5	children, study, creativity, romance
room 6	service, routine, health, debts
room 7	marriage, partners, the public
room 8	hidden changes, in-laws, inheritance; a private decade
room 9	faith, teachers, long journeys; luck through people
room 10	public work and reputation
room 11	friends, gains, elder siblings, networks
room 12	sleep, solitude, foreign lands, expenses

The sub-seasons that matter most

Four of the nine sub-seasons shape the decade most. For each, ask the two questions from Chapter 3: is the sub-lord a friend of the Moon, and where does it sit counted from the Moon? In the 6th, 8th or 12th room from the Moon it is in the "wrong room": the two planets cannot see each other's concerns, and that sub-season wobbles.

Moon/Rahu (a year and six months). The Stranger in the Queen Mother's kitchen. Rahu is hostile to the Moon in the common teaching, so this is the fog inside the season: strange hungers, anxiety, a far-off move. In a wrong room, the household itself is unsettled.

STORY: THE QUEEN MOTHER AND THE STRANGER. *A smoke-headed traveller arrived at the kitchen door and asked for shelter. The Queen Mother, who fed everyone, fed him. But he wanted a dish from a country nobody had heard of, then another, then the recipe, then the cook. Within a month the kitchen smelled of unfamiliar spices and the servants could not sleep. He left as suddenly as he came, and three of his recipes were now family favourites. Rule: Moon/Rahu unsettles the household and widens its table; keep your sleep and you will keep the good recipes.*

Moon/Jupiter (a year and four months). The Royal Priest blesses the house. Jupiter counts the Moon among his friends, and the Moon has no enemies at all, so this is usually the warmest stretch: children, teachers, faith, growth in the family. In a wrong room the blessing still comes, with cost or delay attached.

Moon/Saturn (a year and seven months). The old Judge audits the household: duty, tiredness, elders who need care. Not cruel, but heavy. If Saturn tests you, protect sleep, keep routine, and do not take on dependents you cannot carry.

Moon/Venus (a year and eight months, the longest). The Minister of Pleasure furnishes the house: comfort, companionship, beauty, and some spending for comfort.

What to do, and what not to do

Do: protect your sleep like a job; tend your mother, or those who mothered you, while you can; make your home a place you want to be in, even a rented room; face the public through work that holds people; and on Mondays, the Moon's day, do one quiet kind thing for someone who depends on you. A practice, not a bargain.

Do not: buy a pearl because someone said your Moon is "weak" (a stone strengthens; it does not steady a mind); make big decisions on a bad night; or isolate. The Moon season heals through people, even when people are what hurt.

Two lives through the Moon season

The dates below are approximate to the month, as all dasha dates are.

Devika, July 2004 to July 2014

Devika is our Aries rising. Her Moon sits at 14° Sagittarius in room 9, nearly full (about 159 degrees ahead of the Sun), in Jupiter's sign; Jupiter sits in the Moon's sign, Cancer, at its strongest place in room 4. They have swapped homes, and since the Moon is mixed for Aries rising, the exchange sets the tone: her Moon season borrows Jupiter's grace.

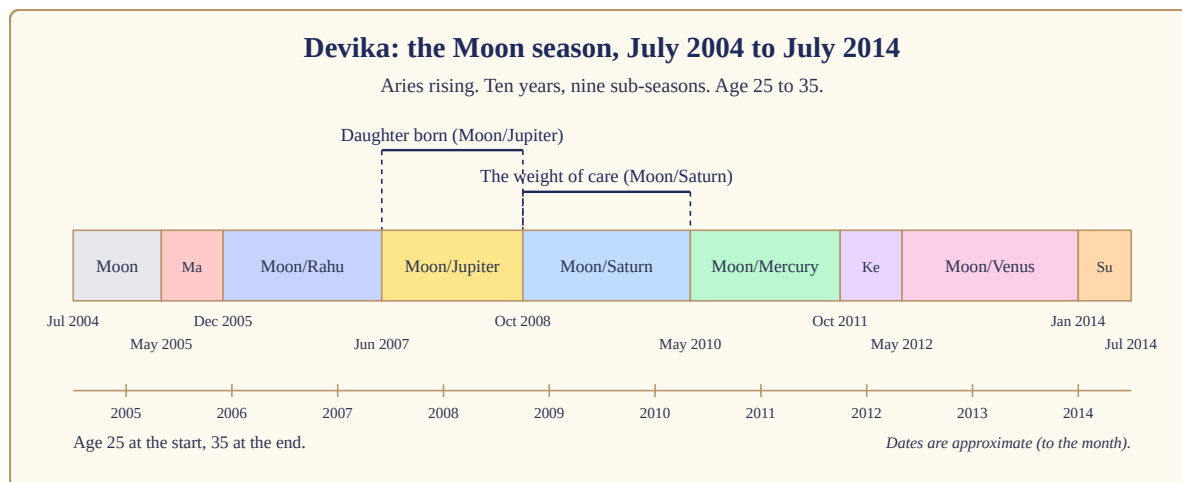


Figure 7.2: Devika's Moon season, age 25 to 35. The daughter arrived in Moon/Jupiter (June 2007 to October 2008).

She entered the season at 25, newly married (Chapter 6). Moon/Moon built the household; Moon/Mars (May to December 2005) was brisk. Moon/Rahu (December 2005 to June 2007) was the fog, but her Rahu sits in room 5, the children's room, 9th from the Moon: the placement under which a couple starts talking about a family.

Then Moon/Jupiter, June 2007 to October 2008, and her daughter was born. Here is an honest problem. Counted from her Moon in room 9, Jupiter in room 4 is in the 8th room: a wrong room by our first check, and the rule alone would have predicted a wobble. Three things outvote it. The exchange: planets that swap homes behave as if each sat in the other's room, so Jupiter effectively acts from room 9, beside the Moon. Jupiter stands for children and is at its strongest place in a pillar room. And Jupiter owns room 9, one of her three lucky rooms. The wrong-room rule is the first question, not the last.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: when the 6/8/12 check says "wobble" but the sub-lord is strong, on your side, and tied to the season lord by an exchange or by sitting with it, trust the strength. The room rule is a tie-breaker, not a judge.

Moon/Saturn (October 2008 to May 2010) was the weight of care: a baby, broken sleep, and Saturn, who tests her, sitting in the children's room. Nothing went wrong; everything was heavy. Knowing it had an end date is worth more than any stone.

Moon/Mercury and Moon/Ketu (May 2010 to May 2012) were the quieter middle. Moon/Venus (May 2012 to January 2014) softened the decade through siblings, short trips and a settled house; Venus sits with Mars in room 3, 7th from the Moon. Moon/Sun (January to July 2014) was the bridge: the Sun sits in room 4, the home, with Jupiter; the temperature rose, and in July 2014 the Commander took the keys (Chapter 8).

Arjun, December 1996 to December 2006

Arjun is our Cancer rising, which makes the Moon his rising-sign lord. It sits at 6° Taurus, at its strongest place, in room 11, and was a fat growing crescent at birth, about 78 degrees ahead of the Sun. Bright, strong, on his side. He had his Moon season as a child, from age 1.8 to 11.8.

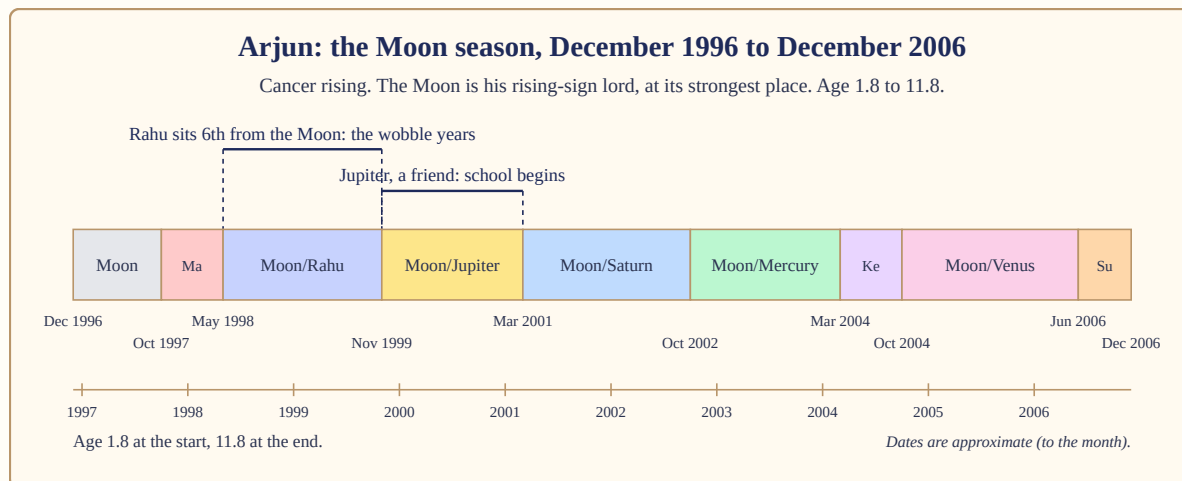


Figure 7.3: Arjun's childhood Moon season, age 1.8 to 11.8, with his Moon at its strongest place in room 11.

Arjun's file gives me no childhood events, and I will not invent any. A child does not run his own season; his household does. A bright rising-sign Moon in room 11 is the season of a well-held child, surrounded by cousins and the children of the colony.

Moon/Rahu (May 1998 to November 1999), age three to four, is the one wobble: Rahu sits in room 4, the home, the 6th room from his Moon. If the household was unsettled in any year (a move, a change in who lived there), this is where I would look. Moon/Jupiter (November 1999 to March 2001), age four to six, is the opposite: Jupiter, on his side, in room 5 (study), 7th from the Moon, the natural stretch for a child to start school and take to it.

Moon/Saturn and Moon/Mercury (March 2001 to March 2004) both work from room 8, 10th from his Moon: ordinary primary-school years. Moon/Venus (October 2004 to June 2006), with Venus 9th from the Moon, was comfort and friendship. Moon/Sun (June to December 2006) was the bridge to Mars at 11.8.

The same season asked two different things: of Devika, to build a household; of Arjun's parents, to hold a child.

In one breath

- The Moon season is ten years when the Queen Mother runs the household: mind, mother, home, nourishment, the public and belonging.
- It asks you to tend: your sleep, your mind, your home and the people who depend on you.

- Cancer, Scorpio and Pisces rising have the Moon as a friend; Taurus, Virgo, Capricorn and Aquarius rising are tested by it; the rest are mixed.
- The Moon's phase at birth matters most here: a bright, growing Moon steadies the decade; a dark Moon asks you to protect your sleep and mind.
- The sub-seasons that shape it most are Rahu (the fog), Jupiter (the blessing), Saturn (the weight) and Venus (the comfort); strength and exchange outvote the 6/8/12 rule.
- Practices, not stones: sleep, routine, tending your mother and your home, work that faces people.

Try this

1. Find your Moon's phase (growing or shrinking). Then write one sentence about how you sleep when life is hard. Do the two match?
2. Using the two tables here, write a two-line summary of what your Moon season was or will be about.
3. If you have lived a Moon season, list the houses you lived in and the women who mattered most, and mark where Moon/Rahu and Moon/Saturn fell.
4. A factual check: how long is Moon/Venus, and why is it the longest sub-season inside the Moon's ten years?

Answers

4. One year and eight months: $(10 \times 20) \div 120$ years. Venus's 20 years is the largest allocation in the timetable, so Venus always gets the biggest slice of any season it enters.

Chapter 8: The Mars Season (7 Years): The Commander Takes Charge

My father's younger brother once told me he could divide his life into the years before he bought his land and the years after. He bought it at 38, against everyone's advice, with a loan he could barely carry, after a quarrel with a cousin nobody will discuss, and he started running every morning at five. "I don't know what came over me," he said. What came over him was the Commander.

The Mars season is seven years: the shortest of the long seasons and the hottest of all. It does not ask you to tend, or to learn, or to let go. It asks you to **act**.



The Mars season in three panels.

The Commander takes the keys

In the court, Mars is the Commander of the army. He guards the gates, trains the soldiers, defends the kingdom's land and starts most of the fights. He is loyal to the King, impatient with the clever Prince, and has no idea what the Minister of Pleasure is for.

When his season begins, the palace becomes a barracks. Decisions get made faster. Arguments that have simmered for years come to a head. Things that were "someday" (the house, the business, the confrontation, the fitness) become "now".

STORY: THE COMMANDER TAKES THE KEYS. *The Queen Mother handed over the keys and the Commander did not even look at them. He walked straight to the boundary wall, found the crack everyone had stepped around for a decade, and had it rebuilt in a week. Then he started a dispute with the neighbouring kingdom over a field and bought three horses the treasury could not afford. By the end of his seven years the court was exhausted, bruised and in possession of a stronger wall, a bigger field, a fitter household and two feuds. "Was it worth it?" asked the Priest. "Ask me in the next season," said the Commander. **Rule:** the Mars season builds, defends and fights, in that order of value; your job is to choose the fights.*

What the season asks of you: **courage with aim.** Act, but at a target. Build something that outlasts the heat. Defend what is yours, and learn the difference between defending and attacking.

How the Mars season feels

Body. Mars stands for blood, muscle, heat, cuts and surgery. The body wants to move and pays you back when you let it. It also runs hot: inflammation, fevers, accidents from hurry. Wear the helmet. Keep the check-up.

Mind. Impatience, and clarity. You know what you want faster, and what you do not want, loudly.

Home. Property: buying land, building, renovating, or fighting over who owns what. Brothers and sisters come forward as allies or rivals.

Love. Passion rises and patience falls. A good partnership fights well and makes up well. A fragile one finds out how fragile it is.

Work. Ambition, competition, promotions sought rather than waited for. Tools, machines, uniform, sport, land: all do well.

Money. Spent on action: property, vehicles, equipment, a venture. Mars does not save; it deploys. Bold loans need a budget behind them.

The arc: first year, middle, last year

The **first five months** are Mars's own sub-season: a sudden rise in temperature. People start things: a gym, a fight, a business. It can feel like waking up.

The **middle**, roughly years two to six, holds Rahu, Jupiter, Saturn, Mercury and Venus, each around a year. The property gets bought, the health gets tested, the rival gets faced.

The **last year** belongs to the Sun (four months) and the Moon (seven months). The Sun is the Commander's King, so the end often brings recognition for what was built. The Moon's months are the bridge to Rahu: a cooling before the eighteen-year churning.

WHY IS THE MARS SEASON SO SHORT AND SO HOT? Two layers. **Tradition:** Parashara gives Mars seven of the 120 years, the same as Ketu, with no reason attached. **The system's own logic:** Mars is fire, and fire burns fast; of the planets beyond the Earth it is also the quickest, crossing a sign in about forty-five days where Jupiter takes a year and Saturn two and a half. A fast, hot planet gets a fast, hot season. Everyday parallel: a pressure cooker. Seven minutes on a high flame does what an hour of simmering does, and you cannot leave the kitchen while it is on.

When Mars is on your side, and when it tests you

Mars is a hard planet by nature; Parashara lists it among the cruel ones. But whether it is *your* hard planet or your best friend depends on the rooms it owns for your rising sign.

Rising sign	Mars owns	In your Mars season
Aries	rooms 1 and 8	● on your side: your own planet takes charge
Taurus	rooms 7 and 12	○ tests you: heat lands on marriage and expenses
Gemini	rooms 6 and 11	○ tests you: rivals, debts, gains through struggle
Cancer	rooms 5 and 10	● your best planet: career and children rise together
Leo	rooms 4 and 9	● your best planet: home, land, luck and faith gain
Virgo	rooms 3 and 8	○ tests you: effort without ease, sudden changes
Libra	rooms 2 and 7	○ tests you: money, family speech and marriage tested
Scorpio	rooms 1 and 6	● on your side: your own planet, with a taste for competition
Sagittarius	rooms 5 and 12	● on your side: children, creativity, faraway places
Capricorn	rooms 4 and 11	○ tests you: property and gains with friction
Aquarius	rooms 3 and 10	○ tests you: ambition at work, rivalry, a tired household
Pisces	rooms 2 and 9	● on your side: money, family and luck grow

The reason is Parashara's own logic, from Book 1: a planet works for the rooms it owns. For Cancer rising, Mars owns a pillar room and a lucky room, both rooms you want strong, so their owner is on your side

whatever its nature. For Taurus rising it owns rooms 7 and 12, neither a lucky room, so it has no stake in your fortune. Everyday parallel: a tough building contractor is the best man in town when he is building *your* house, and a problem when he is building the one that blocks your light.

The room Mars sits in changes the story

Mars sits in	The Mars season tends to be about
room 1	your own body and will; fitness, a hotter temper
room 2	bold earning, sharp words at the dinner table
room 3	courage, siblings, short journeys; Mars's natural room
room 4	home, land, mother, vehicles; buying or fighting over property
room 5	children, sport, speculation, romance; competitive and risky
room 6	rivals, debts, service, health; Mars wins contests here
room 7	heat in the partnership: fights and passion together
room 8	sudden changes, surgery, inheritance; take care of the body
room 9	faith, father, long journeys; courage with purpose
room 10	career and public action; authority won
room 11	gains, friends, elder siblings; acquisitive
room 12	expenses, foreign lands, hospitals; energy spent far away

A Mars walking backwards (as Arjun's is) turns the energy inward: a person who thinks before charging. A Mars outshone by the Sun (as Devika's is) is a Commander standing too close to his King, loyal but with less force of his own.

The sub-seasons that matter most

Mars's friends are the Sun, the Moon and Jupiter; Mercury is its enemy; Venus and Saturn are neutral. For each sub-season ask: is the sub-lord a friend, and where does it sit counted from Mars? The 6th, 8th or 12th room from Mars is the wrong room, and that sub-season wobbles.

Mars/Rahu (a year). The Stranger hands the Commander a map of a country he has never seen. Ambition becomes outsized; risks get taken. In a good room, a genuine leap. In a wrong room, a leap without a landing: check the budget twice.

Mars/Jupiter (eleven months). The Royal Priest advises the Commander, and the Commander listens: the right property bought, the right fight chosen. If Jupiter is on your side, this is the sub-season to build.

Mars/Saturn (a year and a month). The accelerator and the brake, pressed together. This is the stretch in a Mars season to take health seriously: slow down, see the doctor, finish what was started. Not a verdict. A speed limit.

STORY: THE COMMANDER AND THE JUDGE. *The Commander had three campaigns planned when the old Judge of Labour arrived with his ledgers. "You cannot march," said the Judge, "until the wall is paid for." The Commander raged, then sulked, then, for the first time in years, sat still. In the stillness he noticed that his shoulder had hurt for months and that two of his best soldiers were unwell. He spent the year mending, paying and resting, and hated every day of it. The next spring his army was the fittest it had ever been.* **RULE:** Mars/Saturn stops the Commander so the body and the accounts can catch up; the stop is the gift.

Mars/Venus (a year and two months, the longest). The Minister of Pleasure in the barracks: passion, marriage heat, property bought for comfort. In a good room from Mars, the sweetest stretch of the season; in a wrong room, distraction and over-spending.

What to do, and what not to do

Do: move your body every day (a body that trains does not pick fights); build something that outlasts the heat; choose your fights in writing, and if you cannot write down what you want from one, do not have it; repair one sibling relationship; and on Tuesdays, Mars's day, do something that costs you effort for someone else. A practice, not a payment.

Do not: buy red coral because someone says your Mars is "weak" (a stone strengthens; it does not calm); sign a property deal in a hurry; drive angry; or mistake the season's heat for your character. You are hotter for seven years, not forever.

IF YOU READ FOR OTHERS: never say "you will have an accident" or "you will have surgery". Say: "This is a season to take the body seriously, especially from this month to that month. See the doctor about the small things."

Two lives through the Mars season

All dates below are approximate to the month, as dasha dates always are.

Devika, July 2014 to July 2021

Devika is Aries rising, so Mars is her rising-sign lord. He owns rooms 1 and 8 and sits in room 3 (courage, siblings, effort) in Gemini, with Venus beside him, outshone by the Sun eight degrees away.

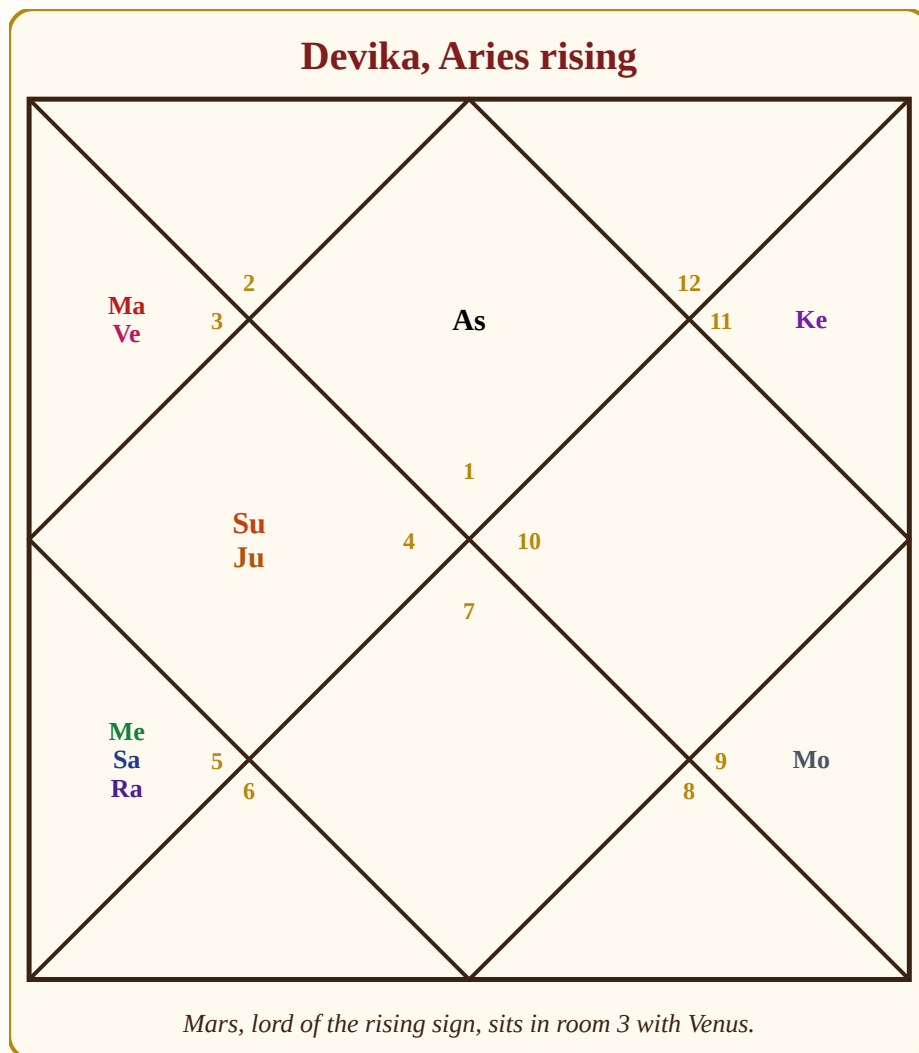


Figure 8.1: Devika's chart. Mars, lord of her rising sign, sits in room 3 with Venus; Saturn, Mercury and Rahu share room 5.

She came into the season at 35, with a six-year-old daughter. Mars/Mars (July to December 2014) was the rise in temperature; Mars/Rahu (December 2014 to January 2016) pushed ambition outward, with Rahu 3rd from Mars. Mars/Jupiter (January to December 2016) was the good year: Jupiter, on her side and at its strongest place, 2nd from Mars in room 4, the home.

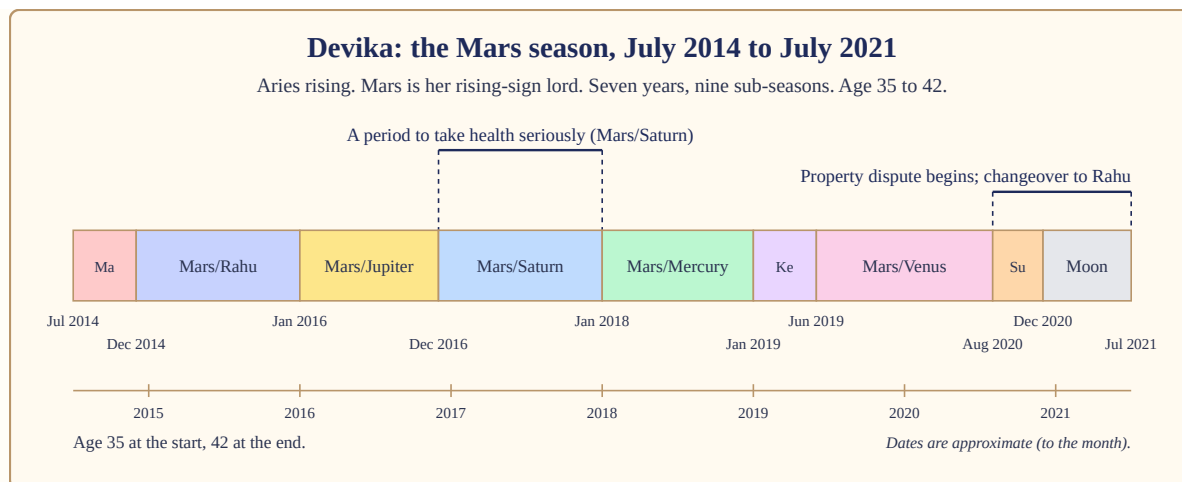


Figure 8.2: Devika's Mars season, age 35 to 42. Mars/Saturn was a period to take health seriously; the property dispute began in 2020.

Then Mars/Saturn, December 2016 to January 2018: a period to take health seriously, with surgery and a long recovery in it. Here is how the chart said so. Saturn tests her by ownership, but sits 3rd from Mars, so the wrong-room rule does not fire. Look instead at what Mars owns: room 8, the room of hidden things and the body's deep repairs. When the season lord owns room 8 and hands the keys to a slow, testing planet, the body asks for attention. Add that Mars is outshone, and the reading is plain: slow down, see the doctor, let the accounts catch up. She did.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: when the season lord owns room 6 or 8, a testing planet's sub-season is a health check, whatever room that planet sits in. Say it that way and only that way.

Mars/Mercury (January 2018 to January 2019) was recovery and paperwork; Mercury is Mars's landlord here (Mars sits in Gemini), so the stretch had his flavour: forms, follow-ups, siblings helping. Mars/Ketu (January to June 2019) was brief. Mars/Venus (June 2019 to August 2020), the longest, had the Minister of Pleasure beside the Commander in room 3: comfort, home improvements, the pleasures of a body that worked again.

Then Mars/Sun (August to December 2020). The Sun sits in room 4, land and home, and it is the Sun who outshines her Mars; in his sub-season the Commander's attention went where the King's was. The dispute over family property began in 2020. Mars/Moon (December 2020 to July 2021), the bridge, carried it on, and it was still open when the Stranger took the keys. Chapter 9 picks it up at the changeover.

Arjun, December 2006 to December 2013

Arjun is Cancer rising, which makes Mars his best planet: owner of room 10 (career) and room 5 (study, merit). His Mars sits at 21° Leo in room 2, walking backwards. He had his Mars season from age 11.8 to 18.8: the school years.

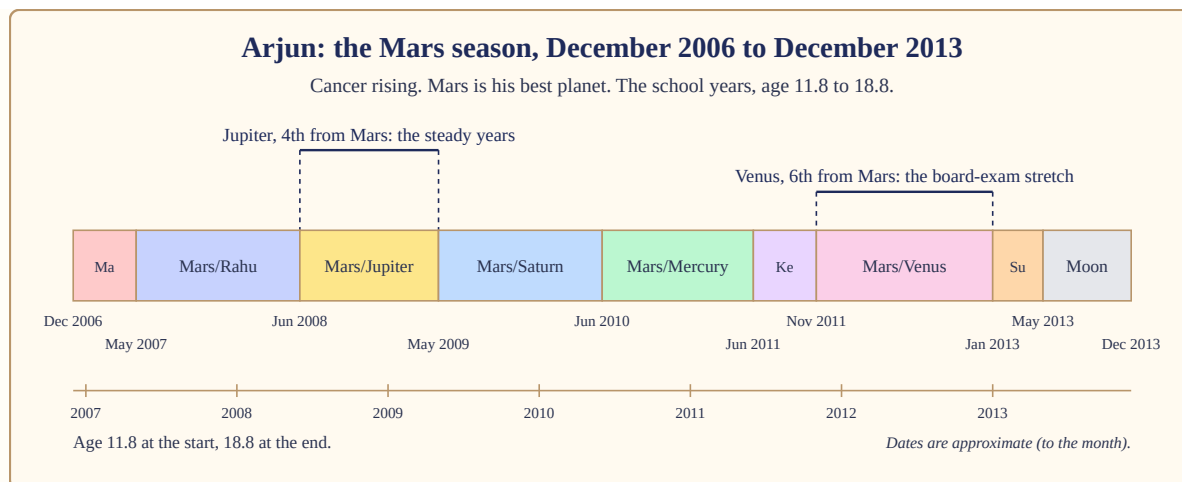


Figure 8.3: Arjun's school-years Mars season, age 11.8 to 18.8. Mars is his best planet, walking backwards in room 2.

I have no school events in Arjun's file and will not invent marks or medals. I can read the shape.

Mars/Mars (December 2006 to May 2007), age twelve: the child becomes a competitor. Mars/Rahu (May 2007 to June 2008), with Rahu in room 4, home and schooling, 3rd from Mars: outsized wanting in a thirteen-year-old. Mars/Jupiter (June 2008 to May 2009), with Jupiter in room 5, the room of study, 4th from Mars: the steady year, the Priest teaching the young soldier.

Mars/Saturn (May 2009 to June 2010) and Mars/Mercury (June 2010 to June 2011) both work from room 8, 7th from Mars: likely years of grind. If he sat his class ten boards at the usual age, they fell in Mars/Mercury, spring 2011.

Mars/Venus (November 2011 to January 2013) is the one wobble: Venus tests him and sits in room 7, the 6th room from Mars. Age sixteen to seventeen: friendships, first attractions, distraction. Mars/Sun (January to May 2013) covered the spring of his class twelve examinations. And Mars/Moon (May to December 2013), the bridge: his strong rising-sign Moon in room 11 (friends), 10th from Mars. College, new friends, a new city perhaps. In December 2013, at 18.8, the Stranger took the keys.

In one breath

- The Mars season is seven years when the Commander runs the court: courage, conflict, property, siblings, sport, ambition, blood and muscle.
- It asks for courage with aim: act, build, defend, and choose your fights in writing.
- Mars is a friend for Aries, Cancer, Leo, Scorpio, Sagittarius and Pisces rising and tests the other six; the rooms it owns decide, not its nature.
- The sub-seasons that shape it most are Rahu (the leap), Jupiter (the wise build), Saturn (the brake, and the time to take health seriously) and Venus (the longest, passion and comfort).
- When the season lord owns room 6 or 8, a testing planet's sub-season is a health check; say it that way and never as an event.

- Practices, not stones: daily movement, construction, chosen fights, practical care of the body.

Try this

1. Using the two tables here, write a two-line summary of what your Mars season was or will be about.
2. If you have lived a Mars season, list what you built and what you fought over, and mark where Mars/Saturn fell. Does it line up?
3. Write down one fight you are in or avoiding. In one sentence, what do you actually want from it?
4. A factual check: using the proportional rule from Chapter 3, how long are Mars/Saturn and Mars/Venus, and which is longer?

Answers

4. Mars/Saturn is $(7 \times 19) \div 120$ years, about one year, one month and nine days. Mars/Venus is $(7 \times 20) \div 120$ years, exactly one year and two months. Venus's is longer by about three weeks.

Chapter 9: The Rahu Season (18 Years): The Great Churning

There is an old story about the churning of the ocean. Gods and demons pulled a serpent back and forth around a mountain until the sea gave up the nectar of immortality. A demon in disguise slipped into the line of gods and drank. The Sun and Moon told on him. His head was cut off, but the nectar had passed his throat, so the head lived on: forever hungry, never full. That head is Rahu. The body, which wants nothing, is Ketu.

The Rahu season is the most misunderstood of the nine, and the story holds the key: eighteen years of hunger. Not evil. Hunger. What you do with it is the whole season.



The Rahu season in three panels.

The Stranger takes the keys

In the court, Rahu is the smoke-headed Stranger at the gate. He has no kingdom of his own and wants everything he sees. He speaks every language a little, knows the newest machines, the foreign markets, the shortcut, and is magnificent at promising.

When his season begins, the court is pulled outward: towards the new, the foreign, the big. The Stranger says there is more, and you can have it. Sometimes he is right. The sudden rises of a lifetime happen in Rahu seasons. So do the sudden falls, and the long fogs between.

STORY: THE STRANGER TAKES THE KEYS. *The Commander handed over the keys and the Stranger smiled with a mouth nobody could quite see. Within a year the palace had a telegraph, a foreign cook, three new trade routes and a debt to a kingdom nobody had heard of. And yet the treasury doubled, the young people learned languages, and a servant's son became a minister. When the Stranger left, the court could not agree whether it had been robbed or enriched. Both, said the Judge. **Rule:** the Rahu season brings more of everything, including confusion; it rewards those who know what they actually want.*

What the season asks of you: **hunger with direction.** Want big, but know what you want. Go far, but keep one honest friend who will tell you when the smoke is just smoke.

How the Rahu season feels

Body. Nerves, light sleep, the hard to diagnose. Take care with what you put in the body. Ordinary check-ups matter because Rahu's complaints are the vague ones.

Mind. Restless, ambitious, easily obsessed. You can hold a goal with a grip you never had before, or lose a year to a screen. Illusion is the risk: seeing what you want to see.

Home. Far away: another city, another country, another kind of community.

Love. Unconventional, intense, often outside the circle the family expected.

Work. Technology, foreign companies, new industries. Rises come fast and sideways; titles inflate. Ask "is this real?" twice a year.

Money. Big swings. Debt taken for appearances is the Rahu trap. Debt taken for a real build is the Rahu gift.

The arc: first years, middle, last years

The **first two years and eight months** are Rahu's own sub-season: fog and hunger together. People change direction sharply here, often without knowing why.

The **middle**, roughly years three to fifteen, holds Jupiter, Saturn, Mercury, Ketu and Venus, each between one and three years.

The **last three years** belong to the Sun, the Moon and Mars, the courtiers Rahu is least at ease with: the hunger meets the heart, and the season closes with a push of will. Then Jupiter arrives, and the changeover from hunger to meaning is one of the great turns of a life (Chapter 15).

WHY EIGHTEEN YEARS? Tradition. Parashara gives Rahu eighteen of the 120 years and no reason. Rahu's actual journey around the sky takes about 18.6 years, but the tradition does not make this connection, and the other eight seasons have no such match; treat it as a coincidence. Everyday parallel: a shop that happens to be eighteen minutes' walk from your house is not eighteen minutes away *because* of your house.

Why Rahu borrows: the shadow planet

Here is the rule that decides every Rahu season. **Rahu takes the colour of the planet whose sign it sits in, and of the planets it sits with.** This is the common teaching across Indian practice, not a line from Parashara.

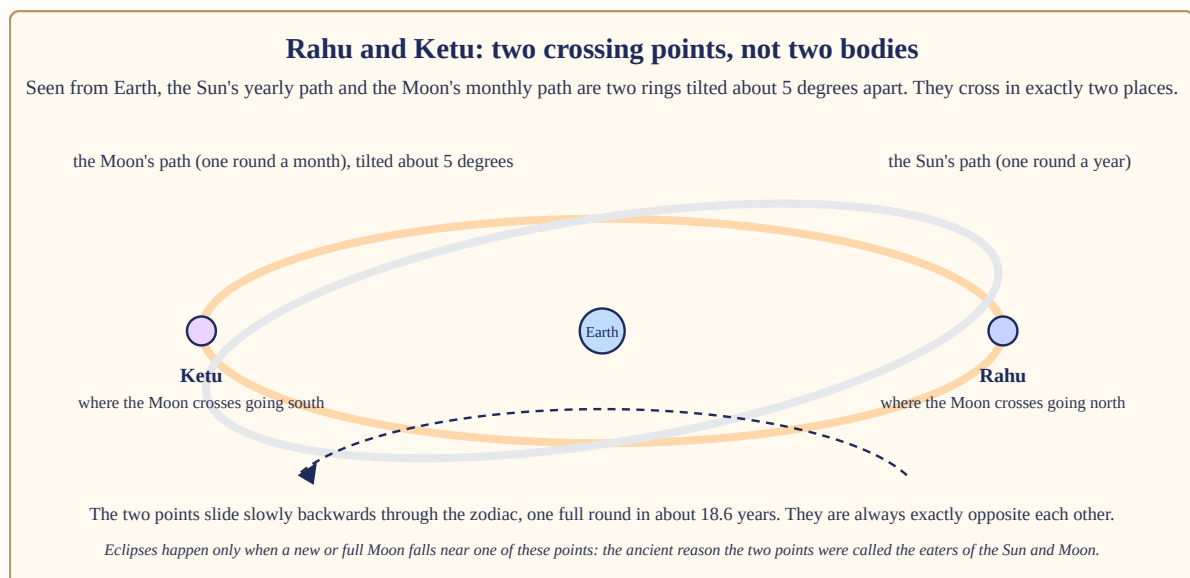


Figure 9.1: Rahu and Ketu are the two points where the Moon's path crosses the Sun's path, always opposite each other, sliding backwards through the zodiac, one round in about 18.6 years.

WHY DOES RAHU BORROW ITS NATURE? Two layers. **Astronomy:** Rahu is not a body. Seen from Earth, the Sun's yearly path and the Moon's monthly path are two rings tilted about five degrees apart; they cross at two points, Rahu and Ketu. Eclipses happen only when a new or full Moon falls near one of them: hence the old stories of the swallows of the Sun and Moon. A crossing point has no light, no colour, no nature. **Common practice's logic:** a shadow takes the colour of whatever it falls on. Everyday parallel: a tenant has no address of his own; he uses the landlord's, and the landlord's house tells you a great deal about the tenant.

STORY: THE STRANGER BORROWS A COAT. The Stranger arrived at court with no clothes of his own. He borrowed the Priest's robe, and everyone found him wise; the Commander's armour, and everyone found him brave; the Minister of Pleasure's silks, and everyone found him charming. "Who is he really?" asked the King. "Whoever he is standing next to," said the Judge, "so look at who is standing next to him." **Rule:** judge Rahu by the lord of its sign and by the planets in its room; Rahu itself is a mirror with an appetite.

When Rahu is on your side, and when it tests you

Because Rahu borrows, this table names, for each rising sign, the landlords whose colour puts Rahu on your side, tests you, or leaves it mixed (Parashara's room-ownership table, Book 1). The landlords' signs: the Sun owns Leo; the Moon, Cancer; Mars, Aries and Scorpio; Mercury, Gemini and Virgo; Jupiter, Sagittarius and Pisces; Venus, Taurus and Libra; Saturn, Capricorn and Aquarius. Companions in the room shift the result, and tradition adds that Rahu does best in the growing rooms, 3, 6, 10 and 11.

Rising sign	● on your side when the landlord is	● mixed	○ tests you when the landlord is
Aries	Sun, Mars, Jupiter	Moon	Mercury, Venus, Saturn
Taurus	Saturn, Sun, Mercury	Venus	Moon, Jupiter, Mars
Gemini	Venus, Saturn, Mercury	Moon	Mars, Jupiter, Sun
Cancer	Mars, Jupiter, Moon	Sun, Saturn	Venus, Mercury
Leo	Mars, Jupiter, Sun	Moon	Mercury, Venus, Saturn
Virgo	Venus, Mercury	Sun, Saturn	Mars, Jupiter, Moon
Libra	Saturn, Mercury, Venus	Moon	Jupiter, Sun, Mars
Scorpio	Jupiter, Moon, Sun, Mars	(none)	Mercury, Venus, Saturn
Sagittarius	Sun, Mars, Jupiter	Mercury, Moon	Venus, Saturn
Capricorn	Venus, Mercury, Saturn	Sun	Mars, Jupiter, Moon
Aquarius	Venus, Saturn	Mercury, Sun	Jupiter, Moon, Mars
Pisces	Mars, Moon, Jupiter	(none)	Saturn, Venus, Sun, Mercury

The room Rahu sits in changes the story

Rahu sits in	The Rahu season tends to be about
room 1	reinvention; a hunger to be seen
room 2	money and speech in big swings
room 3	bold effort, media, technology; a growing room
room 4	home far from home; land unsettled, then rebuilt
room 5	children, speculation, unusual studies and loves
room 6	rivals and debts fought and won; a growing room
room 7	an unconventional partner; the public in your life
room 8	sudden changes, hidden matters, research
room 9	foreign teachers, far journeys, a faith remade
room 10	a career that rises sideways and fast; a growing room
room 11	gains, networks, outsized friends; the classic rise
room 12	foreign lands, hospitals, sleep, spending

The sub-seasons that matter most

By the common rule Rahu is at ease with Venus, Saturn and Mercury and hostile to the Sun, Moon and Mars; Jupiter is left out, and I treat him as neutral. For each sub-season ask where the sub-lord sits counted from Rahu: the 6th, 8th or 12th room is the wrong room, and that stretch wobbles. One more Rahu rule: the landlord's own sub-season brings the whole season's theme to a head.

Rahu/Rahu (two years and eight months). Fog and hunger. The direction of life changes before the reason is clear. Keep a journal.

Rahu/Jupiter (two years and five months). The Priest sits with the Stranger, and the hunger finds a meaning: studies completed, a teacher found, a real job, a child. With Jupiter on your side and in a good room from Rahu, this is the best stretch of the eighteen years. Hunger that reads is better than hunger that does not.

Rahu/Saturn (two years and ten months). The Judge audits the Stranger's promises. Whatever was inflated deflates here, and whatever was real holds. If Saturn tests you, this is the stretch to take seriously: routine, duty, no shortcuts.

Rahu/Mercury (two years and seven months). The clever Prince at the Stranger's desk: ideas, plans, courses, all at once. When Mercury is on your side, a brilliant stretch of learning and trade. When Mercury tests you or sits in a hard room, cleverness with nowhere to go: the "stuck" years.

Rahu/Venus (three years, the longest). The Minister of Pleasure: comfort, love, money, a softening. When Venus is Rahu's landlord, this is where the whole season's theme arrives.

What to do, and what not to do

Do: write down the one thing you actually want this year, and read it monthly; keep one honest friend who is allowed to say "that is smoke"; learn the new thing; serve strangers and outsiders in some small regular way; protect your sleep from screens; and on Saturdays (tradition gives Rahu no weekday of its own; most teachers use Saturn's) check your plans against reality.

Do not: buy a hessonite because someone frightened you (a stone cannot give a hungry mind direction); borrow for appearances; take the shortcut or the deal that must be kept quiet; or decide that a confusing year means a cursed life. Fog lifts.

Two lives through the Rahu season

All dates are approximate to the month, as dasha dates always are.

Arjun, December 2013 to December 2031

Arjun is Cancer rising. His Rahu sits at 12° Libra in room 4, alone. Libra belongs to Venus, so his Rahu wears Venus's colour, and for Cancer rising Venus tests him (she owns rooms 4 and 11); his Venus sits in room 7, a pillar room. A Stranger in the home room, dressed as a Minister who is not quite on his side: a season about home, belonging and relationship.

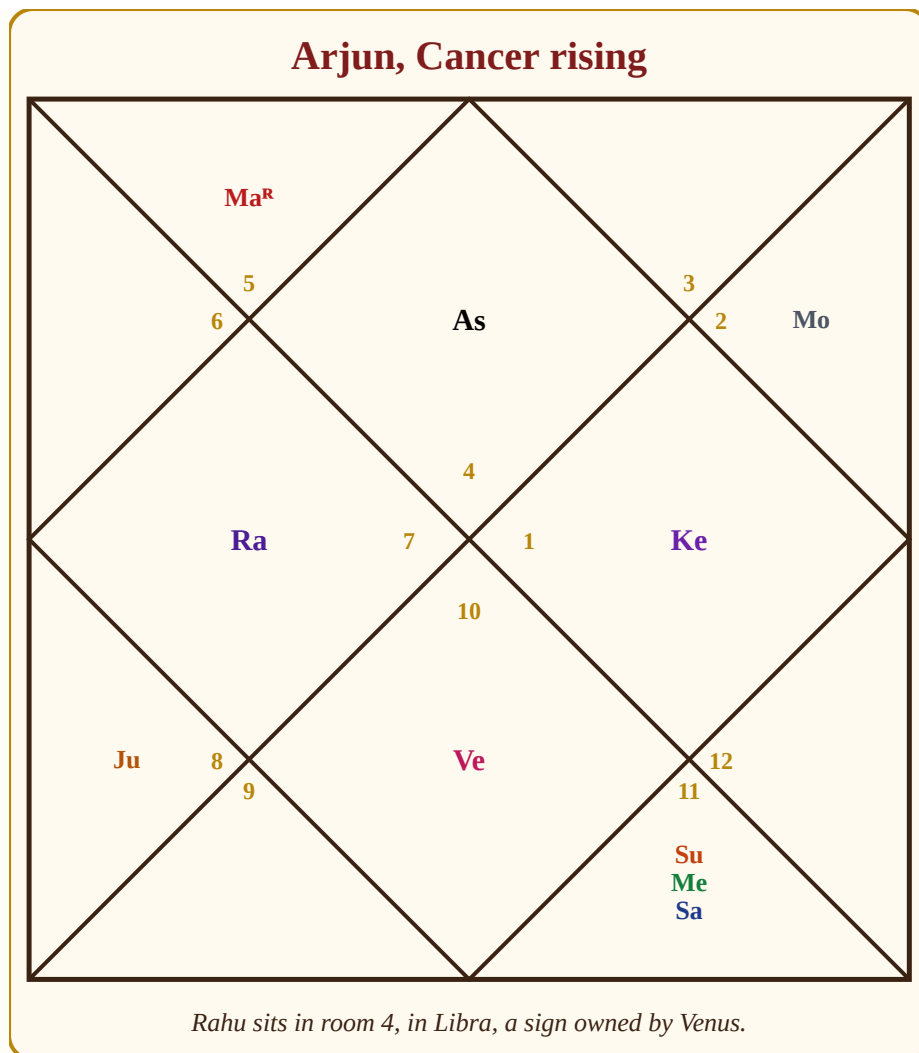


Figure 9.2: Arjun's chart. Rahu sits alone in room 4, in Libra, Venus's sign; Venus sits in room 7.

He entered at 18.8, in his first year of college. Rahu/Rahu (December 2013 to August 2016) was the fog: wanting several futures at once.

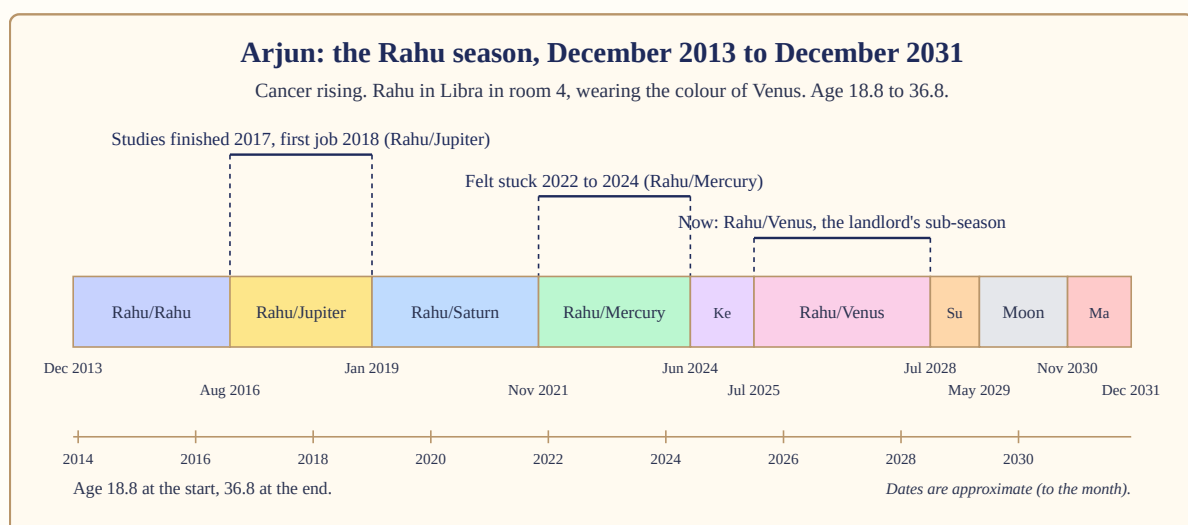


Figure 9.3: Arjun's Rahu season, age 18.8 to 36.8: studies and first job in Rahu/Jupiter, the stuck stretch in Rahu/Mercury, Rahu/Venus running now.

Rahu/Jupiter (August 2016 to January 2019): Jupiter, on his side, in room 5, the room of study, 2nd from Rahu. He finished his studies in 2017 and took his first job in 2018. Hunger that reads.

Rahu/Saturn (January 2019 to November 2021), with Saturn neutral for him, outshone, in room 8, 5th from Rahu: the grind of the first years at work.

Rahu/Mercury (November 2021 to June 2024): he felt stuck from 2022 to 2024. Mercury tests him (he owns rooms 3 and 12 for Cancer rising) and sits in room 8, a hard room. Rahu and Mercury get on by the common rule; the Prince simply had nothing good to offer. Clever years with nowhere to go.

Rahu/Ketu (June 2024 to July 2025): the headless Sadhu opposite the Stranger, in room 10, the career room. A year of letting go of a path.

And now Rahu/Venus (July 2025 to July 2028): the landlord's sub-season, so these three years bring the whole season's theme to a head: home, partnership, belonging. Venus sits in room 7, marriage and partners, 4th from Rahu, a strong room; but she tests him by ownership, so what arrives comes with a cost or a choice. If I were sitting across from Arjun today I would say: this is where you decide who and where you belong to; decide slowly. Rahu/Sun follows (July 2028 to May 2029), then Rahu/Moon (May 2029 to November 2030), with his strong Moon 8th from Rahu, a wrong room: the heart pulling against the hunger. Rahu/Mars (November 2030 to December 2031), his best planet 11th from Rahu, is the strong close and the bridge to Jupiter at 36.8.

Devika, July 2021 to July 2039

Devika is Aries rising. Her Rahu sits at 3° Leo in room 5, with Mercury and Saturn. Leo belongs to the Sun, who is on her side, so Rahu's borrowed colour is warm; both companions test her, which cools it. Mixed, in the room of children and big bets.

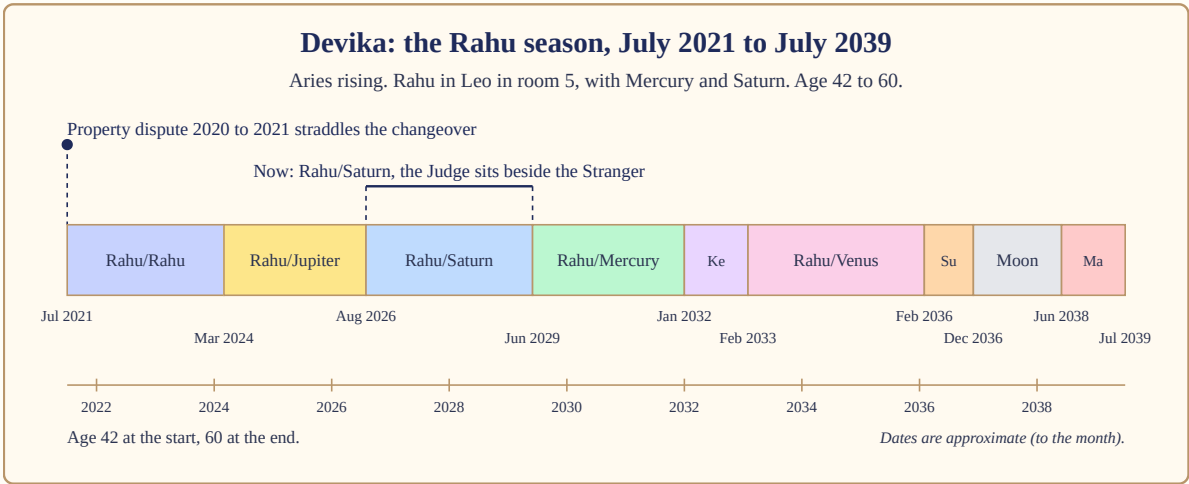


Figure 9.4: Devika's Rahu season, age 42 to 60. The property dispute straddled the changeover from Mars; Rahu/Saturn runs now.

The property dispute of 2020 to 2021 sat exactly on the changeover. In the Mars season's last year the Commander fought for land; in the Rahu season's first months the Stranger took over the same fight: outsiders, lawyers, paperwork. That is what a changeover looks like: the same event handed from one courtier to another, changing character as it passes.

Rahu/Rahu (July 2021 to March 2024) was the churning and the dispute's long tail. Rahu/Jupiter (March 2024 to August 2026): Jupiter is on her side, at its strongest place, in room 4, but 12th from Rahu, a wrong room: good things with a cost, and by the rule of thumb in Chapter 7 the strength holds. Rahu/Saturn (August 2026 to June 2029) is running now: the Judge beside the Stranger in the children's room. Work, duty, a daughter at the age of examinations and leaving home: the stretch to take seriously, with routine and no shortcuts. Rahu/Mercury (June 2029 to January 2032) follows, then Ketu, then three years of Rahu/Venus from February 2033, the softening. Her Jupiter season begins in July 2039, at sixty.

In one breath

- The Rahu season is eighteen years when the Stranger runs the court: hunger, ambition, foreign places, technology, illusion, sudden rises and falls.
- It asks for hunger with direction: want big, know what you want, keep one honest friend.
- Rahu has no nature of its own; it takes the colour of the lord of its sign and of the planets beside it, and does best in rooms 3, 6, 10 and 11. Find the landlord first.
- The sub-seasons that shape it most are Jupiter (meaning), Saturn (the audit), Mercury (the stuck years) and Venus (the softening); the landlord's sub-season brings the theme to a head.
- Arjun's Rahu (2013 to 2031) wears Venus's colour and is in Rahu/Venus, the landlord's sub-season, now; Devika's (2021 to 2039) sits with Mercury and Saturn, in Rahu/Saturn now.
- Practices, not stones: a written goal, an honest friend, learning the new thing, sleep, and service to strangers.

Try this

1. Find the sign your Rahu sits in, its lord, and who shares the room. Write Rahu's "borrowed colour" in one line.
2. If you are in or have lived a Rahu season, write down the one thing you most wanted in its first three years. Was it what you thought it was?
3. Mark the landlord's sub-season on your season map. If it is past, what came to a head? If ahead, what would you like to have decided by then?
4. A factual check: using the proportional rule from Chapter 3, which is the longest sub-season inside Rahu's eighteen years, how long is it, and which comes second?

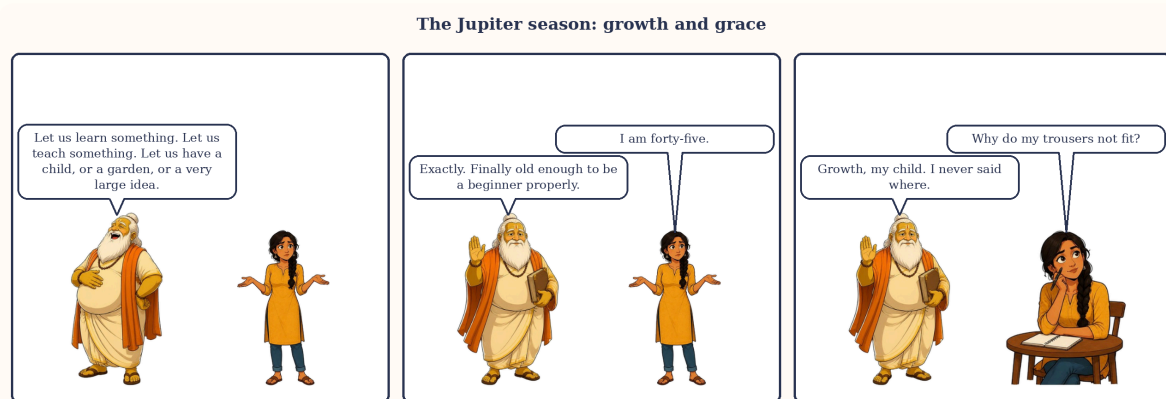
Answers

4. Rahu/Venus, at $(18 \times 20) \div 120$ years: three years exactly. Second is Rahu/Saturn, at $(18 \times 19) \div 120$ years: two years, ten months and six days.

Chapter 10: The Jupiter Season (16 Years): Growth and Grace

If you asked a hundred people which season they would choose, most would choose this one. Jupiter is the planet the old books call the great benefic, the Royal Priest of our court, the one who blesses weddings, teaches the children and keeps the King honest. Sixteen years with the Priest running the household sounds like sixteen years of grace.

Often it is: a late child, a first house, a teacher who changes a life. But I have also sat across from people halfway through a Jupiter season who were confused and a little ashamed: "Everyone told me these would be my best years. Why do I feel heavier, slower and poorer?" This chapter is for both. Jupiter's season is the season of growth, and growth is not the same as ease. As in every chapter of this part, the dates for our case-study lives are approximate, to within a month or two.



The Jupiter season in three panels.

The Priest runs the household

STORY: THE PRIEST TAKES THE KEYS. When the Royal Priest's turn came to run the palace, the first thing he did was open the storerooms and feed everyone. He hired tutors for the children, invited scholars from distant kingdoms, and blessed every marriage proposal at the gate. By the third year the treasury was lower, the kitchen busier, and every courtier had put on weight, including the Priest. "You are generous to a fault," said the Judge. "Yes," said the Priest, "and in my years the fault and the generosity come together. Learn to tell them apart." **Rule:** Jupiter's season expands whatever it touches: wisdom, children, faith, money, and also waistlines, debts and promises made too freely.

The season asks three things. **Grow in the right direction:** Jupiter stands for wisdom, teachers, children, faith, law and wealth, and this is when those doors open; walk through the ones that matter instead of saying yes to all of them. **Give, and learn to receive:** you become the one the family turns to for advice, loans and blessings, which can hollow you out; the season also asks you to let others help you. **Believe in something:** not necessarily a religion. The season raises the question "what do I actually believe?" and rewards an honest answer.

How it feels

Body. Jupiter is the planet of fat and the liver in the old lists. Many people gain weight, especially in the Jupiter and Venus sub-seasons. A period to take the liver, blood sugar and weight seriously, with kindness rather than panic.

Mind. Calmer and broader than the Rahu season that usually precedes it. People read more, think about meaning more, are more easily moved by a teacher. The shadow is complacency.

Home. Children arrive, grow up, or leave for study. Elders lean on you; the home fills with guests.

Love. Jupiter is the planet of marriage, and of the husband, in a woman's chart in the traditional reading; in anyone's it favours commitment over flirtation. Where Jupiter tests you, it can bring a partner or in-law who is more preacher than companion.

Work. Teaching, law, finance, advising, publishing, counselling: anything paid for judgement rather than speed. A mentor appears, or you become one.

Money. More comes in, and more goes out. The people who finish richer treated generosity as a budget line.

The arc of sixteen years

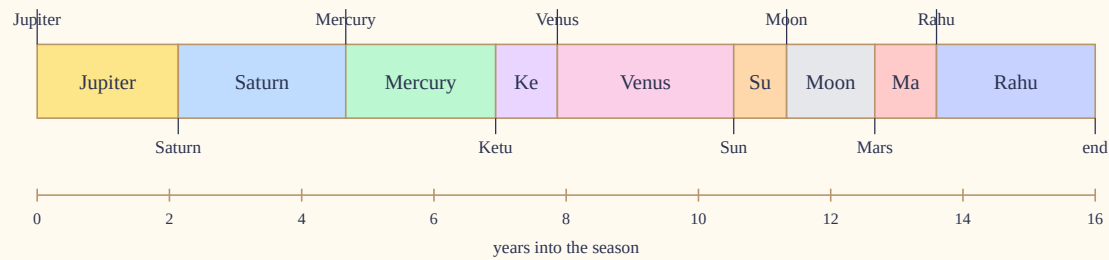
The first year. Jupiter's own sub-season, usually a relief after Rahu. Something lifts; a blessing arrives early. It is also where the overspending starts, because everything feels possible.

The middle. Years two to eleven hold the long Saturn, Mercury, Ketu and Venus sub-seasons: a child's education, a long project, a slow rise in standing. The Saturn stretch corrects the complacency; the Venus years, around nine to eleven, are the sweetest.

The last year. The Rahu sub-season closes the season, the Stranger walking the Priest's halls. The hunger returns just as Saturn's season approaches. Hold steady; Chapter 15 covers that changeover.

The Jupiter season: sixteen years in nine sub-seasons

Each sub-season lasts $(16 \times \text{the sub-lord's years}) / 120$. Widths are to scale.



Longest: Venus (2y 8m), Saturn (2y 6m), Rahu (2y 5m), Mercury (2y 3m), Jupiter (2y 2m).

Shortest: Sun (9m 18d), Ketu and Mars (11m 6d each), Moon (1y 4m).

Figure 10.1: The sixteen-year Jupiter season in its nine sub-seasons, to scale.

WHY SIXTEEN YEARS, AND WHY WEIGHT? The length is tradition: Parashara's 120-year timetable gives Jupiter 16 years and no reason, and I will not invent one. The weight is the system's own logic: Jupiter is the planet that stands for fat, the liver and abundance, so its season brings abundance to the body as readily as to the bank. Everyday parallel: the relative whose house you always leave heavier, in every sense.

When Jupiter is on your side, and when it tests you

Here is the part most books leave out, and the part that most often explains a disappointing Jupiter season. Whether a planet is on your side depends on your rising sign, because the rising sign decides which rooms that planet owns. Jupiter owns Sagittarius and Pisces. For some rising signs those fall in the lucky rooms; for others, in the hard or greedy ones.

Rising sign	Jupiter owns rooms	Jupiter and you	The season tends to bring
Aries	9 and 12	● on your side	fortune, teachers, long journeys, faith
Taurus	8 and 11	○ tests you	gains with strings, sudden changes, in-law matters
Gemini	7 and 10	○ tests you	marriage and career both demanding
Cancer	6 and 9	● on your side	fortune wins over struggle; protection
Leo	5 and 8	● on your side	children, creativity, inheritance handled well
Virgo	4 and 7	○ tests you	home and partner heavy; growth as obligation
Libra	3 and 6	○ tests you	effort, competition, debts, health routines
Scorpio	2 and 5	● on your side	wealth, speech, children, learning
Sagittarius	1 and 4	● on your side	self and home flourish; your own planet's season
Capricorn	3 and 12	○ tests you	expenses, foreign places, effort for little return
Aquarius	2 and 11	○ tests you	money comes; ambition outgrows wisdom
Pisces	1 and 10	● on your side	identity and career grow together; your own planet's season

WHY CAN THE GREAT BENEFIC'S SEASON DISAPPOINT? This is the system's own logic, set out by Parashara. Lords of the three lucky rooms (1, 5, 9) help you; lords of rooms 3, 6 and 11 work against you; and a naturally kind planet that owns the pillar rooms (4, 7, 10) loses its kindness there, because the pillars demand action and a priest is not built for action. So for Taurus, Gemini, Virgo, Libra, Capricorn and Aquarius rising, Jupiter owns the wrong rooms, and its season delivers Jupiter's themes through Jupiter's hardest offices: debt, obligation, the in-laws, the heavy career. The great benefic has not turned cruel; he has been given the wrong job. Everyday parallel: the kindest uncle in the family is made treasurer of the housing society. He is still kind. He is also now the man who chases you for the maintenance money.

If Jupiter tests you, do not dread this season. It still brings learning and growth; it simply sends the bill with them: the child who needs expensive schooling, the promotion that eats your evenings, the guru who wants a donation. Knowing this in advance is most of the protection.

The room Jupiter sits in changes the story

Jupiter in room	The season leans towards
1	you become the wise one; weight and dignity both increase
2	family wealth, good food, a persuasive voice; watch indulgence
3	writing, teaching siblings, short pilgrimages
4	a house, a car, mother's blessing; Jupiter's happiest room
5	children, students, creative work, a faith of your own
6	service, debts paid down, health through discipline
7	a marriage or partnership that teaches
8	inheritance, research, slow transformation; faith tested
9	the classic room: a guru, long journeys, father's fortune, grace
10	a visible rise at work, a reputation for judgement
11	gains, elder siblings, a wide circle; ambition dressed as wisdom
12	foreign lands, retreats, expenses on good causes

The sub-seasons that matter most

Two questions decide any sub-season's tone, as Chapter 3 explained: are the season lord and sub-lord friends, and where does the sub-lord sit counted from the season lord? A sub-lord in the 6th, 8th or 12th room counted from Jupiter is in a "wrong room", and that sub-season works against the season's promises even if the planets are friendly. Four stretches matter most.

Jupiter/Jupiter (the first 2 years 2 months). The Priest alone. If Jupiter is on your side, blessings; if it tests you, the first bills arrive dressed as opportunities. Whatever happens here is the theme of the next fourteen years.

Jupiter/Saturn (2 years 6 months). The Priest and the Judge are neutral to each other, the best Saturn gets from anyone. Still, the season slows here: delays in children's matters, a demanding senior, a parent's needs. It usually passes with something solid built.

Jupiter/Mercury (2 years 3 months). Not friends; Jupiter finds Mercury clever without being wise, and Mercury finds Jupiter long-winded. A busy sub-season of paperwork, exams and arguments about money: good for study, bad for grand decisions.

Jupiter/Rahu (the last 2 years 5 months). The Stranger closing the Priest's season. Ambition returns, often as a foreign offer or a scheme. Because it leads straight into Saturn, treat it as a bridge: finish things, do not start a loan.

STORY: THE PRIEST AND THE JUDGE COUNT THE GRAIN. *In the Priest's third year the Judge came to the storeroom with his ledger. "You have promised grain to four villages, and we have grain for two." The Priest was wounded. "I promised in good faith." "Faith is yours," said the Judge, "arithmetic is mine." They sat up all night and found a way: two villages now, two after the harvest, and an honest letter from the Priest to each. The villages loved him more for the letter than for the grain. **Rule:** the Saturn sub-season inside a Jupiter season turns promises into schedules; meet it with honesty and it strengthens the season.*

What to do, and what not to do

This season rewards practices more than purchases, whether Jupiter is on your side or tests you.

- **Teach something.** A niece's maths, a colleague's spreadsheet. Jupiter's season flows best when knowledge moves through you rather than piling up in you.
- **Keep a generosity budget.** Decide in advance what you give each month, in money and in time, and give it gladly. Say no to the rest without guilt. This one habit separates those who finish richer from those who finish tired.
- **Thursday as a quiet day.** Jupiter's day in the tradition: a simpler meal, a chapter of something worth reading, yellow lentils or turmeric given to someone who cooks for others. The rhythm matters, not the ritual.
- **Do not** buy a yellow sapphire because a shop said your Jupiter is weak. If Jupiter tests you, strengthening it is the opposite of what you want; if it is on your side, conduct does more than a stone.
- **Do not** stand guarantor for anyone's loan in the Rahu sub-season.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: In a Jupiter season, say yes to learning and no to lending. Most of the regret I hear about from these sixteen years comes from the second kind of yes.

Two lives approaching the Priest's years

None of our three case-study people is in a Jupiter season as I write; two are approaching it, so this is a forward look. The dates are solid, because the timetable is arithmetic; the texture is a reading of tendencies, what I would say to a friend over tea, not a prophecy.

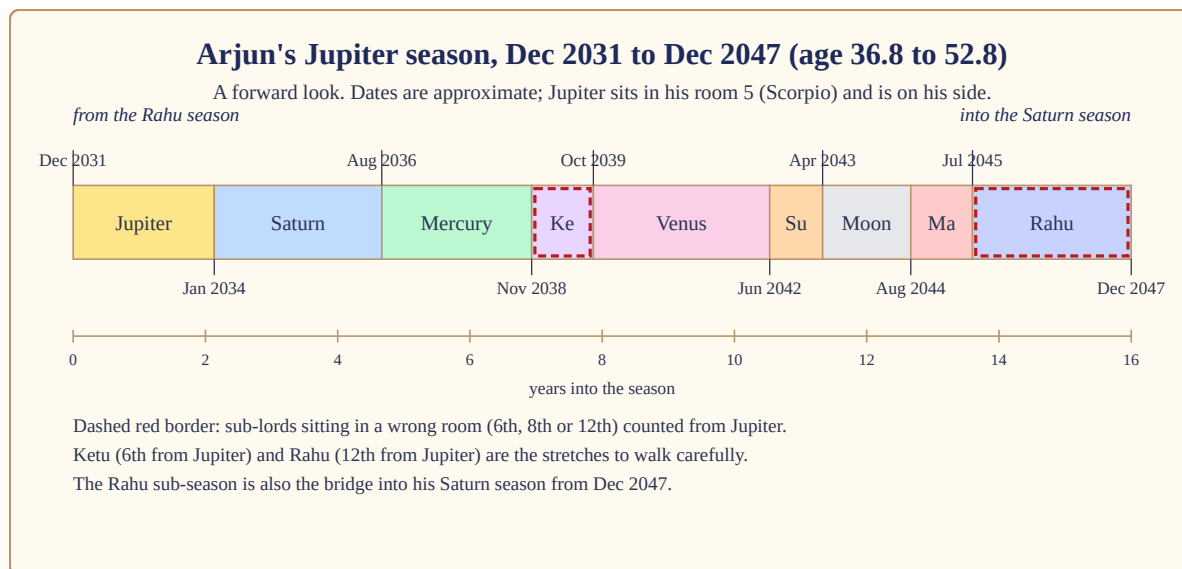


Figure 10.2: Arjun's Jupiter season, December 2031 to December 2047. The dashed sub-seasons are those whose lords sit in a wrong room counted from his Jupiter.

Arjun, Cancer rising. His Rahu season ends around December 2031, and Jupiter runs until December 2047, from age 36.8 to 52.8. For Cancer rising Jupiter owns rooms 6 and 9, and the 9th wins: Jupiter is on his side. It sits in his room 5, Scorpio, the room of children, students and creative work, in the sign of his best planet, Mars. On paper this should feel like coming home after a long hard trip: a teacher, perhaps a child, work that uses his judgement.

Counting rooms from Jupiter in Scorpio: his Saturn, Sun and Mercury in Aquarius are 4th from it, Venus 3rd, the Moon 7th, Mars 10th; none in a wrong room. Two are: Ketu in Aries, 6th from Jupiter (around November 2038 to October 2039), and Rahu in Libra, 12th (around July 2045 to December 2047). So the first dozen years look clear, with the usual Saturn slowing from early 2034 to mid 2036; the short Ketu stretch may bring a withdrawal he should not act on hastily; and the closing Rahu years are his bridge into Saturn, where I would want him finishing things. That is as far as I will go.

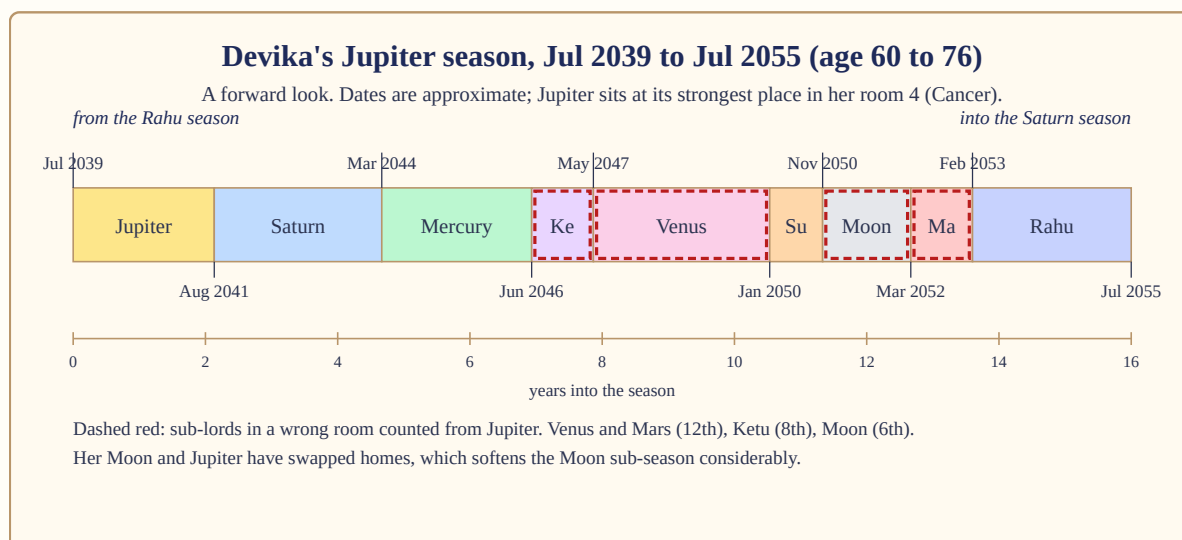


Figure 10.3: Devika's Jupiter season, July 2039 to July 2055, age 60 to 76. Several sub-lords sit in wrong rooms from her Jupiter, but her Jupiter itself is unusually strong.

Devika, Aries rising. Her Jupiter season runs from around July 2039 to July 2055, age 60 to 76. For Aries rising Jupiter owns rooms 9 and 12, and again the 9th wins. Her Jupiter sits at its strongest place, Cancer, in her room 4, the room of home, mother and inner peace, beside her Sun; and her Moon and Jupiter have exchanged homes, which the tradition reads as a binding of mind and wisdom.

Four sub-lords do sit in wrong rooms from her Jupiter: Venus and Mars in Gemini (12th), Ketu in Aquarius (8th), the Moon in Sagittarius (6th, softened by that exchange). So the Venus years, around May 2047 to January 2050, may bring expenses and a quieter social life rather than the usual sweetness. Against that, a Jupiter this strong in the room of home tends to carry its season. If I were reading for her in 2039 I would say: this is your season to teach, to settle, to give the household its shape. Enjoy it.

STORY: THE PRIEST'S TWO PUPILS. *The Priest once took two pupils. The first came from the lucky rooms of the palace, and every lesson landed softly. The second was the treasurer's son, and every lesson came with a cost: a fee, a duty, a ledger to balance. Years later both were wise. "Who learned more?" asked the King. "The same," said the Priest. "Who paid more?" "The second. And he will never lend grain he does not have."* **Rule:** *when Jupiter tests you, the season still teaches; it only charges tuition.*

In one breath

- The Jupiter season is sixteen years when the Royal Priest runs the household: teachers, children, faith, law, wealth and expansion of every kind, including weight and debt.
- It asks you to grow in the right direction, to give within a budget, and to decide what you believe.
- Whether Jupiter is on your side depends on your rising sign; for Taurus, Gemini, Virgo, Libra, Capricorn and Aquarius rising it owns the wrong rooms, and its blessings arrive with a bill.
- Watch Jupiter/Jupiter (the theme), Jupiter/Saturn (the audit), Jupiter/Mercury (the paperwork) and Jupiter/Rahu (the bridge into Saturn).
- Arjun enters this season around December 2031 and Devika around July 2039; both have Jupiter on their side, with a few sub-seasons to walk carefully.

Try this

1. Find your rising sign in the table and note whether Jupiter is on your side. If you have lived through any of a Jupiter season, write three things that grew in those years. Were they the things you wanted?
2. In a free app, find your Jupiter season, past or future, and mark the Jupiter/Saturn and Jupiter/Rahu sub-seasons. If they are past, what slowed in the first and what tempted you in the second?

3. Count the rooms from your Jupiter to each other planet. Which sit in the 6th, 8th or 12th from it? Note those sub-seasons' dates.
4. A factual check: for Cancer rising, which rooms does Jupiter own, and why is it counted as on your side?

Answers

4. Sagittarius and Pisces are rooms 6 and 9 for Cancer rising. Parashara's rule treats the lord of a lucky room (1, 5 or 9) as on your side, and the 9th outweighs the 6th; Arjun's chart is an example.

Chapter 11: The Saturn Season (19 Years): The Long Audit

Nobody comes to me excited about their Saturn season. They come with the phrase "Saturn is coming" said the way you would say a monsoon is coming to a house with a leaking roof.

The Saturn season is nineteen years when the old Judge of Labour runs the household. It is slow, serious, and it does not let you skip steps. It is also, in my experience, the season that builds the most: a house paid for, a skill actually learned, a body finally looked after, a short list of friends who are real. It is the season people fear and the one they thank, usually about ten years later.

None of our three case-study lives is in a Saturn season yet, so this chapter leans on a composite, a man I read for in Saturn/Saturn at 52, with Meera's far-future season as a note. Dates are approximate, to within a month or two.



The Saturn season in three panels.

The Judge runs the household

STORY: THE JUDGE OPENS THE LEDGER. When the old Judge of Labour took the keys, he did not open the storerooms as the Priest had. He opened the ledger. Every courtier was shown their page: what they had promised, done and borrowed. The Minister of Pleasure wept; the Prince talked very fast; the Commander found the gate locked. "I am not punishing anyone," said the Judge. "I am reading. Then we will work until the pages balance, and after that you will be free in a way you have never been." The courtiers who worked grew strong. The ones who argued with the ledger grew old. **Rule:** Saturn's season is an audit, not a sentence; the work it asks for is the work you were always going to have to do.

The season asks three things. **Do the work, slowly:** Saturn stands for labour, discipline, delay and endurance, and whatever you have been avoiding (the qualification, the debt, the body) comes to the front of the queue and stays there. **Accept limits:** the season teaches the difference between what you want and what you can carry. **Serve someone:** Saturn is the servant in the court, the planet of workers, elders and the poor, and the season goes better for people who have someone to look after.

How it feels

Body. Bones, teeth, joints, nerves, anything chronic rather than sudden; fatigue is the common complaint. A period to take long-term health seriously: sleep, posture, the back, a yearly check.

Mind. Sober. Many describe the first years as a grey filter, not sadness exactly but a loss of lightness; later it settles into a steadiness they would not trade. If the greyness becomes an inability to get out of bed, that is a doctor's matter.

Home. Responsibility for elders, repairs, a practical move, fewer guests.

Love. Saturn tests commitments, which strengthens the real ones and exposes the rest. Loneliness is a theme even inside a good marriage.

Work. Saturn's real home: long hours, slow rises, recognition that comes late and lasts.

Money. Slow and steady, paying down rather than piling up; debt is what this season punishes.

The arc of nineteen years

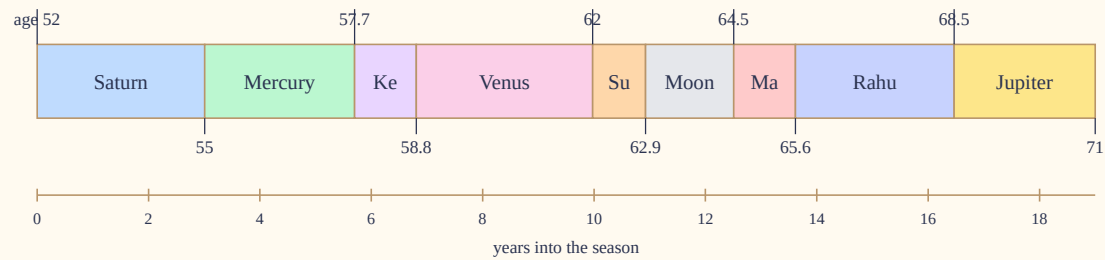
The first year. The Saturn/Saturn sub-season lasts three years, so the "first year" is really a first phase, often the heaviest of the nineteen. Something is taken off the table: a plan, a comfort, an illusion.

The middle. From about year three to fourteen the season runs through Mercury, Ketu, Venus, Sun, Moon and Mars. The Venus stretch, around years six to nine, is the kindest; the short Sun, Moon and Mars years are where the building becomes visible.

The last year. Rahu and then Jupiter close the season, and the Jupiter stretch (the final two and a half years) is where Saturn pays. The old books say Saturn gives his results late, and this is the lateness: the promotion, the finished house, late respect.

A Saturn season by age: the composite man who began it at 52

Nineteen years in nine sub-seasons. Each lasts (19 x the sub-lord's years) / 120.



Longest: Venus (3y 2m), Saturn (3y 0m), Rahu (2y 10m), Mercury (2y 8m), Jupiter (2y 6m).

Shortest: Sun (11m 12d), Ketu and Mars (1y 1m each), Moon (1y 7m).

Figure 11.1: Nineteen years in nine sub-seasons, by age, for the composite man who began his Saturn season at 52.

WHY NINETEEN YEARS, AND WHY SO SLOW? Two answers, kept apart. The length is tradition: Parashara's 120-year timetable gives Saturn 19 years and no reason, and I will not invent one. The slowness is astronomy: Saturn takes about 29.5 years to circle the sky, about two and a half years a sign, the slowest of the visible planets, so the ancients gave the slowest hand on the clock the meanings of slowness: delay, age, things that last. Everyday parallel: the hour hand seems not to move, yet it is the hand that tells the real time.

When Saturn is on your side, and when it tests you

Saturn owns Capricorn and Aquarius; your rising sign decides which rooms those are.

Rising sign	Saturn owns rooms	Saturn and you	The season tends to bring
Aries	10 and 11	○ tests you	career pressure, ambition without ease
Taurus	9 and 10	● on your side, your best planet	fortune through work; a late, lasting rise
Gemini	8 and 9	● on your side	slow luck, inheritance, deep study
Cancer	7 and 8	◐ neutral	partnership and hidden matters tested
Leo	6 and 7	○ tests you	work, health and marriage under audit
Virgo	5 and 6	◐ neutral	children and service weigh; study rewarded
Libra	4 and 5	● on your side, your best planet	home, property and children built solidly
Scorpio	3 and 4	○ tests you, mildly	effort for home and comfort; fair but demanding
Sagittarius	2 and 3	○ tests you	money and family slow; courage earned
Capricorn	1 and 2	● on your side	your own planet's season; identity and wealth mature
Aquarius	12 and 1	● on your side	your own planet's season; solitude becomes strength
Pisces	11 and 12	○ tests you	expenses, foreign places; gains that leave

WHY? The system's own logic from Parashara. A naturally hard planet that owns a lucky room (1, 5 or 9) becomes your worker rather than your warden, and one that owns a pillar room (4, 7 or 10) loses its harshness there; Saturn is the best planet for Taurus and Libra rising because it owns both at once. For Aries, Leo, Sagittarius and Pisces it owns rooms 3, 6, 11 or 12, the rooms of effort, struggle, greed and loss, and keeps its sternness. Everyday parallel: a strict teacher is a gift when she teaches your child, and a burden when she is your landlord.

When Saturn tests you, the answer is not to fight it but to out-work it: do the dull thing, on time, for years.

The room Saturn sits in changes the story

Saturn in room	The season leans towards
1	you age into yourself; responsibility, a serious face
2	slow money, careful speech, duty to family
3	effort rewarded; work with the hands, siblings' burdens
4	home repairs, mother's care, property through patience
5	children's matters delayed or demanding; disciplined study
6	Saturn's good room: debts cleared, enemies outlasted, service
7	marriage tested and matured; partnerships that need contracts
8	inheritance, research, chronic matters managed
9	a late teacher, journeys for work, father's affairs
10	Saturn's other good room: a career built brick by brick
11	gains through labour, elder siblings' needs, a truer circle
12	foreign work, hospitals as service, solitude

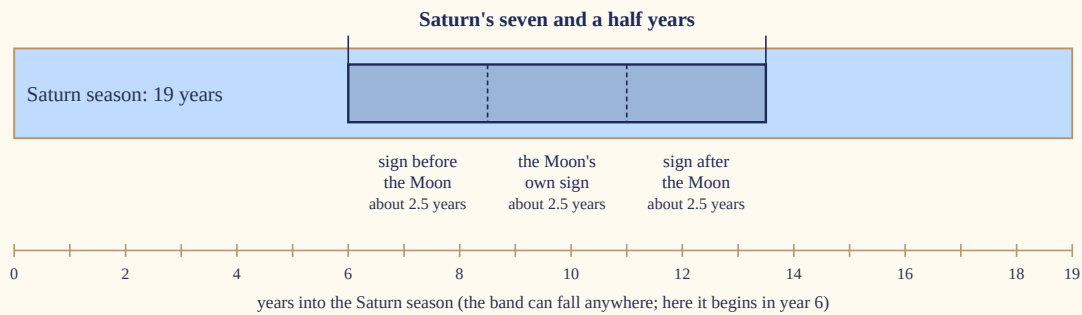
Saturn's seven and a half years inside a Saturn season

Now the thing people fear most.

Saturn's seven and a half years (Sade Sati) is weather, not season. It is the stretch when Saturn, moving overhead now, passes through the sign before your Moon, your Moon's own sign, and the sign after it: three signs at about two and a half years each. Everyone gets it roughly every thirty years, in any season (Chapter 14). When it falls inside a Saturn season, you hear the Judge twice: through the season and through the sky. Of all the stretches in all nine seasons, this is the heaviest. Not the worst; the heaviest.

The audit years: seven and a half inside nineteen

Two voices of the same Judge at once: the season (the long bar) and the weather overhead (the dark band).



Why 7.5 years: Saturn needs about 2.5 years to cross one sign, and the band covers three signs,

the sign before your Moon, the Moon's own sign, and the sign after it. Three times 2.5 is 7.5.

Why it often falls inside a Saturn season: Saturn circles the sky in about 29.5 years, so in any 19-year stretch it crosses about two thirds of the zodiac. Many Saturn seasons catch the band; some do not.

What it feels like: the same Judge speaking by season and by weather. Heavier, and the clearest audit of all.

Figure 11.2: A nineteen-year Saturn season with a seven-and-a-half-year band of Saturn's weather inside it; the band can fall anywhere, or miss the season entirely.

WHY IS THIS THE HEAVIEST STRETCH, AND WHY DOES IT BUILD THE MOST? Both answers are the system's own logic. Heaviest: the season says which planet's themes fill your years, and the weather says which planet is pressing on your mind (the Moon) right now; when both are Saturn, there is no second voice to soften the first. Builds the most: Saturn stands for labour, longevity and anything that lasts, and the tradition, Parashara included, says Saturn gives his results late and keeps them. Whatever you make while two Saturns are watching is made properly. Everyday parallel: a bridge inspected by two engineers takes twice as long to approve, and it is the one you trust for forty years.

STORY: THE JUDGE VISITS THE QUEEN MOTHER. In his seventh year as head of the household, the Judge went to live in the Queen Mother's wing, as he does every thirty years. She had always run the mood of the palace, and now the mood was his: sober breakfasts, early nights, every worry written down and dated. The courtiers said the palace had never been so gloomy. The Queen Mother said it had never been so honest: "He only asks me what is true, and then helps me carry it." When he left, her accounts were clear for the first time. **Rule:** when Saturn's weather crosses your Moon inside a Saturn season, the task is honesty about your own mind; it is the heaviest stretch and the most clarifying.

The sub-seasons that matter most

As always: is the sub-lord a friend of Saturn, and in which room does it sit counted from Saturn? A sub-lord in the 6th, 8th or 12th room from Saturn is in a wrong room, and its sub-season pulls against the season even when the planets are friendly.

Saturn/Saturn (the first 3 years). The Judge alone, the longest opening sub-season of any planet. If Saturn is on your side, this lays a foundation that carries nineteen years; if it tests you, the avoided work becomes unavoidable. Either way, start.

Saturn/Mercury (2 years 8 months). Friends, and a working sub-season: training, qualifications, paperwork. If Mercury sits in a wrong room from Saturn, the paperwork is about debts or disputes.

Saturn/Venus (3 years 2 months). The longest sub-season and the kindest: the Minister of Pleasure is let back into the Judge's palace, with a budget. In a wrong room from Saturn, expect expense and strain instead.

Saturn/Jupiter (the last 2 years 6 months). The Priest closes the Judge's season: the paying-out stretch, where nineteen years of work become visible.

What to do, and what not to do

Practices, not stones. In nineteen years you will be offered a blue sapphire more than once. Decline.

- **Pick one dull thing and do it daily.** A walk, a page of a textbook, a ledger. Saturn rewards repetition, not intensity; the habit you keep for nineteen years is what you will have at the end.
- **Serve someone below you in the world's eyes.** The domestic worker, the watchman, the elderly neighbour, the stray dog. Saturn is their planet.
- **Saturday as a plain day.** Saturn's day in the tradition: simple food, an early night, a blanket given to someone who needs it.
- **Do not** borrow to look prosperous, and do not mistake the season's greyness for a verdict on your life. It is a filter, and it lifts.

IF YOU READ FOR OTHERS: Never say "Saturn is coming" and leave it there; say it is slow, it builds, and where it eases. Hopelessness that does not lift goes to a doctor the same week.

A man in Saturn/Saturn at 52

A composite from my notebook. Call him R. He came to me at 52, two years into his Saturn season, in Saturn/Saturn, with Saturn's seven and a half years also running over his Moon. Both voices at once.

He was a manager in a manufacturing firm, Taurus rising, so Saturn owned his rooms 9 and 10 and was his best planet. Nobody had told him this; a relative and an app had told him his Saturn years would be his undoing. He described the previous two years: a restructuring that gave him a harder role running a plant, his father's health needing his weekends, a loan for a flat that ate half his salary, and a persistent tiredness he put down to age.

I had him read the Taurus row aloud, then told him the honest thing: Saturn/Saturn would run until about his fifty-fifth birthday; the seven and a half years would lift about three years after that; the Mercury sub-season would suit him; and the Venus years, from about 58 to 62, would be when the flat felt like a home and the plant job turned into a reputation. I asked him to keep the loan payments as the first line of every month, mentor one person at the plant, and see a doctor about the tiredness rather than blaming the planet. He did all three; the tiredness had an ordinary cause, now managed. At 56 he told me the plant was the best work he had ever done, and that Saturn was no longer the enemy but the man with the ledger who had, for once, been on his side.

A note on Meera. Her Saturn season lies far ahead: around May 2084 to June 2103, from age 95.5, with Saturn/Saturn running until about June 2087. For Scorpio rising Saturn tests her mildly, owning rooms 3 and 4, and hers sits in room 2, outshone by the Sun: a season of family duty and careful speech at the very end of a long life. Arjun's begins around December 2047, at 52.8.

STORY: THE JUDGE'S LATE PAYMENT. *On the last day of his nineteen years, the courtiers gathered to see the Judge hand back the keys, expecting a lecture. Instead he opened the ledger to the last page and read out what each now owned: the Commander, a fortress built stone by stone; the Minister, a garden tended through two droughts; the Prince, a library. "You thought I was taking," said the Judge. "I was holding. Here it is."* **Rule:** Saturn gives late and gives what lasts; the end of the season is where the work is paid.

In one breath

- The Saturn season is nineteen years when the old Judge of Labour runs the household: work, limits, duty to elders, loneliness, maturity and slow rewards.
- The length is tradition; the slowness is astronomy, from Saturn's 29.5-year walk around the sky.
- Whether Saturn is on your side depends on your rising sign: best for Taurus and Libra, sternest for Aries, Leo, Sagittarius and Pisces.
- Saturn's seven and a half years is weather, not season; inside a Saturn season both voices say the same thing: the heaviest stretch, and the one that builds the most.
- Watch Saturn/Saturn (the weight lands), Saturn/Mercury (the training), Saturn/Venus (the kindness) and Saturn/Jupiter (the payment).
- Practices, not stones: one dull daily habit, service to someone below you, plain Saturdays, no new debt. Hopelessness that does not lift is a doctor's matter.

Try this

1. Find your rising sign in the table and note whether Saturn is on your side, tests you or is neutral. If you have lived through any of a Saturn season, write what you built in those years.
2. In a free app, find your Moon sign and work out when Saturn's seven and a half years last ran or will next run. Does it fall inside your Saturn season?
3. Choose the one dull daily thing you would keep for nineteen years, and start tomorrow.
4. A factual check: why is Saturn's seven and a half years that long, and is the length tradition or astronomy?

Answers

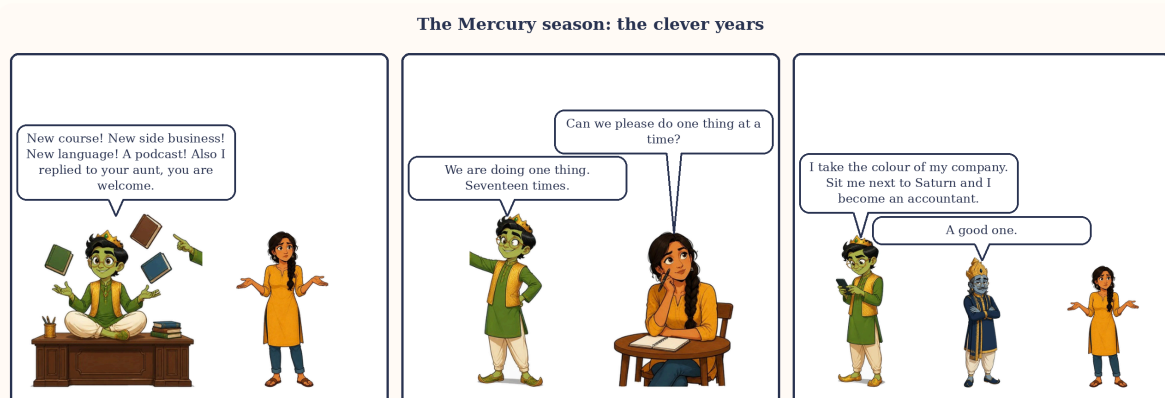
4. Saturn takes about two and a half years to cross one sign, and the stretch covers three signs (the one before your Moon, the Moon's own sign, and the one after): three times two and a half is seven and a half. The length is astronomy, from Saturn's orbit; the choice of these three signs around the Moon is tradition.

Chapter 12: The Mercury Season (17 Years): The Clever Years

After the Judge, the Prince. The Mercury season comes straight after Saturn's nineteen years in the fixed order, and people who live through that changeover describe it the same way: the window opens. Suddenly there are ideas, conversations, a course, a trip, three plans at once. The clever young Prince has the keys, and the palace fills with messengers.

For many readers, though, it is the first season of childhood, because the Moon's star at birth so often lands them there; Meera is one of those. Either way, the season asks the same thing of a child or a seventy-year-old: learn, speak, trade, move, and do not scatter yourself so thin that nothing finishes.

One warning first, and it is the key to the chapter: Mercury has no fixed nature; the Prince takes the colour of his company, so this season is read from who Mercury sits with in your chart. As throughout this part, dates for our case-study lives are approximate, to within a month or two.



The Mercury season in three panels.

The Prince runs the household

STORY: THE PRINCE TAKES THE COLOUR OF THE ROOM. When the clever young Prince took the keys, the court noticed how he changed with his company. In the Priest's study he spoke of law. In the Minister of Pleasure's garden he wrote songs. Beside the Commander he grew sharp-tongued. Beside the Judge he became a careful clerk who finished every file. Left alone, he was simply bright and busy, loyal to no plan for more than a week. "Who are you, really?" asked the Queen Mother. "Whoever I am standing next to," said the Prince, "so choose my company carefully." **RULE:** Mercury has no nature of its own; its season takes the colour of the planets it sits with and the room it sits in.

The season asks three things. **Learn, and keep learning:** Mercury stands for intellect, speech, writing, mathematics, trade and the nerves, and seventeen years of it is a long schooling at any age. **Trade honestly:** the season rewards cleverness and punishes cleverness that cuts corners, because the Prince gets caught. **Finish something:** Mercury's weakness is scatter, and the season's deepest task is to turn quickness into completion.

How it feels

Body. Nerves, skin, lungs and sleep. People feel wired: a busy head at night, meals at odd hours. Take the nerves seriously in plain ways: less caffeine, more walking, a fixed bedtime.

Mind. Fast, curious, easily bored, youthful at any age. People pick up new technology quickly; they also worry quickly, running the same thought in circles. The gift is adaptability; the shadow is anxiety dressed as planning.

Home. Siblings, cousins and neighbours matter more. Books, devices and paperwork pile up; short trips, moves for study, a child's exams.

Love. Mercury is the planet of friendship more than romance; relationships grow through talk and shared projects.

Work. Writing, teaching, accounting, trade, sales, media, software: anything where words and numbers earn the money. Several job changes in seventeen years is normal, not failure.

Money. Many small streams rather than one river; good for traders and freelancers, hard for anyone who wants a single steady salary.

The arc of seventeen years

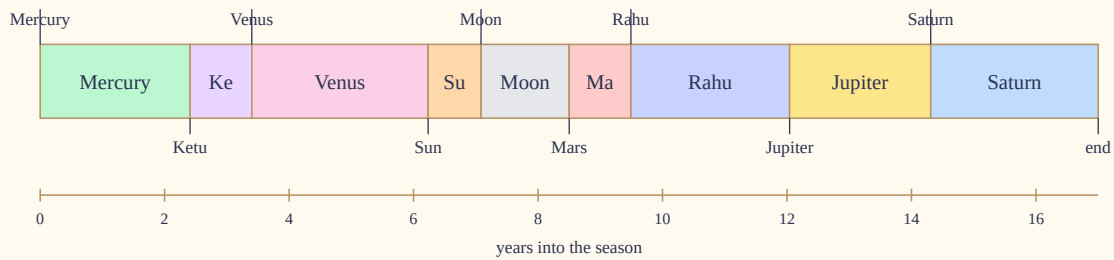
The first year. The Mercury/Mercury sub-season runs about two years five months. After Saturn, this is the window opening: offers, courses, conversations; in a child, first words and endless questions.

The middle. Years three to twelve carry Ketu, Venus, Sun, Moon, Mars and Rahu. The Venus stretch, around years three to six, is the sweetest; the Rahu stretch, around years ten to twelve, the biggest ambitions and confusions.

The last year. Jupiter and then Saturn close the season. The Saturn sub-season (the final two years eight months) is where the scattered threads are gathered and judged: what did you actually finish? It is also the bridge into the Ketu season, so the end often brings a quieting that surprises people.

The Mercury season: seventeen years in nine sub-seasons

Each sub-season lasts $(17 \times \text{the sub-lord's years}) / 120$. Widths are to scale.



Longest: Venus (2y 10m), Saturn (2y 8m), Rahu (2y 7m), Mercury (2y 5m), Jupiter (2y 3m).

Shortest: Sun (10m 6d), Ketu and Mars (11m 27d each), Moon (1y 5m).

Figure 12.1: The seventeen-year Mercury season in its nine sub-seasons, to scale.

WHY DOES MERCURY TAKE THE COLOUR OF ITS COMPANY? This is Parashara's own rule, written into the planet's nature in the classical texts: Mercury is kind alone or with kind planets, and difficult with difficult ones. The logic is that Mercury is the intellect, and the intellect has no values of its own; a clever thief and a clever doctor are both clever. Everyday parallel: the youngest child in a joint family, polite at the grandparents' table and wild at the cousins' table, honest both times.

When Mercury is on your side, and when it tests you

Mercury owns Gemini and Virgo; your rising sign decides which rooms those are, and so whether the Prince works for you or against you.

Rising sign	Mercury owns rooms	Mercury and you	The season tends to bring
Aries	3 and 6	○ tests you	effort, competition, debts, paperwork about disputes
Taurus	2 and 5	● on your side	money through speech, children's learning, creative work
Gemini	1 and 4	● on your side	your own planet's season; identity, home and education grow
Cancer	12 and 3	○ tests you	expenses, travel, siblings' needs; busy for little return
Leo	11 and 2	○ tests you	gains with greed, money through talk; watch your promises
Virgo	1 and 10	● on your side	your own planet's season; a career of skill and words
Libra	9 and 12	● on your side	fortune through learning, foreign places, a distant teacher
Scorpio	8 and 11	○ tests you	sudden changes, gains with strings, hidden research
Sagittarius	7 and 10	● neutral	partnership and career demanding; a kind planet in two pillars
Capricorn	6 and 9	● on your side	fortune through service and study; the 9th wins
Aquarius	5 and 8	● neutral	children and transformation; mixed, read the company
Pisces	4 and 7	○ tests you	home and marriage both busy; two pillars for a kind planet

WHY? The system's own logic, from Parashara: lords of the lucky rooms (1, 5, 9) help you, lords of 3, 6 and 11 work against you, and a naturally kind planet owning the pillar rooms (4, 7, 10) loses its kindness there. For most rising signs Mercury owns one helpful room and one unhelpful one, and the table shows which wins. Everyday parallel: a smart cousin can be the one who files your taxes or the one who talks you into a bad investment, depending on where he sits at the family table.

Even so, remember the colour rule: a testing Mercury with Jupiter gives a mild, bookish season; a helpful Mercury with Rahu in the 8th room gives a brilliant, risky one.

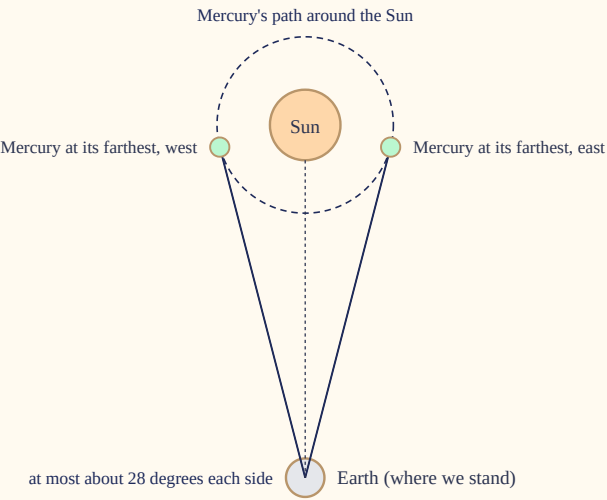
The room Mercury sits in changes the story

Mercury in room	The season leans towards
1	you become the talker, the explainer; youthful looks, a restless body
2	money through speech and trade; a family of talkers
3	writing, siblings, short journeys, small skills; Mercury's natural room
4	education, a home office, mother's influence on the mind
5	clever children, exams, games of skill; creative writing
6	service through skill, accounts, disputes won on paper
7	a talkative or younger partner; business partnerships
8	research, secrets, paperwork; a sharp mind turned to hidden things
9	higher study, publishing, a teacher met through travel
10	a career of words and numbers; several job changes
11	gains through networks, friends in trade; many small incomes
12	foreign study or work, writing in solitude, expenses on courses

Never far from the King

Why the Prince is never far from the King

Mercury circles inside the Earth's path, so from here it never appears more than about 28 degrees from the Sun.



So in every birth chart Mercury sits in the Sun's sign or the one next door, and is often outshone by it. Not to scale. This is astronomy, not tradition: it is simply where Mercury can ever be seen from here.

Figure 12.2: Mercury's path lies inside the Earth's, so from here it never strays far from the Sun.

WHY IS MERCURY NEVER FAR FROM THE SUN? Astronomy, not tradition. Mercury circles the Sun inside the Earth's own path, so from where we stand it can never swing out more than about 28 degrees from the Sun. So in every birth chart Mercury is in the same sign as the Sun or the sign next door, and it is often outshone by the Sun, so close that its own light is lost in the King's. An outshone Mercury gives a bright mind that struggles to be heard apart from authority: the father, the boss. Everyday parallel: the clever younger brother always introduced as "so-and-so's brother", who takes years to be known by his own name.

STORY: THE PRINCE AND THE KING. The Prince was never allowed far from the throne. Wherever the King went, the Prince went a few steps behind, carrying the letters. Sometimes he stood so close to the King's blaze that nobody saw him at all, and his best ideas were announced in the King's voice. He did not sulk. He wrote everything down, so that when the King was away, even briefly, the court discovered how much of its cleverness had been his. **Rule:** Mercury is always within a sign of the Sun; when outshone, it works best in writing and in the King's absence.

The sub-seasons that matter most

Two questions for every sub-season: is the sub-lord Mercury's friend, and in which room does it sit counted from Mercury? A sub-lord in the 6th, 8th or 12th room from Mercury is in a wrong room, and its stretch pulls against the season even if the planets like each other.

Mercury/Mercury (the first 2 years 5 months). The Prince alone. If Mercury is on your side, the window opens: study, offers, a new skill. If it tests you, a busy, scattered start where much begins and little finishes.

Mercury/Venus (2 years 10 months, the longest). Friends, and the sweetest sub-season: charm, friendships, art, money through pleasant work. If Venus sits in a wrong room from Mercury, it turns into expenses and distraction.

Mercury/Rahu (2 years 7 months). The Stranger in the Prince's palace: technology, foreign places, big ideas, confusion. People change careers, move countries or fall for a scheme here; keep contracts in writing.

Mercury/Saturn (the last 2 years 8 months). Friends, and the gathering: the Judge comes to see what the Prince has finished. Good for qualifications and serious decisions, and the bridge into the Ketu season.

What to do, and what not to do

Practices, not stones. An emerald will not organise your mind; a notebook will.

- **Keep one notebook, not six.** Mercury's season scatters; a single place for every idea, list and plan is the most useful practice I know for these years.
- **Learn one thing to completion each year.** A language level, a certificate, a recipe book cooked through. The point is the finishing.
- **Wednesday as a learning day.** Mercury's day in the tradition: an hour of study, a letter actually written, green moong or a book given to a child who needs one. Rhythm over ritual.
- **Walk and breathe.** Mercury rules the nerves and the lungs; a daily walk and slow breathing do more than any clever system.
- **Do not** sign anything in the Rahu sub-season that you have not read twice, slowly, and do not mistake restlessness for a sign that you should change everything. Sometimes it is just the Prince wanting a walk.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: In a Mercury season, judge your year by what you finished, not by what you learned about. The first list is shorter, and it is the one that counts.

Meera's childhood: born in the middle of the Prince's season

Meera was born on 12 December 1988 with the Moon at 21 degrees of Cancer, in the star Ashlesha, whose lord is Mercury. So her first season was Mercury's, and because the Moon had already crossed part of that star, she arrived with 11.475 of the seventeen years remaining: birth to around June 2000, age eleven and a half.

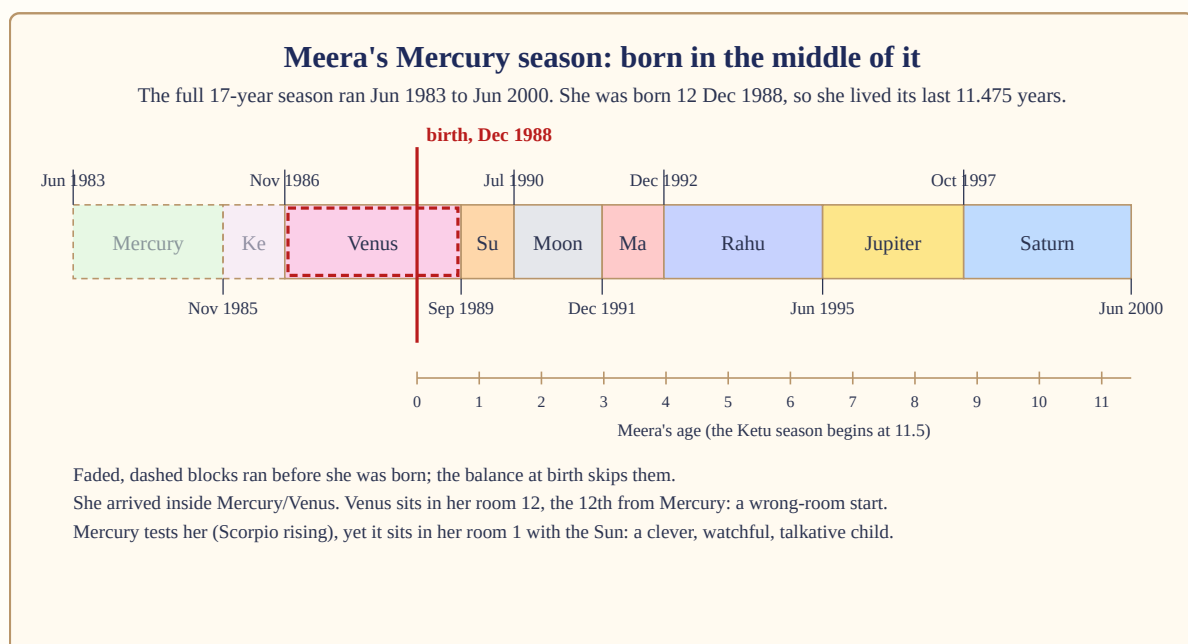


Figure 12.3: Meera was born inside the Mercury/Venus sub-season; the faded blocks ran before she arrived.

For Scorpio rising, Mercury owns rooms 8 and 11 and tests her. But read the company: her Mercury sits in room 1, Scorpio, with the Sun, 19 degrees apart, so not outshone. A testing Mercury in the room of the self, beside the King: a child who is sharp, watchful, talkative, argues back, and likes finding out what the adults are hiding.

Her sub-seasons, counted in rooms from Mercury in Scorpio: she was born inside Mercury/Venus, which ran until about September 1989. Venus sits in her room 12, the 12th from Mercury, a wrong room, which in a baby's first nine months means little beyond expenses and interrupted sleep. Then Mercury/Sun to about July 1990 (a strong-willed toddler), Mercury/Moon to about December 1991 (the Moon in her 9th: grandmother, stories), Mercury/Mars to about December 1992 (Mars in her 5th: first fights, first games), Mercury/Rahu to about June 1995 (Rahu in her 4th: a change at home, a new school), Mercury/Jupiter to about October 1997 (Jupiter in her 7th, on her side: a good teacher, learning to love reading), and Mercury/Saturn to June 2000 (Saturn in her 2nd: school getting serious, money tighter).

That last stretch led into her Ketu season, which Chapter 4 described, and into Saturn's seven and a half years over her Cancer Moon from 2000 to 2007. If you had read for her parents in 1999, the kind thing to say would have been: she has had eleven years of a bright, busy, questioning mind; the next seven will be quieter and more inward, and that is not a loss.

A note on Arjun. His Mercury season comes at the other end of life, around December 2066 to December 2083, from age 71.8. For Cancer rising Mercury owns rooms 12 and 3 and tests him, and it sits in his room 8 with the Sun and Saturn, in the Judge's company: a late season of research, writing and the sorting of family papers, careful rather than playful. Chapter 16 reads his whole life.

STORY: THE PRINCE'S UNFINISHED LETTERS. *At the end of his seventeen years the Prince brought the Judge a chest of letters. Hundreds: brilliant, witty, half-written. "Which of these did you send?" asked the Judge. The Prince counted. Eleven. "Then your season is eleven letters long," said the Judge, "and the rest is weather." The Prince took one unfinished letter, finished it, and sent it, and that was the one the kingdom remembered. Rule: a Mercury season is measured by what was finished; the Saturn sub-season at its end is when the count is taken.*

In one breath

- The Mercury season is seventeen years when the clever young Prince runs the household: learning, speech, trade, travel, nerves, youthfulness and scattered attention.
- Mercury has no nature of its own; the season takes the colour of the planets Mercury sits with and the room it sits in.
- Mercury is never more than about 28 degrees from the Sun, so it always sits in the Sun's sign or the one beside it, and is often outshone; that is astronomy.

- Whether Mercury is on your side depends on your rising sign: helpful for Taurus, Gemini, Virgo, Libra and Capricorn, testing for Aries, Cancer, Leo, Scorpio and Pisces.
- Watch Mercury/Mercury (the theme), Mercury/Venus (the sweetness), Mercury/Rahu (the confusion) and Mercury/Saturn (the count).
- Meera lived the last 11.475 years of a Mercury season as her childhood, birth to June 2000; Arjun's comes at the end of his life, from December 2066.

Try this

1. Find your rising sign in the table and note which rooms Mercury owns for you. Which planets sit with your Mercury, and in which room? Write one sentence about the colour it takes.
2. If your first season was Mercury's (your Moon in Ashlesha, Jyeshtha or Revati), ask a parent or older sibling what you were like as a child. Does it fit the Prince?
3. Make the two lists from the rule of thumb for the past year: what you learned about, and what you finished. Move one item from the first list to the second.
4. A factual check: Meera was born with 11.475 years of Mercury's season remaining. How many years had already passed, and which sub-season was running at her birth?

Answers

4. Seventeen minus 11.475 leaves 5.525 years already passed. Adding the sub-seasons in order (Mercury 2.41 years, Ketu 0.99, Venus 2.83) reaches 6.23 years, so at 5.525 years she was inside Mercury/Venus, with about 0.7 years of it left; it ended around September 1989.

Chapter 13: Where the Planet Sits Changes the Season

Two women are both in a Venus season. One spends twenty years in a house full of music, hosting weddings, buying saris she does not need. The other spends the same twenty years paying for other people's comfort, quietly, from a room at the back. Same courtier. Same years. Completely different seasons.

Part II gave you nine portraits. This chapter turns a portrait into a photograph of a particular person: where that planet sits in your own chart. Every date here is approximate.

I ask three questions of any season lord, the questions you would ask about a new manager at your office: what is this person in charge of, how strong is their position, and who do they sit with at lunch?



Same planet, different room: the three questions before you judge a season.

Question one: which rooms does it own, and which room does it sit in?

Every planet except Rahu and Ketu owns one or two signs, and in your chart each sign falls in one of the twelve rooms (bhavas, which Book 1 calls houses). So every season lord manages one or two rooms, and when its season comes the matters of those rooms arrive on your desk whether you asked for them or not.

Then there is the room the planet sits in: where the season does its work. A planet that owns the marriage room but sits in the career room runs a marriage season from the office: the partner met at work, the wedding squeezed between projects.

WHY? The system's own logic. Parashara builds the whole chart on the idea that a planet carries the business of the signs it owns into the place where it stands; the season is the years when that business comes to the front. Everyday parallel: when the finance head becomes acting director, finance files suddenly reach every department.

The dots judge the room, not the person.

Where the season lord sits	What the season tends to feel like	
A pillar room: 1, 4, 7, 10 (the kendras of Book 1)	Visible, active, out in the open; shapes life's main structure	●
A lucky room: 1, 5, 9 (the trikonas)	Fortunate, help arrives; tends to leave you better off	●
A growing room: 3, 6, 10, 11	Improves with effort; slow at first, better later	◐
Room 2	Family, money, speech; depends on the lord's nature	◐
One of the three hard rooms: 6, 8, 12	Works behind the scenes: debts, health to manage, losses, foreign places, privacy; demanding but deep	○

Question two: how strong is it?

Strength decides how much of the promise gets delivered: fully and on time, or late, thin, and in a changed form.

At home (in its own sign, which the books call swakshetra). The planet owns the sign it sits in; it has keys to every cupboard. Meera's Venus in Libra and Arjun's Saturn in Aquarius are at home.

At its strongest place (exalted). Each planet has one sign where tradition says it is lifted: the Sun in Aries, the Moon in Taurus, Mars in Capricorn, Mercury in Virgo, Jupiter in Cancer, Venus in Pisces, Saturn in Libra. Arjun's Moon and Devika's Jupiter are at their strongest places.

At its weakest place (debilitated). The sign opposite the strongest place (Jupiter in Capricorn, Saturn in Aries, and so on). None of our three has one. A friend with Jupiter at its weakest place spent his Jupiter season learning that wisdom, for him, would come through hard practical work, not teachers. He got there. The tradition softens this too: when the sign's owner is strong, much of the weakness is cancelled. Never pronounce a season weak from one line.

Outshone by the Sun (combust). A planet within about ten to seventeen degrees of the Sun. Meera's Saturn is seven degrees from her Sun; so is Arjun's. Devika's Mars is eight degrees from hers. Its season still comes, but its themes arrive mixed with the King's: identity, father, authority.

Walking backwards (retrograde). Meera's Mars and Jupiter and Arjun's Mars appear to move the wrong way against the stars. The reading I trust most: the planet's matters come back for a second look. A walking-backwards Jupiter often brings back a teacher or a faith you once dropped. Not weaker. Revisited.

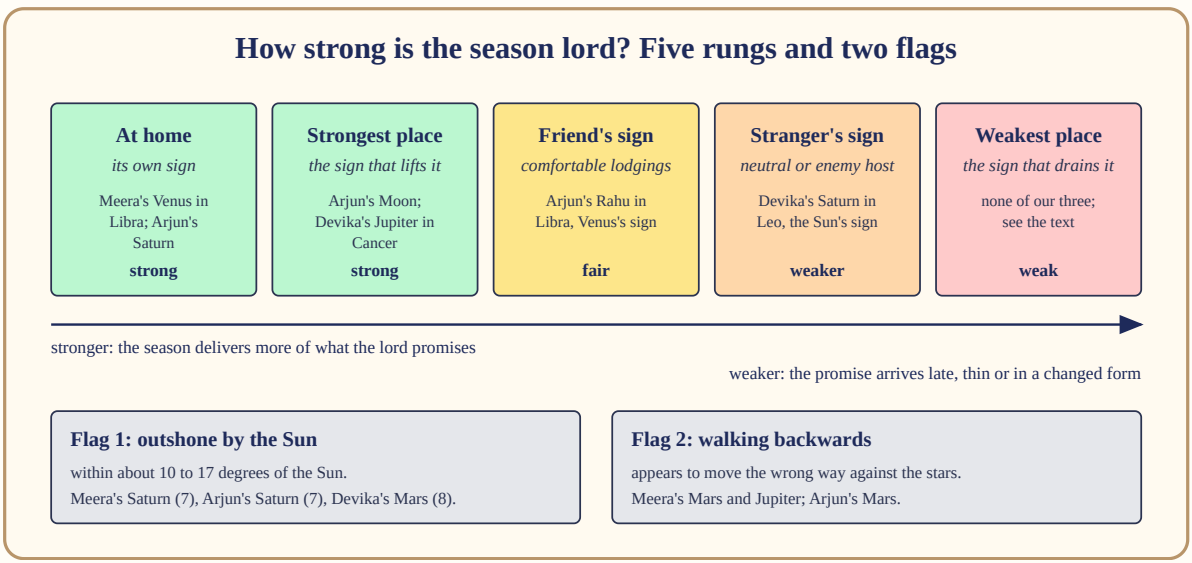


Figure 13.1: The strength ladder. The two flags change the manner of delivery rather than the amount.

WHY? Two layers here. Outshone by the Sun is astronomy: a planet near the Sun is lost in the glare, and the old astronomers took "cannot be seen" as "cannot act freely". Walking backwards is also astronomy: a planet appears to reverse when the Earth overtakes it, and at that moment it is closest to us and brightest, which is why some teachers call it strong and others disturbed. The strongest and weakest places are tradition: Parashara gives the list without a reason, and I will not invent one. Everyday parallel: everyone agrees the examination hall is quiet (astronomy); which school is best is something the city has decided over time (tradition).

STORY: THE JUDGE WHO STOOD TOO NEAR THE THRONE. The old Judge of Labour had a report to read to the court: twenty years of accounts. But he stood a step too close to the King, and the King was in full voice. Every time the Judge opened his mouth, the hall heard only the King. The accounts were real; the Judge's season still came. But the kingdom remembered those years as the King's years, about pride and position and the father's name. **Rule:** a season lord outshone by the Sun still gives its season, but its themes arrive tangled with the Sun's: identity, authority, the father, the ego.

Question three: who is it with?

A planet sharing a room with another shares its season with it. The friendship table from Book 1 (A.3 in the reference tables) says whether the company is good: the Sun with Jupiter is a King with his Priest; Saturn with Mars is the Judge and the Commander, who have never once agreed.

Two things matter more than the table: is the companion on your side, by your rising sign, and how close are they? Two planets within a few degrees are in each other's laps; fifteen degrees apart, they are at different tables.

WHY? The system's own logic again: Parashara's friendships come from the court roles, so a season lord with a friend works with help and with an enemy works with interference. Everyday parallel: a manager who shares an office with her college friend gets things done in a week; one who shares it with a rival spends the month in meetings about the meetings.

The hidden agenda: the planet whose star it sits in

Now a refinement, clearly labelled, because it comes from a more modern school.

The dasha system is built on the 27 stars: your first season is chosen by the star your Moon sits in. The modern practice influenced by K.S. Krishnamurti's school (KP astrology, twentieth century) goes one step further: every planet sits in some star, that star has a lord, and the planet quietly speaks for that lord too. A season lord has an open agenda (its own rooms and nature) and a hidden one (its star lord's). Mainstream Parashara readers do not need this step; many good astrologers use it anyway, because it answers "why did my Venus season feel like a Jupiter season?"

To find the star you need the planet's degree, which any app shows; the 27-star table is in the reference appendix. I computed all three of ours so I would not slip.

STORY: THE STRANGER WHO CARRIED THE SADHU'S MESSAGE. *The smoke-headed Stranger was given the household for eighteen years, and everyone braced for noise and hunger. But he had taken his lodgings, by chance, in the Sadhu's old cell, and the longer he lived there the more the Sadhu's silence crept into his voice. He still wanted everything. He also kept giving things away, and could not explain why. The court said: he speaks for himself, but the cell he sleeps in speaks through him. Rule: a season lord also carries the agenda of the planet whose star it sits in; the loudest voice is its own, the second comes from the star.*

Worked: Meera's Venus season, ending around June 2027

Meera is Scorpio rising, in the farewell sub-season (Venus/Ketu) of a twenty-year Venus season that runs from June 2007 to around June 2027.

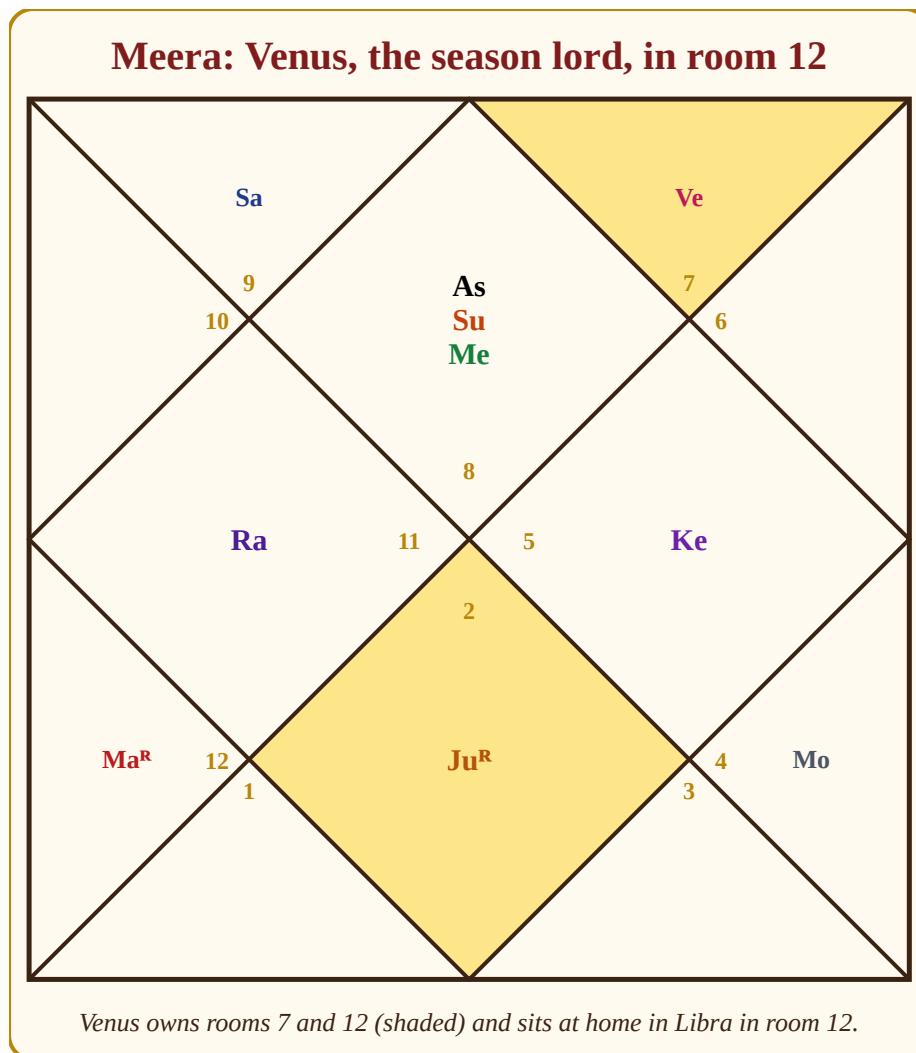


Figure 13.2: Meera's chart. Venus owns Taurus (room 7) and Libra (room 12) and sits in room 12, at home.

Rooms. Venus owns room 7 (marriage, partnership) and room 12 (expenses, foreign places, sleep, privacy, letting go), and sits in room 12. So her Venus season was always going to be about partnership, run from a private room, and paid for. For a Scorpio rising, Venus tests her, and this is how a testing Venus behaves: sweet, and costly.

Strength. At home in Libra, not outshone (her Sun is thirty-six degrees away), not walking backwards. Whatever Venus promised, it delivered: the marriage in Venus/Rahu in 2016, the comforts too, with a steady leak of money and privacy she noticed only around Venus/Saturn (2020 to 2023).

Company. Alone.

Hidden agenda. Venus at 22° Libra is in Vishakha, Jupiter's star. Her Jupiter is on her side, owns rooms 2 (family, savings) and 5 (children, creativity), and sits in room 7 in Taurus, Venus's own sign: tied in both directions. This is why her Venus season, for all its expense, built a family and a home full of books, and why her partner is more teacher than charmer.

Worked: Arjun's Rahu season, December 2013 to December 2031

Arjun is Cancer rising, in year thirteen of an eighteen-year Rahu season, in the Rahu/Venus sub-season (July 2025 to July 2028).

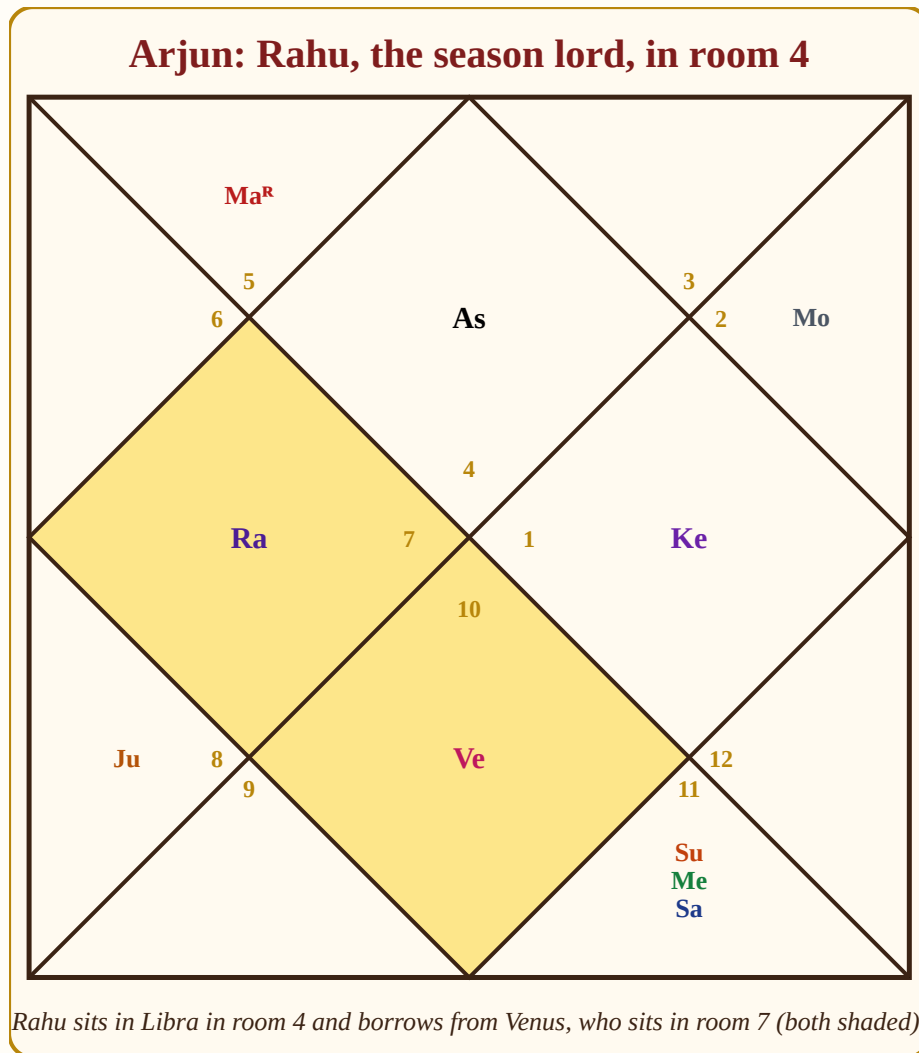


Figure 13.3: Arjun's chart. Rahu in room 4 borrows Venus's nature; Venus itself sits in room 7.

Rooms. Rahu owns nothing, so the question becomes: whose sign is it in, and where is that owner? Rahu sits in Libra in room 4 (home, mother, land, formal education). Libra belongs to Venus, who owns rooms 4 and 11 (gains, friends, networks) and sits in room 7 (partnership). So the Rahu season borrowed Venus's business: home, property, education, gains through networks, and lately partnership. He finished his studies in Rahu/Jupiter (2017), took his first job in 2018, and felt stuck in Rahu/Mercury (2022 to 2024), when the sub-lord Mercury, which tests him, sat in room 8 with his Sun and Saturn.

Strength. Rahu has no home, and the tradition argues about its strongest place, so I grade it by its landlord: Libra is a friend's sign for Rahu, and room 4 is a pillar room. Fair to strong. Neither flag applies to Rahu.

Company. Alone. Its landlord Venus sits in room 7, the fourth room counted from Rahu: not one of the wrong rooms (6, 8 or 12 from the lord) you met in Chapter 3. The current Rahu/Venus sub-season is therefore

workable: busy about partnership, not hostile.

Hidden agenda. Rahu at 12° Libra is in Swati, Rahu's own star. No second voice. This is rarer than you would think, and it makes a season single-minded: eighteen years asking where home is and what he will leave to find it.

Worked: Devika's Rahu season, July 2021 to July 2039

Devika is Aries rising, in year five of an eighteen-year Rahu season. Rahu/Jupiter ended in August 2026; Rahu/Saturn has just begun and runs to around June 2029.

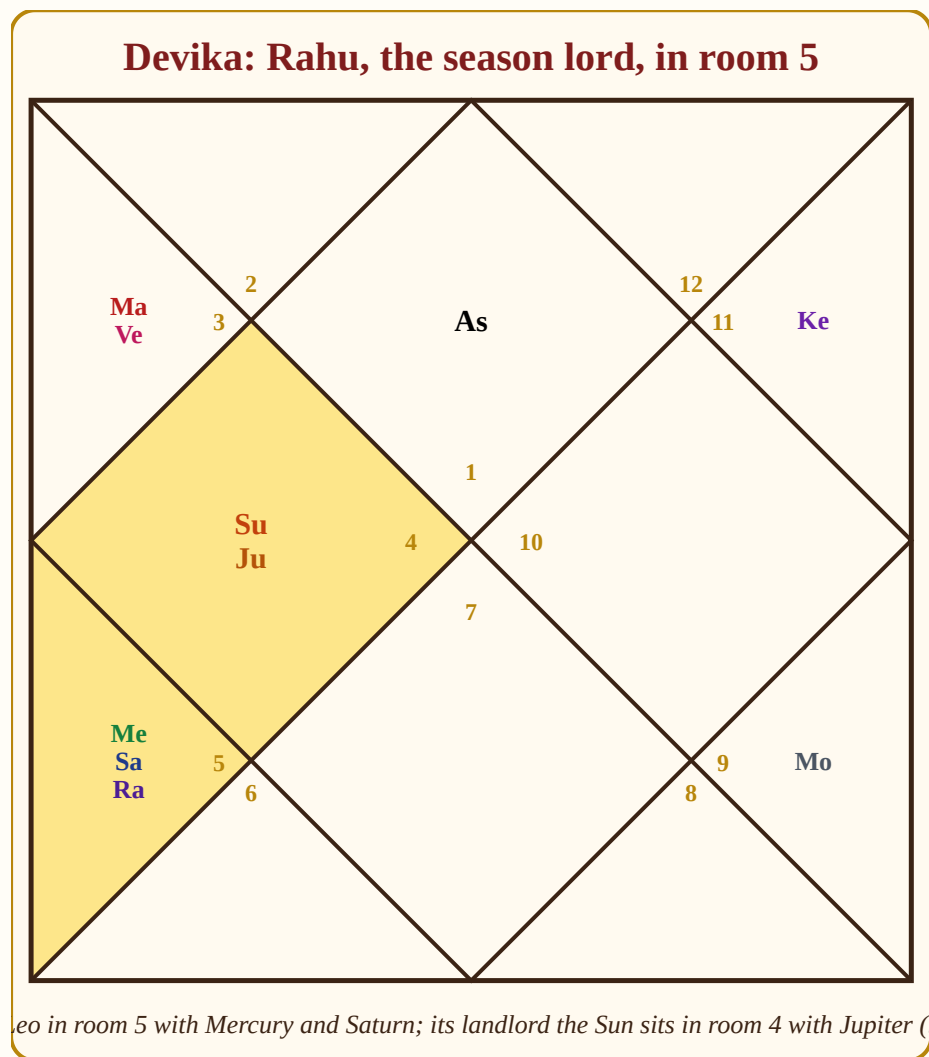


Figure 13.4: Devika's chart. Rahu, Mercury and Saturn in room 5; the landlord Sun in room 4 with Jupiter.

Rooms. Rahu sits in Leo in room 5 (children, intelligence, creativity). Leo is the Sun's sign, and her Sun, firmly on her side as an Aries rising, sits in room 4 (home, mother, land) with Jupiter at its strongest place. So Rahu borrows the Sun: a hunger for recognition, played out through her daughter, her creative work and the home. The property dispute of 2020 to 2021 sat at the changeover into this season: room 4 matters, through the Sun, arriving early.

Strength. The Sun and Rahu are not friends by any convention: an unfriendly sign, a lucky room, a very strong landlord. Mixed, but the landlord carries it.

Company. Here her season gets its texture. Mercury sits at 1° Leo, two degrees from Rahu at 3°: in Rahu's lap. Saturn sits at 18°, at the far table. Both test her, and both are friendly to Rahu, so the company helps Rahu and not her: a clever, anxious, hard-working edge. The sub-season just begun, Rahu/Saturn, puts the sub-lord in the season lord's own room: not a wrong room, but a heavy companion for nearly three years, and a stretch to let creative work be slow.

Hidden agenda. Rahu at 3° Leo is in Magha, Ketu's star. Her Rahu speaks for Ketu, which sits in room 11 (gains, friends, elder siblings): the gains of this season come through letting go. Magha is also the star of ancestors and lineage, a fair description of a property dispute inside a family.

STORY: THE MINISTER'S OWN HOUSE. *When the Minister of Pleasure was given the household, she did not move into the palace. She ran it from her own mansion, where every carpet was hers and every servant knew her. The court grumbled that she was never seen, that money left by the back gate. All true. But nothing she promised failed to arrive: the weddings were held, the music played, the beds were soft.* **Rule:** *a season lord at home delivers its promise fully, in the manner of the room it sits in.*

Reading the three answers together

	Meera: Venus	Arjun: Rahu	Devika: Rahu
Rooms owned and occupied	Owns 7 and 12, sits in 12 (hard room, but at home) 🟡	Borrows Venus (4 and 11), sits in 4 (pillar room) 🟢	Borrows the Sun (5), sits in 5 (lucky room) 🟢
Strength	At home, unflagged 🟢	Friend's sign, pillar room 🟢	Unfriendly sign, strong landlord 🟡
Company	Alone 🟡	Alone 🟡	Mercury close, Saturn far; both test her 🟠
Hidden agenda	Jupiter (on her side) 🟢	Rahu itself: one voice 🟡	Ketu (room 11) 🟡
On her or his side?	Tests her 🟠	Borrows a planet that tests him 🟡	Borrows a planet on her side 🟢

No row decides the season alone. Meera's Venus tests her from a hard room, yet it is at home and speaks for a friendly Jupiter: a sweet, expensive, family-building twenty years. Devika's Rahu has the best rooms and the hardest company: fortunate in outline, tiring in its days.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: Ask the three questions in order, rooms then strength then company, and write one sentence for each before you allow yourself an opinion. Then check the star. If it contradicts everything else, trust everything else; if it explains a puzzle, keep it.

In one breath

- Ask three questions about any season lord: which rooms it owns and sits in, how strong it is, and who it sits with.
- The rooms owned bring their matters into the season; the room occupied is where the season does its work.
- Strength in plain words: at home, strongest place, weakest place, outshone by the Sun, walking backwards. The first three are tradition; the last two are astronomy.
- Company changes the texture: a friend helps, an enemy interferes, closeness matters.
- The hidden agenda is the modern, KP-influenced refinement: a season lord also speaks for the planet whose star it sits in. Use it to explain puzzles, not to overrule the chart.
- Meera's Venus: at home in a hard room, speaking for Jupiter. Arjun's Rahu: a pillar room, speaking for itself. Devika's Rahu: a lucky room, heavy company, speaking for Ketu.

Try this

1. From your own chart, write the three answers for your current season lord in three plain sentences. No opinion yet.
2. Find your season lord's degree in your app and look up its star's lord in the reference appendix. Does the second voice explain anything about your season so far?
3. Meera's Sun sits at 28° Scorpio. Which star is that, and which planet is the hidden agenda of her coming Sun season?
4. Devika's Mercury (1° Leo) and Rahu (3° Leo); Arjun's Saturn (25° Aquarius) and Sun (18°). Which pair is closer company, and which involves a planet outshone by the Sun?
5. Think of one past season that felt unlike its portrait in Part II. Which of the three questions, or the star, best explains the difference?

Answers

3. Jyeshtha (16°40' to 30° Scorpio), whose lord is Mercury. Mercury owns her rooms 8 and 11 and sits with the Sun in room 1. 4. Devika's Mercury and Rahu are the closer company. Arjun's Saturn is outshone (seven degrees, within Saturn's limit of about fifteen). Rahu is never outshone.

Chapter 14: Weather Inside the Season

A season is a climate. Jaipur in a Venus season is still Jaipur: hot, dry, beautiful. But inside the climate there is weather. Some weeks it rains in the desert; some years the monsoon does not come. Know only the climate and you will be surprised every afternoon; know only the weather and you will never understand why the same rain is a blessing in one city and a flood in another.

The dasha system is the climate. The planets moving overhead right now are the weather (gochar, which Book 1 and most apps call transit). This chapter teaches you to read the two together, which is the only way either makes sense. Every date here is approximate; your app has the exact ones.



Weather inside the season: a transit is a visitor passing the window, not a new manager.

Only the slow planets are weather that matters for seasons

The Moon crosses a sign in about two and a quarter days; the Sun, Mercury and Venus take about a month each; Mars about a month and a half. These are showers. They matter for choosing a wedding date, not for understanding a year of your life.

Three movements are slow enough to shape a year:

- **Saturn** takes about two and a half years to cross a sign, and about twenty-nine and a half years to go round.
- **Jupiter** takes about a year a sign, twelve years for the round.
- **Rahu and Ketu** take about a year and a half a sign, eighteen and a half years for the round, moving backwards through the signs, always exactly opposite each other.

WHY? Astronomy. The further a planet is from the Sun, the slower it orbits: Jupiter's year is twelve of ours, Saturn's nearly thirty. Rahu and Ketu are not bodies but the two points where the Moon's path crosses the Sun's, and those points drift slowly backwards as the Moon's orbit wobbles. Everyday parallel: local trains rush through the platform every few minutes and you stop noticing them; the one long-distance train changes the shape of your afternoon.

Two places to stand: from the rising sign and from the Moon

A moving planet is always in some sign, which is one room counted from your rising sign and another counted from your Moon's sign. Counting from the rising sign tells you **which part of life** the weather falls on: career, home, partnership. Counting from the Moon tells you **how it will feel**, because the Moon is the mind, and the tradition's oldest weather rules are all counted from the Moon. The dots judge the room; a red dot is a room where that planet's passage is traditionally felt as pressure, not a sentence passed on you.

Moving planet	Good rooms from the Moon (classical)	The rest	Felt most as pressure
Saturn	3, 6, 11 ●	●	12, 1, 2 (the seven and a half years) and 4, 8 ○
Jupiter	2, 5, 7, 9, 11 ●	●	6, 8, 12 ○
Rahu / Ketu	3, 6, 11 ● (common practice, not Parashara)	●	1, 7, 8, 12 ○

WHY? Tradition, with a logic underneath. The classical authors give the lists without derivation, but you can see the shape: Saturn, the planet of work, is welcome in the growing rooms where effort pays and heavy on the rooms of self and comfort; Jupiter, the planet of gifts, is welcome where gifts land. Everyday parallel: a strict uncle visiting is a help at exam time and a strain at a party.

Saturn's seven and a half years, explained from the Moon

Now the weather everybody has heard of and almost everybody misunderstands: Saturn's seven and a half years (Sade Sati, which simply means "seven and a half" in Hindi).

Take your Moon's sign. Saturn, at two and a half years a sign, will at some point enter the sign before it: the first phase. Then it crosses your Moon's own sign: the second phase, the heaviest. Then the sign after: the

third, when the weight lifts. Three signs, seven and a half years in all, roughly once every thirty years: in the late twenties, the late fifties, the late eighties, give or take.

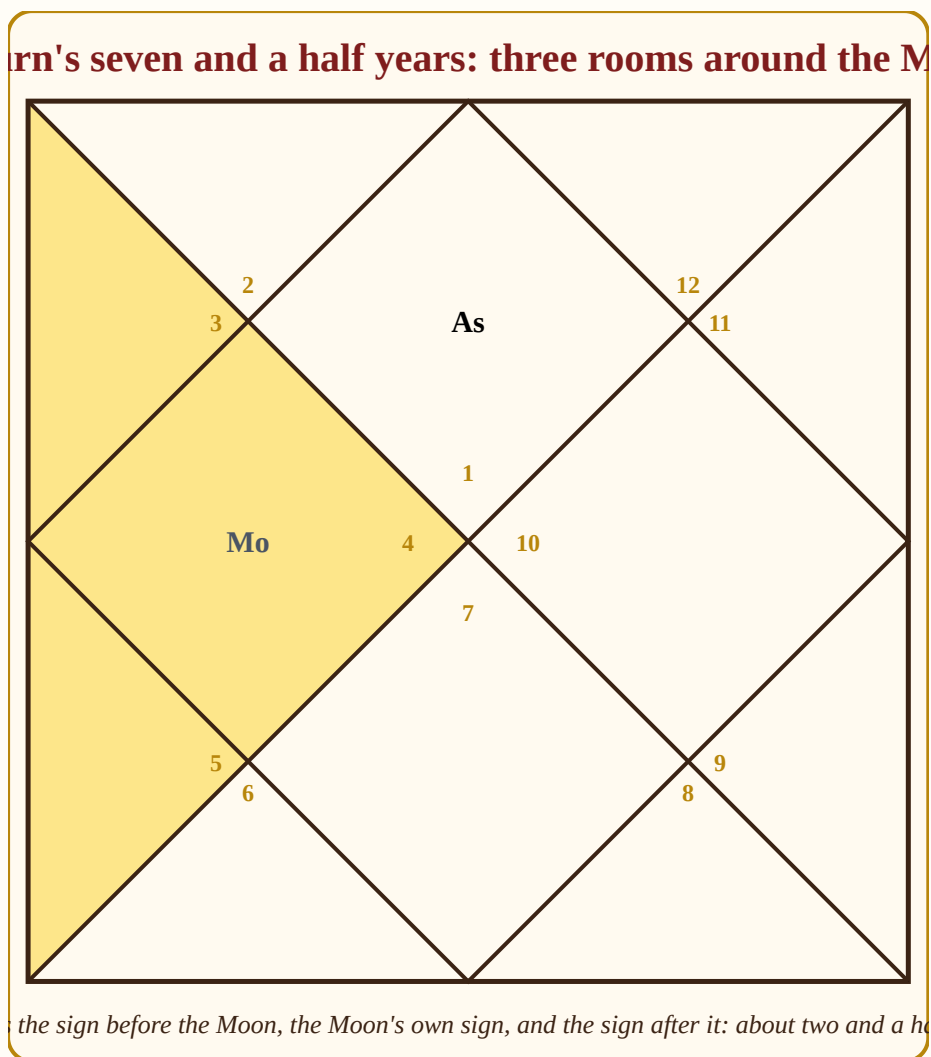


Figure 14.1: Saturn's seven and a half years. Saturn crosses the sign before the Moon, the Moon's sign, and the sign after, about two and a half years each.

Here is the honest framing, which I wish every WhatsApp forward included. Three of the twelve signs are "in" the seven and a half years at any moment: a quarter of everyone alive. As I write in late 2026, Saturn is in Pisces, so everyone with the Moon in Aquarius, Pisces or Aries is somewhere in it, hundreds of millions of people having every kind of year. When Saturn enters Aries around mid-2027, the Aquarius Moons are released and the Taurus Moons begin. It is a tide, not a curse.

What it asks is real, though. Saturn over the Moon is the old Judge of Labour going through the Queen Mother's accounts. The mind feels heavier. Things take longer. Supports you leaned on are tested: a parent ages, a job becomes work, a friendship shows its true weight. People who come out well used the years to take responsibility for something they had been avoiding. People who come out badly spent seven years waiting for it to end.

The tradition adds two smaller Saturn stretches, in the fourth and the eighth sign from the Moon, two and a half years each: lighter, but felt as pressure on home and comfort (the fourth) or on security (the eighth). And a strong Moon bears the audit better: a Moon at its strongest place, at home, or with Jupiter softens Saturn's weight. Arjun's Moon is at its strongest place; his seven and a half years, beginning around mid-2027, should be a real audit but not a crushing one.

STORY: THE JUDGE VISITS THE QUEEN MOTHER. *Once in a generation the old Judge of Labour came to audit the Queen Mother's household. He arrived in the room before hers and sat for two and a half years, reading. Then he moved into her own apartments and the palace went quiet; the feasts stopped, every servant's work was weighed. Then he moved to the room beyond and slowly the music returned. The Queen Mother who had kept honest accounts wept at the start and thanked him at the end: he had found three servants stealing and one old debt she could at last pay off. The one who had hidden things wept all the way through.* **Rule:** *Saturn's seven and a half years is an audit of the mind's household; it rewards whoever has nothing to hide and whoever starts keeping accounts now.*

The same weather, a friendly season and a testing season

The weather does not act on its own. It acts on whatever the season has already put in the room.

Picture Saturn crossing your rising sign, room 1, tiring for anyone. In a Jupiter season, with Jupiter on your side, the tiredness is the weight of real responsibility: a promotion that costs your evenings, a child, a house with a loan. You are carrying something worth carrying. In a Saturn season, with Saturn testing you, the same Saturn is the season lord itself walking over you: no gift inside it yet, only the task, which is to endure well and build slowly. Both people say "Saturn is on my rising sign and I am exhausted." Only one is in trouble, and hers is the kind that builds a person.

The same is true the other way. Jupiter over your room 10 in a friendly season is the Priest blessing work you are already doing: recognition, a good offer, a mentor. In a Ketu season it is a blessing on a desk you are trying to leave: good news about a job you no longer want. Still good weather, on a different climate.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: The season decides what can happen. The weather decides when it is likely, and how it feels that year. Never read the weather without first asking which season it falls into.

STORY: RAIN ON TWO FIELDS. The same monsoon fell on two farms outside the city. On the first, the Priest had spent the year sowing, and the rain brought a harvest that filled the storerooms. On the second, the headless Sadhu had let the land rest, and the rain brought wildflowers and a flooded path. The second farmer was not cursed. He had simply not planted anything, because it was not that kind of year for him, and the rain honoured what was there. **Rule:** the weather waters whatever the season has planted; good weather on an empty field grows wildflowers, not grain.

The two signatures: how astrologers time an event

Now the most useful timing tool I know, clearly labelled: a modern Indian teaching, spread by the Delhi school of K.N. Rao and his students, not a line from Parashara. Practitioners call it the double transit (Jupiter and Saturn together); I call it the two signatures.

The rule: an event in some area of life tends to happen in the year when **both Saturn and Jupiter touch that room or its lord**, by sitting in it or by looking at it, **and** the running season or sub-season promises that matter. Jupiter alone is a wish. Saturn alone is a duty. Both together, on a room the season has opened, is a date.

"Looking at" is the gaze from Book 1: every planet looks at the room opposite it; Saturn also at the third and the tenth from itself; Jupiter also at the fifth and the ninth. So each slow planet touches four rooms at any time.

WHY? The system's own logic, as its teachers explain it. Jupiter is the planet of permission and growth; Saturn is the planet of structure and completion. A matter needs both: the expansion that makes it possible and the solidity that makes it real. Everyday parallel: a large bank cheque needs two signatures, the director's and the accountant's. One gets you a smile at the counter; two gets you the money.

Two cautions. The season must promise the matter: two signatures on the marriage room in a season unconnected to marriage give you a year of weddings in the family, not your own. And Saturn's signature lasts about two and a half years, so the rule narrows the window to Jupiter's year within Saturn's stretch. That is as precise as honest astrology gets.

The sky from 2026 to 2030, approximately

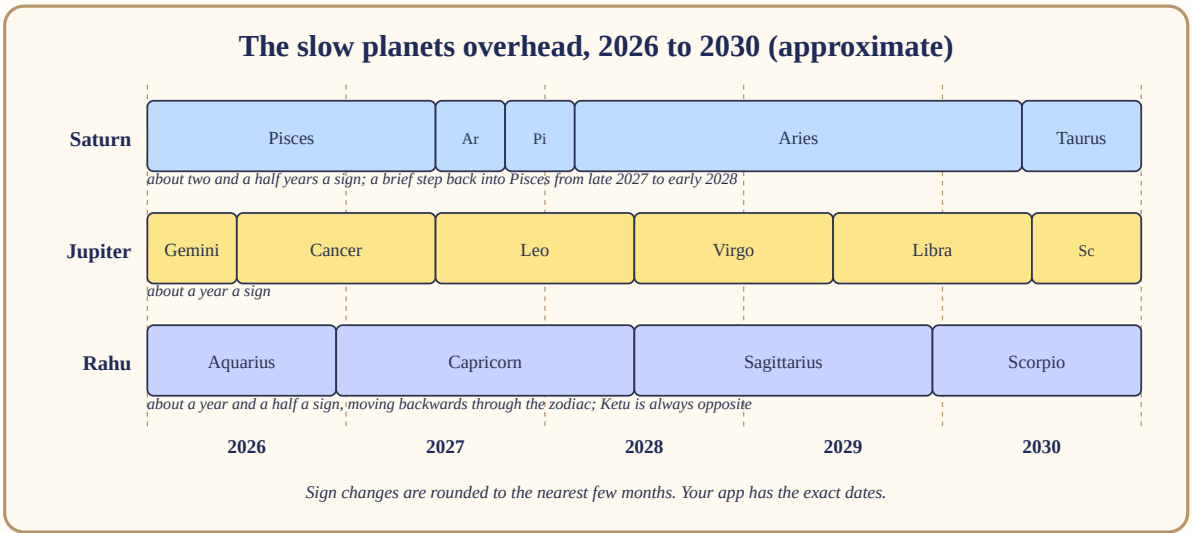


Figure 14.2: The slow planets overhead, 2026 to 2030. Approximate: sign changes are rounded to the nearest few months. Check an app for exact dates.

In words, with "about" before every date: **Saturn** is in Pisces until mid-2027, then Aries, stepping back into Pisces from late 2027 to early 2028, then Aries again, reaching Taurus from about 2030. Aries is Saturn's weakest place, so those are slower, more irritable Saturn years for everyone. **Jupiter** is in Gemini until June 2026, Cancer (its strongest place) to mid-2027, Leo to mid-2028, Virgo to mid-2029. **Rahu** is in Aquarius until December 2026, then Capricorn until mid-2028, then Sagittarius; Ketu is always opposite. If your app disagrees by a month or two, trust the app.

Where it lands for our three lives

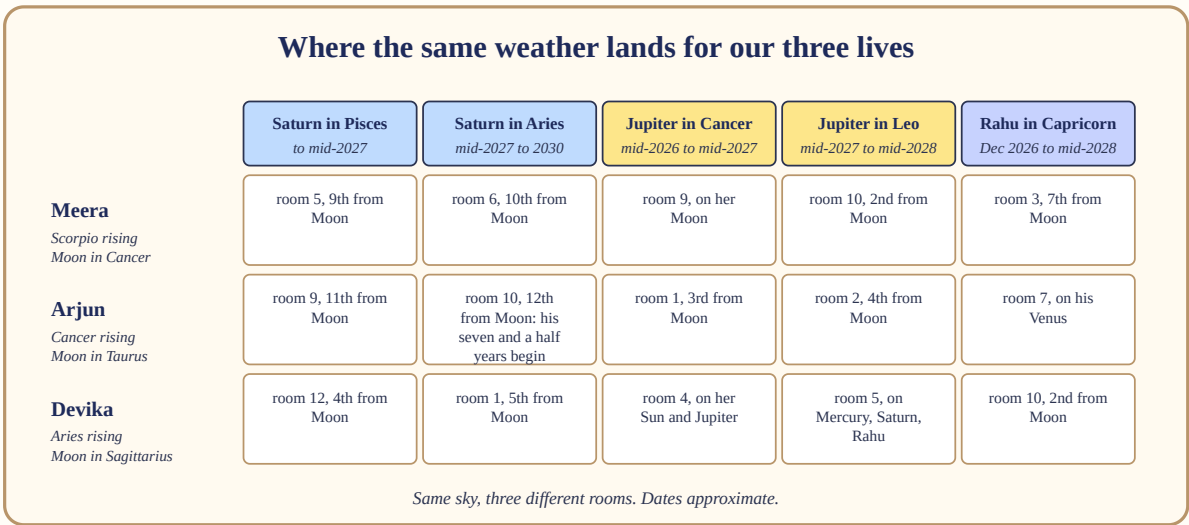


Figure 14.3: The same sky, three different rooms: the room from the rising sign and the count from the Moon.

Meera (Scorpio rising, Moon in Cancer). Her seven and a half years ran from 2000 to 2007, inside her Ketu season, when she was a schoolgirl; the next begins in the early 2030s, inside her Moon season. Until 2030 Saturn is kind to her Moon: Pisces is the ninth sign from Cancer, Aries the tenth, Taurus the eleventh. From the rising sign, Saturn sits in her room 5 until mid-2027 and then in room 6, daily work and health routines. Jupiter in Cancer from mid-2026 to mid-2027 sits on her Moon itself, in room 9: a year when faith, a teacher or a long journey comes to the mind, in the farewell sub-season of Venus. Then Jupiter in Leo from mid-2027 sits in her room 10, the career room, in the first year of her Sun season, and the Sun is the lord of room 10. Two signatures? In that first Sun year Saturn sits in room 6 and Jupiter from Leo looks straight at it: daily work, service, health, competition. Not a glamorous room. But the Sun season asks who you are when nobody is watching, and room 6 is exactly where nobody watches. I would expect her first Sun year to be about the discipline of work rather than its glory, with the glory coming later.

Arjun (Cancer rising, Moon in Taurus). Saturn enters Aries, the twelfth sign from his Moon, around mid-2027: his seven and a half years begin, inside his Rahu season, and run through the end of Rahu into the first years of Jupiter from December 2031. His strong Moon will help. From the rising sign, Saturn in Aries is in

his room 10, the career room, and from there it looks at room 7, where his Venus sits, and at room 4, where Rahu sits. Meanwhile Jupiter in Cancer (mid-2026 to mid-2027) sits in his room 1 and looks at room 7, while Rahu moves into Capricorn, his room 7, from December 2026, sitting on his Venus. Partnership is being asked about loudly through 2027, in a Rahu/Venus sub-season whose sub-lord sits in that very room. Whether it answers as a marriage or a business partner is for him and his chart to decide; the weather only puts the question on the table. Then from mid-2027 to mid-2028, Saturn sits in his room 10 and Jupiter in Leo looks at it: two signatures on career, in the last year of Rahu/Venus and the first months of Rahu/Sun. A career turn is very likely in that window, and it will feel like work, because Saturn is signing from inside the room.

Devika (Aries rising, Moon in Sagittarius). Her seven and a half years are behind her: Saturn walked through Scorpio, Sagittarius and Capricorn from around late 2014 to early 2023, covering her Mars season and the changeover into Rahu, the surgery of 2016 to 2018 and the property dispute of 2020 to 2021. Now Saturn in Pisces is the fourth sign from her Moon until mid-2027, one of the smaller Saturn stretches, and from Pisces it looks straight at her Moon's sign. From the rising sign it sits in her room 12 while Jupiter in Cancer sits in her room 4, on her Sun and her own Jupiter, and looks at room 12. Two signatures on room 12 from mid-2026 to mid-2027: expenses, hospitals, foreign places, rest, letting go. In the first year of Rahu/Saturn I would tell her plainly: a year to take rest and health seriously and to spend deliberately, possibly a year of a long journey. Then from mid-2027, Saturn sits in her room 1 while Jupiter in Leo sits in room 5, on her Mercury, Saturn and Rahu, and looks at room 1. Two signatures on the self: a reshaping year, with Saturn signing from the room of the body. Slower, more serious, and hers.

In one breath

- The season is the climate; the planets overhead now are the weather. Read them together or you will misread both.
- Only the slow movers shape a year: Saturn (two and a half years a sign), Jupiter (about a year), Rahu and Ketu (a year and a half, backwards).
- Count the weather from the rising sign for which part of life it touches, and from the Moon for how it feels.
- Saturn's seven and a half years is Saturn crossing the sign before the Moon, the Moon's sign and the sign after. A quarter of everyone alive is in it at any moment. An audit, not a curse.
- The same weather lands differently inside a friendly season and a testing season: good weather on an empty field grows wildflowers, not grain.
- Two signatures: when Saturn and Jupiter both touch a room or its lord, and the season promises that matter, that is the year to expect it. A modern teaching, widely used.

Try this

1. Find your Moon's sign and the signs on either side of it. Using Figure 14.2, is Saturn in any of the three between now and 2030? If so, note when, and which season and sub-season you will be in.
2. Devika's Moon is in Sagittarius. Which sign is the fourth from it, and when is Saturn there according to this chapter? Which sign is the eighth from it?
3. Take your current season lord and the room it sits in. Between now and 2030, is there a stretch when both Saturn and Jupiter touch that room, by sitting or by gaze? Mark it in pencil.
4. Think of the hardest year of your past decade and look up where Saturn was. Was it in a pressure room from your Moon? Which season were you in? Write two lines on how the climate changed the weather.

Answers

2. The fourth sign from Sagittarius is Pisces; Saturn is there until about mid-2027, with a brief return from late 2027 to early 2028. The eighth sign is Cancer; Saturn is not there in this window.

Chapter 15: The Changeover

Your app will give you a date. Venus ends on the ninth of June; the Sun begins on the tenth. It looks like a border post: one country on each side and a line painted on the road.

Life does not work on painted lines, and neither, in my experience, does the dasha system. The turning point between seasons (dasha sandhi, the junction of the seasons) is not a line but a bridge. You step onto it about a year before the date and step off about a year after. For those two years you have one foot on each bank, which is why the changeover is both the most confusing stretch of a life and the one most worth preparing for. All dates in this chapter are approximate, and the ones in the future are hedged twice.



The changeover: the awkward year when one courtier packs and the next arrives early.

The bridge: the last year and the first year

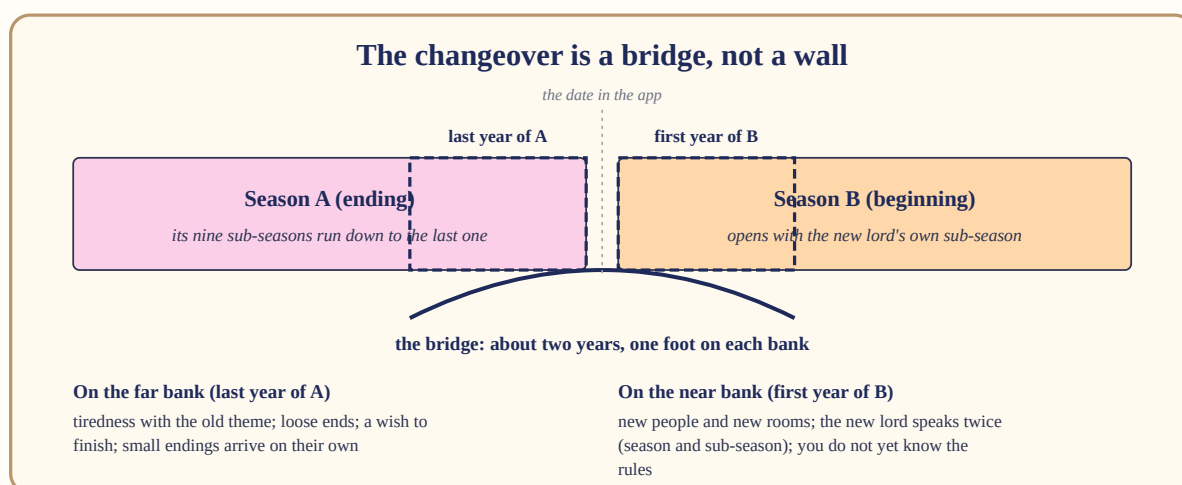


Figure 15.1: The changeover as a bridge. The date in the app is the middle of it, not the start.

A season ends with its last sub-season, which always belongs to the planet just before the season's own lord in the fixed order. A Venus season ends with Venus/Ketu. A Rahu season ends with Rahu/Mars. A Saturn

season ends with Saturn/Jupiter. That last sub-lord is, by construction, the one furthest in the order from the planet about to take over: the household is being run by the outgoing lord's most distant colleague.

A season begins with its own lord speaking twice: Sun/Sun, Jupiter/Jupiter, Mercury/Mercury. For those first months the new planet's nature is undiluted. You get the pure form before you have learned the rules.

WHY? The system's own logic, plus tradition. The logic is the order of sub-seasons, which starts with the season's own lord and so must end with the planet just before it; check it in the sub-season table in Chapter 3. The tradition is that the classical authors and every working astrologer I know treat the junction as sensitive: results mixed, promises half-kept, care advised. Parashara gives no mechanism for the feeling; experience does. Everyday parallel: the last week of one job and the first week of the next. You are employed throughout, but nobody would call those two weeks ordinary.

STORY: THE YEAR OF TWO KEYS. By palace custom, a courtier leaving the running of the household did not simply hand over the keys on the appointed day. For a year before, the incoming courtier walked beside him through the kitchens and the treasury, learning which doors stuck and which servants could be trusted. For a year after, the outgoing one stayed in a room near the gate, answering questions. So for two years the palace had two sets of keys, and the servants never quite knew whose orders to follow. Things were lost in that time, and things were found, because new eyes saw what the old ones had stopped seeing. **Rule:** the changeover runs from the last year of the old season to the first year of the new; expect two years with two sets of keys.

What people typically feel

On the far bank, in the last year of the old season: a tiredness with the season's theme, as if you have had enough of the thing you spent years wanting. Loose ends closing on their own: a lease ends, a friend moves, a project finishes without you pushing. Nostalgia, sometimes before the thing is over. A wish to finish properly. People in a last year often say "I don't know what I want any more," which is accurate: the old wanting is done and the new has not arrived.

On the near bank, in the first year of the new season, the feelings flip. New people appear, often in a rush. New rooms of life open that had been quiet for years. Excitement or disorientation or both, and a sense that you do not know the rules yet, because you do not: the person you were in the old season is standing in a house she has never managed. Decisions made in these months are made by someone who does not yet know who she is becoming.

Two honest notes. Some people feel nothing at the date and see the change only in hindsight, when their friends, work and worries have all quietly been replaced. And the strength of the feeling depends on how different the two lords are: Moon to Mars is a change of mood, Venus to Sun a change of person.

Preparing: four closing rituals in plain terms

Nothing here needs a priest, a stone or a fee: these are the things a sensible person does when a chapter closes, done on purpose instead of by accident.

1. Review. Write the story of the ending season on one page. What did it give? What did it take? What did it teach you that you could not have learned any other way? Be fair to it. Even a season that tested you kept some promise, and naming it is the beginning of being able to leave.

2. Gratitude. List the people the season brought you, and thank at least three of them in words. A season is partly its people, and the ones leaving with it deserve to know they mattered. This is also how you find out which of them are coming with you.

3. Clearing. Physical first: the clothes, papers and photographs of the season, kept or let go deliberately. Then the undone: debts settled, apologies made, postponed conversations finished. Loose ends do not disappear at the changeover; they become the new season's baggage, and the last year is the cheapest time to carry them to the door.

4. A letter to the next season. Address it by name: "Dear Sun season." Say what you know about what it asks (Part II told you), what you want from it, and what you promise it. Seal it. Open it at the first sub-season change, about a year in, and see how much of it you still mean.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: Finish things in the last year; start nothing irreversible in the first six months. The bridge is for walking across, not for building on.

WHY? Tradition and plain experience, not astronomy. The tradition's advice to take care at a junction becomes, in practice, a timing rule: an ending season still has the authority to close its own business, and a beginning season has not yet shown you what it is. Everyday parallel: in a new job, the wise person spends the first months watching how things are done before changing anything, and uses the last months of the old job to leave the files in order.

Five changeovers that ask for extra care

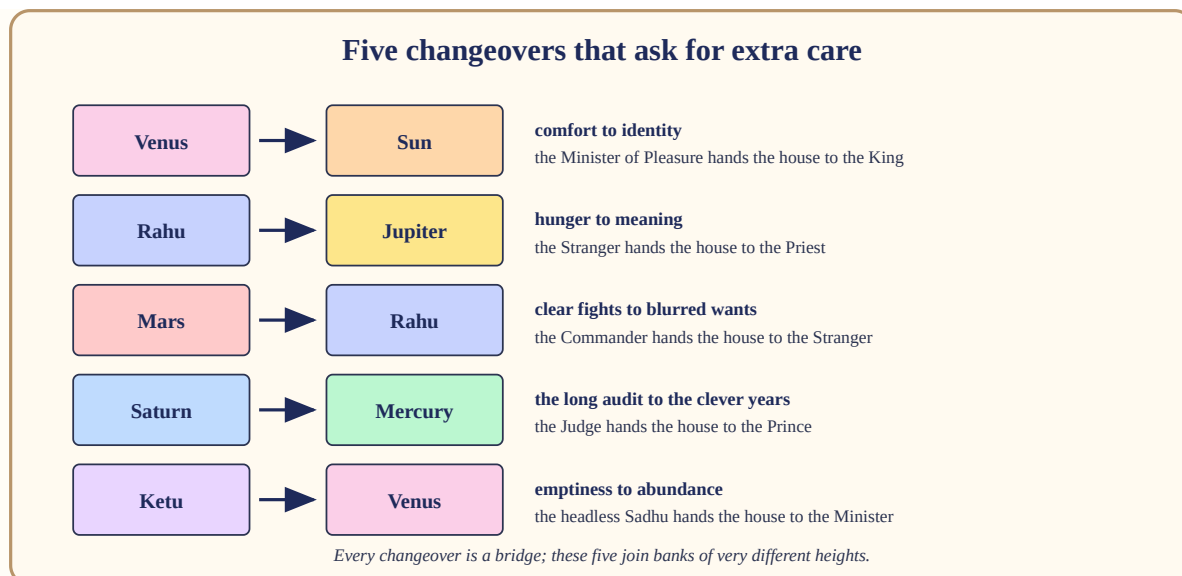


Figure 15.2: Every changeover is a bridge; these five join banks of very different heights.

Venus to the Sun: comfort to identity. Twenty years of the Minister of Pleasure, then six of the King. The person arriving has spent two decades learning to accommodate, to please, to be part of a pair; the Sun season asks who she is on her own. The first Sun year often brings a sharp interest in the father, or in authority at work, or in being seen, and a prickliness that surprises everyone, including her. It is also a period to take the health of the heart and the spine seriously, in the ordinary way: walk, check, rest. The gift on the far side is a spine, in both senses.

Rahu to Jupiter: hunger to meaning. Eighteen years of the Stranger's wanting, then sixteen of the Priest's teaching. The first Jupiter year can feel like the morning after a long festival: the pace drops, the appetite drops, and the person wonders what was wrong with her that she wanted all that. The mistake is to keep running at Rahu's speed in Jupiter's house. The right move is to let a teacher appear, and to notice that meaning arrives slowly and does not announce itself.

Mars to Rahu: clear fights to blurred wants. Seven hot, direct years, then eighteen in the smoke. In the Mars season you knew what you were fighting and whom: property, siblings, courage, the body. In Rahu's first year the opponents become unclear and the wants become large and foreign: a city abroad, a technology, an ambition with no shape yet. Devika walked this bridge from around mid-2020 to mid-2022, with a property dispute, a Mars matter, straddling the date in July 2021: exactly the kind of loose end the Commander leaves on the Stranger's desk. The task is to finish the clear fights before the smoke comes in.

Saturn to Mercury: the long audit to the clever years. Nineteen years of the Judge, then seventeen of the Prince. The person stepping off this bridge is usually older and has carried weight so long that lightness feels like a trick. Mercury scatters attention where Saturn fixed it, brings talk, trade, travel and young people where Saturn brought silence and duty. The first Mercury year asks her to trust that the audit is over and she is allowed to be curious again. Many spend it still filing reports nobody has asked for.

Ketu to Venus: emptiness to abundance. Seven years of the headless Sadhu, then twenty of the Minister of Pleasure. The person has learned not to want, and now the season of wanting begins. Meera walked this

bridge at eighteen and a half, from around mid-2006 to mid-2008: a withdrawn, inward schoolgirl just out of Saturn's seven and a half years, arriving in college and in the long bloom. People on this bridge have to relearn appetite, and often feel guilty about it. They should not. The Sadhu's lesson was not that wanting is wrong, but that one can survive without; having learned that, one is finally safe to enjoy things.

STORY: THE MINISTER LEAVES AND THE KING ARRIVES. *For twenty years the Minister of Pleasure had run the household, and the palace had grown soft and warm: music in the evenings, guests in every room, the accounts a little loose. On the day the King took over, he walked through the halls in silence, and the first thing he did was open the shutters. The light showed dust on everything. The servants, used to being asked how they felt, were now asked what they had done. Some left. The ones who stayed found that they stood straighter. He simply needed to know who was who, starting with himself. Rule: the Venus-to-Sun changeover trades comfort for clarity; expect light on things that were pleasantly dim.*

Meera's changeover, live: Venus to the Sun around June 2027

Here is the bridge as it stands under someone's feet right now. I write in late 2026, so everything past that date is a forward look, hedged as I would hedge it to Meera's face: I do not know what will happen. I know what is being asked.

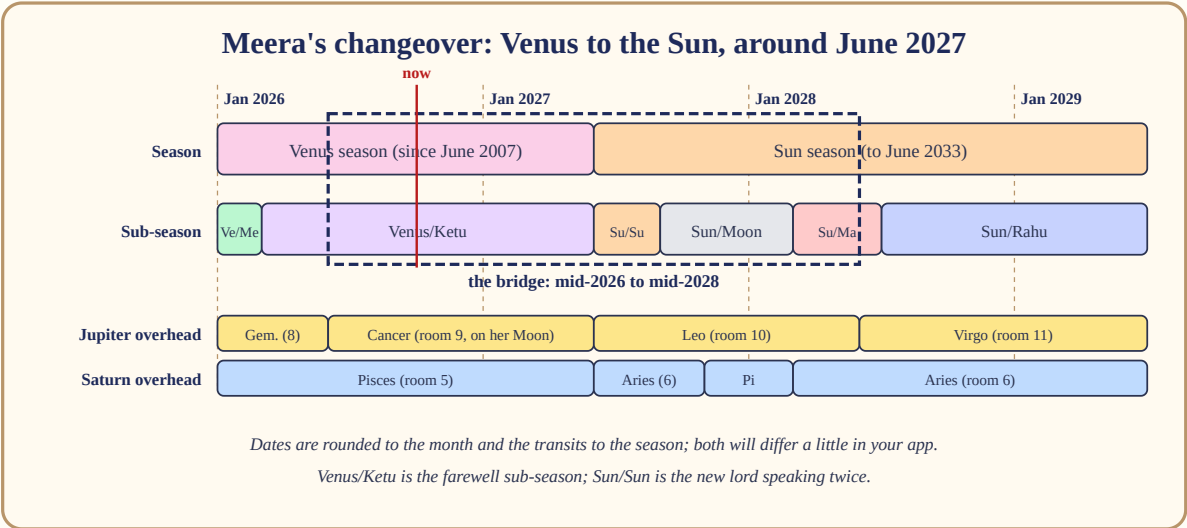


Figure 15.3: Meera's bridge, mid-2026 to mid-2028. Venus/Ketu is the farewell sub-season; Sun/Sun is the new lord speaking twice. Dates rounded to the month; transits to the season.

The far bank. Her Venus season, begun in June 2007, closes around June 2027. Its last sub-season is Venus/Ketu, from around March 2026 until the season ends. Ketu sits in her room 10, the career room, in Leo, the Sun's own sign. So the farewell year of her Venus season is a letting-go in the room of work, in the sign of the planet about to take over: a rehearsal. I would expect her to lose interest in some part of her

working life that she had held onto out of comfort rather than conviction, and to feel oddly unbothered by the loss. Overhead, Jupiter in Cancer from about mid-2026 to mid-2027 sits on her Moon in room 9: a year when faith, a teacher or a long journey comes to the mind during the farewell.

The near bank. Sun/Sun runs from around June to September 2027, then Sun/Moon to around March 2028, then Sun/Mars to around July 2028. Her Sun sits at 28° Scorpio in room 1 with Mercury; it owns room 10 and is on her side. A Sun that owns the career room and sits in the room of the self: the Sun season's question, who am I when nobody is watching, will be asked through work and answered in her own person. The hidden agenda from Chapter 13: the Sun sits in Jyeshtha, Mercury's star, and Mercury owns her rooms 8 and 11 and tests her. The second voice: an identity involving other people's resources and a network of friends, and argued over.

The weather on the near bank. Jupiter moves into Leo, her room 10, around the month the Sun season begins, and stays about a year: the Priest standing in the career room in the sign of the new King. Saturn enters Aries, her room 6, at about the same time, with a brief step back into Pisces late in 2027. As Chapter 14 showed, both slow planets touch room 6 in that first year, the room of daily work, routines and health. So my honest forward look: the first year of her Sun season will be about discipline rather than glory, about the shape of a working day and the care of the body, with recognition held back until the discipline is real. Sun/Moon from around September 2027 may bring the mother and the home forward, since the Moon sits in and owns her room 9, a fortunate pairing for a Scorpio rising.

What I would tell her to do on the bridge. Review: write the Venus season's one page now, in Venus/Ketu, while it is still hers to write. Gratitude: three letters, at least one to someone from the Venus/Rahu years around her marriage. Clearing: the comfort she keeps out of habit in the career room, let go of deliberately rather than waiting for Ketu to do it. The letter: "Dear Sun season," written before June 2027 and opened at Sun/Moon. And the rule of thumb: finish in the Venus year; watch in the first Sun months; build from about the start of 2028.

STORY: THE STRANGER MEETS THE PRIEST AT THE GATE. *When the smoke-headed Stranger's eighteen years were done, he met the Royal Priest at the gate and tried to hand over a list: all the things the household still wanted. The Priest read it, folded it, and put it in his sleeve. "We will see which of these were hungers and which were needs," he said. For the first year the list sat unread and the household felt strangely empty, and then one morning a teacher arrived who had been invited by nobody, and the Priest's years began in earnest. Rule: at the Rahu-to-Jupiter changeover, let the list sit; the first Jupiter year sorts hunger from need before it gives anything.*

IF YOU READ FOR OTHERS: *The most useful thing you can give a person at a changeover is permission: to be tired of the old theme, not to know the new rules yet, to wait six months before deciding. Say the next season's task plainly and kindly, and do not predict its events. The task is yours to name; the events are theirs to live.*

In one breath

- The changeover is a bridge, not a line: the last year of the old season and the first year of the new, about two years with one foot on each bank.
- The old season ends with its most distant colleague's sub-season; the new one begins with its lord speaking twice, which is why the junction feels mixed.
- Last year: tiredness with the theme, loose ends closing, not knowing what you want. First year: new people, new rooms, not knowing the rules.
- Prepare with four plain rituals: review on one page, gratitude to three people, clearing of things and loose ends, and a letter to the next season.
- Finish in the last year; start nothing irreversible in the first six months.
- Five steep bridges: Venus to Sun, Rahu to Jupiter, Mars to Rahu, Saturn to Mercury, Ketu to Venus.
- Meera's Venus-to-Sun bridge runs from about mid-2026 to mid-2028; its task is a working identity built through discipline, and nobody, including me, knows its events.

Try this

1. Find your current season's end date in your app. Mark one year before it and one year after it on your season map. Are you on the bridge now?
2. Meera's Venus season ends around June 2027. Using the sub-season lengths from Chapter 3, which sub-season does her Sun season open with, how long does it last, and which follows it?
3. Write the one-page review of your most recently finished season, even if it ended years ago: what it gave, what it took, what it taught.
4. Write the first paragraph of a letter to your next season, addressed by its lord's name. Keep it in this book.
5. Think of someone you know who is clearly on a bridge. Without naming any planets, write the three sentences of permission you would offer them.

Answers

2. It opens with Sun/Sun, which lasts 3 months and 18 days ($6 \times 6 \div 120$ of a year): around June to September 2027. Sun/Moon follows, lasting 6 months, to around March 2028.

Chapter 16: Three Lives in Seasons

We have walked the nine seasons one at a time. Now let us do what an astrologer does when a person sits down across the table: read a whole life, from the first season to the one running today, as one story.

I will do it three times, for Meera, Arjun and Devika, the constructed charts that have travelled with us since Chapter 2, using only the events we already know about them. Each story ends with the two questions that matter most in a reading: what does the current season ask of this person now, and what will the next one ask?

One note for the whole chapter: every date here is approximate. Your app may say June 2027 where your cousin's says May 2027, and both are right to the precision this method has. Read "around", not "on".



Three lives in October 2026.

Meera: the long bloom, and a door opening

Meera was born in Jaipur on a December morning in 1988, Scorpio rising, the Moon at 21° Cancer in Ashlesha, Mercury's star. The Moon had walked $4^\circ 20'$ of the star's $13^\circ 20'$, so two-thirds of the Mercury season was left to her: 11.475 years, to around June 2000.

Mercury, birth to June 2000 (age 0 to 11.5). A childhood under the clever young Prince: quick, talkative, bookish. Mercury sits in her first room with the Sun, so the season showed in her face: the child who asked "why" and could not be fobbed off. Mercury tests her, owning her eighth and eleventh rooms, which in a child means little more than restlessness and a nervous stomach before exams.

Ketu, June 2000 to June 2007 (age 11.5 to 18.5). The headless Sadhu ran her teenage years, and Saturn's seven and a half years lay over the same stretch. That is a heavy pairing between twelve and eighteen: a season of letting go while the old Judge presses on the Moon. Ketu sits in her tenth room, so the letting go

touched what she thought she would become. The nine sub-seasons ran from Ketu/Ketu to Ketu/Mercury, which closed the season as she finished school. This is the season that made her inward.

Venus, June 2007 to June 2027 (age 18.5 to 38.5). Then the Minister of Pleasure took the household for twenty years. Venus is at home in Libra in her twelfth room, strong but placed in the room of far places, expenses and retreat, and for Scorpio rising Venus tests her. A long, real bloom with a bill attached. The sub-seasons:

- **Venus/Venus, June 2007 to October 2010.** College and the first taste of adult freedom.
- **Venus/Sun, Venus/Moon and Venus/Mars, October 2010 to August 2014.** Three planets on her side: the years one grows into one's own face.
- **Venus/Rahu, August 2014 to July 2017.** Her marriage, in 2016, at twenty-seven and a half. Rahu sits in her fourth room, the room of home, five rooms on from Venus and not in any of the three wrong rooms (6, 8, 12) from the season lord. The planet that stands for marriage ran the season; a friend from the room of home ran the sub-season.
- **Venus/Jupiter, July 2017 to March 2020.** The Royal Priest, her best planet, in her seventh room of partnership: the settling years after a wedding.
- **Venus/Saturn, March 2020 to May 2023.** The testing stretch. Saturn mildly tests her and sits outshone by the Sun in her second room (family, money, speech). Slowness, duty, bills, the adult discovery that comfort is work. The method does not call this a disaster; it calls it an audit.
- **Venus/Mercury, May 2023 to March 2026.** The Prince again, testing her from the first room: busy, scattered, full of plans.
- **Venus/Ketu, March 2026 to May 2027.** Now. The last sub-season of a twenty-year season is always the Sadhu's, and he is loosening her grip on the things of the season.

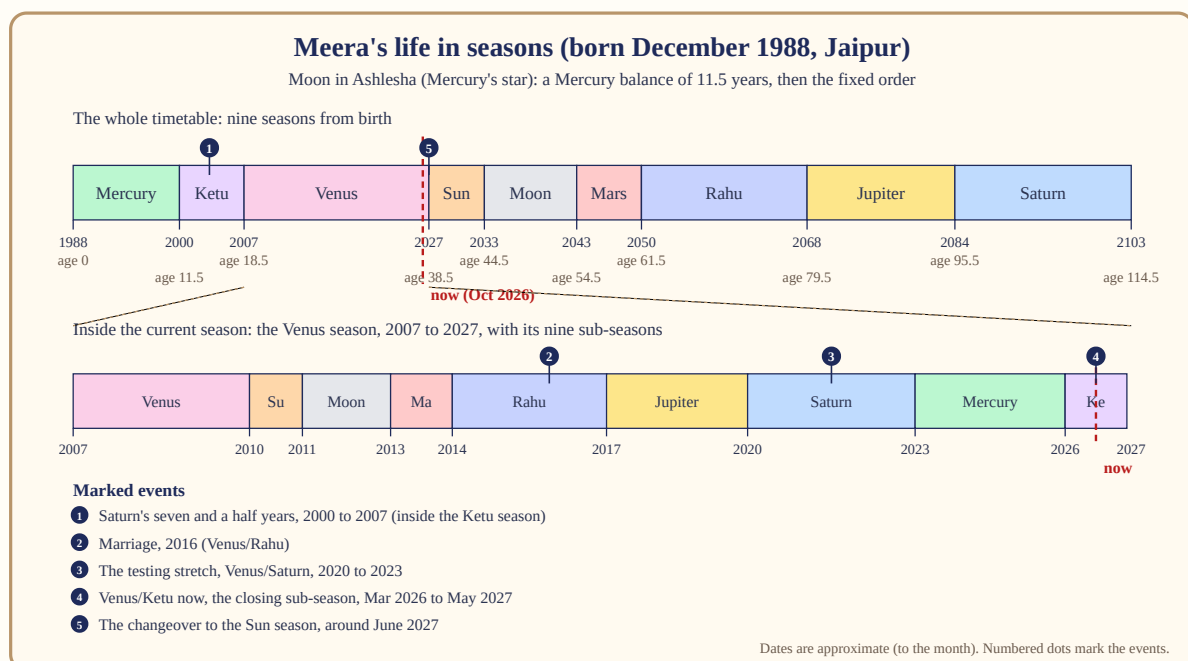


Figure 16.1: Meera's season map. The top bar is the whole timetable; the lower bar opens the Venus season (June 2007 to June 2027). The dashed red line is October 2026.

WHY? Why did the marriage fall in Venus/Rahu and not Venus/Jupiter, when Jupiter sits in her marriage room? The system's own logic, with its limits. The season lord opens the subject: Venus stands for marriage, so all twenty years were marriage-coloured. The sub-lord picks the moment: Rahu sits in her room of home, is well placed from Venus, and is the courtier who makes things happen suddenly and in public. The method gave two or three good windows; life chose one. Everyday parallel: the monsoon is the season for rain; which Tuesday the roof leaks is another matter.

STORY: THE MINISTER HANDS OVER THE KEYS. For twenty years the Minister of Pleasure (Venus) has run Meera's household: music in the evenings, a wedding in the courtyard, a bill for all of it in a drawer in the twelfth room. In the final year the headless Sadhu (Ketu) walks the corridors behind him, quietly closing doors. Then the King (Sun) arrives from the first room, where he has always lived, and asks a question nobody has asked her in twenty years: "Who are you, apart from what you love and who loves you?" **Rule:** the last sub-season of any season belongs to the planet before the season lord in the fixed order, so Venus always ends in Ketu, and the Sun always begins from Ketu's loosened grip.

What this season asks of her now. A gentle inventory. What in these twenty years was hers, and what was borrowed comfort? Which relationships nourish and which are habit? The Sadhu in the tenth room asks her to let the old picture of her work go without panic. This is not the time to start the next big thing. It is the time to finish, to thank, to clear a cupboard.

What the next one will ask. The Sun season, around June 2027 to June 2033, opens with Sun/Sun for three and a half months and then Sun/Moon to around March 2028. Her Sun is on her side, in her first room. The King will ask her to stand in her own name: to be visible, to lead something, to take her health (heart, spine, eyes) seriously, and to make peace with her father or with authority itself. After twenty years of Venus it will feel bright and a little exposed. It is a short season, so the asking will be clear and quick.

Arjun: the great churning at thirty-one

Arjun was born in Pune on a March evening in 1995, Cancer rising, the Moon at 6° Taurus, at its strongest place, in Kritika, the Sun's star. The Moon had 4° of the star left, so he received only 1.8 years of the Sun season, to around December 1996.

Moon, December 1996 to December 2006 (age 1.8 to 11.8). His childhood belonged to the Queen Mother, and his Moon is his strongest planet, in his eleventh room of friends and gains. For a Cancer-rising child this is as kind a season as the method gives: mother, home, food, a crowd of friends.

Mars, December 2006 to December 2013 (age 11.8 to 18.8). The Commander ran his school years, and Mars is his best planet, owning his fifth and tenth rooms. Sport, competition, the boy who could not sit still in class but could lead a team. Mars walks backwards in his second room, so the energy turned inward as often as out: a quick temper at the dinner table, a fierce privacy about his ambitions.

Rahu, December 2013 to December 2031 (age 18.8 to 36.8). Then the smoke-headed Stranger, for eighteen years. Rahu sits in his fourth room in Libra, Venus's sign, so Rahu borrows the Minister's nature: a hunger for beauty, comfort, a fine home, approval. In the room of home and formal education, the hunger first turned to study.

- **Rahu/Rahu, December 2013 to August 2016.** The college years: restless, foreign-facing, full of appetite.
- **Rahu/Jupiter, August 2016 to January 2019.** The Royal Priest, on his side, in his fifth room of learning, two rooms on from Rahu. He finished his studies in 2017, at twenty-two, and took his first job in 2018. A good planet in a good room from the season lord, and the two events a young man most wants landed in it.
- **Rahu/Saturn, January 2019 to November 2021.** The Judge, neutral for Cancer rising, outshone in his eighth room. Early career, long hours, the first taste of how slowly a workplace moves.
- **Rahu/Mercury, November 2021 to June 2024.** The stuck years, 2022 to 2024. Mercury tests him, owning his third and twelfth rooms, and sits in the eighth room with the Sun and Saturn. The Stranger's hunger met the Prince's scattering: too many plans, too many tabs open, running hard and staying in place. Nothing broke. A stuck sub-season is a sub-season, not a verdict, and it had a date on it.
- **Rahu/Ketu, June 2024 to July 2025.** The Sadhu's thirteen months: a clearing, the two shadow planets facing each other, home against work.
- **Rahu/Venus, July 2025 to July 2028.** Now. Venus owns his fourth and eleventh rooms and tests him, but she sits in his seventh room of partnership and is Rahu's natural friend.

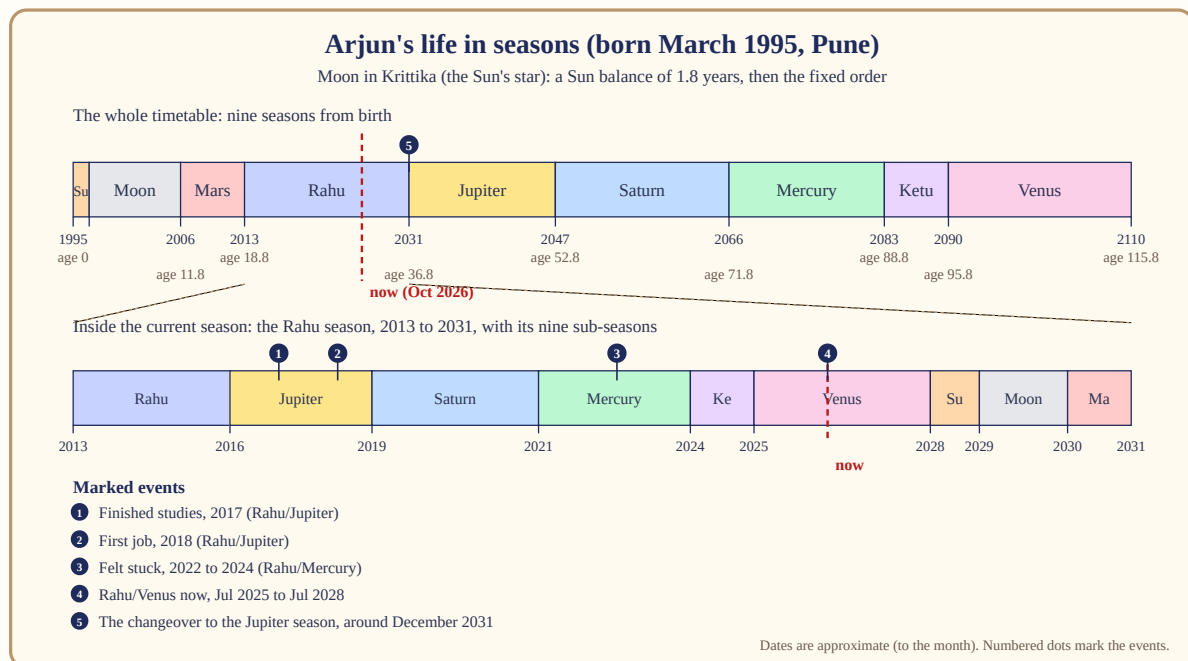


Figure 16.2: Arjun's season map. The lower bar opens the Rahu season (December 2013 to December 2031). He stands a little past the first third of Rahu/Venus.

STORY: THE STRANGER INVITES THE MINISTER TO DINNER. *The smoke-headed Stranger (Rahu) has been master of Arjun's house for twelve years and has filled it with books (the Priest's years), ledgers (the Judge's) and half-finished letters (the Prince's). Now the Minister of Pleasure (Venus) comes to stay for three years. She hangs curtains in the seventh room, the room of partners, and the Stranger, who already wears her sign like a borrowed coat, is enchanted. Everything becomes about the one person across the table and the house they might share. The old Judge, watching from the eighth room, mutters that the Minister owns two rooms that cost this household dearly. **Rule:** when a sub-lord is the season lord's natural friend but tests you by what it owns, the sub-season feels pleasant and spends more than it earns; enjoy it with a budget.*

WHY? *Why does Rahu borrow Venus's nature here? Tradition and the system's own logic together. Rahu and Ketu own no signs (Parashara gives them none), so the tradition says they speak with the voice of the planet whose sign they sit in: Rahu in Libra speaks like Venus; in Capricorn he would speak like Saturn. Everyday parallel: a new tenant takes on the habits of the building. In a building full of musicians, he starts humming.*

What this season asks of him now. To want well. The Stranger wants everything; the Minister wants beauty and company. Together, in the room of partnership, they ask: can you let someone in without losing yourself to their approval? Can you make a home (the fourth room, where Rahu sits) without buying one you cannot afford (the eleventh, Venus's other charge)? It is a sociable, spending, falling-in-love sub-season, and the task is to keep one foot on the ground while enjoying it. Rahu/Sun follows, July 2028 to May 2029, and will ask him to be clear about who he is inside whatever he has made.

What the next one will ask. The Jupiter season, around December 2031 to December 2047, begins when he is nearly thirty-seven. Jupiter is on his side in his fifth room of children, learning and the things one creates. After eighteen years of hunger the Priest will ask him to find meaning in what the hunger gathered: to teach, to raise, to believe in something. The Rahu-to-Jupiter changeover is one of the special bridges of Chapter 15, and the last Rahu sub-season, Rahu/Mars (November 2030 to December 2031), will feel like a sprint before a long walk.

Devika: four seasons in one adult life

Devika was born in Kolkata at five minutes to midnight in July 1979, Aries rising, the Moon at 14° Sagittarius in Purva Ashadha, Venus's star. The Moon had only just entered the star, so she received almost all of it: a Venus balance of nineteen years, to around July 1998.

WHY? Why nineteen years and not twenty? The system's own logic, and you can check it on your fingers. Purva Ashadha runs from 13°20' to 26°40' Sagittarius. Her Moon at 14° had 12°40' of the 13°20' still to walk: 95 per cent, and 95 per cent of twenty years is nineteen. Everyday parallel: board a train that has already covered a tiny part of its route and you get nearly the whole journey.

Venus, birth to July 1998 (age 0 to 19). Her whole childhood and youth under the Minister of Pleasure. Venus sits in her third room in Gemini with Mars, her rising-sign lord, and for Aries rising Venus tests her. Nineteen years is long enough for a season to become a personality: the adults who know Devika as graceful, hospitable and a little indulgent are describing her first season.

Sun, July 1998 to July 2004 (age 19 to 25). The King, on her side, in her fourth room with Jupiter at its strongest place. Six years of finding her own authority. The last sub-season, **Sun/Venus, July 2003 to July 2004**, brought her marriage at twenty-four: the season lord stood for identity, the sub-lord for marriage, and the planet of her nineteen-year childhood came back for one year to hand her into a new house.

Moon, July 2004 to July 2014 (age 25 to 35). Her Moon sits in the ninth room in Jupiter's sign while Jupiter sits in the Moon's: the two have swapped homes and carry each other's business. In **Moon/Jupiter, June 2007 to October 2008**, her daughter was born. The Moon stands for mother, Jupiter for children, and the two planets that had exchanged houses ran the season and the sub-season together. If I could teach only one example of the timetable touching a life, it would be this one. Moon/Saturn and Moon/Mercury (October 2008 to October 2011) were the tired years of a small child's mother.

Mars, July 2014 to July 2021 (age 35 to 42). The Commander, her rising-sign lord, on her side but outshone by the Sun. **Mars/Saturn, December 2016 to January 2018**, was her surgery, 2016 to 2018. Mars stands for the surgeon's knife; Saturn tests her and sits in her fifth room with Rahu and Mercury. I will say what the method says and no more: it was a stretch to take the body seriously, and she did, and it passed.

The changeover, 2020 to 2021. Her property dispute fell exactly across the bridge from Mars to Rahu. Mars stands for land; Rahu for the stranger at the gate, the outsider's claim. A property quarrel at that handover is almost a textbook illustration of why Chapter 15 asked you to watch the changeovers.

Rahu, July 2021 to July 2039 (age 42 to 60). Rahu sits in her fifth room in Leo, the Sun's sign, with Saturn and Mercury, and borrows the King's voice: a hunger for recognition, for the stage, for her children's success. Rahu/Rahu (to March 2024) set the themes. **Rahu/Jupiter, March 2024 to August 2026**, brought her best planet, but from the twelfth room counted from Rahu, one of the wrong rooms: help came sideways and quietly, I suspect, rather than in the open. And now **Rahu/Saturn, August 2026 to June 2029**. The Judge and the Stranger sit in the same room of her chart, and Saturn tests her. This is the sub-season I would have circled in advance.

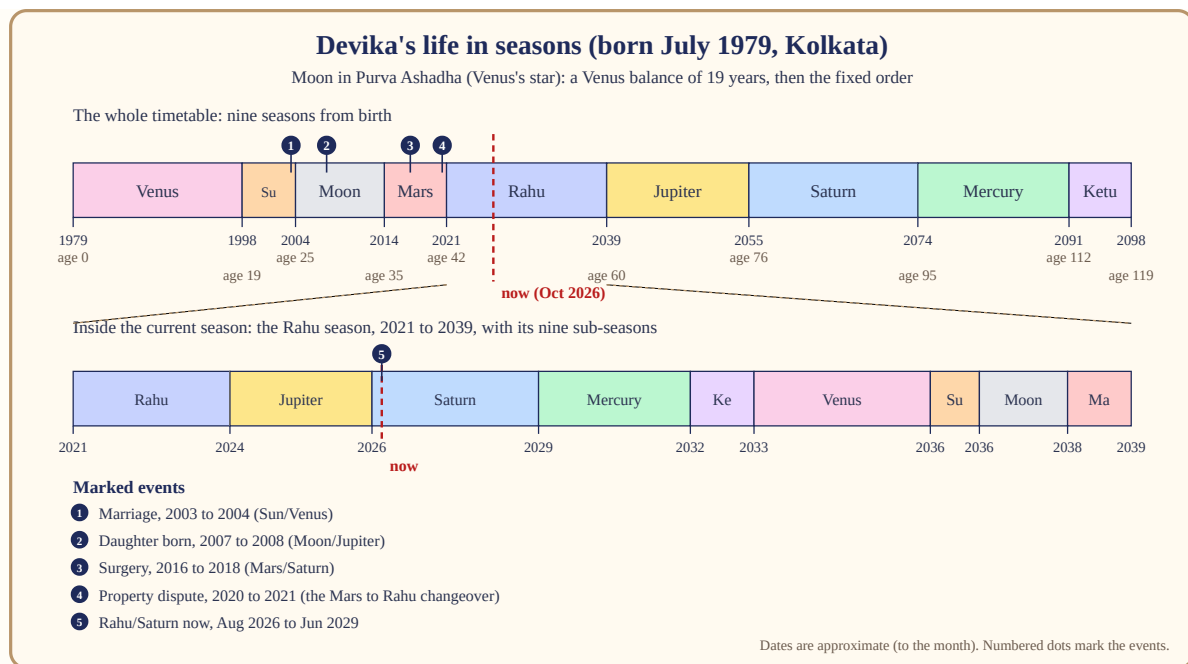


Figure 16.3: Devika's season map. Four seasons have passed in her adult life; the lower bar opens the Rahu season (July 2021 to July 2039), which she entered at forty-two.

STORY: THE JUDGE MOVES INTO THE STRANGER'S ROOM. In Devika's palace the fifth room, the room of children and of the heart's creations, is crowded. The smoke-headed Stranger (Rahu) has lived there since 2021, hungry to be seen. The clever young Prince (Mercury) keeps his papers there. And the old Judge of Labour (Saturn) has his desk in the corner, where he has always been, except that now, for two years and ten months, he is on duty. He asks the Stranger for receipts. He asks the Prince to finish one letter before starting the next. He asks the mistress of the house to slow down, attend to her elders, and accept that recognition arrives by the servants' staircase, late and on foot. **Rule:** a sub-lord sitting in the same room as the season lord does not soften the season; it concentrates it in that room's affairs.

What this season asks of her now. Patience in the very place she is hungriest: children, creativity, the wish to be recognised. Saturn's tasks are always the same. Keep the routine. Do the unglamorous work. Attend to the old people in the family. Treat the body as a tenant who deserves repairs. Do not borrow against the future for appearances; the Stranger will suggest it and the Judge will present the bill. Her Jupiter, at its strongest place in her room of home, is the floor under her feet, and its practices from Chapter 17 are the ones I would lean on. The stretch has an end date, and it is on the map.

What the next one will ask. The remaining Rahu sub-seasons carry her to sixty. Then the Jupiter season, around July 2039 to July 2055, sixteen years with her best planet, strong, in the room of home. The Priest will ask her to become what the Stranger only wanted to be seen as: a source of wisdom in her family, a teacher of something, a woman whose home others come to for counsel. She crosses the Rahu-to-Jupiter bridge in 2039, eight years after Arjun crosses his.

What the three maps have in common

The same nine courtiers run every household in the same order, but no two lives hear them at the same age: Meera's youth was Ketu's, Arjun's was Mars's, Devika's was Venus's. The events we know fell where the method says they tend to fall: marriage under Venus or in a Venus sub-season, a child under the Moon and Jupiter, a surgery under Mars with Saturn, a property quarrel at a Mars-to-Rahu bridge, a career start under Jupiter, a stuck patch under a testing Mercury. I chose clean examples to teach with, and real lives are messier, but the direction is real. And all three are in a sub-season right now that asks them to slow down, close, or steady. From their ages alone, 37, 31 and 47, you would not have guessed it. The season map tells you what the calendar cannot.

In one breath

- A whole life reads as one story when you walk its seasons in order and pause where the timetable and the life touched.
- Meera: a Mercury childhood, a Ketu adolescence under Saturn's seven and a half years, twenty years of Venus (marriage in Venus/Rahu, 2016; the testing Venus/Saturn, 2020 to 2023), now Venus/Ketu, with the Sun season from around June 2027.
- Arjun: a Moon childhood, a Mars adolescence, a Rahu season from late 2013 (degree and first job in Rahu/Jupiter; stuck in Rahu/Mercury), now Rahu/Venus to July 2028, with Jupiter from late 2031.
- Devika: nineteen years of Venus, marriage in Sun/Venus, a daughter in Moon/Jupiter, a surgery in Mars/Saturn, a property dispute at the Mars-to-Rahu changeover, now Rahu/Saturn to June 2029.
- The season lord opens the subject, the sub-lord picks the moment, and the rooms they sit in say where in life it lands.
- Every date is approximate; you are reading the shape, not the day.

Try this

TRY THIS:

1. Cover the event lists in the three figures. From the bars and what you know of the courtiers, write one line about each person's current sub-season. Then uncover the lists and compare.
2. Pick the life whose shape is most like yours (a long first season, a short one, a testing stretch in your thirties) and write down why.
3. Choose one past sub-season of Meera, Arjun or Devika that I did not comment on and write, in two sentences, what the court was doing in that household.
4. Which "what the next season will ask" paragraph moved you most? That is probably the season you are closest to. Write its question in your own words.

Chapter 17: Living Well in a Hard Season

Somebody in your family has said one of these sentences. "His Saturn has started." "She is in Rahu, poor thing." "It is Ketu, nothing will move for seven years." They are said in the tone people use for a diagnosis, and they take a stretch of time that has a task in it and turn it into a sentence to be served.

This chapter is the antidote: the three seasons people fear, the sub-seasons inside them that genuinely bite, and how to live through them well. By well I do not mean comfortably. I mean awake, useful and unafraid. Every date here, as always, is approximate.



Living well in a hard season.

The three feared seasons

Three courtiers frighten people: the old Judge of Labour (Saturn, nineteen years), the smoke-headed Stranger (Rahu, eighteen) and the headless Sadhu (Ketu, seven). Between them they hold forty-four of the hundred and twenty years, so more than a third of any long life is spent in one of them. If they were curses, the human race would have given up long ago. They are teachers, and each teaches what the others cannot.

Saturn tests by weight. Work, limits, the slow discovery of what you can and cannot carry, and lessons about time: that it passes, that it must be respected, that effort put in now pays out later and not before. Parashara's results for a badly placed Saturn are not pleasant reading, but the same tradition calls Saturn the planet that stands for longevity and for the servant who stays. The people I know who came out of a Saturn season well came out steadier, with fewer friends and better ones.

Rahu tests by hunger. Ambition, obsession, foreign places and new technologies, sudden rises, and the confusion of wanting too many things at once. His season is not grey like Saturn's; it is loud and exciting, and the damage is done at the top of the ride, not the bottom. The task is to want well: to pick the hungers worth feeding and stay honest while you feed them.

Ketu tests by subtraction. Endings, detachment, a pull towards solitude or the inner life, and a sense that nothing is happening while, under the surface, everything is being rearranged. People misread it as stagnation. It is pruning.

WHY? Why do these three frighten, when Mars and the Sun are also hard by nature? The system's own logic. Mars and the Sun are hard the way fire is hard: fast, visible, over quickly, with short seasons. Saturn, Rahu and Ketu are hard the way weather is hard: slow, invisible and long. The fear is really a fear of duration. Everyday parallel: a slap stings and is forgotten; a damp wall worries you for years, not because it hurts but because it does not stop.

The sub-seasons that bite

A nineteen-year season is not nineteen years of one weather. The rule from Chapter 3 holds: is the sub-lord a friend of the season lord, and does it sit in a wrong room (6, 8 or 12) counted from the season lord in your chart? The first question I can answer for everyone, using the working friendships from Book 1; the second only your chart can. So this table is the general picture, to be corrected by your map.

Season	Usually bite	Usually ease	The one to circle
Saturn (19 y)	○ Saturn/Saturn (the first 3 years) · ○ Saturn/Mars · ○ Saturn/Sun · ○ Saturn/Moon	● Saturn/Venus · ● Saturn/Mercury · ◐ Saturn/Jupiter · ◐ Saturn/Rahu · ◐ Saturn/Ketu	Saturn/Saturn, especially if Saturn's seven and a half years are also running
Rahu (18 y)	○ Rahu/Rahu (the first 2 years 8 months) · ○ Rahu/Sun · ○ Rahu/Moon · ○ Rahu/Mars · ◐ Rahu/Ketu	● Rahu/Venus · ● Rahu/Mercury · ◐ Rahu/Saturn (friends, but two slow planets) · ◐ Rahu/Jupiter (depends on your Jupiter)	Rahu/Saturn: nearly three years of hunger under audit
Ketu (7 y)	○ Ketu/Moon · ○ Ketu/Sun · ◐ Ketu/Ketu (the first 5 months) · ◐ Ketu/Rahu	● Ketu/Mars · ● Ketu/Venus · ● Ketu/Saturn · ◐ Ketu/Jupiter · ◐ Ketu/Mercury	Ketu/Moon: seven months in which the mind feels unmoored

Your chart overrides the dots. Devika's Rahu/Jupiter was a friendly sub-lord in a wrong room; Meera's Venus/Saturn a sub-lord in a fine room who tests her by what he owns. The dots say where to look; the chart says what you will find.

COMMON MISTAKE: Reading the first sub-season as the whole season. Saturn/Saturn is three years; Rahu/Rahu under three; Ketu/Ketu five months. Many people decide in the first year that "this is what the next nineteen years will be like" and arrange their lives around that fear. The first sub-season is the loudest, not the truest.

The mindset: a season has a task

My whole philosophy of hard seasons in one sentence: a season is not a verdict on you; it is a task set for you.

This is not my softening of the tradition. The classical theory of karma, given in plain words in Chapter 1, says the chart shows the portion of the past that has ripened for this life, and that what you do now is yours. The season tells you what kind of work has come due. It does not say how you will do it, and it never says you will fail.

WHY? Why "task" and not "fate"? The tradition's own reasoning. Parashara describes each season's results as tendencies conditioned by the planet's strength and placement, and the same tradition prescribes a practice (upaya) for every planet, which would make no sense if the results were fixed. A system that hands you a practice does not believe in a sentence. Everyday parallel: a school sets an exam, not a grade.

So in a hard season I ask three questions, in this order. What is the task? (Saturn: work, endure, simplify, honour time and elders. Rahu: want well and stay honest. Ketu: let go and look inward.) What is the task doing to my body and my mind? Write it down; this is what you take to a doctor if you need one. And what would a person who had understood the task do this week? Not this year. This week.

STORY: THE JUDGE'S LONG TABLE. *A young merchant was told the old Judge of Labour (Saturn) would run his household for nineteen years, and he went home and wept. On the first morning the Judge laid a long table and set on it everything the merchant owned: the ledgers, the debts, the promises made and forgotten. "I am not here to ruin you," the Judge said. "I am here to go through all of it with you, one page a day, until it is in order. The Minister of Pleasure (Venus) will visit in a few years and the Prince (Mercury) after her, and you will be glad of them. But the table is mine, and we start today." The merchant found that a page a day was not unbearable. It was only steady. Rule: Saturn's season asks for a daily portion of honest work, never a heroic burst; the length of the season is the length of the table, not the depth of the punishment.*

Daily practices matched to each planet

The tradition gives each planet a weekday, a conduct, a service and a routine. I give all nine, because the sub-lord changes every year or three and you will want the matching row. These are things to do, not things to buy; nothing here costs more than a packet of sesame. The dots mark how safe each row is for anyone, in any season, without a reading.

Planet (its day)	Conduct	Service	Routine	Safe for all?
Saturn (Saturday)	Keep your word, especially to those who cannot make you. Be punctual.	The old, the disabled, the labourer, the watchman. Sesame, mustard oil, iron, a blanket.	One fixed duty at the same hour daily. Walk. Early to bed.	●
Rahu (Saturday; some say Wednesday)	Tell the truth when a shortcut is available. Finish one thing before starting the next.	The outsider: a migrant worker, a stranger in town. A coconut, a blanket, dark blue cloth.	No screen late at night. Write what you want; cross out all but three.	●
Ketu (Tuesday or Thursday)	Let a grievance go on purpose. Be alone without filling the time.	Stray dogs. A blanket or sesame. Give away what you have not used in a year.	Ten quiet minutes a day with no phone.	●
Sun (Sunday)	Stand up straight, in body and opinion. Respect your father, or his memory.	Wheat, jaggery, copper; a government school.	Up at sunrise on Sundays. Morning sunlight. Check heart and eyes.	●
Moon (Monday)	Be kind to your mother, and to your own moods.	Rice, milk, white cloth, to a woman in need.	Water first thing. Regular meals and sleep. A clean house.	●
Mars (Tuesday)	Courage without cruelty: say the hard thing without raising your voice.	Red lentils, red cloth; a brother or a soldier's family.	Daily exercise to a sweat. Mind the knife, the stove, the road.	● (easily becomes a fight)
Mercury (Wednesday)	Speak accurately. Do not exaggerate, even in jokes.	Green moong; books or stationery to a student.	Read ten pages. Write a page. Keep accounts.	●
Jupiter (Thursday)	Teach what you know. Respect teachers.	Chana dal, turmeric, yellow cloth, books; a child's school fee.	Study something hard a few minutes a day. A simple meal on Thursdays if health allows.	●
Venus (Friday)	Be gracious. Make something beautiful: a meal, a room, a song.	Curd, ghee, rice, white cloth; a young woman in need.	Clean clothes, a clean bed, music in the evening. Spend within a limit set on Friday.	● (easily becomes shopping)

In a Saturn season the Saturn row is your base for nineteen years and you add the row of whichever sub-lord is running; in a Rahu season the Rahu row is the base, and so on. When two rows disagree (Rahu says "no screen late", Mercury says "read ten pages"), do both: read ten pages of paper.

WHY? Why is Saturday Saturn's day, and why do practices sit on weekdays at all? Astronomy and tradition together. The seven weekdays are named for the seven visible planets in an order that comes from the ancient planetary hours: each hour was given to a planet in order of apparent speed, and the planet of the first hour named the day. Saturday is literally Saturn's day in English, as in Sanskrit (Shanivar). That a planet is most reachable on its own day is tradition. Everyday parallel: you can post a letter any day, but you go to the office on the day the clerk you need is at the counter.

When to seek medical or psychological help

A season describes weather; it is not a diagnosis. If you are in a Saturn season and your knees hurt, see a doctor about your knees. If you are in a Ketu season and have lost interest in everything you used to love, talk to a counsellor; do not wait seven years. If you are in a Rahu season and have not slept properly for weeks, that is a sleep problem, and sleep problems are treatable. The season may explain why this is happening now. It never replaces the treatment.

These signs mean "book the appointment this week", whatever the sky is doing:

- Sleep broken, or appetite gone, for more than two weeks.
- Weight dropping or rising without your trying.
- A low mood or dread there every morning for more than two weeks, or that stops you working, washing or eating.
- Panic out of nowhere, more than once.
- Drinking or smoking more to get through the day.
- Any thought of harming yourself or of not wanting to be here. This is an emergency, not a season. In India the government's Tele-MANAS line is 14416, free, at any hour. Wherever you live, there is a number. Call it, or ask someone to sit with you while you do.
- Chest pain, breathlessness, a sudden severe headache, a fall, bleeding that does not stop: the hospital, today.

I have sent people in a Saturn season for vitamin D and thyroid tests, people in Ketu to a counsellor, people in Rahu to a doctor about sleep, and in each case the astrology was useful precisely because it pushed them towards a professional. Any astrologer who tells you to postpone a doctor because "it is the dasha" has misunderstood both.

IF YOU READ FOR OTHERS: Never diagnose, and never let a planet become a reason to delay care. My sentence is: "This is a stretch to take the body seriously, so let us make sure the doctor has had a look." If someone tells you something that frightens you, give them a number to call before you give them a date.

What not to buy

Hard seasons are when people are sold things, because fear opens the purse. The thing most often sold is a stone: a blue sapphire "for Saturn", a hessonite "for Rahu", a cat's eye "for Ketu", priced by the buyer's fear rather than the stone's weight, and sold with the sentence "this will pacify the planet".

Here is the classical rule, labelled as such because it is what the tradition itself says: a stone strengthens the planet it belongs to. It does not pacify, soften or calm it; it gives it more voice. You wear a stone for a planet that is on your side and needs strength. You do not wear one for a planet that is testing you, because you would be handing a louder microphone to the one courtier already asking the hardest questions. When a Saturn season is hard because Saturn tests you by what he owns, a blue sapphire is exactly the wrong purchase; when it is hard even though Saturn is on your side, you might consider one, but only after a reading of the whole chart, never from a stall that has looked at your date of birth and nothing else.

What is offered	Dot	Why
A stone for the season lord, when that planet tests you	○	The classical rule: a stone strengthens; you do not strengthen the planet testing you.
A stone for the season lord when it is on your side, sold without reading the whole chart	◐	Possibly right, but only a full reading can say; the stall cannot.
An expensive ritual "to remove" the season	○	A season cannot be removed, only lived. The price is the tell.
The practices in the table above	●	Free, safe, the tradition's first prescription for every planet.
A doctor, a counsellor, a lawyer, an accountant, as the season requires	●	Saturn's season asks for exactly these people.

STORY: THE STRANGER'S BAZAAR. *When the smoke-headed Stranger (Rahu) runs a household, a bazaar springs up outside its gate: blue stones and orange stones, threads, amulets, a seven-day ritual and a seven-year one. A frightened woman walks the stalls with her purse open. The old Judge (Saturn), passing on his Saturday rounds, stops her. "What are you buying?" "Something to make it stop." "Nothing here makes anything stop," he says. "That orange stone is the Stranger's own. Wear it and he will shout louder. Go home. Feed the watchman. Sleep before midnight. Come to me on Saturdays and I will show you the accounts." She goes home with a full purse and a short list. **Rule:** a stone belongs to one planet and strengthens that planet; in a testing season the planet's own stone is the one thing never to buy.*

How to talk to family about their seasons

The hardest reading you will ever give is to your own mother across the kitchen table, because she hears everything twice as loudly. My rules: lead with the task, not the planet. Give the end date as a horizon ("by the middle of 2029 this stretch is done"), never as a threat ("three more years of this"). Ask permission before you say anything. Say nothing about death, divorce, bankruptcy or illness, ever; you do not know, and the sentence cannot be unsaid. Keep the planet's name for later, or for never. And say what you yourself will do, because a season shared is a season halved.

- Instead of "Papa, your Saturn has started": "Papa, this is the kind of stretch where the body wants slow repairs and the days want a routine. Shall we book the check-up we keep postponing, and walk together on Saturdays?"
- Instead of "Didi, you are in Rahu, be careful": "Didi, the next few years will put a lot of shiny things in front of you. When something feels urgent, call me before you sign. I will do the same for you."
- Instead of "Ma, it is Ketu, nothing will move": "Ma, this is a quiet stretch, the kind where things get sorted out underneath. It is a good time for the things you always said you would do if you had time. What were they?"
- When a relative is frightened by what someone else said: "Whoever said that was describing weather, not pronouncing a sentence. Tell me exactly what they said and we will take it apart together."
- When asked "how long?": "The heaviest stretch ends around the middle of next year. The larger season runs several more, but it changes character every year or two, and I will tell you when the next change is coming."

STORY: THE QUEEN MOTHER'S KITCHEN. *The Queen Mother (Moon) sat at the kitchen table and her daughter, who had learnt the timetable, came in with a printout. The daughter began, "Your Saturn...", and the Queen Mother's face closed like a door. The daughter stopped, put the printout away, and started again. "Ma, the next few years want you to slow down and look after your knees, and I want to do it with you. Let us walk on Saturday mornings." The door opened. Later, when the Queen Mother asked, "Is it a bad time?", the daughter said, "It is a working time, and it has an end, and I am here for all of it."* **Rule:** *when you speak of a season to someone you love, say the task, say the horizon, say what you will do beside them, and leave the planet's name in your pocket.*

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: *In a hard season, change nothing big in the first sub-season, buy nothing out of fear, see the doctor before the astrologer, and do the planet's practice on its day for one month before deciding whether it helps.*

In one breath

- Saturn, Rahu and Ketu hold forty-four of the hundred and twenty years; they are teachers, not curses, and the fear of them is mostly a fear of duration.
- Saturn tests by weight, Rahu by hunger, Ketu by subtraction; the first sub-season is the loudest, and the season lord's enemies bite hardest.
- A season is a task, not a verdict: ask what the task is, what it is doing to body and mind, and what a person who understood it would do this week.
- Each planet has a day, a conduct, a service and a routine; these cost nothing and are the tradition's first prescription.
- Sleep, appetite, mood, panic, drinking, any thought of self-harm: the doctor and the counsellor, this week, whatever the sky is doing.
- A stone strengthens the planet it belongs to (the classical rule), so the season lord's own stone, in a testing season, is the one thing never to buy.
- With family, lead with the task, give the end as a horizon, and keep the planet's name in your pocket.

Try this

TRY THIS:

1. Find your current season and sub-season. Write each lord's task in one line, then what a person who understood both would do this week.
2. Do the practice row for your season lord, weekday included, for one month, with a two-line diary each night. Then decide honestly whether anything shifted.
3. Recall a sentence about your seasons that once frightened you. Rewrite it by this chapter's rules: task first, horizon not threat, no planet's name.
4. Write the names of two people you would call if a hard season became more than weather: one medical, one you simply trust. Put the numbers in your phone tonight.

Chapter 18: Your Season Map

Everything so far has been reading. This chapter is writing. You will need a free app or program (Appendix C shows how to get the table out of it), a sheet of paper turned sideways, a pencil, a few coloured pencils, and an hour on a quiet afternoon. By the end you will have something I wish someone had handed me at twenty-five: your own life drawn as seasons, with the one you are standing in marked, and a letter to it in your own hand.

I will use Meera, Arjun and Devika where an example helps, but this chapter is about you. Dates here, as everywhere in this book, are approximate; your app will give days, and you should read them as months.



Your season map: it was never random.

Ten steps from a printout to a season map

Step 1. Get the printout. Enter your birth date, time and place and find the dasha table. You want the list of your nine seasons with dates, and the sub-season tables for every season you have lived through plus the current one. Screenshot or print them. Check the settings once: sidereal zodiac, the standard Indian setting (Lahiri), the 120-year timetable (Vimshottari). Write down the Moon's star.

Step 2. Draw the bar. Turn the sheet sideways. Draw a line from your birth year to your birth year plus a hundred. Above it draw the seasons as boxes in the fixed order from your first season, each as long as its years, the first one shortened by the balance at birth. Colour them if you like. Nothing on this map is black.

Step 3. Write the ages. At every boundary write the year and your age. Meera's read 2000 (11.5), 2007 (18.5), 2027 (38.5), 2033 (44.5). This step sounds trivial and is the one that makes people go quiet, because a life divided into four or five blocks is a life you can suddenly see.

Step 4. Open the lived seasons. Below the bar, for each season lived and the current one, list its nine sub-seasons with dates and your age at each. If the app gives only the current season's, Table A.2 gives the

lengths and order.

Step 5. Mark your events. The part only you can do. Write every event you can date to within a year: moves, schools, exams, each job, relationships begun and ended, marriage, children, deaths in the family, surgeries and long illnesses (yours and those you nursed), money gained and lost, houses, journeys, the year you took something up or gave it up. Use documents, photographs, old phones, the family WhatsApp group, your mother. Put each as a dot on the bar with a word. Do not interpret yet. Just mark.

WHY? Why mark the events before reading the seasons? The method's own logic, and it protects you from yourself. Read the seasons first and you will remember the events that fit and forget the ones that do not; every student does it, and so did I. Mark the events first, blind, and the map has to earn its keep against your real life. Everyday parallel: you set a new watch by the station clock, not the other way round.

Step 6. Name the courtiers. For each season lived, write its planet's role in the court, the rooms that planet owns and sits in (Chapter 13), and whether it is on your side or tests you for your rising sign. Three lines per season.

Step 7. Read the past honestly. Fill in the worksheet in the next section for every past season, in pencil. The point is not to prove the method right; it is to see where it was right, where it was wrong, and what the shape of your life has been.

Step 8. Find yourself. Draw a vertical line at today's date. Read off the season, the sub-season and both end dates, and write them large. Meera writes: Venus to around June 2027; Venus/Ketu to around May 2027. Devika writes: Rahu to around July 2039; Rahu/Saturn to around June 2029.

Step 9. Look at the next bridge. Write the next sub-season and the next season, with their lords and start dates, and answer in a sentence each: what will each ask? Chapter 15 guides the big bridge, Chapter 3 the small ones.

Step 10. Write the letter and date the map. Write the one-page letter described below. Then date the map, pin it somewhere, and come back to it once a year, on your birthday, with a pencil.

STORY: THE PRINCE'S NOTEBOOK. *The clever young Prince (Mercury), secretary to the court, was asked by the King (Sun) why the household's accounts never taught anybody anything. "Because, Majesty, nobody writes anything down until after it has happened, and then they write only what makes them look wise." So the Prince began a notebook. On the first page of each year he wrote which courtier ran the household and which ran the month. Below, as the year passed, he wrote what actually happened, in pencil, without comment. At year's end he read the page and, in a different colour, wrote one line of what it had taught. After twelve years the notebook was the most valuable book in the palace, because it was about this house. **Rule:** a season map is only as good as the honest dates written on it; mark first, read second, and keep the two in different colours.*

Reading past seasons honestly: the worksheet

One row per past season. Copy it into a notebook with wide pages.

Season, dates, ages	Courtier; rooms owned and sat in; on my side or testing me	Three events I remember	What I would have predicted, knowing only the courtier	What actually happened	One lesson, one line
<i>Example: Devika's Moon season, Jul 2004 to Jul 2014, age 25 to 35</i>	<i>Queen Mother; owns room 4, sits in room 9 (the Moon and Jupiter have swapped homes); neutral for Aries rising</i>	<i>Marriage settling in; daughter born 2007 to 2008 in Moon/Jupiter; tired years in Moon/Saturn and Moon/Mercury</i>	<i>A decade of home, mother, feeling, probably a child</i>	<i>Exactly that, plus a fatigue I should have predicted, because Saturn tests her</i>	<i>The season lord names the subject; the testing sub-lords name the cost</i>
Your first season					
Your second season					
(and so on)					

Three rules for filling it honestly. Write the fourth column before the fifth, so you cannot quietly adjust the prediction. Count the misses: if the method fits every row perfectly you are not being honest, and the rows where it missed usually point to something you have not weighed (a planet in a wrong room from the season lord, a planet outshone by the Sun, weather overhead pulling against the season). And mark the testing sub-seasons with a dot of their own; after three or four seasons you will notice the same planet's sub-season was

hard every time. That planet's practices from Chapter 17 should become a lifelong habit, because it will be back.

WHY? Why does the tradition weigh the past so heavily before speaking of the future? The tradition's own method. Parashara, and every teacher after him that I have read, tests a reading against known events before saying anything about events to come, and fitting an uncertain birth time to a known life (Appendix C) is the same habit formalised. Everyday parallel: a good doctor takes your history before she takes your pulse.

The current sub-season and its task

With the map drawn and the past read, your task is three sentences long.

Sentence one: the season lord's task. Saturn: work, limits, time. Rahu: want well. Ketu: let go. Venus: love and enjoy without going soft. The Sun: stand in your own name. The Moon: tend the household of the mind. Mars: act with courage, mind the body. Jupiter: grow and give. Mercury: learn, speak, trade, and do not scatter.

Sentence two: the sub-lord's task, and how the two sit together. Write the sub-lord's task, then ask Chapter 3's two questions: is it a friend of the season lord, and does it sit in a wrong room (6, 8 or 12) from the season lord in your chart? If both answers are kind, the sub-season is the season's task made easier. If either is unkind, this is where the season's bill is presented, and both planets' practices go on your weekly list.

Sentence three: the task in my life this year. The rooms the two planets sit in say where it lands: room 4, at home or with your mother; room 7, in marriage or partnership; room 10, at work; room 2, in money and family. Write it in plain words about your actual life, with no planet's name in it.

Arjun writes: "Want well. Enjoy a sociable, loving stretch (Venus is Rahu's friend, in my room of partnership, not in a wrong room) while watching what it spends, because Venus owns rooms that cost me. This year that means: let someone in, and do not buy a flat to impress them." That is a reading. It took him ten minutes.

STORY: THE JUDGE READS THE LEDGER BACKWARDS. *A nervous householder asked the old Judge of Labour (Saturn) what the coming year would bring. The Judge did not answer. He opened the household ledger at the first page and read it forward, year by year, aloud, until he reached today. "There," he said, closing it. "You have now heard what every courtier does in this house when it is his turn. The Stranger (Rahu) spends. The Minister (Venus) decorates and then presents a bill. The Priest (Jupiter) blesses, quietly, from a back room. The Sadhu (Ketu) empties a cupboard. You did not need me to tell you the coming year. You needed to hear your own ledger read without flinching."* **Rule:** the best prediction of how a planet will behave in your next sub-season is how it behaved in its last one.

A letter to this season

This is the one practice in this book that is mine and not the tradition's, so I will not pretend otherwise. It came from a hard year in which I could not make the season stop and discovered that I could at least address it.

The letter is one page, by hand, in five paragraphs: who you are addressing (the season and sub-season, by courtier, with dates); what you understand its task to be; what you are afraid of, said plainly and once; what you intend to do each week while it runs; and what you will thank it for when it ends. Date it, fold it, put it inside the map. When the sub-season ends, read it and write the reply on the back. Here is a model, Meera's, to the sub-season she stands in.

To my closing season: Venus, running since June 2007, and the Sadhu's last stretch inside it, March 2026 to May 2027.

You have run my house for almost twenty years. You gave me college, my own face, a wedding, a home, and a long audit in the middle when I learned that comfort is work. I understand what you ask of me in your last year: to look at everything I gathered and decide what is mine. To close the drawers I left open. To stop starting things.

I am afraid that when you leave I will not know who I am without the things you gave me. I am saying that once, here, and not again.

Each week while you run I will do three things. I will clear one shelf, one folder or one obligation, on purpose. I will spend Fridays well: a clean house, music, a meal cooked for someone, no shopping. I will sit ten quiet minutes a day with the phone in another room, because the Sadhu is running your last stretch and that is his hour.

When you end, around June 2027, I will thank you for the twenty years, for the person across my table, and for teaching me the difference between what I love and what I was merely used to. Then I will open the door to the King, and stand up straight.

Meera, October 2026.

Write yours. It will be shorter or longer than this and it will be better, because it will be true.

ANUSHKA'S RULE OF THUMB: One page, by hand, five paragraphs, one fear said once. Two pages means you are bargaining with the season; no fear means you are not being honest with it. Read it only at the changeover.

A twenty-question self-reading

Sit with the map and write the answers; do not just think them. Questions 1 to 7 are about the facts of your map, 8 to 14 about the past, 15 to 20 about now and next.

1. What is the Moon's star at my birth, and which planet's season did I begin life in?
2. How many years of that first season did I receive, and at what age did my second season begin?
3. Which seasons have I completed, with their ages?
4. Which season am I in now, from when to when, and how far through it am I?
5. Which sub-season am I in now, from when to when?
6. Which season comes next, at what age, and for how many years?
7. Which of the three long seasons (Venus, Rahu, Saturn) falls in the middle of my working life: behind me, around me, or ahead?
8. Which completed season does my family call "my good years", and does the courtier agree?
9. Which do I privately think of as my hardest stretch, and what was its courtier doing in my chart?
10. Which sub-lord's sub-seasons have been hard for me more than once?
11. Which have been kind more than once?
12. Where did the map miss, and what in the chart might explain the miss?
13. Did any big event fall within a year of a changeover between seasons?
14. Did Saturn's seven and a half years overlap any season of mine, and what do I remember of that stretch?
15. What is the one-line task of my current season lord?
16. What is the one-line task of my current sub-lord, and is it a friend of the season lord in a good room from it?
17. In which room of my life does this sub-season land, and what is it asking there this year?
18. Which planet's practices from Chapter 17 should be my weekly habit now, and on which day?
19. What will the next sub-season ask of me, and when does it begin?
20. What will the next season ask, how do I want to arrive at its door, and what must I finish before then?

If you can answer all twenty from your own map, in your own words, with no Sanskrit in them, you can do what this book promised in its first chapter. You can also do it for your mother, your brother and your friend, gently, in the sentences of Chapter 17.

STORY: THE SADHU'S LETTER. *A woman in the last year of a long season went to the headless Sadhu (Ketu), who was sweeping the courtyard, and asked what she should do. He did not stop sweeping. "Write to the season," he said. "Not to me. To the one who has been running your house. Tell it what it gave you and what it is asking. Tell it the one thing you fear. Tell it what you will do on Fridays. Then fold the letter and sweep." She did, and found that a season thanked in writing is a season you can leave without looking back. The King (Sun) arrived the next June and found the courtyard clean. Rule: the changeover is easier for the person who has written down what the ending season gave, what it asked, and what they will do while it closes.*

A closing letter

Dear reader,

We began with a woman at 24, 31 and 40 who seemed to be three people, and the promise that there was a timetable behind that which you could learn to read with a free app and a pencil. If you have drawn your map, you have kept my side of the promise for me.

Let me say honestly what I think you now have, and what you do not.

You do not have a script. Nothing on your map says what will happen, and I would be ashamed if anything in this book made you feel it did. The timetable's own tradition says the chart shows what has ripened and leaves what you do now to you, and I believe that more firmly after writing this book than before.

What you have is a sense of the weather. You know which courtier is running your house and roughly how long the arrangement lasts. You know the hard stretch has a date on it, and that the date is a horizon, not a threat. You know a season has a task, and you can say it in one plain sentence without a word of Sanskrit. You know the stone at the stall is not for you, that the doctor comes before the astrologer, and that your mother will hear you better if you lead with the walk on Saturday rather than the planet's name.

I taught myself this because the books I was given failed me, and I have tried to write the one I needed. I am not standing on a hill. I am a few steps ahead on the same road, turning round to point at the signposts. Where I was uncertain I said so, and where the tradition gives a rule without a reason I told you that too, because I would rather you trusted the ground under you than trusted me.

Keep the map. Add to it on your birthday. Read your letter at the changeover and write the reply on the back. And when someone you love says, in that frightened voice, "my Saturn has started", you will know what to say: that it is a working time, that it has an end, and that you are there for all of it.

With love, and a pencil,

Anushka

In one breath

- A season map is built in ten steps: printout, bar, ages, sub-seasons, events, courtiers, honest reading of the past, the present line, the next bridge, and a letter.
- Mark events before you read the seasons, so the map has to earn its keep against your real life.
- Read each past season with the worksheet, prediction before outcome, counting misses as well as hits; the sub-lord that was hard more than once will be back.
- Your current task is three sentences: the season lord's task, the sub-lord's task and how the two sit together, and where it lands in your life this year.
- Write a one-page letter to this season, by hand, with one fear said once; read it at the changeover and reply on the back.
- Twenty questions answered from your own map, in your own words, are the whole skill this book promised.

Try this

TRY THIS:

1. Do the ten steps. Give it an afternoon. Date the map.
2. Fill the worksheet for your hardest past season first, prediction column before outcome column. Then for your kindest.
3. Write the three sentences of your current task, with no planet's name in the third. Read the third aloud to someone who knows you and ask whether it sounds like your year.
4. Write the letter. Fold it into the map.
5. Answer the twenty questions in a notebook, with a date beside them. Answer them again in a year, on the same pages, in a different colour.

Appendix A: The Tables

Every number in this book agrees with the tables on these pages. When you are drawing your map, keep this appendix open. Where a table judges, it carries the usual dots; where it only lists, it does not. All dates in the last table are approximate and say so.

A.1 The nine seasons and their lengths

The order never changes; the starting point is the Moon's star at birth. The lengths are tradition (Parashara's 120-year timetable), not astronomy, and the tradition gives no reason for them.

Order	Season (the courtier)	Length	Share of the 120 years
1	Ketu (the headless Sadhu)	7 years	5.8%
2	Venus (the Minister of Pleasure)	20 years	16.7%
3	Sun (the King)	6 years	5.0%
4	Moon (the Queen Mother)	10 years	8.3%
5	Mars (the Commander)	7 years	5.8%
6	Rahu (the smoke-headed Stranger)	18 years	15.0%
7	Jupiter (the Royal Priest)	16 years	13.3%
8	Saturn (the old Judge of Labour)	19 years	15.8%
9	Mercury (the clever young Prince)	17 years	14.2%
	Total	120 years	100%

After Mercury the order returns to Ketu. A life that begins in, say, the Rahu season runs Rahu, Jupiter, Saturn, Mercury, Ketu, Venus, Sun, Moon, Mars.

A.2 The sub-seasons: lengths inside each season

Row is the season lord, column is the sub-season lord. Length = (season years × sub-season years) ÷ 120. Sub-seasons run in the fixed order starting from the season's own lord (the Venus season runs Venus, Sun, Moon, Mars, Rahu, Jupiter, Saturn, Mercury, Ketu).

Season \ Sub	Ketu	Venus	Sun	Moon	Mars	Rahu	Jupiter	Saturn	Mercury
Ketu (7y)	0y 4m 27d	1y 2m 0d	0y 4m 6d	0y 7m 0d	0y 4m 27d	1y 0m 18d	0y 11m 6d	1y 1m 9d	0y 11m 27d
Venus (20y)	1y 2m 0d	3y 4m 0d	1y 0m 0d	1y 8m 0d	1y 2m 0d	3y 0m 0d	2y 8m 0d	3y 2m 0d	2y 10m 0d
Sun (6y)	0y 4m 6d	1y 0m 0d	0y 3m 18d	0y 6m 0d	0y 4m 6d	0y 10m 24d	0y 9m 18d	0y 11m 12d	0y 10m 6d
Moon (10y)	0y 7m 0d	1y 8m 0d	0y 6m 0d	0y 10m 0d	0y 7m 0d	1y 6m 0d	1y 4m 0d	1y 7m 0d	1y 5m 0d
Mars (7y)	0y 4m 27d	1y 2m 0d	0y 4m 6d	0y 7m 0d	0y 4m 27d	1y 0m 18d	0y 11m 6d	1y 1m 9d	0y 11m 27d
Rahu (18y)	1y 0m 18d	3y 0m 0d	0y 10m 24d	1y 6m 0d	1y 0m 18d	2y 8m 12d	2y 4m 24d	2y 10m 6d	2y 6m 18d
Jupiter (16y)	0y 11m 6d	2y 8m 0d	0y 9m 18d	1y 4m 0d	0y 11m 6d	2y 4m 24d	2y 1m 18d	2y 6m 12d	2y 3m 6d
Saturn (19y)	1y 1m 9d	3y 2m 0d	0y 11m 12d	1y 7m 0d	1y 1m 9d	2y 10m 6d	2y 6m 12d	3y 0m 3d	2y 8m 9d
Mercury (17y)	0y 11m 27d	2y 10m 0d	0y 10m 6d	1y 5m 0d	0y 11m 27d	2y 6m 18d	2y 3m 6d	2y 8m 9d	2y 4m 27d

To use it: find your season's row, then read across in the fixed order starting from the season's own column, adding each length to the season's start date. The months are twelfths of a year and the days thirtieths of a month, as the tradition reckons them, which is why your app's dates may differ from this arithmetic by a few days.

A.3 The Moon's star and the first season

Each star spans 13°20' of the zodiac. The lords repeat three times in the fixed order. Find the Moon's position in your chart, read its star, and the third column gives the season you were born into. The balance at birth is the part of the star the Moon had still to cross, divided by 13°20', multiplied by the lord's years.

#	Star (nakshatra)	Span	First season (its full length)
1	Ashwini	0°00' to 13°20' Aries	Ketu (7)
2	Bharani	13°20' to 26°40' Aries	Venus (20)
3	Krittika	26°40' Aries to 10°00' Taurus	Sun (6)
4	Rohini	10°00' to 23°20' Taurus	Moon (10)
5	Mrigashira	23°20' Taurus to 6°40' Gemini	Mars (7)
6	Ardra	6°40' to 20°00' Gemini	Rahu (18)
7	Punarvasu	20°00' Gemini to 3°20' Cancer	Jupiter (16)
8	Pushya	3°20' to 16°40' Cancer	Saturn (19)
9	Ashlesha	16°40' to 30°00' Cancer	Mercury (17)
10	Magha	0°00' to 13°20' Leo	Ketu (7)
11	Purva Phalguni	13°20' to 26°40' Leo	Venus (20)
12	Uttara Phalguni	26°40' Leo to 10°00' Virgo	Sun (6)
13	Hasta	10°00' to 23°20' Virgo	Moon (10)
14	Chitra	23°20' Virgo to 6°40' Libra	Mars (7)
15	Swati	6°40' to 20°00' Libra	Rahu (18)
16	Vishakha	20°00' Libra to 3°20' Scorpio	Jupiter (16)
17	Anuradha	3°20' to 16°40' Scorpio	Saturn (19)
18	Jyeshtha	16°40' to 30°00' Scorpio	Mercury (17)
19	Mula	0°00' to 13°20' Sagittarius	Ketu (7)
20	Purva Ashadha	13°20' to 26°40' Sagittarius	Venus (20)
21	Uttara Ashadha	26°40' Sagittarius to 10°00' Capricorn	Sun (6)
22	Shravana	10°00' to 23°20' Capricorn	Moon (10)
23	Dhanishta	23°20' Capricorn to 6°40' Aquarius	Mars (7)
24	Shatabhisha	6°40' to 20°00' Aquarius	Rahu (18)
25	Purva Bhadrapada	20°00' Aquarius to 3°20' Pisces	Jupiter (16)
26	Uttara Bhadrapada	3°20' to 16°40' Pisces	Saturn (19)

#	Star (nakshatra)	Span	First season (its full length)
27	Revati	16°40' to 30°00' Pisces	Mercury (17)

Our three case lives: Meera's Moon at 21° Cancer is in Ashlesha (Mercury, balance 11.475 years); Arjun's at 6° Taurus is in Krittika (Sun, balance 1.8 years); Devika's at 14° Sagittarius is in Purva Ashadha (Venus, balance 19 years).

A.4 Season by age: a ready-reckoner for the nine starting seasons

Find the row for your first season (from A.3). Read across for the ages at which each later season begins and ends. **The table assumes you received the whole of your first season.** In real life the first season is shortened by the balance at birth, so every age in your row is reduced by the part of the first season you did not receive. Meera's row is the Mercury row minus 5.5 years (she received 11.5 of Mercury's 17); Arjun's is the Sun row minus 4.2 years; Devika's is the Venus row minus 1 year.

First season	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th	6th	7th	8th	9th
Ketu	Ketu 0 to 7	Venus 7 to 27	Sun 27 to 33	Moon 33 to 43	Mars 43 to 50	Rahu 50 to 68	Jupiter 68 to 84	Saturn 84 to 103	Mercury 103 to 120
Venus	Venus 0 to 20	Sun 20 to 26	Moon 26 to 36	Mars 36 to 43	Rahu 43 to 61	Jupiter 61 to 77	Saturn 77 to 96	Mercury 96 to 113	Ketu 113 to 120
Sun	Sun 0 to 6	Moon 6 to 16	Mars 16 to 23	Rahu 23 to 41	Jupiter 41 to 57	Saturn 57 to 76	Mercury 76 to 93	Ketu 93 to 100	Venus 100 to 120
Moon	Moon 0 to 10	Mars 10 to 17	Rahu 17 to 35	Jupiter 35 to 51	Saturn 51 to 70	Mercury 70 to 87	Ketu 87 to 94	Venus 94 to 114	Sun 114 to 120
Mars	Mars 0 to 7	Rahu 7 to 25	Jupiter 25 to 41	Saturn 41 to 60	Mercury 60 to 77	Ketu 77 to 84	Venus 84 to 104	Sun 104 to 110	Moon 110 to 120
Rahu	Rahu 0 to 18	Jupiter 18 to 34	Saturn 34 to 53	Mercury 53 to 70	Ketu 70 to 77	Venus 77 to 97	Sun 97 to 103	Moon 103 to 113	Mars 113 to 120
Jupiter	Jupiter 0 to 16	Saturn 16 to 35	Mercury 35 to 52	Ketu 52 to 59	Venus 59 to 79	Sun 79 to 85	Moon 85 to 95	Mars 95 to 102	Rahu 102 to 120
Saturn	Saturn 0 to 19	Mercury 19 to 36	Ketu 36 to 43	Venus 43 to 63	Sun 63 to 69	Moon 69 to 79	Mars 79 to 86	Rahu 86 to 104	Jupiter 104 to 120
Mercury	Mercury 0 to 17	Ketu 17 to 24	Venus 24 to 44	Sun 44 to 50	Moon 50 to 60	Mars 60 to 67	Rahu 67 to 85	Jupiter 85 to 101	Saturn 101 to 120

A quick way to read it: those who begin in Ketu spend their teens and twenties in Venus; those who begin in Venus leave it at twenty and meet Rahu in their mid-forties; those who begin in the Sun or Mercury enter Rahu or Venus in their mid-twenties; those who begin in the Moon, Mars or Rahu meet Saturn somewhere between forty and fifty; and those who begin in Jupiter or Saturn have their Saturn season early and their Venus season in their forties and fifties.

A.5 The slow planets overhead, 2026 to 2032 (approximate)

These are the sign positions of the three planets whose weather matters most (Chapter 14), given to the nearest few months. **They are approximate.** The planets walk backwards for part of every year and cross sign boundaries more than once, so a planet near a boundary may be in either sign on a given day. Check an app for the exact date before you rely on one. Ketu is always in the sign opposite Rahu.

Planet	Sign and approximate dates
Saturn (about 2½ years a sign)	Pisces until about mid-2027 · Aries from about mid-2027, with a return to Pisces from late 2027 to early 2028 · Aries again from early 2028 until about 2030 · Taurus from about 2030
Jupiter (about a year a sign)	Gemini until about mid-2026 · Cancer to about mid-2027 · Leo to about mid-2028 · Virgo to about mid-2029 · Libra to about late 2030 · Scorpio to about late 2031 · Sagittarius through 2032
Rahu (about 1½ years a sign, walking backwards)	Aquarius until about December 2026 · Capricorn to about mid-2028 · Sagittarius to about early 2030 · Scorpio to about mid-2031 · Libra from about mid-2031
Ketu (opposite Rahu)	Leo until about December 2026 · Cancer to about mid-2028 · Gemini to about early 2030 · Taurus to about mid-2031 · Aries from about mid-2031

Saturn's seven and a half years run while Saturn crosses the sign before your Moon's sign, your Moon's sign, and the sign after. From this table: a Pisces Moon is in the middle phase until mid-2027; an Aries Moon has begun the first phase and enters the middle phase around mid-2027; a Taurus Moon begins the first phase around mid-2027 and the middle phase around 2030; an Aquarius Moon is in the last phase until mid-2027. Everything else about the weather is in Chapter 14.

Appendix B: Plain Words to Sanskrit

This book speaks English. When you open an app, sit with a family astrologer or pick up an older book, you will meet the Sanskrit. This list translates in both directions: the plain word used in these pages, the Sanskrit in parentheses, a one-line meaning, and the chapter where the idea first appears. Spellings vary from app to app (dasa or dasha, bhukti or antardasha); the sounds are the same.

The timetable

- **season**, or **major season** when contrasting with a sub-season (mahadasha): the years when one planet runs your household; the top row of a dasha table (Ch 1).
- **sub-season** (antardasha; in South Indian usage bhukti): one of the nine divisions of a season, run by a second planet beside the first; the indented row in an app (Ch 3).
- **the small turns** (pratyantardasha): the nine divisions of a sub-season, lasting weeks to months; mentioned once and not lived by (Ch 3).
- **the 120-year timetable** (Vimshottari dasha): Parashara's season system, 120 years divided among the nine planets in a fixed order; the word means "a hundred and twenty" (Ch 1).
- **dasha** (dasha, dasa): literally "state" or "condition"; the system of seasons, and the one Sanskrit word this book keeps in prose (Ch 1).
- **season lord** (dasha nath, dasha swami): the planet whose years are running (Ch 1).
- **sub-lord** (antardasha nath, bhukti nath): the planet running the current sub-season (Ch 3).
- **the balance at birth** (dasha shesha, balance of dasha): the part of the first season still unspent at birth, in proportion to the part of the Moon's star still to cross (Ch 2).
- **the changeover**, the turning point between seasons or sub-seasons (dasha sandhi): the sensitive months on either side of a handover (Ch 3, Ch 15).
- **MD, AD, PD**: app abbreviations for mahadasha, antardasha and pratyantardasha, that is season, sub-season and small turn (Ch 3).
- **season map, the chart's timetable** (dasha chart): the table of your seasons and sub-seasons with dates, as an app prints it (Ch 2).
- **the 108-year timetable** (Ashtottari dasha): an alternative season system Parashara gives for some births; not used in this book (Ch 2).
- **Parashara**: the sage to whom the great textbook of Vedic astrology is attributed; "the tradition" in this book usually means his text (Ch 1).
- **BPHS** (Brihat Parashara Hora Shastra): Parashara's textbook, written as a conversation with his student Maitreya; the source of the 120-year timetable (Ch 1).
- **Vedic astrology** (Jyotish): "the science of light"; the Indian astrology this book uses (Ch 1).

- **the science of hours**, predictive astrology (hora shastra): the branch of Vedic astrology that reads birth charts, as distinct from calendar-keeping (Ch 1).

The Moon and its stars

- **the Moon's star, your birth star** (nakshatra; janma nakshatra for the one at birth): one of 27 equal divisions of the Moon's path, each 13°20' wide; its lord is your first season lord (Ch 1, Ch 2).
- **quarter of a star** (pada): one of four 3°20' parts of a star; used in naming and in finer charts, not in the season sum (Ch 2).
- **Ashlesha**: the ninth star, 16°40' to 30° Cancer, Mercury's; Meera's birth star (Ch 2).
- **Krittika**: the third star, 26°40' Aries to 10° Taurus, the Sun's; Arjun's birth star (Ch 2).
- **Purva Ashadha**: the twentieth star, 13°20' to 26°40' Sagittarius, Venus's; Devika's birth star (Ch 2).
- **the Moon's sign at birth** (janma rashi, chandra rashi): the sign the Moon occupied at birth; the base from which Saturn's seven and a half years is counted (Ch 14).
- **the Moon's phase**, bright or dark fortnight (paksha: shukla, krishna): whether the Moon was waxing or waning at birth; it colours the Moon season (Ch 7).

The chart

- **birth chart** (kundali, janma patrika, janma kundali): the map of the sky at the minute and place of birth (Ch 1).
- **rising sign** (Lagna, also "ascendant"): the sign rising in the east at birth; it fixes the twelve rooms and decides which planets are on your side (Ch 1).
- **lord of the rising sign** (lagnesh, Lagna lord): the planet that owns your rising sign; treated as on your side (Ch 13).
- **sign** (rashi): one of twelve 30° divisions of the zodiac belt (Ch 2).
- **the zodiac belt** (rashi chakra): the ring of twelve signs through which the Moon and planets travel (Ch 2).
- **room**, one of the twelve rooms of your chart (bhava; "house" in English books): an area of life, counted from the rising sign (Ch 1).
- **whole-sign rooms** (rashi bhava): the Vedic default in which one sign is one room (Ch 2).
- **lord of a room** (bhava adhipati, bhavesh): the planet that owns the sign in that room; its seasons bring that room's matters due (Ch 3).
- **planet** (graha; "that which grasps"): one of the nine actors of the chart; Rahu and Ketu keep their own names (Ch 1).
- **the two shadow planets** (chhaya graha): Rahu and Ketu, the two points where the Moon's path crosses the Sun's; the north and south nodes (Ch 1).
- **the star-fixed zodiac** (nirayana, sidereal): the zodiac measured against the actual stars, which Vedic astrology uses (Ch 2).

- **the season-fixed zodiac** (sayana, tropical): the zodiac measured from the spring equinox, used by Western astrology (Ch 2).
- **the standard Indian setting** for the zodiac (Lahiri ayanamsa, also Chitrapaksha): the official Indian value for the gap between the two zodiacs, adopted in 1955; set it once in your app (Ch 2).
- **the gap between the two zodiacs** (ayanamsa): the slowly growing offset, about 24°, between the star-fixed and season-fixed zodiacs (Ch 2).
- **almanac** (panchanga, panchang): the five-limbed Indian calendar of lunar day, weekday, star, and two further measures; the name behind Drik Panchang (Ch 2).

Rooms by group

- **the four pillar rooms**, 1, 4, 7 and 10 (kendra): the angles of the chart; planets here act strongly and steadily (Ch 3).
- **the three lucky rooms**, 1, 5 and 9 (trikona): rooms of merit and fortune; a sub-lord here, counted from the season lord, works with the season (Ch 3).
- **the three hard rooms**, 6, 8 and 12 (dusthana, trik): rooms of struggle, upheaval and loss; the "wrong rooms" when counted from a season lord (Ch 3).
- **the growing rooms**, 3, 6, 10 and 11 (upachaya): rooms that improve with time and effort (Ch 13).
- **the two rooms of endings**, 2 and 7 (maraka): rooms whose lords are watched for health in old age in classical texts; this book does not predict from them (Ch 13).
- **the obstructing room** (badhaka): a room, varying by rising sign, whose lord brings obstacles in some schools; glossary only (Ch 13).
- **the room of marriage**, room 7 (kalatra bhava, yuvati bhava): spouse and partnership; Venus owns it for Meera (Ch 3).

Strength and company

- **a planet that is on your side** (functional benefic, shubha for your rising sign): a planet that owns helpful rooms for your rising sign and so gives good results in its seasons (Ch 4, Ch 13).
- **a planet that tests you** (functional malefic, papa for your rising sign): a planet that owns difficult rooms for your rising sign; its seasons bring tasks (Ch 4, Ch 13).
- **your best planet** (yogakaraka): the single planet that owns both a pillar room and a lucky room for your rising sign (Ch 4).
- **naturally gentle planet** (saumya or shubha graha): Jupiter, Venus, the waxing Moon and well-placed Mercury (Ch 13).
- **naturally harsh planet** (krura or papa graha): the Sun, Mars, Saturn, Rahu, Ketu and the waning Moon; harsh by nature, not necessarily against you (Ch 13).
- **at its strongest place** (uccha, exalted): the sign where a planet works best, such as the Moon in Taurus or Jupiter in Cancer (Ch 13).

- **at its weakest place** (neecha, debilitated): the sign opposite its strongest, where a planet struggles, such as the Sun in Libra (Ch 13).
- **at home** (swakshetra, own sign): a planet in a sign it owns, such as Venus in Libra; steady and comfortable (Ch 3).
- **the planet's favourite stretch of its own sign** (moolatrikona): a particular span within one own sign where it is strongest (Ch 13).
- **outshone by the Sun** (asta, combust): a planet so close to the Sun that it loses strength, such as Meera's Saturn (Ch 3).
- **walking backwards** (vakri, retrograde): a planet that appears to move backwards against the stars for some months; its results come inwardly or late (Ch 13).
- **sits with** (yuti, conjunction): two planets in the same sign and room (Ch 13).
- **looks at**, casts its gaze on (drishti, aspect): a planet's influence on a room some distance from it; the 7th for all, with extra gazes for Mars, Jupiter and Saturn (Ch 13).
- **natural friendship** (naisargika maitri): the fixed friendships and enmities among the planets; Question one for any sub-season (Ch 3).
- **temporary friendship** (tatkalya maitri): friendship from position in a particular chart, combined with natural friendship by careful readers (Ch 13).
- **exchange of homes** (parivartana): two planets each sitting in the other's sign, fusing their rooms; Devika's Moon and Jupiter (Ch 7).
- **the planet whose star the season lord sits in** (nakshatra lord, "star lord" in the KP school): the hidden agenda of a season in the modern practice (Ch 13).
- **the planet that stands for something** (karaka): the natural signifier of a matter, such as the Sun for the father, Venus for marriage, Jupiter for children (Ch 5).
- **a combination** (yoga): a pattern of planets with a named result in the classics; this book describes such patterns in English (Ch 13).
- **a royal combination** (raja yoga): a pillar-room lord joined with a lucky-room lord, promising a rise in status in its seasons (Ch 13).
- **the ninefold chart** (navamsa, D9): a finer chart used for marriage and inner strength; not used in this book (Ch 13).
- **the divided charts** (varga): the family of finer charts of which the ninefold chart is one; Book 1 territory (Ch 13).

The weather overhead

- **the weather** (gochar, gochara, transit): where the planets are moving now, laid over the birth chart (Ch 14).
- **Saturn's seven and a half years** (Sade Sati): Saturn's passage over the sign before, the sign of, and the sign after your birth Moon, about 2½ years each (Ch 4, Ch 14).

- **Saturn's two and a half years over the fourth or eighth** (dhaiya, kantaka Shani, ashtama Shani): shorter testing passages counted from the birth Moon (Ch 14).
- **the Moon as rising sign** (chandra lagna): reading the chart with the birth Moon's sign as the first room, used for all weather from the Moon (Ch 14).

Practices and conduct

- **a practice** (upaya; never "remedy" alone in this book): a conduct, service or routine matched to a season's planet (Ch 17).
- **giving** (daan, dana): gifts of food, cloth or time as a practice for a planet (Ch 17).
- **repetition** (japa): repeating a short sacred phrase a set number of times (Ch 17).
- **a short sacred phrase** (mantra): the words repeated in japa; the planets each have one (Ch 17).
- **gemstone** (ratna): the stones sold for planets; this book advises against buying them out of fear (Ch 17).
- **the planet's weekday** (vara): each planet owns a day, Sunday for the Sun through Saturday for Saturn; practices are often done on that day (Ch 17).

Karma, in three words

- **the whole store** (sanchita karma): everything ever set in motion, which no chart can read (Ch 1).
- **the portion allotted to this life** (prarabdha karma): what has ripened and is due now; the part a chart and its seasons show (Ch 1).
- **what you do now** (kriyamana karma): the choices made inside each season; entirely yours (Ch 1).

The court

- **the King** (Surya, the Sun): authority, father, identity (Ch 1, Ch 6).
- **the Queen Mother** (Chandra, the Moon): mind, mother, home, moods (Ch 1, Ch 7).
- **the Commander** (Mangala or Kuja, Mars): energy, courage, property, conflict (Ch 1, Ch 8).
- **the clever young Prince** (Budha, Mercury): learning, speech, trade (Ch 1, Ch 12).
- **the Royal Priest** (Guru or Brihaspati, Jupiter): wisdom, teachers, children, growth (Ch 1, Ch 10).
- **the Minister of Pleasure** (Shukra, Venus): love, marriage, comfort, beauty (Ch 1, Ch 5).
- **the old Judge of Labour** (Shani, Saturn): work, limits, time, maturity (Ch 1, Ch 11).
- **the smoke-headed Stranger** (Rahu, the north node): hunger, foreign places, illusion, sudden rises (Ch 1, Ch 9).
- **the headless Sadhu** (Ketu, the south node): letting go, detachment, research, solitude (Ch 1, Ch 4).

Appendix C: Getting Your Season Map from Free Tools

You need three things from any tool: the Moon's star at your birth, the list of your nine seasons with dates, and the sub-season table for the seasons you want to read. Two free tools give all three. Menus move between versions, so where I say "look for" rather than "click", that is why.

What to set, in any tool

Before you read a single date, check three settings. They are usually already right in Indian software and sometimes wrong in Western apps.

1. **Zodiac: sidereal.** The star-fixed zodiac that Vedic astrology uses. If the tool offers "tropical", that is the Western one; do not use it.
2. **The standard Indian setting: Lahiri** (called the ayanamsa in the menus; also written Chitrapaksha or Chitra Paksha). Every date in this book assumes it. A different setting moves the Moon by up to a degree or two and can shift your balance at birth by months.
3. **The timetable: the 120-year one (Vimshottari).** Tools offer several timetables; ignore the others for now.

Also use whole-sign rooms (one sign, one room), which is the Vedic default, so that your rooms match Chapter 13.

Jagannatha Hora (Windows, free)

This is the program most serious Indian astrologers use, and it costs nothing. Download it from its author's site (search "Jagannatha Hora download"; the program is by P. V. R. Narasimha Rao). It runs on Windows; on a Mac it needs a Windows layer.

1. Open the program. The first dialog, or the **Birth data** item under the first menu, asks for name, date, time and place. Type the city and pick it from the list so the longitude, latitude and time zone fill in; check that the time zone matches the place and year (India is +5:30).
2. Open **Preferences**, then the section on calculations. Set the zodiac to sidereal and the setting to Lahiri. Set the house system to whole sign. Save, and tick the option that keeps these as defaults so you do not do this again.
3. The main window shows the chart. Look for the Moon's star: the panel of planet positions lists each planet with its sign, degree and star, and the star's lord. Write the Moon's star and lord down; that is

your first season.

4. Click the **Dasas** tab along the top of the window. In the list of dasha systems on the left, choose the 120-year timetable (spelt "Vimsottari" there). The right-hand panel shows your nine seasons with start and end dates.
5. Click a season to open its nine sub-seasons; click a sub-season to open the small turns inside it. The dates appear in the same panel.
6. To keep it: right-click in the panel for a copy option and paste into a document, or use the print and save options under the first menu (the program can save the whole chart as a web page). A screenshot of the open panel works just as well.

The AstroSage app (Android and iPhone, free)

1. Install **AstroSage Kundli** and open it. Choose **Kundli**, then the option to create a new one. Enter name, date, time and place; pick the place from the suggestions so the coordinates fill in.
2. Open the app's settings (the gear icon) and check that the chart style is one you can read (north or south), the zodiac is sidereal and the setting is Lahiri (Chitrapaksha). It usually is.
3. Open the chart you made. The screen has tabs along the top or bottom. The **Basic** tab lists the Moon's sign and star ("Nakshatra") and the star's lord: your first season.
4. Find the **Dasha** tab. The first screen lists your nine seasons (labelled "Mahadasha") with start and end dates. Tap a season to see its sub-seasons (labelled "Antardasha"), and tap a sub-season to see the small turns inside it.
5. To keep it: take a screenshot of each screen you need (the seasons list, and the sub-season list for your current season and the past seasons you want to read). Some versions offer a shareable report as a file; the screenshot is enough.

Drik Panchang, in one line

The Drik Panchang website also casts a chart with the 120-year season table under its "Kundali" tools, and its day-by-day panchang pages are the quickest way to check which star the Moon was in on your date of birth.

If the birth time is uncertain

Most people know their birth time to within an hour or two; some know only "morning" or "night"; a few know only the day. Here is what that does to your map, so you know what you can trust.

The first season rarely changes; the balance does. The Moon moves about 13° a day, a sign every 2¼ days, and a star (13°20') in about a day. So if your time is wrong by an hour, the Moon is wrong by about half a degree, which is a small part of a star: your first season is almost always the same, but the balance at birth shifts. The rule of thumb: an hour's error moves every later date on your map by about 4 per cent of your first

season's full length. That is about ten months if your first season is Venus (20 years), nine if Saturn, eight or nine if Rahu or Mercury, eight if Jupiter, five if the Moon, three if the Sun, Mars or Ketu. A whole morning's uncertainty can be a year or more. Changeover dates are the ones to hold loosely.

If the Moon sits near the edge of a star, within a degree or two, a modest error can push it into the next star and change the first season entirely. The apps show the degree; if your Moon's degree is within 1° of a star boundary in Table A.3, treat your first season as uncertain and read both possibilities against your life.

Fit the clock to the life. Cast the chart for the earliest and latest times you think possible. Compare the sub-season dates each gives for two or three events you can date exactly (a marriage, a first job, a child). The time whose sub-seasons fit the events best is the one to use. This is a plain version of what astrologers call rectification, and it is honest work, not cheating, as long as you fit to events you already know and not to hopes.

If you know only the day, cast the chart for noon. The Moon will be within about 6½° of its true place, which keeps it inside one star more often than not, and the first season will usually be right. The rising sign, the rooms and the exact dates will not be; read the seasons as themes and keep the dates to the nearest year or two.

If the day itself is uncertain, as it is for some older relatives, the timetable cannot be built. Read the weather (Chapter 14) and the planets' natures instead, and be honest with the person about why.

Whatever you find, write the time you used and the settings you chose on the map itself, so that when you redraw it in a year you draw the same map.

Appendix D: The Story Bank: Every Memory Tale in One Place

The reader who commissioned this book said: lists fade, stories stay. Here are all the stories from the chapters, in order, each with its one-line rule, so you can revise the whole grammar of astrology in an evening by reading the tales alone. The cast never changes: the **King** (Sun), the **Queen Mother** (Moon), the **Commander** (Mars), the young **Prince** and secretary (Mercury), the **Royal Priest** (Jupiter), the **Minister of Pleasure** (Venus), the old **Judge of Labour** (Saturn), and the two strangers at the gate: smoke-headed **Rahu** and the headless sadhu **Ketu**. The twelve houses are the rooms of the palace, the signs are the districts of the kingdom, the nakshatras are its streets, and the dashas are the railway timetable.

From Chapter 1: The Same Person, Different Lives

STORY: THE HOUSEHOLD CHANGES HANDS. *In Book 1 the nine planets were a royal court, and I am keeping them. The **King** (the Sun), proud and warm, wants to be seen. The **Queen Mother** (the Moon) runs the household and knows everyone's moods because she has them all herself. The **Commander** (Mars) guards the gate and starts the fights. The clever young **Prince** (Mercury) writes the letters and counts the coins. The **Royal Priest** (Jupiter) teaches, blesses and gives too much. The **Minister of Pleasure** (Venus) arranges music, weddings and comfort. The old **Judge of Labour** (Saturn) keeps the ledger of every debt. At the gate stand two strangers: **Rahu**, the smoke-headed traveller who wants everything he sees, and **Ketu**, the headless sadhu who wants nothing. When the Minister holds the keys, the house fills with music and visitors. When the Judge takes over, the music stops and the accounts come out. Same household, different person in charge. **Rule:** a season is the years when that courtier runs your household; to understand the season, ask what that courtier wants.*

STORY: THE QUEEN MOTHER'S CALENDAR. *The court argued about who should keep the royal calendar. The King said: I am the light of the kingdom, measure the year by me. The Priest said: I move slowly and wisely, measure it by me. The old Judge said nothing and kept his own accounts. The Queen Mother listened, then asked one question. "Which of you knows, tonight, what every member of this household is feeling?" Nobody answered. "Then the calendar is mine," she said, "because a year is not what happens in a kingdom. It is what the people in it live through." From that night the court's seasons were counted from where she stood when each child was born. **Rule:** the first season is chosen by the Moon's star at birth, because seasons are lived through the mind, and the Moon is the mind.*

From Chapter 2: The Sky's Timetable: How the Seasons Work

STORY: THE ORDER OF THE PROCESSION. *Once a year the court walks in procession through the city, in an order settled so long ago that nobody remembers the quarrel that fixed it. The headless Sadhu goes first, because he wants nothing and cannot be bribed to let anyone ahead. The Minister of Pleasure follows, strewing flowers for a very long way. Then the King, briefly, in full sun. Then the Queen Mother, slow and attentive. The Commander marches past quickly. The Stranger wanders for miles, looking at everything. The Priest walks and teaches. The old Judge walks longest and checks that nothing has been left behind. The young Prince runs alongside, talking, and then the Sadhu is at the front again. A new courtier once asked to change places. The Judge said, "You may change your pace. You may not change your place."* **Rule:** the nine seasons always run Ketu, Venus, Sun, Moon, Mars, Rahu, Jupiter, Saturn, Mercury, and then round again.

STORY: THE PRINCE'S HALF-FINISHED TERM. *A child was born in the palace while the clever young Prince was steward of the household. He had already spent a third of his term; two thirds remained. The nurse asked whether the Prince would start again from the beginning, for the baby's sake. The old Judge, who kept the ledger, shook his head. "The term belongs to the household, not to the child. She joins it where it stands." So the child's first season was the Prince's remaining years, not a day more, and when they ran out the headless Sadhu took the keys exactly on schedule. Rule: your first season is only the part of its lord's years still unspent at your birth; the fraction of the star left for the Moon to cross is the fraction of the season left for you.*

From Chapter 3: Seasons Inside Seasons

STORY: THE MINISTER TAKES THE FIRST TURN. *When the Minister of Pleasure was given the keys to the household for twenty years, she invited the whole court to serve under her, one at a time. "But I go first," she said, "so that everyone sees how I like things done." For three years and four months she ran the household alone, all music and new curtains. Then the King came to help, for one year, and the house became grander and louder. Then the Queen Mother, then the Commander, each bringing their own manner into her rooms. The old Judge's turn came late and lasted over three years, and the household learned that even the Minister's house has accounts. The headless Sadhu came last and quietly took down the curtains for the King's own term.* **Rule:** *sub-seasons run in the fixed order, starting with the season's own lord; the first stretch of a season is its purest expression, the last already smells of the changeover.*

STORY: THE GUEST IN THE WRONG ROOM. *The Minister of Pleasure was running the household when the Commander's turn came to serve beside her. The two had always been civil. But his quarters lay in the sixth room from hers, past the kitchens, and every morning he marched through her music-room in boots to reach the door. Within a month the musicians had left and the Minister had a headache. "It is not that he is bad," she told the Queen Mother. "It is where he lives." When the Stranger's turn came, he lodged in the fifth room from hers, with a window onto the same garden, and they got on so well that there was a wedding.* **Rule:** *count the sub-lord's room from the season lord's; the 6th, 8th and 12th pull against the season, the 1st, 5th and 9th pull with it, whatever the planets' temperaments.*

From Chapter 4: The Ketu Season (7 Years): The Art of Letting Go

STORY: THE SADHU TAKES THE KEYS. When it was Ketu's turn to run the palace, the courtiers panicked. Who would arrange the feasts, plan the campaigns, keep the accounts? The Sadhu said nothing, having no head to speak with, and simply walked through the palace opening windows. Within a year the storerooms were half empty, the guest list short, and the King's youngest daughter sat in the courtyard reading manuscripts nobody had opened in decades. "Nothing is being done," the courtiers complained. The Queen Mother disagreed. "Everything that did not matter is being put down," she said, "so that our hands are free when the Minister of Pleasure returns." **Rule:** Ketu's season does not build; it clears. Judge it by what you have put down, not by what you have picked up.

STORY: THE SADHU AND THE MINISTER OF PLEASURE. The Minister of Pleasure arrived at the Sadhu's bare courtyard with musicians and sweets. He could not eat them, having no mouth, but he did not send her away. He let her hang one lamp, plant one jasmine bush, and sit with him in the evenings. When she left she took the musicians but left the jasmine. **Rule:** Venus inside Ketu brings a small, real comfort. Keep the jasmine; do not try to keep the band.

STORY: THE TWO STRANGERS FACE EACH OTHER. Once a year the Sadhu and the smoke-headed Stranger must share a corridor. The Stranger talks all night about distant cities and new machines; the Sadhu cannot answer, and cannot leave. By morning the Stranger has sold him a telescope. **Rule:** In Ketu/Rahu, sleep on every purchase and every plan for a month. The hunger is borrowed and will pass.

From Chapter 5: The Venus Season (20 Years): The Long Bloom

STORY: THE MINISTER HANGS THE LAMPS. *The Sadhu left the palace bare, and the Minister of Pleasure walked in behind him with a long list. She hung lamps in every corridor, planted the courtyard, hired musicians and sent for the cooks. Within three years the palace was full of guests, laughter and the smell of ghee. The old Judge grumbled about the bills. But the Queen Mother noticed that the courtiers were kinder, marriages were being arranged, and the treasury, oddly, was growing, because people like to pay a house that makes them welcome. "Twenty years of this," said the Judge. "Yes," said the Minister, "and you will have to find your own way not to get fat."* **Rule:** Venus's season fills the house. The task is to keep your shape inside the abundance.

STORY: THE STRANGER AT THE WEDDING. *The Minister of Pleasure was arranging a wedding when the smoke-headed Stranger offered to help. He doubled the guest list, hired a band from another country, and introduced the bride to a man nobody had vetted. The wedding was the talk of the kingdom, and the marriage, surprisingly, was good: the Stranger's choices are often right, only reached by strange roads.* **Rule:** Venus/Rahu brings love and commitments by unconventional routes. Check the road, not just the destination.

STORY: THE JUDGE INSPECTS THE GARDEN. *After thirteen years of feasts the old Judge of Labour walked through the Minister's garden with a ledger. He did not uproot a single plant. He simply asked of each one, "Who waters this, and with what?" By the end of his three years the garden was smaller and every plant in it was paid for.* **Rule:** Venus/Saturn does not end the bloom. It asks what you can actually afford to keep.

From Chapter 6: The Sun Season (6 Years): Who Am I When Nobody Is Watching?

STORY: THE KING WALKS THE KINGDOM ALONE. When the Minister of Pleasure's long tenure ended, the King sent the musicians home and walked out of the palace in plain clothes. For six years he visited every village and asked everyone he met one question: "What are you for?" Many could not answer; they had been busy being comfortable. The King was not angry; he wrote their names in a book and moved on. When he came back, those who knew what they were for were given work; those who did not had been given six years to find out. **Rule:** The Sun's season asks what you stand for and makes it visible. There is nowhere to hide, and that is the gift.

STORY: THE ECLIPSE AT COURT. One afternoon the smoke-headed Stranger stood in front of the King and, for a few minutes, the court could not see the throne. Ministers took orders from the Stranger; courtiers wore his clothes. Then the shadow passed and the King was exactly where he had always been, embarrassed by how quickly everyone had forgotten him. **Rule:** In Sun/Rahu you will be tempted to become someone else. Wait for the shadow to pass before signing anything in the new name.

STORY: THE KING AND THE JUDGE. The old Judge of Labour came to audit his father's household and found the ledgers empty, because kings do not keep accounts. For eleven months he made the King sign for every lamp, every meal, every title he had handed out. The King hated it. At the end he knew, for the first time, what his kingdom cost and what he was for. **Rule:** Sun/Saturn is the audit of your authority. Do the paperwork; the clarity is worth the humiliation.

From Chapter 7: The Moon Season (10 Years): The Household of the Mind

STORY: THE QUEEN MOTHER TAKES THE KEYS. When the King's season ended the court expected quiet. Instead the Queen Mother walked through every room with a bunch of keys and opened doors nobody had opened in years. "Who sleeps here? Who cooks for them? When did this child last see her mother?" The Commander wanted a campaign; she sent him to repair the well. The Prince wanted to publish accounts; she asked him to write to the relatives. By the end of the year the palace was fuller, warmer, noisier and more emotional, and nobody could say what had been achieved, except that everyone had been fed. **Rule:** the Moon season measures success by how well the household is held, not by what is won.

STORY: THE QUEEN MOTHER'S LAMP. Every evening the Queen Mother walked the corridors with a lamp. Some years it was full of oil and the whole palace saw her coming and felt safe. Some years the oil was low, and the servants said she was angry, when really she could not see them. The King said nothing; he was the Sun, the source of the oil, and he lit her only when she stood far enough from him to catch his light. **Rule:** a Moon far from the Sun at birth is a bright Moon and a steadier mind; a Moon near the Sun is a dark Moon, not a bad one, and needs tending.

STORY: THE QUEEN MOTHER AND THE STRANGER. A smoke-headed traveller arrived at the kitchen door and asked for shelter. The Queen Mother, who fed everyone, fed him. But he wanted a dish from a country nobody had heard of, then another, then the recipe, then the cook. Within a month the kitchen smelled of unfamiliar spices and the servants could not sleep. He left as suddenly as he came, and three of his recipes were now family favourites. **Rule:** Moon/Rahu unsettles the household and widens its table; keep your sleep and you will keep the good recipes.

From Chapter 8: The Mars Season (7 Years): The Commander Takes Charge

STORY: THE COMMANDER TAKES THE KEYS. *The Queen Mother handed over the keys and the Commander did not even look at them. He walked straight to the boundary wall, found the crack everyone had stepped around for a decade, and had it rebuilt in a week. Then he started a dispute with the neighbouring kingdom over a field and bought three horses the treasury could not afford. By the end of his seven years the court was exhausted, bruised and in possession of a stronger wall, a bigger field, a fitter household and two feuds. "Was it worth it?" asked the Priest. "Ask me in the next season," said the Commander. **Rule:** the Mars season builds, defends and fights, in that order of value; your job is to choose the fights.*

STORY: THE COMMANDER AND THE JUDGE. *The Commander had three campaigns planned when the old Judge of Labour arrived with his ledgers. "You cannot march," said the Judge, "until the wall is paid for." The Commander raged, then sulked, then, for the first time in years, sat still. In the stillness he noticed that his shoulder had hurt for months and that two of his best soldiers were unwell. He spent the year mending, paying and resting, and hated every day of it. The next spring his army was the fittest it had ever been. **Rule:** Mars/Saturn stops the Commander so the body and the accounts can catch up; the stop is the gift.*

From Chapter 9: The Rahu Season (18 Years): The Great Churning

STORY: THE STRANGER TAKES THE KEYS. *The Commander handed over the keys and the Stranger smiled with a mouth nobody could quite see. Within a year the palace had a telegraph, a foreign cook, three new trade routes and a debt to a kingdom nobody had heard of. And yet the treasury doubled, the young people learned languages, and a servant's son became a minister. When the Stranger left, the court could not agree whether it had been robbed or enriched. Both, said the Judge. **Rule:** the Rahu season brings more of everything, including confusion; it rewards those who know what they actually want.*

STORY: THE STRANGER BORROWS A COAT. *The Stranger arrived at court with no clothes of his own. He borrowed the Priest's robe, and everyone found him wise; the Commander's armour, and everyone found him brave; the Minister of Pleasure's silks, and everyone found him charming. "Who is he really?" asked the King. "Whoever he is standing next to," said the Judge, "so look at who is standing next to him." **Rule:** judge Rahu by the lord of its sign and by the planets in its room; Rahu itself is a mirror with an appetite.*

From Chapter 10: The Jupiter Season (16 Years): Growth and Grace

STORY: THE PRIEST TAKES THE KEYS. When the Royal Priest's turn came to run the palace, the first thing he did was open the storerooms and feed everyone. He hired tutors for the children, invited scholars from distant kingdoms, and blessed every marriage proposal at the gate. By the third year the treasury was lower, the kitchen busier, and every courtier had put on weight, including the Priest. "You are generous to a fault," said the Judge. "Yes," said the Priest, "and in my years the fault and the generosity come together. Learn to tell them apart." **Rule:** Jupiter's season expands whatever it touches: wisdom, children, faith, money, and also waistlines, debts and promises made too freely.

STORY: THE PRIEST AND THE JUDGE COUNT THE GRAIN. In the Priest's third year the Judge came to the storeroom with his ledger. "You have promised grain to four villages, and we have grain for two." The Priest was wounded. "I promised in good faith." "Faith is yours," said the Judge, "arithmetic is mine." They sat up all night and found a way: two villages now, two after the harvest, and an honest letter from the Priest to each. The villages loved him more for the letter than for the grain. **Rule:** the Saturn sub-season inside a Jupiter season turns promises into schedules; meet it with honesty and it strengthens the season.

STORY: THE PRIEST'S TWO PUPILS. The Priest once took two pupils. The first came from the lucky rooms of the palace, and every lesson landed softly. The second was the treasurer's son, and every lesson came with a cost: a fee, a duty, a ledger to balance. Years later both were wise. "Who learned more?" asked the King. "The same," said the Priest. "Who paid more?" "The second. And he will never lend grain he does not have." **Rule:** when Jupiter tests you, the season still teaches; it only charges tuition.

From Chapter 11: The Saturn Season (19 Years): The Long Audit

STORY: THE JUDGE OPENS THE LEDGER. *When the old Judge of Labour took the keys, he did not open the storerooms as the Priest had. He opened the ledger. Every courtier was shown their page: what they had promised, done and borrowed. The Minister of Pleasure wept; the Prince talked very fast; the Commander found the gate locked. "I am not punishing anyone," said the Judge. "I am reading. Then we will work until the pages balance, and after that you will be free in a way you have never been." The courtiers who worked grew strong. The ones who argued with the ledger grew old. **Rule:** Saturn's season is an audit, not a sentence; the work it asks for is the work you were always going to have to do.*

STORY: THE JUDGE VISITS THE QUEEN MOTHER. *In his seventh year as head of the household, the Judge went to live in the Queen Mother's wing, as he does every thirty years. She had always run the mood of the palace, and now the mood was his: sober breakfasts, early nights, every worry written down and dated. The courtiers said the palace had never been so gloomy. The Queen Mother said it had never been so honest: "He only asks me what is true, and then helps me carry it." When he left, her accounts were clear for the first time. **Rule:** when Saturn's weather crosses your Moon inside a Saturn season, the task is honesty about your own mind; it is the heaviest stretch and the most clarifying.*

STORY: THE JUDGE'S LATE PAYMENT. *On the last day of his nineteen years, the courtiers gathered to see the Judge hand back the keys, expecting a lecture. Instead he opened the ledger to the last page and read out what each now owned: the Commander, a fortress built stone by stone; the Minister, a garden tended through two droughts; the Prince, a library. "You thought I was taking," said the Judge. "I was holding. Here it is." **Rule:** Saturn gives late and gives what lasts; the end of the season is where the work is paid.*

From Chapter 12: The Mercury Season (17 Years): The Clever Years

STORY: THE PRINCE TAKES THE COLOUR OF THE ROOM. When the clever young Prince took the keys, the court noticed how he changed with his company. In the Priest's study he spoke of law. In the Minister of Pleasure's garden he wrote songs. Beside the Commander he grew sharp-tongued. Beside the Judge he became a careful clerk who finished every file. Left alone, he was simply bright and busy, loyal to no plan for more than a week. "Who are you, really?" asked the Queen Mother. "Whoever I am standing next to," said the Prince, "so choose my company carefully." **Rule:** Mercury has no nature of its own; its season takes the colour of the planets it sits with and the room it sits in.

STORY: THE PRINCE AND THE KING. The Prince was never allowed far from the throne. Wherever the King went, the Prince went a few steps behind, carrying the letters. Sometimes he stood so close to the King's blaze that nobody saw him at all, and his best ideas were announced in the King's voice. He did not sulk. He wrote everything down, so that when the King was away, even briefly, the court discovered how much of its cleverness had been his. **Rule:** Mercury is always within a sign of the Sun; when outshone, it works best in writing and in the King's absence.

STORY: THE PRINCE'S UNFINISHED LETTERS. At the end of his seventeen years the Prince brought the Judge a chest of letters. Hundreds: brilliant, witty, half-written. "Which of these did you send?" asked the Judge. The Prince counted. Eleven. "Then your season is eleven letters long," said the Judge, "and the rest is weather." The Prince took one unfinished letter, finished it, and sent it, and that was the one the kingdom remembered. **Rule:** a Mercury season is measured by what was finished; the Saturn sub-season at its end is when the count is taken.

From Chapter 13: Where the Planet Sits Changes the Season

STORY: THE JUDGE WHO STOOD TOO NEAR THE THRONE. *The old Judge of Labour had a report to read to the court: twenty years of accounts. But he stood a step too close to the King, and the King was in full voice. Every time the Judge opened his mouth, the hall heard only the King. The accounts were real; the Judge's season still came. But the kingdom remembered those years as the King's years, about pride and position and the father's name. Rule: a season lord outshone by the Sun still gives its season, but its themes arrive tangled with the Sun's: identity, authority, the father, the ego.*

STORY: THE STRANGER WHO CARRIED THE SADHU'S MESSAGE. *The smoke-headed Stranger was given the household for eighteen years, and everyone braced for noise and hunger. But he had taken his lodgings, by chance, in the Sadhu's old cell, and the longer he lived there the more the Sadhu's silence crept into his voice. He still wanted everything. He also kept giving things away, and could not explain why. The court said: he speaks for himself, but the cell he sleeps in speaks through him. Rule: a season lord also carries the agenda of the planet whose star it sits in; the loudest voice is its own, the second comes from the star.*

STORY: THE MINISTER'S OWN HOUSE. *When the Minister of Pleasure was given the household, she did not move into the palace. She ran it from her own mansion, where every carpet was hers and every servant knew her. The court grumbled that she was never seen, that money left by the back gate. All true. But nothing she promised failed to arrive: the weddings were held, the music played, the beds were soft. Rule: a season lord at home delivers its promise fully, in the manner of the room it sits in.*

From Chapter 14: Weather Inside the Season

STORY: THE JUDGE VISITS THE QUEEN MOTHER. *Once in a generation the old Judge of Labour came to audit the Queen Mother's household. He arrived in the room before hers and sat for two and a half years, reading. Then he moved into her own apartments and the palace went quiet; the feasts stopped, every servant's work was weighed. Then he moved to the room beyond and slowly the music returned. The Queen Mother who had kept honest accounts wept at the start and thanked him at the end: he had found three servants stealing and one old debt she could at last pay off. The one who had hidden things wept all the way through. Rule: Saturn's seven and a half years is an audit of the mind's household; it rewards whoever has nothing to hide and whoever starts keeping accounts now.*

STORY: RAIN ON TWO FIELDS. *The same monsoon fell on two farms outside the city. On the first, the Priest had spent the year sowing, and the rain brought a harvest that filled the storerooms. On the second, the headless Sadhu had let the land rest, and the rain brought wildflowers and a flooded path. The second farmer was not cursed. He had simply not planted anything, because it was not that kind of year for him, and the rain honoured what was there. Rule: the weather waters whatever the season has planted; good weather on an empty field grows wildflowers, not grain.*

From Chapter 15: The Changeover

STORY: THE YEAR OF TWO KEYS. *By palace custom, a courtier leaving the running of the household did not simply hand over the keys on the appointed day. For a year before, the incoming courtier walked beside him through the kitchens and the treasury, learning which doors stuck and which servants could be trusted. For a year after, the outgoing one stayed in a room near the gate, answering questions. So for two years the palace had two sets of keys, and the servants never quite knew whose orders to follow. Things were lost in that time, and things were found, because new eyes saw what the old ones had stopped seeing. **Rule:** the changeover runs from the last year of the old season to the first year of the new; expect two years with two sets of keys.*

STORY: THE MINISTER LEAVES AND THE KING ARRIVES. *For twenty years the Minister of Pleasure had run the household, and the palace had grown soft and warm: music in the evenings, guests in every room, the accounts a little loose. On the day the King took over, he walked through the halls in silence, and the first thing he did was open the shutters. The light showed dust on everything. The servants, used to being asked how they felt, were now asked what they had done. Some left. The ones who stayed found that they stood straighter. He simply needed to know who was who, starting with himself. **Rule:** the Venus-to-Sun changeover trades comfort for clarity; expect light on things that were pleasantly dim.*

STORY: THE STRANGER MEETS THE PRIEST AT THE GATE. *When the smoke-headed Stranger's eighteen years were done, he met the Royal Priest at the gate and tried to hand over a list: all the things the household still wanted. The Priest read it, folded it, and put it in his sleeve. "We will see which of these were hungers and which were needs," he said. For the first year the list sat unread and the household felt strangely empty, and then one morning a teacher arrived who had been invited by nobody, and the Priest's years began in earnest. **Rule:** at the Rahu-to-Jupiter changeover, let the list sit; the first Jupiter year sorts hunger from need before it gives anything.*

From Chapter 16: Three Lives in Seasons

STORY: THE MINISTER HANDS OVER THE KEYS. *For twenty years the Minister of Pleasure (Venus) has run Meera's household: music in the evenings, a wedding in the courtyard, a bill for all of it in a drawer in the twelfth room. In the final year the headless Sadhu (Ketu) walks the corridors behind him, quietly closing doors. Then the King (Sun) arrives from the first room, where he has always lived, and asks a question nobody has asked her in twenty years: "Who are you, apart from what you love and who loves you?"* **Rule:** *the last sub-season of any season belongs to the planet before the season lord in the fixed order, so Venus always ends in Ketu, and the Sun always begins from Ketu's loosened grip.*

STORY: THE STRANGER INVITES THE MINISTER TO DINNER. *The smoke-headed Stranger (Rahu) has been master of Arjun's house for twelve years and has filled it with books (the Priest's years), ledgers (the Judge's) and half-finished letters (the Prince's). Now the Minister of Pleasure (Venus) comes to stay for three years. She hangs curtains in the seventh room, the room of partners, and the Stranger, who already wears her sign like a borrowed coat, is enchanted. Everything becomes about the one person across the table and the house they might share. The old Judge, watching from the eighth room, mutters that the Minister owns two rooms that cost this household dearly.* **Rule:** *when a sub-lord is the season lord's natural friend but tests you by what it owns, the sub-season feels pleasant and spends more than it earns; enjoy it with a budget.*

STORY: THE JUDGE MOVES INTO THE STRANGER'S ROOM. *In Devika's palace the fifth room, the room of children and of the heart's creations, is crowded. The smoke-headed Stranger (Rahu) has lived there since 2021, hungry to be seen. The clever young Prince (Mercury) keeps his papers there. And the old Judge of Labour (Saturn) has his desk in the corner, where he has always been, except that now, for two years and ten months, he is on duty. He asks the Stranger for receipts. He asks the Prince to finish one letter before starting the next. He asks the mistress of the house to slow down, attend to her elders, and accept that recognition arrives by the servants' staircase, late and on foot.* **Rule:** *a sub-lord sitting in the same room as the season lord does not soften the season; it concentrates it in that room's affairs.*

From Chapter 17: Living Well in a Hard Season

STORY: THE JUDGE'S LONG TABLE. A young merchant was told the old Judge of Labour (Saturn) would run his household for nineteen years, and he went home and wept. On the first morning the Judge laid a long table and set on it everything the merchant owned: the ledgers, the debts, the promises made and forgotten. "I am not here to ruin you," the Judge said. "I am here to go through all of it with you, one page a day, until it is in order. The Minister of Pleasure (Venus) will visit in a few years and the Prince (Mercury) after her, and you will be glad of them. But the table is mine, and we start today." The merchant found that a page a day was not unbearable. It was only steady. **Rule:** Saturn's season asks for a daily portion of honest work, never a heroic burst; the length of the season is the length of the table, not the depth of the punishment.

STORY: THE STRANGER'S BAZAAR. When the smoke-headed Stranger (Rahu) runs a household, a bazaar springs up outside its gate: blue stones and orange stones, threads, amulets, a seven-day ritual and a seven-year one. A frightened woman walks the stalls with her purse open. The old Judge (Saturn), passing on his Saturday rounds, stops her. "What are you buying?" "Something to make it stop." "Nothing here makes anything stop," he says. "That orange stone is the Stranger's own. Wear it and he will shout louder. Go home. Feed the watchman. Sleep before midnight. Come to me on Saturdays and I will show you the accounts." She goes home with a full purse and a short list. **Rule:** a stone belongs to one planet and strengthens that planet; in a testing season the planet's own stone is the one thing never to buy.

STORY: THE QUEEN MOTHER'S KITCHEN. The Queen Mother (Moon) sat at the kitchen table and her daughter, who had learnt the timetable, came in with a printout. The daughter began, "Your Saturn...", and the Queen Mother's face closed like a door. The daughter stopped, put the printout away, and started again. "Ma, the next few years want you to slow down and look after your knees, and I want to do it with you. Let us walk on Saturday mornings." The door opened. Later, when the Queen Mother asked, "Is it a bad time?", the daughter said, "It is a working time, and it has an end, and I am here for all of it." **Rule:** when you speak of a season to someone you love, say the task, say the horizon, say what you will do beside them, and leave the planet's name in your pocket.

From Chapter 18: Your Season Map

STORY: THE PRINCE'S NOTEBOOK. *The clever young Prince (Mercury), secretary to the court, was asked by the King (Sun) why the household's accounts never taught anybody anything. "Because, Majesty, nobody writes anything down until after it has happened, and then they write only what makes them look wise." So the Prince began a notebook. On the first page of each year he wrote which courtier ran the household and which ran the month. Below, as the year passed, he wrote what actually happened, in pencil, without comment. At year's end he read the page and, in a different colour, wrote one line of what it had taught. After twelve years the notebook was the most valuable book in the palace, because it was about this house. Rule: a season map is only as good as the honest dates written on it; mark first, read second, and keep the two in different colours.*

STORY: THE JUDGE READS THE LEDGER BACKWARDS. *A nervous householder asked the old Judge of Labour (Saturn) what the coming year would bring. The Judge did not answer. He opened the household ledger at the first page and read it forward, year by year, aloud, until he reached today. "There," he said, closing it. "You have now heard what every courtier does in this house when it is his turn. The Stranger (Rahu) spends. The Minister (Venus) decorates and then presents a bill. The Priest (Jupiter) blesses, quietly, from a back room. The Sadhu (Ketu) empties a cupboard. You did not need me to tell you the coming year. You needed to hear your own ledger read without flinching." Rule: the best prediction of how a planet will behave in your next sub-season is how it behaved in its last one.*

STORY: THE SADHU'S LETTER. *A woman in the last year of a long season went to the headless Sadhu (Ketu), who was sweeping the courtyard, and asked what she should do. He did not stop sweeping. "Write to the season," he said. "Not to me. To the one who has been running your house. Tell it what it gave you and what it is asking. Tell it the one thing you fear. Tell it what you will do on Fridays. Then fold the letter and sweep." She did, and found that a season thanked in writing is a season you can leave without looking back. The King (Sun) arrived the next June and found the courtyard clean. Rule: the changeover is easier for the person who has written down what the ending season gave, what it asked, and what they will do while it closes.*

48 stories in all. If you can retell them, you can read a chart.

About the Author

Anushka Bharti is a practising Vedic astrologer. She came to the subject through curiosity about her own life and the lives of the people she loved, found the classical books closed to her, and rebuilt the subject for herself from first principles, insisting on a reason and a story for every rule.

Her first book, *Astrology, Gently*, teaches the whole of chart reading in plain English. *Your Life in Seasons* is the second book in the series and takes one idea, the dasha system of planetary seasons, and goes deep.

She believes the most important use of astrology is not prediction but understanding: of one's own nature, of one's seasons, and of the people one loves.

If this book helped you, tell someone who is in a hard year. And if you find an error, please write; a second edition should always be better than the first.